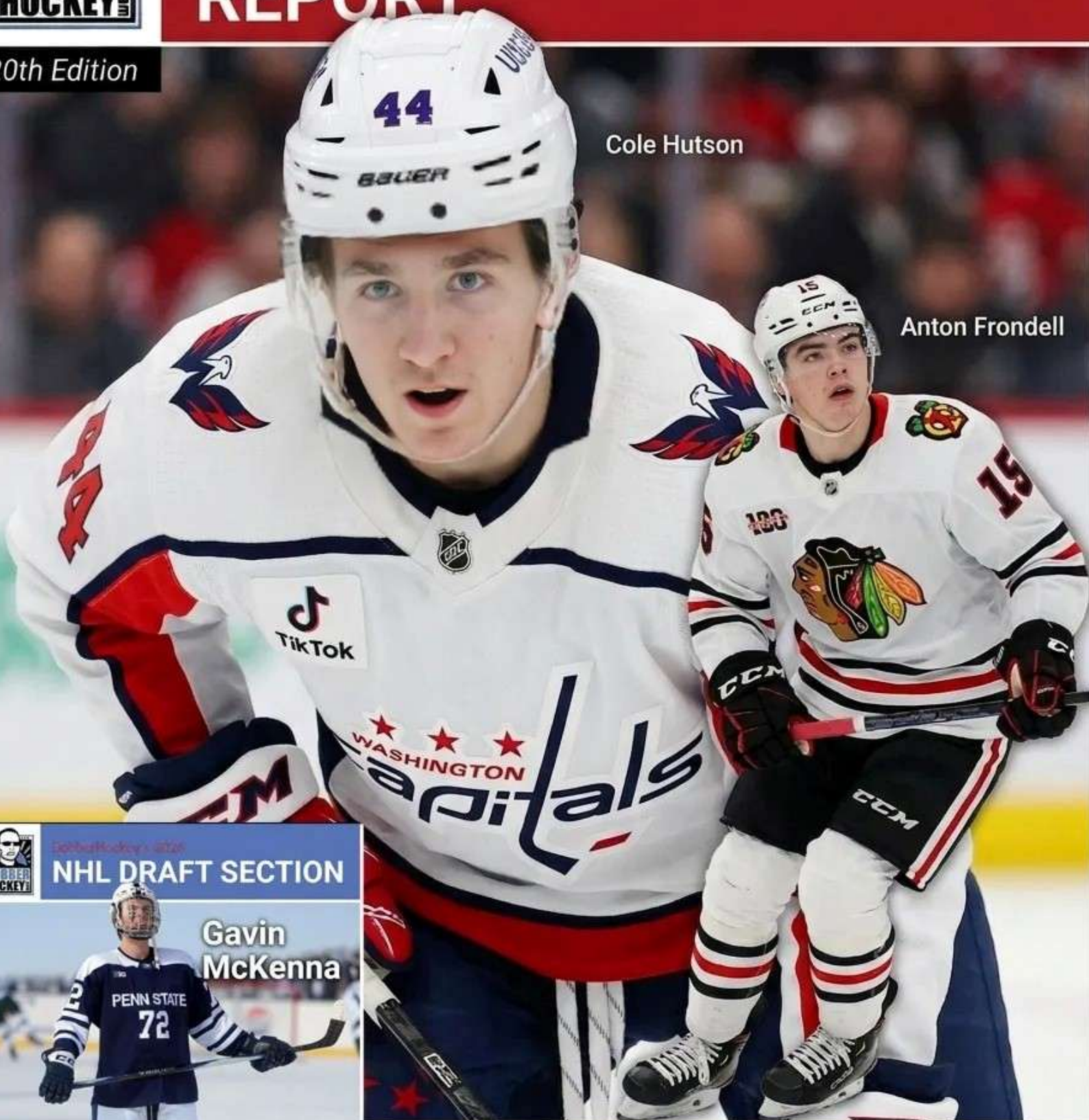


DobberHockey's 2026

FANTASY PROSPECTS REPORT

20th Edition



Cole Hutson

Anton Frondell



NHL DRAFT SECTION



Gavin
McKenna

BONUS
DRAFT
SECTION!

Projected impact of McKenna,
Stenberg, Verhoeff and other
2026 draft picks



Dobber's 2026 Fantasy Prospects Report

Home of the Top Fantasy Hockey Player Rankings

What an absolute pleasure it is to research and report on the future of fantasy hockey for the 20th year. Not just the obvious players, such as Ivan Demidov, last year's cover player, or Matthew Schaefer, who appeared on the cover of the draft section, but also the lesser-known players whose hype you may have tempered (Matt Savoie) or overlooked entirely (Emmitt Finnie, Fraser Minten, Justin Sourdif, Oliver Kapanen). Selfishly, this deep dive helps me in my own leagues, and 20 years in, the process of uncovering these gems is as addictive as ever.

Over two decades, I've watched incredible talent pass through the Dobber Sports Network. From NHL and OHL scouting roles to the team at Elite Prospects, we have become the scouting world's premier pipeline. The crew we've assembled for this year's FPR is, quite frankly, as sharp as any I can remember. The insights they've unearthed—details even I hadn't caught—are exactly why this remains the industry standard.

This 20th edition comes at a perfect time for me. I'm currently navigating a rebuild in one of my dynasties (aiming for a quick turnaround, not a Buffalo-style 14-year fiasco). But the FPR isn't just for rebuilding teams—it also helps contenders drafting late.

In one of my dynasty leagues, the manager who just won (a DobberHockey / Prospects reader, of course!) only had late picks last summer and still snagged Nick Lardis. With the last pick of one dynasty, I took Hampton Slukynsky, and with the last pick of another, I grabbed Matvei Gridin.

That type of success is common for regular readers of the Fantasy Prospects Report, and I promise this year will be no different.

Now go kick some ass at the draft!

- Dobber
@DobberHockey / @DobberProspects

Updated: July 12, 2026 (Some minor fixes, a Daws update)

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DobberHockey's 2026 Fantasy Hockey Prospects Report

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Top 50 Skaters: Prospects 2026

Here is our 20th annual list of the Top 50 players that our experts would select, in order, for their keeper leagues. We rolled up the lists into: 1) Dobber's list; 2) Staff consensus; and 3) Pat Quinn's list (Managing Editor, Feature Article Content, DobberProspects.com).

Different from the online Fantasy Hockey Prospect Rankings, this list excludes **all** prospects that have played even **one single regular season NHL game**. Top players of the 2026 Draft are included, as well. One more difference: **defensemen** were **weighted** such that for them a goal is worth two points, while an assist counts for one (forwards are one each).

With that in mind, Dobber and Quinn pit their lists against a consensus from a panel of DobberProspects.com writers and scouts consisting of: Alforque, Babos, Crocker, Downey, Epps, Gheordanescu, Kalmar, Kaminsky, Nuno, Orr, Quinn, Soboleski, Sharma, and Wyatt. We took into consideration how close a prospect is, how certain they are of reaching their potential, as well as their offensive upside.

Note: Players that have played even one or two regular season NHL games are **ineligible** for this list. However, playing a playoff game does **not** render a player ineligible (i.e. Nikishin and Buium).

Dobber			Consensus			Quinn		
1	Gavin McKenna	'26	1	Gavin McKenna	'26	1	Gavin McKenna	'26
2	Ivar Stenberg	'26	2	Ivar Stenberg	'26	2	Ivar Stenberg	'26
3	Tij Iginla	UTA	3	Tij Iginla	UTA	3	Roman Kantserov	CHI
4	Chase Reid	'26	4	Michael Hage	MON	4	Viggo Björck	'26
5	Roman Kantserov	CHI	5	Chase Reid	'26	5	Daxon Rudolph	'26
6	Alex Zharovsky	MON	6	Jake O'Brien	SEA	6	Andrew Cristall	WAS
7	Kashawn Aitcheson	NYI	7	Roman Kantserov	CHI	7	Chase Reid	'26
8	Viggo Bjorck	'26	8	Caleb Desnoyers	UTA	8	Adam Jiricek	STL
9	Cameron Reid	NSH	9	Caleb Malhotra	'26	9	Michael Hage	MON
10	Michael Hage	MON	10	Alex Zharovsky	MON	10	Quentin Musty	SJS
11	Jake O'Brien	SEA	11	Roger McQueen	ANA	11	Cole Reschny	CGY
12	Cole Reschny	CGY	12	Andrew Cristall	WAS	12	Trevor Connelly	VGK
13	Andrew Cristall	WAS	13	Cole Reschny	CGY	13	Jackson Smith	CBJ
14	Caleb Desnoyers	UTA	14	Carson Carels	'26	14	Ethan Wyttenbach	CGY
15	Adam Jiricek	STL	15	Kashawn Aitcheson	NYI	15	Keaton Verhoeff	'26
16	Dean Letourneau	BOS	16	Viggo Bjorck	'26	16	Tij Iginla	UTA
17	Charlie Stramel	MIN	17	Keaton Verhoeff	'26	17	Alex Zharovsky	MON
18	Caleb Malhotra	'26	18	Egor Surin	NSH	18	Caleb Malhotra	'26
19	Wyatt Cullen	'26	19	Justin Carbonneau	STL	19	Jake O'Brien	SEA
20	Jackson Smith	CBJ	20	Max Plante	DET	20	Roger McQueen	ANA
21	Egor Surin	NSH	21	Adam Jiricek	STL	21	Yegor Surin	NSH
22	Max Plante	DET	22	Daxon Rudolph	'26	22	Justin Carbonneau	STL
23	Carson Carels	'26	23	Jackson Smith	CBJ	23	Jagger Firkus	SEA
24	Nikita Klepov	'26	24	Ethan Belchetz	'26	24	Ben Hemmerling	VGK
25	Ryan Roobroeck	'26	25	Liam Greentree	NYR	25	Lynden Lakovic	WAS

Dobber			Consensus			Quinn		
26	Liam Greentree	NYR	26	Trevor Connelly	VGK	26	Terik Parascak	WAS
27	Ben Rautiainen	TBL	27	Carter Bear	DET	27	Emil Hemming	DAL
28	Xavier Villeneuve	'26	28	Cole Eiserman	NYI	28	Cole Beaudoin	UTA
29	Keaton Verhoeff	'26	29	Ryan Lin	'26	29	Filip Bystedt	SJS
30	Trevor Connelly	VGK	30	Alberts Smits	'26	30	Max Plante	DET
31	Roger McQueen	ANA	31	Quentin Musty	SJS	31	Vitali Pinchuk	NSH
32	Eric Pohlkamp	SJS	32	Dean Letourneau	BOS	32	Caleb Desnoyers	UTA
33	Justin Carbonneau	STL	33	Lynden Lakovic	WAS	33	Liam Greentree	NYR
34	Quentin Musty	SJS	34	Benjamin Rautiainen	TBL	34	Cullen Potter	CGY
35	J.P. Hurlbert	'26	35	Xavier Villeneuve	'26	35	Cayden Lindstrom	CBJ
36	Emil Hemming	DAL	36	Cole Beaudoin	UTA	36	Maxim Masse	ANA
37	Ryker Lee	NSH	37	Cayden Lindstrom	CBJ	37	Charlie Stramel	MIN
38	Cameron Schmidt	DAL	38	Jagger Firkus	SEA	38	Cole Eiserman	NYI
39	Aiden Fink	NSH	39	William Horcoff	PIT	39	J.P. Hurlbert	'26
40	Ethan Wyttenbach	CGY	40	Cameron Reid	NSH	40	Carson Carels	'26
41	Sam O'Reilly	TBL	41	Cullen Potter	CGY	41	Henry Mews	CGY
42	William Horcoff	PIT	42	Tynan Lawrence	'26	42	Marcus Nordmark	'26
43	Vaclav Nestrasil	CHI	43	Charlie Stramel	MIN	43	William Horcoff	PIT
44	Marek Vanacker	CHI	44	Bryce Pickford	MON	44	Dean Letourneau	BOS
45	Adam Benak	MIN	45	Vaclav Nestrasil	CHI	45	Wyatt Cullen	'26
46	Vitali Pinchuk	NSH	46	Ryker Lee	NSH	46	Adam Novotny	'26
47	Jagger Firkus	SEA	47	Eric Pohlkamp	SJS	47	Kieron Walton	WPG
48	I. Miroshnichenko	WAS	48	Stian Solberg	ANA	48	Ty Nelson	SEA
49	Cole Eiserman	NYI	49	Ethan Wyttenbach	CGY	49	Tanner Molendyk	NSH
50	Lynden Lakovic	WAS	50	Filip Bystedt	SJS	50	Ryan Lin	'26



Top 50 Skaters: Consensus Breakdown

Just 109 players were on one Top 50 list or another (down from 126 in each of the last two years). See below for where the participating writers/scouts had each player ranked.

<i>Prospect</i>		<i>Dobber</i>	<i>Alforque</i>	<i>Babos</i>	<i>Crocker</i>	<i>Downey</i>	<i>Epps</i>	<i>Gheordanesc</i>	<i>Kalmar</i>	<i>Kaminsky</i>	<i>Nuno</i>	<i>Orr</i>	<i>Quinn</i>	<i>Sharma</i>	<i>Soboleski</i>	<i>Wyatt</i>
Gavin McKenna	'26	1	1	1	1	1	1	2	2	1	1	1	1	1	1	1
Ivar Stenberg	'26	2	2	2	2	3	2	1	1	2	2	2	2	2	2	2
Tij Iginla	UTA	3	3	5	3	2	3	3	5	6	4	3	16	4	5	6
Michael Hage	MON	10	5	3	4	5	6	9	11	4	5	6	9	6	4	5
Chase Reid	'26	4	6	4	21	10	4	10	34	5	3	11	7	5	3	3
Jake O'Brien	SEA	11	7	10	9	18	17	6	3	24	7	7	19	8	10	4
Roman Kantserov	CHI	5	12	14	13	46	7	8	24	15	9	4	3	9	14	10
Caleb Desnoyers	UTA	14	9	7	8	14	15	4	8	12	19	13	32	20	9	14
Caleb Malhotra	'26	18	13	13	18	22	12	13	10	13	10	10	18	12	6	13
Alex Zharovsky	MON	6	4	6	6	29	14	29	51	3	6	5	17	7	16	16
Roger McQueen	ANA	31	24	15	10	33	39	5	6	11	14	8	20	15	12	15
Andrew Cristall	WAS	13	17	23	28	30	18	16	26	10	20	20	6	19	18	7
Cole Reschny	CGY	12	51	11	12	6	13	31	21	22	11	12	11	13	31	19
Carson Carels	'26	37	10	22	14	44	5	27	36	9	21	22	40	3	7	20
Kashawn Aitcheson	NYI	7	11	30	7	7	10	37	27	18	27	25	51	23	19	25
Viggo Bjorck	'26	8	14	29	25	26	11	51	17	16	25	28	4	28	26	32
Keaton Verhoeff	'26	29	19	8	5	20	9	33	51	19	38	26	15	37	15	23
Egor Surin	NSH	21	26	19	23	8	27	20	51	23	17	17	21	17	28	39
Justin Carbonneau	STL	33	40	18	11	38	35	17	30	28	13	14	22	11	40	11
Max Plante	DET	22	8	20	51	19	28	48	14	27	18	30	30	21	17	30
Adam Jiricek	STL	15	48	31	30	16	16	24	33	14	28	40	8	24	36	42
Daxon Rudolph	'26	51	16	17	40	42	20	51	51	25	12	23	5	14	8	33
Jackson Smith	CBJ	20	51	40	34	39	25	19	12	31	35	16	13	34	32	28
Ethan Belchetz	'26	51	36	16	22	24	23	41	51	21	16	15	51	16	21	35
Liam Greentree	NYR	26	25	38	15	43	33	32	38	39	34	19	33	32	23	17
Trevor Connolly	VGK	30	15	48	51	51	36	7	4	51	51	51	12	51	11	8
Carter Bear	DET	51	20	51	19	13	19	14	16	35	48	48	51	46	20	26
Cole Eiserman	NYI	50	18	51	16	15	22	18	23	41	51	51	38	51	24	9
Ryan Lin	'26	51	21	9	51	25	32	51	51	32	8	9	50	10	51	29
Alberts Smits	'26	51	30	25	41	4	8	51	51	8	30	27	51	35	51	22
Quentin Musty	SJS	34	51	39	17	9	41	39	25	51	33	34	10	31	30	51
Dean Letourneau	BOS	16	34	45	51	35	21	15	7	40	41	47	44	38	27	51
Lynden Lakovic	WAS	51	50	24	27	21	51	51	9	51	22	24	25	26	46	48
Ben Rautiainen	TBL	27	51	21	51	51	34	51	51	7	15	31	51	18	48	27
Xavier Villeneuve	'26	28	27	35	51	27	31	50	51	20	29	32	51	30	51	34
Cole Beaudoin	UTA	51	51	37	46	51	51	36	51	37	32	33	28	25	13	36

<i>Prospect</i>		<i>Dobber</i>	<i>Alforque</i>	<i>Babos</i>	<i>Crocker</i>	<i>Downey</i>	<i>Epps</i>	<i>Gheordanesc</i>	<i>Kalmar</i>	<i>Kaminsky</i>	<i>Nuno</i>	<i>Orr</i>	<i>Quinn</i>	<i>Sharma</i>	<i>Soboleski</i>	<i>Wyatt</i>
<i>Cayden Lindstrom</i>	CBJ	51	51	32	31	51	51	51	18	51	26	29	35	29	33	49
<i>Jagger Firkus</i>	SEA	48	31	51	42	47	51	35	19	51	51	51	23	51	22	18
<i>William Horcoff</i>	PIT	43	23	43	45	51	48	30	13	43	42	41	43	45	35	51
<i>Cameron Reid</i>	NSH	9	51	51	20	31	24	51	51	50	44	44	51	40	51	45
<i>Cullen Potter</i>	CGY	51	22	50	39	28	51	38	47	49	46	21	34	42	50	47
<i>Tynan Lawrence</i>	'25	51	32	36	38	51	43	51	51	33	37	38	51	43	29	31
<i>Charlie Stramel</i>	MIN	17	35	51	51	45	26	25	51	51	51	51	37	51	25	51
<i>Bryce Pickford</i>	MON	51	47	26	51	51	51	21	51	51	24	45	51	27	51	21
<i>Vaclav Nestrasil</i>	CHI	44	43	28	50	51	49	47	51	46	23	35	51	22	41	38
<i>Ryker Lee</i>	NSH	38	49	42	51	23	44	40	51	44	40	18	51	44	51	43
<i>Eric Pohlkamp</i>	SJS	32	51	51	51	12	40	12	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	24
<i>Stian Solberg</i>	ANA	51	51	44	51	40	51	22	49	26	39	39	51	39	51	51
<i>Ethan Wyttenbach</i>	CGY	41	45	51	51	48	45	28	35	51	51	51	14	51	51	51
<i>Filip Bystedt</i>	SJS	51	29	51	51	51	51	51	15	51	51	51	29	51	34	51
<i>Emil Hemming</i>	DAL	36	51	51	36	51	30	45	44	51	51	51	27	51	44	51
<i>Radim Mrtka</i>	BUF	51	51	27	26	41	51	51	51	17	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Adam Novotny</i>	'26	51	51	41	47	51	51	51	51	30	36	37	46	33	51	51
<i>Nikita Klepov</i>	'26	24	28	51	51	51	29	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Marek Vanacker</i>	CHI	45	51	51	51	51	51	43	51	51	51	51	51	51	37	12
<i>Kasper Halttunen</i>	SJS	51	51	51	24	11	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Mason West</i>	CHI	51	51	34	49	51	51	51	51	51	31	43	51	36	51	51
<i>Wyatt Cullen</i>	'26	19	51	46	51	51	51	49	51	36	51	51	45	51	51	51
<i>Maxim Masse</i>	ANA	51	51	51	32	51	51	51	31	51	51	51	36	51	51	46
<i>Terik Parascak</i>	WAS	51	42	51	51	51	51	51	40	51	51	51	26	51	42	51
<i>Sam O'Reilly</i>	TBL	42	46	51	35	51	47	44	45	51	51	51	51	51	45	51
<i>Tanner Molendyk</i>	NSH	51	51	51	29	34	51	51	39	51	51	51	49	51	51	51
<i>Jack Pridham</i>	TBL	51	39	33	44	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	39	51
<i>Nikita Artamonov</i>	CAR	51	51	51	33	50	51	51	41	51	49	51	51	51	51	41
<i>J.P. Hurlbert</i>	'26	35	51	51	51	51	42	51	51	51	51	51	39	51	51	51
<i>Adam Benak</i>	MIN	46	51	47	51	51	51	51	51	45	45	46	51	41	51	51
<i>Alfons Freij</i>	WPG	51	51	51	51	17	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Logan Hensler</i>	OTT	51	51	51	37	51	51	51	51	51	43	42	51	48	51	51
<i>Malte Gustafsson</i>	'26	51	41	51	51	51	51	51	51	29	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Eddie Genborg</i>	'26	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	20	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Oscar Hemming</i>	'26	51	51	51	51	51	37	51	51	34	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Lucas Pettersson</i>	ANA	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	22	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Ben Hemmerling</i>	VGK	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	24	51	51	51
<i>Ryan Roobroeck</i>	'26	25	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Charlie Cerrato</i>	CAR	51	51	51	51	51	51	26	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Vitali Pinchuk</i>	NSH	47	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	31	51	51	51

<i>Prospect</i>		<i>Dobber</i>	<i>Alforque</i>	<i>Babos</i>	<i>Crocker</i>	<i>Downey</i>	<i>Epps</i>	<i>Gheordanesc</i>	<i>Kalmar</i>	<i>Kaminsky</i>	<i>Nuno</i>	<i>Orr</i>	<i>Quinn</i>	<i>Sharma</i>	<i>Soboleski</i>	<i>Wyatt</i>
<i>Julius Miettinen</i>	SEA	51	33	51	51	51	51	46	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Sasha Pastujov</i>	ANA	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	28	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Amadeus Lombardi</i>	DET	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	29	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Henry Mews</i>	CGY	51	51	51	48	51	51	51	42	51	51	51	41	51	51	51
<i>Cameron Schmidt</i>	DAL	39	51	51	51	51	46	51	48	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>L Sahlin Wallenius</i>	SJS	51	51	51	51	32	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Tarin Smith</i>	ANA	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	32	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Elton Hermansson</i>	'26	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	47	51	51	51	51	38	51
<i>Ty Nelson</i>	SEA	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	48	51	51	37
<i>Teddy Stiga</i>	NSH	51	51	51	51	36	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Liam Ruck</i>	'26	51	37	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Cole McKinney</i>	SJS	51	51	51	51	37	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Cruz Lucius</i>	PIT	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	37	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Yegor Shilov</i>	'26	51	38	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Maddox Dagenais</i>	'26	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	38	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Oliver Suvanto</i>	'26	51	51	51	51	51	38	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Tyson Jugnauth</i>	SEA	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	50	51	51	51	51	40
<i>Aiden Fink</i>	NSH	40	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Anton Silayev</i>	NJD	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	42	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Marcus Nordmark</i>	'26	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	42	51	51	51
<i>Tinus Luc Koblar</i>	TOR	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	43	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>TJ Hughes</i>	COL	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	43	51
<i>Alexander Huang</i>	NSH	51	51	51	43	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Oliver Bonk</i>	PHI	51	44	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Mikhail Ilyin</i>	PIT	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	44
<i>Maxmilian Curran</i>	CGY	51	51	49	51	51	51	51	51	51	47	51	51	50	51	51
<i>Eric Nilson</i>	ANA	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	46	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Kieron Walton</i>	WPG	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	47	51	51	50
<i>Jack Berglund</i>	PHI	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	47	51
<i>Niklas Aaram-Olsen</i>	'26	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	48	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Dmitri Buchelnikov</i>	STL	51	51	51	51	51	50	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	49	51
<i>I Miroshnichenko</i>	WAS	49	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51
<i>Mikhail Gulyayev</i>	COL	51	51	51	51	49	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51	51

The advertisement features a dark blue background with a faint, glowing hockey rink and player movement lines. At the top left, there is a cartoon illustration of two men: one with glasses and the other with sunglasses and a goatee. The main headline is in large, bold, red letters. Below it, a white box contains text and a bulleted list. At the bottom, there is a dark blue banner with white text and a red banner with white text.

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Top 25 Goalies: Prospects 2026

Here are the 25 goaltender prospects (five regular season games or fewer) to own in a keeper league, based on a combination of upside, wait-time and certainty.

Criteria: Goaltender cannot have played more than five NHL regular season games.

	Dobber		Harris	
1	Sebastian Cossa	DET	Trey Augustine	DET
2	Semyon Frolov	CAR	Michael Hrabal	UTA
3	Michael Hrabal	UTA	Sebastian Cossa	DET
4	Mikhail Yegorov	NJD	Mikhail Yegorov	NJD
5	Ilya Nabokov	COL	Sergei Murashov	PIT
6	Semyon Vyazovoy	SEA	Drew Commesso	CHI
7	Hampton Slukynsky	LAK	Ilya Nabokov	COL
8	Drew Commesso	CHI	Jack Ivankovic	NSH
9	Yegor Zavragin	PHI	Hampton Slukynsky	LAK
10	Adam Gajan	CHI	Pyotr Andreyanov	CBJ
11	Trey Augustine	DET	Scott Ratzlaff	BUF
12	Josh Ravensbergen	SJS	Carter George	LAK
13	Tobias Trejbal	'26	Semyon Frolov	CAR
14	Jack Ivankovic	NSH	Josh Ravensbergen	SJS
15	Dmitri Borichev	'26	Lucas Beckman	OTT
16	Sergey Murashov	PIT	Adam Gajan	CHI
17	Michael DiPietro	BOS	Pavel Moysevich	VGK
18	Dylan Garand	NYR	Petteri Rimpinen	LAK
19	Niklas Kokko	SEA	Tobias Trejbal	'26
20	Samuel Jonsson	EDM	Rudy Guimond	DET
21	Erik Portillo	LAK	Dmitri Borichev	'26
22	Carson Bjarnason	PHI	Michal Pradel	DET
23	Carter George	LAK	Alexei Medvedev	VAN
24	Arseni Sergeev	CGY	Brady Knowling	'26
25	William Lacelle	'26	Linards Feldbergs	'26

Always Updated

The Fantasy Prospects Report gets updated until just before the NHL Draft, with reader-voted added profiles and the Mock Draft. There is also another update shortly after the Draft where we indicate in the draftee profiles section which team selected that player and when he was drafted.

But the updates don't actually end there. Each player in this document is hyperlinked to his profile on [DobberProspects.com](https://www.dobberprospects.com).

That profile page is where our staff of over 20 writers and editors is updating constantly. Illustrated on the left is the top half of such a player page. Let's take a look at Cameron Schmidt:



<https://www.nhl.com/stars/player/cameron-schmidt-8485363>

Fantasy Summary

Small, explosive right wing with elite straight line speed and a heavy release who drives offense off the rush and has legitimate top-six scoring upside if his game rounds out.

Observations

April 2026 – Schmidt's post-draft season has been dominant. He was tracking at roughly 1.5 points per game with the Vancouver Giants before Seattle acquired him at the WHL trade deadline on January 5 for a massive return: Kaleb Hartmann, two first-round picks, a conditional second, a conditional fourth, and a fifth. That price tag tells you how the CHL views his production. He barely blinked after changing teams. A 21-game point streak with the Thunderbirds (16 goals, 20 assists) pushed him to the top of the WHL scoring race, and he hit both his 100th WHL goal and 200th career WHL point in back-to-back games during his first week in Seattle. He closed the regular season by reaching the 50-goal and 100-point marks in the final week, including a hat trick (his third of the season) in an overtime win over Portland. He was named WHL

Attributes:

Fantasy Upside	8.8
NHL Certainty	6.0
Country	CAN
Position	RW
Roster Type	WHL
Shoot/Glove	Right
Date of Birth	January 19, 2007
Height	5'8"
Weight	161 lbs
Drafted	2025 Round 3, Overall: 94

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Fantasy Summary – This is where we summarize the player in a sentence.

Attributes

Fantasy Upside – We give an upside out of 10 for production. Clicking the little question mark will give you the legend/guidelines.

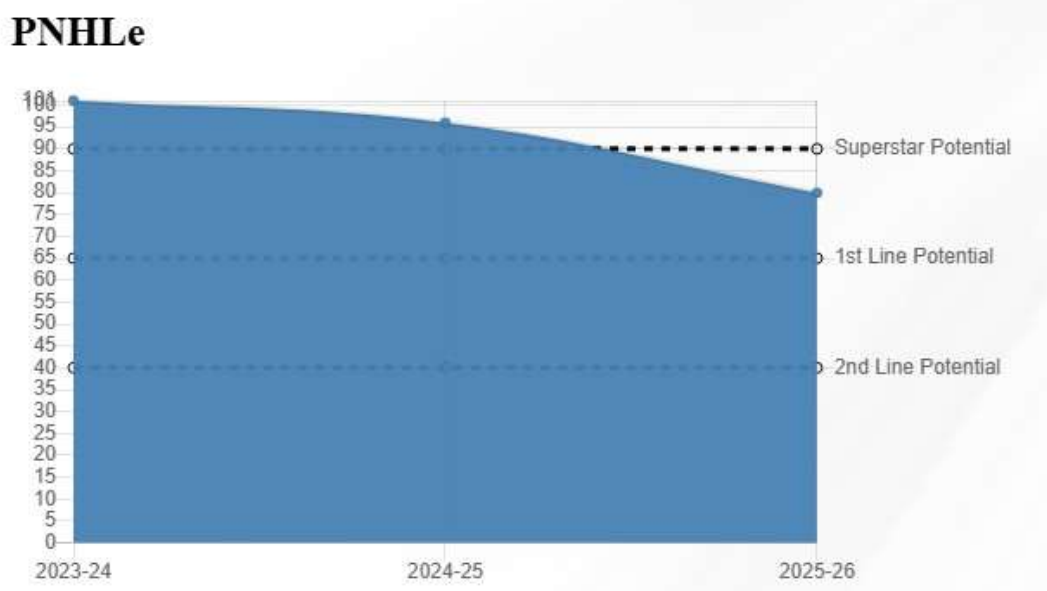
NHL Certainty – Also out of 10, gives our relative odds of that player becoming an NHL regular in some capacity.

Observations – This is where we update with the latest. Clicking 'Read More' here will expand all the notes dating back to, in some cases, before he was even drafted.

Stats – Pulled from Frozen Tools, you are given that player's up-to-date career stats.

After the stats section is the prospect's PNHLe chart. This is a chart that takes the historical production of a player at that age and in that league and extrapolates it to an NHL future.

As you can see here with Dallas prospect Schmidt, he has near-superstar potential based on his prolific scoring rate in the junior circuit.



Not shown here, but underneath this PNHLe chart is a Highlights clip for a quick “eye test”.

And so – the Fantasy Prospects Report really never stops being updated.

Each year on June 1, we just organize and gather everything we’ve learned about all the prospects on the website, tighten it up, rank them and present it to you in this document. Then we go back to updating the website

And since you are likely reviewing this on your tablet or lap top, clicking from this PDF to the website and back is easy. Player links are added, linking to each profile, by the first update (if they’re not there to begin with).

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W-L-OT: 0-1-0 GAA: 3.91 SV%: 0.789 SO: 0

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About Prospects' Profiles

1. The number after each player name in the profile section is the ranking as of June 01, 2026. The number in brackets with 'LY' indicates the ranking in last year's Fantasy Prospect Report. Rankings are from Dobber's Fantasy Prospect Rankings. 'TY' is 'this year', 'NR' is not ranked, though he was/is drafted or signed (and thus was/is eligible), 'N/A' means the player was not drafted or signed last year and thus could not have been ranked.
2. Defensemen have their own chart on the Fantasy Prospects List. This is why there is a 'D' at the end of their ranking.
3. WJC is short form for World Junior Hockey Championships. USNTDP is an acronym for the United States National Team Development Program.
4. ELC is "entry-level contract", which is the first contract a player signs, subject to cap maximums.
5. D+1 refers to the player's season after being drafted. Similarly, D+2 is the second season afterward, and D-1 is the season prior.
5. Player comparisons are for stats only (fantasy purposes). We are not implying that the player plays like the comparable. Only that his numbers could wind up being very similar.
6. 'Upside' is traditionally high with DobberHockey. An 'Upside' is essentially 'What Could Be'. It covers off ideal scenarios (coaching, chemistry with linemates, perfect development, etc.). It is a number set at a level that they will in all likelihood not surpass. If you heard 17 years ago that Brad Marchand's upside was 55 points...well, it turns out that wasn't his upside after all, since he surpassed that by miles many, many times. An extreme example, of course. Here is a better one: Patrick Kane. In his Draft year, hockey analysts conservatively stated that he could one day tally as many as 80 points. And yet he's racked up 110! The upside we had given Kane was 100 and even *that* lofty number was surpassed. But we try our best to give an educated **best-case** scenario. With 19-year-old unproven prospects, we don't have the luxury of seeing how they do over a couple of AHL seasons and a few NHL games. Our goal is to not have our upside surpassed, yet keep it as low as possible while achieving this.
7. '3YP' is a predictive stat that was introduced with the 2010-11 Midseason Fantasy Guide. It refers to 'Three-Year Probable'. It takes a snapshot of what we believe will be the three best years of this player's NHL career going forward and takes an average of those years. Unlike upside, which is rarely adjusted, the 3YP is constantly being adjusted as we see more from the player. **The 3YP does however, assume that he will make the NHL.** If a player's 3YP is 62 points, but he never makes the show, well, that's the result of unlucky breaks, or not performing when his next big opportunity called for it. In the case of a prospect, if his 3YP is a low number, then he will probably be a depth player if/when he makes the NHL.
8. **Note about goalies:** The expected arrival for goalies is the season we expect them to stick in the NHL in a backup capacity. Add two-to-three more seasons to this timeline to come up with their fantasy-worthy season in which they possibly become actual starters. Other than Carey Price, Andrei Vasilevskiy—and now we can add Dustin Wolf, no goalie in the last three decades has given a fantasy-worthy season prior to turning 24...and those three were 23. So, **24 is the age for great goalies** to step in and help your fantasy squad; and **25 or 26 is the age for 'average' goalies** to do the same. Only the elite will help by age 23. Adjust your expectations accordingly.

About DobberHockey Draft Advice

We base this advice on points-heavy dynasty leagues (keep all players) with 12 to 15 teams and 25 to 35 players per team as they head into their annual re-entry Draft (a Draft that is anywhere from three to five rounds). Generally, teams in these leagues carry four to eight prospects, with competitive teams likely with fewer, and rebuilding teams likely with more. All leagues are different, but this should cover most of the keeper league scenarios as a decent guide.

If your league is deeper, then you'll want to 'bump up' our suggested draft-round advice.

We tried to stick to a few different suggestions for you. They are:

1. Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP..

Self-explanatory. Even shallow leagues will want/need these guys.

2. Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.

This player should be drafted early, but don't sell your first-born son to do it. Many shallow leagues will want to consider these players too.

3. Middle-round option.

You can draft this player in a middle round and it should work out for you. He may even slip later.

4. Final-round option.

Same as above, but you could get him later. You'll either have to sit on him for a year or two, or he won't blow out the doors with his production early on.

5. Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling).

This option is to let you know that he could make the team this year and post 30 to 50 points over the next several years. But he either has low upside, or he won't hit any kind of decent upside for a long time.

6. Potential star, draft in late rounds (if you can afford to wait a few years).

This prospect could potentially become an early-round pick in your league next summer, so if you have the room you may want to scoop him up now and sit on him. Those in deeper leagues then described above should probably draft him. Like drafting Kirill Kaprizov when he was drafted – you sat on him for five years, but it was so worth it. But what if he never came over or was a bust?

7. Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.

He's not elite enough to draft and sit on, or you'd have to sit on him for a few years. Best to wait unless your farm system is very deep. This does not mean that next year you would for sure draft him. It means wait a year and see a little bit more from him. This designation could also imply that we'd just like to see another year out of him and see how he progresses.

8. Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.

Far too long of a wait to consider drafting in your league.

9. Do not draft.

If you're in a deeper league, it's your call. But in the league described above, you are best not to draft these players.

Note on Goaltenders: *It is our experience that most goalies do not become fantasy assets until they are 25, 26 or even 27. The top ones might do it at 24, and the rare Carey Price types might be 20. But the range you are looking at will likely be their mid-20s. That being said, because the position is so sparse, fantasy owners generally need to grab them a little early and sit on him. We factor all of this in.*

Note Draft Advice: *We comment on drafting for points-only leagues, but occasionally we'll comment on a player if he is particularly useful for Hits and PIM*

Note on Expected Arrival: *This is the date when he should be ready and given a chance. However, if the prospect is in another league and chooses not to come...or, he is beaten out of a roster spot and never makes the jump, then obviously his arrival date is 'never'.*



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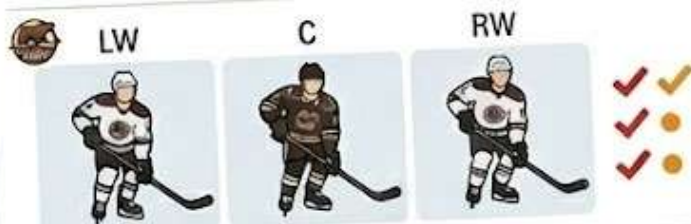
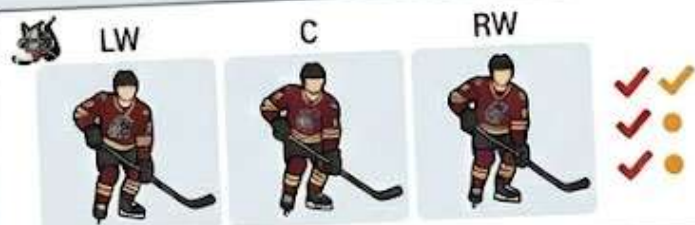
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Anaheim DUCKS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Roger McQueen
 Boom / Bust potential: Sasha Pastujov
 Long-term project: Emile Guite
 Top sniper: Maxim Masse
 Best setup man: Roger McQueen

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Roger McQueen
 Defense: Tarin Smith
 Goal: Damien Clara
 Points only: Roger McQueen
 Multicategory: Lasse Boelius

2026 Draftees: Rian Chudzinski, Eric Frossard, Nikita Klepov, Noah Kosick, Jayden Kurtz, Marcus Nordmark, Gleb Peshkov, Mathis Preston, Jimmy Rieber

by Dobber



Roger McQueen, C

(2026: 18) (2025: N/A)

Last year's 10th-overall pick is a high-upside player, but at 6-5 and 197 pounds, he is still acclimating to his big body as he approaches age 20 (in October). While this may not be a full Tage Thompson situation—where it took six years after being drafted before he became a fantasy asset—the prevailing thought is that it will be fairly close. McQueen moved from the WHL last season to the NCAA, in part because another year in the WHL at his size would have been child's play. With Providence, he started slowly (four points in eight games), finished slowly (four in 11), but in between he was a force (19 in 18) and won Hockey East's Rookie of the Year. He signed his pro contract with Anaheim and had modest results in seven games with San Diego (AHL). He plays a more physical game than Thompson, and he'll probably be in the NHL in a couple of years, but as with Thompson, the points may take a couple more years beyond that.

Upside Comparable: Tage Thompson (35-50-85, 80 PIM)

3YP: 30-40-70, 68 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 95%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Maxim Masse, RW

(2026: 67) (2025: 172)

Masse plays a solid two-way game, and at the junior level has been a prolific scorer, winning the Mike Bossy Trophy for Best Pro Prospect in 2025 and the QMJHL MVP in 2025–26. He has also won gold for Team Canada twice. He led the QMJHL with 102 points, 16 power-play goals, and a plus-62 rating. Yet he finds his name rather low on many prospect lists, even getting drafted in the third round despite proven offense, good size (6-3, 198 pounds), and strong two-way play. This is due to his lack of footspeed and the belief that his tools won't translate to pro hockey. He has committed to the University of Massachusetts for the fall—likely a one-year stint before moving to the AHL—and that should be a great stepping stone for easing into pro hockey.

Upside Comparable: Alex Tuch (40-35-75+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 25-20-45+, 38 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Lucas Pettersson, C

(2026: 118) (2025: 247)

Anaheim's second-round pick in 2024 (35th overall) is blessed with excellent speed and solid two-way upside. He was a key part of Team Sweden's silver medal at the WJC (six points in six games) and has already played a season and a half against men in Sweden's top league (SHL). He has added fifteen pounds of muscle over the past year but is still on the smaller side at 5-11 and 183 pounds. At least now he can hold his own physically. That being said, although he recorded 18 PIM in 21 international games last year, banger-league owners shouldn't expect much in that department—he had zero PIM in the SHL last season. He signed his pro contract a year ago, so when his SHL season ended he came over and joined San Diego, seeing some time with fellow prospect Roger McQueen. Given the higher-end offensive options in Anaheim and those coming up through the system, Pettersson seems destined for a third-line role.

Upside Comparable: Alexander Wennberg (20-45-65+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 10-30-40, 12 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Sasha Pastujov, LW

(2026: 130) (2025: 128)

Since his 12-game ECHL demotion in 2024, Pastujov has returned to lead the AHL San Diego Gulls in points per game (45 in 43) in 2024–25 and then led them in scoring in 2025–26 (57 in 71), playing mainly with journeyman Justin Bailey and prospect Jan Mysak. An early third-round pick in 2021 (66th overall), there has never been any question about his offense. It's his consistency and compete level that come into question, and he also doesn't offer much in terms of size (6-0, 186 pounds). He'll be 23 in July and is no longer waivers-exempt as of this season. That, combined with a good camp, may be enough to get him a shot at an NHL spot early on, but too many high-end Ducks prospects have passed him on the path to the top six. He doesn't have the tools for a checking role, so he needs to go above and beyond in whatever opportunity he's given.

Upside Comparable: Victor Olofsson (25-40-65+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 18-26-44, 18 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Eric Nilson, C

(2026: 153) (2025: N/A)

Nilson was drafted 45th overall last summer, but in a re-draft he would probably slide into the first round, as he has been one of the more improved drafted prospects out there. A two-way center and the son of former NHLer Marcus Nilson, he has shown reliability and strong checking at the college level thanks to a quick stick and high-end hockey sense. He's not the biggest player at 6-0 and 170 pounds, but he is adding bulk and focusing on building muscle—which is a good idea, because he plays an aggressive game that may not hold up in the NHL without it. Also worth noting: after a career spent playing in Sweden, 2025–26 was his first full season on the smaller North American rink. With his offensive teammates at Michigan State, Porter Martone and Charlie Stramel, turning pro, look for Nilson to take on more of an offensive role—including more power-play time—and his numbers as a sophomore should really pop.

Upside Comparable: Mikael Backlund (20-40-60, 60 PIM)

3YP: 18-28-46, 53 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Yegor Sidorov, LW

(2026: 158) (2025: 61)

A prolific scorer in junior hockey (posting 164 points in his last 119 games with Saskatoon), Sidorov got off to a good pro start when he recorded 34 points in 59 games as an AHL rookie. But things went sideways last season, as he slipped by five points despite playing nine more games (and was a minus-20 to boot). His shot volume declined, and he managed just six points in his final 25 games. He mostly played with AHL star Matthew Phillips, so the decline comes as a surprise. The Ducks are banking on his potential as a possible power-play specialist, but his late-season struggles resulted in reduced PP minutes—or perhaps the reduced minutes led to the struggles. Regardless, Sidorov's standing in the organizational depth chart remains high, but his hold on that spot is becoming tenuous. Now 22, he still has another year or two to figure things out at the AHL level.

Upside Comparable: Andrew Mangiapane (30-30-60+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 15-20-35, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Austin Burnevik, RW

(2026: 164) (2025: 360)

A big tree of a forward, Burnevik is a bit of a late bloomer, as is often the case with bigger players. Drafted late in the 2024 Draft (sixth round, 182nd overall), the Minneapolis native stayed local, attending St. Cloud State. In his sophomore season, he led the team with 20 goals in 36 games, kicking off the year with a nine-game point streak, usually playing alongside Calgary prospect Tyson Gross (who later turned pro). Burnevik is 6-4 and 205 pounds, but doesn't play like it. He also has subpar skating. He's working hard on the latter, and with his size and on-ice intelligence, he could absolutely carve out an NHL career as a complementary second-line winger. He announced in April that he is transferring to the University of Minnesota, where his St. Cloud Coach Brett Larson will also be moving. If he lines up alongside Buffalo prospect Brodie Ziemer, you could see a big production bump from both players.

Upside Comparable: Valeri Nichushkin (30-35-65+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 15-20-35, 16 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Nikita Nesterenko, C/LW

(2026: 180) (2025: 179)

The Ducks coveted Nesterenko when he was in college, acquiring him in the John Klingberg deal with Minnesota. They gave him an NHL look several weeks later, and he has seen time with the big club in each season since, including breaking camp with them in October. He is being used in more of a checking capacity, and he has struggled in that role at this level while playing in the bottom six. But he has definitely made strides, showing significant improvement in his 5-on-5 xG% and even earning some penalty-killing time. His production has been what you'd expect from a prospect in the

bottom six (nine points in 29 games), and he has added bulk. He needs to assert himself more physically, and offensively his upside is capped—especially given how he is being groomed.

Upside Comparable: Ilya Mikheyev (15-35-50+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 10-25-35, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Nathan Gaucher, C

(2026: 213) (2025: 118)

Gaucher was the 22nd-overall pick in 2022, with a proven track record as a winner, including two WJC gold medals, a QMJHL Championship, and a Memorial Cup. As we see with many players of his size (6-3, 226 pounds), Gaucher is taking time to come into his own. His upside has never been top-six caliber, but he's looking more and more like a player who will add value in the bottom six. Banger leagues will appreciate the potential for 200+ Hits and 90+ PIM to go along with his modest point totals. He had a brief three-game stint with the club in early April but struggled to handle the speed of the NHL. Prior to the recall, he had a hot run of seven points in three AHL games. The 22-year-old is exempt from waivers this season, so the team will use that flexibility to give him more seasoning. In a best-case scenario, he could become a coveted piece on the third line of a Cup-contending team.

Upside Comparable: Adam Lowry (20-40-60+, 90+ PIM)

3YP: 10-35-45, 86 PIM, 200 Hits

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits).



Emile Guite, LW

(2026: 219) (2025: N/A)

A fifth-round pick last summer (159th overall), Guite exploded for 65 points in 59 games for Chicoutimi of the QMJHL, marking an increase of more than double his total from the year prior. However, he benefited from playing alongside scoring leader (and fellow Ducks prospect) Maxim Masse. This was also the case in 2023–24, when he again played with Masse. It was his decline in 2024–25 (dropping from 57 to 30 points), mostly without Masse on his line, that raises questions about just how much of a passenger he truly is. Though when Masse was out of the lineup due to injury last season, Guite posted four points in four games. That being said, Guite has shown that at the junior level he is capable of keeping up with top talent. How much of an increase he posts in 2026–27—after Masse turns pro—will give us a better indication of where things stand.

Upside Comparable: Mathieu Joseph (30-35-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 20-21-41, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Tarin Smith, LD

(2026: 28D) (2025: 60D)

The offensive rearguard has really rounded out his game over the past two seasons with Everett in the WHL. Last season, he served as team captain, providing leadership while honing his defensive

play and simultaneously boosting his offensive production to 71 points in 65 games. His plus-65 rating led the entire WHL. At 6-2 and 190 pounds, he plays a gritty, aggressive game that looks bigger than his size and offers tremendous multi-cat potential. Still, keep in mind that he accomplished all of this as a 19-year-old playing in a league with younger teenagers. The AHL will be the true test. Because the Ducks already have plenty of left-shot defensemen on the roster, Smith will have several years to marinate. He also became Everett's all-time points leader among defensemen with 176.

Upside Comparable: Darnell Nurse (10-45-55, 80+ PIM)

3YP: 5-31-36, 62 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Tristan Luneau, RD

(2026: 44D) (2025: 18D)

After missing much of 2023-24 and a large portion of 2024-25 with a knee infection, it was nice to see Luneau put in a full, healthy year. His development had stalled, and questions arose about his fit as a potential top-four NHLer, even though he actually led San Diego in scoring in 2024-25. His production declined last season, but his shot volume increased, and he continued to showcase his high-end puck-moving ability. He was called up to the big club at the end of the season and scored. He remains exempt from waivers this season, and it is likely he will spend one more year in the AHL. But he's a right-shot defenseman in an organization that needs him, so do not be surprised if he logs several recalls and exceeds 20 NHL games. He's close.

Upside Comparable: Justin Faulk (10-35-45+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 5-25-30, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Lasse Boelius, LD

(2026: 55D) (2025: N/A)

The two-way defender out of Finland was drafted 60th overall last summer. He boasts tremendous skating, which allows him to cheat a little on offense. He broke into the pro circuit (Liiga) full-time last season despite being just 18 years old. There, he saw limited minutes on the bottom pairing and limited power-play time. Despite that, he managed eight points in 40 games and held his own defensively. It will be a long wait for Boelius, made longer by the fact that the Ducks already have a ton of depth on the left side. The plan is for him to remain in Europe for another couple of seasons, but it will be good to see him get more ice time and responsibility with his Liiga team, Assat.

Upside Comparable: K'Andre Miller (10-35-45+, 100 PIM)

3YP: 5-25-30, 80 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Stian Solberg, LD

(2026: 115D) (2025: 85D)

One of Anaheim's first-round picks in 2024, Solberg was drafted 23rd overall for his aggressive, gritty defensive play. He has already shown that he will rack up banger-league numbers with his

transition to the AHL last season, putting up more than 100 penalty minutes. He's 6-2 and 207 pounds, but he plays like he's 6-5 and 250. Always ready with a sneaky jab of the stick, he looks like a surefire addition to the NHL roster within two years. He offers a playoff brand of hockey, and he even surprised a bit with some offense in his AHL rookie campaign (24 points in 71 games). With the big club, expect the Hits, blocked shots, and PIM to pile up while he likely posts 20–30 points with some upside.

Upside Comparable: Nikita Zadorov (10-30-40, 100 PIM)

3YP: 5-25-30, 85 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 95%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits).



Damien Clara, G

Clara jumped onto fantasy owners' radar with his performance in the Olympic Games for Team Italy. The team, of course, lost every game, but the way Clara stood up to the sheer volume of shots and still posted a 0.911 SV% caught everyone's attention. Drafted 60th overall in 2023, Clara was the fifth goaltender selected in that draft. At 6-6, he has the coveted size NHL GMs crave. Olympics aside, he has yet to truly find his game at the pro level, struggling with Brynas in the SHL and finishing the season in San Diego by allowing 12 goals on 79 shots. With Lukas Dostal locked in for another four years, Clara will have plenty of time to reach his potential.

Upside: NHL starter

3YP: 28-20-5, 3.00 GAA, 0.903 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Calle Clang, G

As with many prospect goaltenders, Clang experienced his share of struggles in his first couple of AHL seasons. He has made strides, though he has been helped by the team around him getting stronger. His waiver exemption expires heading into training camp, but that won't be a deterrent to sending him down, as many goalies—including better prospects—are likely to hit waivers as well. The 24-year-old is now entering that three-year window in which many prospects break through and show NHL readiness. The 6-2, 192-pound Swede made the AHL All-Star Game, but he will need to show consistency all season long—down the stretch he allowed four or more goals in five of his last nine starts. He has yet to play 37 games in a season as a pro, making it fairly clear that a future as a starter is unlikely.

Upside: NHL backup

3YP: 8-9-3, 3.19 GAA, 0.895 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.

Boston BRUINS

At a Glance

Top prospect: James Hagens
 Boom / Bust potential: Cooper Simpson
 Long-term project: Beckett Hendrickson
 Top sniper: Dean Letourneau
 Best setup man: James Hagens

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: James Hagens
 Defense: Frederic Brunet
 Goal: Michael DiPietro
 Points only: James Hagens
 Multicategory: Dean Letourneau

2026 Draftees: Nils Bartholdsson, Roberto Henriquez, Yuri Ivanov, Matvei Kotkov, Cullen McCrate, Oscar Olsson, Jacob Vandeven

by Ioan Gheordanescu



James Hagens, C

(2026: 3) (2025: N/A)



The Bruins chose local talent with their seventh overall pick in 2025, selecting Boston College NCAA center and formerly projected first-overall pick Hagens. In time, Hagens may prove to have fallen too far in his draft year. Prior to the start of training camp, he stated on the record that he wanted to prove his doubters wrong. He was not mincing words—Hagens recorded 47 points in 34 games in his second and final year with Boston College, added four points in six games with Providence, and played his first five games for the NHL Bruins across the regular season and playoffs. After performing very well at the WJC (twice), he was a fourth-line winger for Team USA at the 2026 World Championship (one point in six games). With a play style similar to Jack Hughes and a developing 200-foot game, Hagens may end up a Calder Trophy nominee and a future NHL All-Star.

Upside Comparable: Jack Hughes (30-60-90, 60 PIM)

3YP: 22-43-65+, 34 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 95%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP.



Dean Letourneau, C

(2026: 22) (2025: 409)

Shades of Tage Thompson appeared for Bruins fans catching games and highlights of the towering 6-7 Letourneau in 2025–26. What felt like a bust for many fantasy managers in 2024–25 quickly turned into excitement as Letourneau made up for lost time, scoring 22 goals and 17 assists over 39 games with Boston College. As he gets stronger and has another offseason to refine his skating and puckhandling, we could see Letourneau deliver a dominant performance in the NCAA in 2026–27. Given the offensive progression now trending in the direction that made him the 25th overall pick in 2024, Letourneau is starting to look like a future top-six weapon in the NHL with legitimate PP1 potential. Watch out if he starts using his large frame to dish out more Hits in the NCAA, because if he does, he'll be a multi-cat stud you simply cannot ignore.

Upside Comparable: Tage Thompson (40-40-80+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 31-29-60+, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 85%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28, but may play the final few games this season after his college year.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Fabian Lysell, RW

(2026: 99) (2025: 41)

Now with COL

Once again, Lysell could not crack the Bruins' opening-night roster and did not appear in a single NHL game in 2025–26. He did show consistency in his defensive habits and steady offensive contributions with AHL Providence, recording 42 points in 57 games, but he played only one playoff game and did not register a point. Another unfortunate consistency for Lysell is injuries holding him back, as he appeared in just 79% of Providence's games for the second time in three seasons. He has the skating ability and puckhandling skills to make an impact in the NHL, but at his current development rate within the Bruins' system, he may be better suited for a change of scenery to get a real opportunity at the next level. If he does not crack Boston's lineup in the fall, he will likely become a trade candidate during the season. Or another possibility—since he's no longer waivers-exempt, getting claimed by another team.

Upside Comparable: Kevin Fiala (25-35-60+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 13-27-40+, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Matthew Poitras, C

(2026: 102) (2025: Grad)

After surprisingly making the Bruins' opening night lineup in 2023–24, Poitras has spent the majority of his professional career in the AHL with Providence. Still only 22, Poitras has a realistic floor as a future third-line center, and he may eventually find his scoring touch once he gets stronger and can better hold his own against NHL defensemen. While he has registered only 26 points over 66 NHL games, his AHL numbers are more encouraging, with 13 goals and 31 assists over 69 games in 2025–26 and 41 points in 40 games the year prior. Injuries, including shoulder surgery, have impacted his development as a pro. A smart two-way center, he will once again make a strong push in camp, and this time should make it—especially now has to clear waivers to be sent down.

Upside Comparable: Anthony Cirelli (20-40-60+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 13-28-41+, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling).



William Zellers, LW

(2026: 106) (2025: 239)

Zellers is making the Boston Bruins organization look like bandits. In a March 2025 trade that sent Coyle and a 2026 fifth-round selection to Colorado for Casey Mittelstadt, Zellers, and a second-round pick, few would have guessed the Bruins were acquiring a potential star in Zellers. After putting up 44 goals and 27 assists in 52 USHL games in 2024–25, any doubts about Zellers' ability to translate that offense against stronger competition quickly faded. He made an immediate impact with North Dakota in the NCAA, scoring 18 goals and 16 assists over 38 games, and he was the top point-scorer for Team USA at the World Juniors with five goals and three assists in five games. Zellers clearly has a knack for scoring goals, and his work ethic will earn him ample opportunities from NHL coaches to shine in offensive situations.

Upside Comparable: Bobby Brink (30-40-70+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 23-27-50, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Dans Locmelis, C

(2026: 115) (2025: 144)

Locmelis came back to earth in 2025–26 with the Providence Bruins, registering 15 goals and 13 assists in 43 games before his season ended due to shoulder surgery. This followed an end-of-season run in 2024–25 in which he recorded 12 points in six games after signing with the Bruins out of the NCAA. Though a two-points-per-game pace was clearly unsustainable for Locmelis—who plays a 200-foot game and even earned praise from Sidney Crosby during the 2025 World Cup of Hockey for his performance with Latvia—averaging 0.65 points per game in his first AHL season was a great accomplishment. Assuming full health when training camp rolls around, expect Locmelis to make a strong case for a bottom-six role with Boston, but ultimately start in the minors and be one of the first call-ups in 2027–28.

Upside Comparable: Mikael Backlund (25-35-60+, 16 PIM)

3YP: 14-26-40+, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 90%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



William Moore, C

(2026: 143) (2025: N/A)

Drafted 51st overall in 2025, Moore had a lackluster offensive showing with Boston College in 2025–26 while playing down the depth chart behind James Hagens and Dean Letourneau. His four goals and six assists in 33 games clearly left something to be desired—though it should not worry Bruins fans, considering his success internationally with Team USA in both the U17 and U18 tournaments, where he averaged 1.64 points per game across both events and led the team in scoring each year. The more meaningful test will come in 2026–27 as he gets an opportunity to move up the depth chart with the Eagles, showcase his 200-foot game in a larger role, and improve his offensive output. He likely needs two more seasons in the NCAA before turning pro, and the realistic expectation is that he delivers a point-per-game campaign in his final year of college hockey before transitioning to the Bruins as a bottom-six option as early as 2028–29.

Upside Comparable: Brock Nelson (30-40-70+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 21-23-44, 8 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Cooper Simpson, LW

(2026: 163) (2025: N/A)

The Bruins' amateur scouting staff likely sport wide grins whenever Simpson's name is brought up, as they plucked some of the best hands and sniping ability in the 2025 NHL Draft class at 79th overall. Cooper scored 34 goals and 40 assists for Youngstown of the USHL in 2025–26, the second-highest point total in the entire league—outperforming mostly older players. He will be joining North Dakota (NCAA) for the 2026–27 campaign, a program that has been churning out plenty of NHL talent in recent years. As Cooper will likely get opportunities to play regularly with Cole Reschny (CGY), don't be surprised to see him transition his point-per-game pace to the NCAA—at which point he will become a household name in hockey prospect circles as a potential star.

Upside Comparable: Lawson Crouse (35-30-65+, 70 PIM)
3YP: 20-15-35+, 50 PIM
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%
Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.
DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Christopher Pelosi, C

(2026: 210) (2025: 353)

Quinnipiac University continues to churn out NHL players, and Pelosi is very likely to be another pro emerging from their system over the next couple of years. In his second NCAA campaign, his production improved to 18 goals and 16 assists in 35 games. What you'll commonly see from Pelosi is an aggressive forechecker who retrieves pucks for his team, then parks himself in front of the net and buries goals. He has a floor as a bottom-six NHL grinder with middle-six upside and the potential to serve as a net-front presence on the second power play. He could eventually complement playmakers like Poitras and Hagens in the Bruins system. Should he develop chemistry with Hagens—watch out. That's what it would take for him to fully realize his upside.

Upside Comparable: Alex Killorn (25-35-60+, 60 PIM)
3YP: 19-15-34+, 18 PIM
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%
Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.
DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Beckett Hendrickson, C

(2026: 419) (2025: 302)

It was another underwhelming NCAA year for Hendrickson in 2025-26, as he registered only seven goals and 13 assists for 20 points in 36 games with the Minnesota Golden Gophers. Although the team underperformed as a whole due to the departure of talents such as Jimmy Snuggerud (STL), Matthew Wood (NSH), and Oliver Moore (CHI), that turnover presented an opportunity for Hendrickson to step into a more prominent offensive role. Clearly, that was not the case, and newcomers such as Javon Moore (OTT) and L.J. Mooney (MTL) seized that opportunity instead. Despite being considered by some as a 'coach's dream' due to his work ethic and attention to detail off the puck, Hendrickson won't make the NHL as a top sixer, and he likely tops out as a middle-six forward for Providence if he remains in the Bruins system long term.

Upside Comparable: Alex Wennberg (20-35-55+, 50 PIM)
3YP: 8-15-23+, 24 PIM
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%
Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.
DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Frederic Brunet, LD

(2026: 45D) (2025: 80D)

Brunet had another strong season with Providence in 2025-26, improving offensively with 12 goals and 24 assists in 65 games. He continued to progress defensively, too, posting a plus-18 rating, which should translate well to NHL coaches trusting him in a bottom-four role as early as 2026-27. His continued offensive growth is also generating interest as a sleeper pick in dynasty leagues, as he can contribute in multi-cat formats with more than just Hits and blocks. He led Providence defensemen in points during the regular season and remains a focal point of their offense in the AHL playoffs, recording two assists in four games. No longer exempt from waivers, it will be interesting to see if the Bruins graduate him full-time into their lineup, or risk losing him.

Upside Comparable: Jake Muzzin (10-30-40+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 7-21-28+, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 90%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Michael DiPietro, G

DiPietro earned a two-year, two-way contract with the Bruins before the 2025-26 season and rewarded the organization with an outstanding 34-8-1 record through 45 games for Providence, posting three shutouts along with a stellar 1.91 GAA and 0.930 SV%. He carried that success into the AHL playoffs with a 1.96 GAA and 0.931 SV%, but his team couldn't provide enough goal support to help him win their only playoff round. He has been a model of consistency over the last two campaigns, and unless Boston moves on from Joonas Korpisalo as Jeremy Swayman's backup, DiPietro is likely to remain a star in the AHL in 2026-27. He could also become a trade chip for a team looking to give him an NHL opportunity, which could make him a sneaky waiver-wire pickup.

Upside: NHL starter

3YP: 21-16-4, 2.64, 0.901 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 40%, 55%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.

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Frozen Tools

Buffalo SABRES

At a Glance

Top prospect: Konsta Helenius
 Boom / Bust potential: Melvin Novotny
 Long-term project: Melvin Novotny
 Top sniper: Konsta Helenius
 Best setup man: Konsta Helenius

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Konsta Helenius
 Defense: Radim Mrtka
 Goal: Devon Levi
 Points only: Konsta Helenius
 Multicategory: Stiven Sardarian

2026 Draftees: Dylan Dumont (F), Domán Kristóf Szongoth, Ilia Morozov (F), Olivers Murnieks (F),
Daxon Rudolph (D)

by Dobber



Konsta Helenius, C
 (2026: 6) (2025: 36)



It's hard not to get excited about Helenius' progress over the past year. Savvy fantasy owners would have known that his less-than-impressive production in 2024–25 was nothing more than an opportunity to swoop in and buy low. He was 18 and playing in a pro league (the AHL) against men—his 35 points in 65 games was actually fantastic. At 19, he tied for ninth in AHL scoring. Drafted 14th overall in 2024, Helenius boasts elite hockey sense, plays hard, and made it difficult for Buffalo to send him back down during his call-ups (four points in nine games). He will almost certainly make the team this year—if not out of camp, then shortly after—and he has superstar potential. Look for Helenius to be a top-five Calder Trophy candidate this season.

Upside Comparable: Sebastian Aho (30-55-85+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 25-43-68, 34 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 95%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP..



Brodie Ziemer, RW
 (2026: 82) (2025: 196)

A third-round pick in 2024 (71st overall), Ziemer has seen his stock rise steadily, from his World Junior success (a point per game in 2025 and Team Captain in 2026 with six points in five games) to his NCAA emergence. He finished with 36 points in 36 games for the University of Minnesota and tied for seventh in the nation with 23 goals. He has announced that he will return to college again this season, where he has been named team captain. What he lacks in size (5-11, 195) and defensive acumen, he makes up for with leadership, versatility, and a shoot-first instinct. Another season in college will help him round out his game, and we could see him post gaudy numbers and potentially lead the nation in goals. He is a winner (WJC Gold in 2025) and a natural leader.

Upside Comparable: Josh Doan (30-35-65+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 23-25-48, 38 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 75%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Anton Wahlberg, C

(2026: 97) (2025: 289)

Now with ANA

The power forward, drafted high (39th overall) in 2023, is knocking on the door. At 6-4 and 205 pounds, the points may take a while to come, as big men generally take extra time to develop. But Wahlberg offers a physical presence to a team that loves its big-sized players, and his game is steadily improving. By the numbers, his points-per-game rate, shot volume, and banger metrics have all increased over last season. He was also recalled in February, but only as an injury precaution, so he was unable to get into the lineup. Still exempt from waivers, we'll likely have to wait another year for him. The 21-year-old (as of July) will spend several years apprenticing on a checking line when he does make the jump—a timeline not unlike that of his comparable, Mikael Backlund. When he reaches his prime in his late 20s, expect a limited ceiling but a very high floor.

Upside Comparable: Mikael Backlund (30-35-65, 40 PIM)

3YP: 18-30-48, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Prokhor Poltapov, RW

(2026: 134) (2025: 169)

Poltapov broke through in the KHL in 2024–25 when he posted 40 points in 68 games, tripling his numbers from the year prior. But 2025–26 got off to a slow start, with just 12 points in his first 25 games. Fortunately, things turned around, and he produced 28 points in the following 43 games. Drafted quite high (33rd overall in 2021), the Sabres have been patient with his development. His KHL contract expires at the end of this season, so he is at least a year away. Now 23, he should be very close to NHL-ready when he crosses the pond. He is likely earmarked for a third-line role, but there is some upside. He is a key cog in the top six of a deep Moscow team that includes several former NHLers as well as a couple of future ones. A big 2026–27 season would make Poltapov a coveted name in fantasy circles as the hype builds for the following year.

Upside Comparable: Vincent Trocheck (30-35-65, 60 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Stiven Sardarian, RW

(2026: 172) (2025: 157)

The Russian-born forward broke out as a junior at Michigan Tech when he posted a point-per-game season. He followed that up with an explosive senior year, tallying 44 points in 37 contests, leading his team in scoring and finishing 13th in the nation. He was named CCHA Forward of the Year and earned a spot on the CCHA First All-Star Team. Now 23, he must decide whether to sign with the team that drafted him (and face a tougher path to breaking through) or sign elsewhere as a UFA in August. As strong as his numbers were, he doesn't quite have the clout you sometimes see from top college UFA (remember the scramble to sign Jimmy Vesey?). If and when he reaches the NHL, his potential is that of a middle-six forward with decent banger stats.

Upside Comparable: Michael Bunting (25-40-65, 80 PIM)

3YP: 11-25-36, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 65%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Melvin Novotny, LW

(2026: 236) (2025: N/A)

The Sabres took a flier on Novotny late in last summer's draft (seventh round, 195th overall). He boasts a projectable frame (6-2, 185) and has high-end hockey sense. After growing up in Sweden, he just completed his first season in North America, playing in the USHL and finishing in the top 20 in scoring with 57 points in 48 games, which ranked as the fourth-highest points-per-game average. He has committed to play for the University of Massachusetts this season, where he'll join Anaheim prospect and QMJHL scoring leader Maxim Masse. If they end up playing together, the potential for impressive numbers is there, putting both of them on the fantasy radar (if they're not there yet).

Upside Comparable: Pavel Buchnevich (30-35-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 25 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Radim Mrtka, RD

(2026: 12D) (2025: N/A)

The huge right-shot defenseman from Czechia nearly made the Sabres out of camp at 18. At 6-6 and 218 pounds, he already plays with poise and two-way acumen, which is why he was drafted ninth overall last summer. An untimely illness hurt the end of his camp, resulting in a slow start to his AHL season. He played four games there before moving back to the WHL, where he matched his point total from the previous season with 34 points in 43 games, and then returned to the AHL for another four outings. He injured his shoulder in the first period of Czechia's first pre-WJC exhibition game but still managed to appear in five games at the end. He brings a tough, hard-hitting approach alongside smart decision-making. As with Zdeno Chara years ago, the tools are there for Mrtka to eventually find his offense. Chara posted six seasons of sub-40-point production before becoming a consistent 40–55-point defenseman.

Upside Comparable: Zdeno Chara (10-40-50+, 90+ PIM, 200+ Hits)

3YP: 6-37-43, 76 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 95%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Maxim Strbak, RD

(2026: 34D) (2025: 42D)

After three years of college hockey at Michigan State and two appearances at the World Juniors (a combined 13 points in 10 games), Strbak turned pro in April, signing his entry-level deal. At MSU, Strbak established himself as one of the better two-way defensive prospects in the world. He projects as an ideal second-pairing, secondary-power-play defenseman who can block shots, move the puck, and shut plays down. He got into two games with Rochester to end the season, picking up his first pro assist. At 6-2 and 200 pounds, he already boasts NHL size and shouldn't take long to acclimate to the pro game. Several cups of coffee in the year ahead are likely. Radim Mrtka's rise on the depth chart may push his NHL timeline back a couple of years.

Upside Comparable: Alec Martinez (10-40-50, 50 PIM, 150 BLKS)

3YP: 7-23-30, 38 PIM, 120 BLKS

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Luke Osburn, LD

(2026: 46D) (2025: 141D)

Osburn made a strong impression in his NCAA freshman year, but things began to go sideways at the World Juniors. He went pointless in five games for Team USA and wasn't very noticeable in what was a disappointing tournament for the Americans. Although he finished his season at Wisconsin with 21 points in 33 games, he managed just two points in his final nine. A fourth-round pick in 2024 (108th overall), Osburn was starting to look like a savvy selection for the Sabres after being named the USHL's Top Defenseman for 2024–25. But the last several months of 2025–26 have derailed his stock. With the depth Buffalo now has at the position—and more prospects on the way—Osburn will have plenty of time to develop. He has committed to returning to Wisconsin for the upcoming campaign.

Upside Comparable: Devon Toews (10-40-50+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 5-20-25, 36 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Vsevolod Komarov, RD

(2026: 85D) (2025: 58D)

The former QMJHL Defenseman of the Year—recognized primarily for his offense—is leaning more on his physical traits as a pro. At 6-4 and 211 pounds, he has the size and certainly uses it, topping a penalty minute per game in each of his first two AHL seasons. The Sabres have no shortage of size on the back end, but Komarov's toolset is exactly what the team needs. The fact that he also has a track record of moving the puck (69 points in 60 games in his final QMJHL season) only helps. A fifth-round pick in 2022 (134th overall), the Russian-born, right-shot defenseman is firmly in the mix to become an NHLer—likely on the bottom pair, but possibly in a middle-pairing role supporting one of the team's many puck-movers.

Upside Comparable: Josh Manson (5-35-40+, 120 PIM)

3YP: 5-20-25, 85 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits).



Devon Levi, G

Now with EDM

The Sabres still view Levi as a future starter but have shifted to a more patient approach. With Ukko-Pekka Luukkonen signed for three more seasons, the original plan was for Levi to serve as a backup and transition into a starting role by 2029. Whether that happens in Buffalo may depend on whether the Sabres re-sign Alex Lyon after his strong 2025-26 season. Crucially, Levi is no longer waivers-exempt and would certainly be claimed if waived. As a result, a permanent backup role or a summer trade could be on the horizon. He just completed a career-high 52-game campaign with AHL Rochester as he continues to be groomed for a starting role. Still only 24, Levi is entering the typical three-year window in which most goaltenders graduate to the NHL. This summer will be an interesting one for his fantasy owners. Though slightly undersized for a modern goalie at 6-0, he was a standout in the NCAA and remains highly effective as a pro.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 37-17-4, 2.50 GAA, 0.908 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 80%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Topias Leinonen, G

Leinonen has struggled with injuries on and off for several years, and his debut in North America saw the trend continue. He adjusted to the smaller ice surface, but lost momentum in December when he suffered a lower-body injury that sidelined him until February. When he returned, he was reassigned to the ECHL for regular playing time. He showed flashes of strong play and reminded observers of his upside. A big goalie at 6-6 and 234 pounds, he is only 22 and will definitely need more time—and a full healthy season is a must. His technical consistency remains a work in progress, as his massive frame often leads to over-commitment on lateral plays that more seasoned pros exploit. Devon Levi moving out of his way will help him get the starts he needs, but he has never played 35 games in a single season, which suggests his long-term upside may be limited to that of an NHL backup.

Upside: NHL backup

3YP: 10-8-4, 3.65 GAA, 0.890 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



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Next 3 Days

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Current Fantasy Week

Current Fantasy Week + Next

Remaining Fantasy Week

Remaining Fantasy Week + Next

Next Fantasy Weeks

Next 2 Fantasy Weeks

Full 2025-26 Preseason

2025-26 Week 1

2025-26 Week 1 Extended

Next 3 Days

Next 7 Days

Next 3 Weeks

Next Month

Next 7 Days after Friday

Next 2 Weeks after Friday

Next 3 Weeks after Friday

Home Game						Away Game									
Click on opponent's logo for Fantasy Game Preview!															
Summary						Date		Opponent Stats							
Team	GP	Home	Away	B2B	Light Day	Tue 04/25 (S)	Wed 04/26 (D)	Thu 04/27 (S)	Record	GF/G	GA/G	SF/G	PM/G		
ANA	2	1	1	0	2	CDM		COM	(567) 82-60-22	3.44	3.10	20.91	8.96		
DAL	2	1	1	0	2	MIN		DAL	(534) 66-49-42	3.27	2.58	29.13	7.93		
EDM	2	1	1	0	2	ANA		ANA	(561) 88-68-12	3.23	3.28	28.13	9.03		
MIN	2	1	1	0	2	ANA		DAL	(683) 10-40-24	3.23	2.55	25.89	8.33		
BOS	1	1	1	0	1	BUF			(585) 80-23-0	3.45	2.67	28.22	9.45		
BUF	1	1	0	0	1	BOS			(616) 45-27-10	2.87	2.67	28.47	11.78		
MTL	1	1	1	0	1			Q78	(848) 50-26-6	3.49	2.58	28.41	14.50		
PHI	1	1	0	0	1			JVT	(298) 41-25-16	3.54	2.88	27.15	7.78		
PHI	1	0	1	0	1			CHI	(588) 43-27-12	2.83	2.76	25.24	9.35		
T.B.	1	1	0	0	1			MTL	(568) 48-24-10	5.41	2.91	22.63	16.16		
UTA	1	1	1	0	1			VGK	(578) 82-36-17	3.22	2.82	26.89	7.26		
VGK	1	1	0	0	1			UTA	(561) 42-0-6	2.77	2.77	25.66	9.24		

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Skating Speed

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Name	Compare	Pos	Age	Team	GP	Top Speed	Average Speed	100+ MPH	100+ MPH/G	95
COLIN MILLER	☐	D	33.4	WPG	18	102.47	77.71	3	0.17	
TRAVIS HAMONIC	☐	D	35.6	DET	26	89.45	75.41	0	0.00	
DARREN RADDYSH	☐	D	30.1	T.B.	73	100.13	75.37	1	0.01	
LOUIS CREVIER	☐	D	24.9	CHI	78	102.83	75.16	6	0.08	
PHILIPPE MYERS	☐	D	29.2	TOR	39	99.3	74.64	0	0.00	
TYLER KLEVEN	☐	D	24.2	OTT	70	103.51	74.52	1	0.01	
NOAH JUULSEN	☐	D	29.0	PHI	52	92.13	74.36	0	0.00	
EVAN BOUCHARD	☐	D	26.5	EDM	82	98.08	74.27	0	0.00	
ALEXANDER NIKISHIN	☐	D	24.5	CAR	81	99.4	74.18	0	0.00	
JOEL EDMUNDSON	☐	D	32.8	LA	82	99.09	74.15	0	0.00	

Calgary FLAMES

At a Glance

Top prospect: Zayne Parekh
 Boom / Bust potential: Henry Mews
 Long-term project: Samuel Honzek
 Top sniper: Zayne Parekh
 Best setup man: Cole Reschny

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Cole Reschny
 Defense: Zayne Parekh
 Goal: Arseni Sergeev
 Points only: Cole Reschny
 Multicategory: Brennan Othmann

2026 Draftees: Egor Barabanov (F), Carson Carels (D), Chase Harrington (F), Jack Hextall (F), Joe Iginla (F), Simon Katolicky (F), Bode Laylin (D), Alan Shaikhislamov (F), Tobias Trejbal (G)

by Pat Quinn



Cole Reschny, C

(2026: 14) (2025: N/A)



Reschny was one of many players to transfer from the CHL to the NCAA once the opportunity became available, and while most players struggled with the transition, Reschny stepped in as one of the top playmaking forwards in the league. He registered 35 points in 36 games, with 29 of them being assists. His six goals are really the only blemish on his season, as he has been a consistent middle-tier goal scorer everywhere else. Reschny did not sign with the Flames out of the NCAA, as both the organization and his camp agreed he could benefit from another year of college action. He will use his additional NCAA time to increase his production—especially his shooting—and to add strength. He will likely get a few NHL games at the end of 2026–27.

Upside Comparable: Robert Thomas (25-60-85, 60 PIM)

3YP: 19-48-67, 38 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 95%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28, but may play the final few games this season after his college year.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP.



Cullen Potter, C/LW

(2026: 53) (2025: N/A)

After being drafted 32nd overall at the 2025 NHL Draft, Potter returned to Arizona State University and improved his offensive production. Unfortunately, he also missed half the season due to injury, appearing in just 24 games. His points-per-game rate rose from 0.63 to 1.08, making him one of 41 NCAA players to produce at over a point per game. Potter is the type of player who is solid in all game areas but does not stand out in any one particular aspect. He will likely project as a middle-six option if he reaches the NHL, though there is a chance he could become a complementary top-six player. The speedy forward works to get pucks to the net, consistently presents himself as an offensive threat, and is effective at creating turnovers.

Upside Comparable: Ryan McLeod (25-40-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 25-25-50, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 85%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Sam Honzek, LW/C

(2026: 64) (2025: 55)

Since being drafted 16th overall in 2023, Honzek has been mired in injuries and lackluster production across the CHL, AHL, international play, and the NHL. His 2025–26 season was cut short after 18 games in mid-November due to a shoulder injury, and despite the fact he underwent surgery, he was unable to return to game action—though he did resume practicing with the team late in the season. In his 18 games, he averaged 12:21 in a checking role and registered just four points, including his first NHL goal. He needs consistent playing time to develop, especially as a larger player at 6-4, if he hopes to maintain fantasy relevance. As things stand, his current trajectory suggests he may remain a bottom-six forward for most of his NHL career.

Upside Comparable: Jordan Staal (30-35-65, 30 PIM)

3YP: 18-21-39, 16 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling).



Ethan Wyttenbach, LW/RW

(2026: 69) (2025: N/A)

No drafted NHL prospect has experienced a meteoric rise quite like Wyttenbach did in 2025–26. Selected 144th overall in 2025, he jumped from the USHL to the NCAA and went on to lead the league in points (59) and points per game (1.48). He finished tied for second in goals and fourth in assists over 40 games for the Bobcats. Wyttenbach is returning to the NCAA for 2026–27 to prove his freshman season was no fluke. If he maintains this high production, the Flames have a true late-round gem. Standing 5-10 and 181 pounds, he must be battle-ready for the physical NHL game. Quinnipiac alumni Collin Graf and Sam Anas posted similar numbers, albeit when they were three years older (21 while Wyttenbach was 18).

Upside Comparable: Claude Giroux (35-40-75, 40 PIM)

3YP: 20-26-46, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Brennan Othmann, LW

(2026: 87) (2025: 33)

Othmann has seen his stock slide since being drafted 16th overall by the Rangers in 2021. Everyone who has watched him knows the production should be there, but his year-over-year AHL output and overall development disappointed the Rangers, who traded him to the Flames for prospect Jacob Battaglia. In his two games with the Flames, he produced two points, compared to just one goal in 17 games with the Rangers. With the AHL Wranglers, he recorded 0.5 points per game, slightly below his average production with the Wolf Pack. With a slew of strong young players in the Flames' system, Othmann will face less pressure to become a top producer, but competition in Calgary is fierce. He will need to show he belongs soon, or he risks being passed by other prospects. Fortunately for Othmann, he still projects as at least a bottom-six NHLer.

Upside Comparable: Dustin Brown (30-30-60+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 15-17-32, 57 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits).



Rory Kerins, LW/C

(2026: 111) (2025: 124)

Kerins is the Rodney Dangerfield of the Flames' organization—he gets no respect. Despite recording 150 points over his last three AHL seasons (173 games) with the Wranglers—including 118 points in his last 119 games—he has appeared in only nine NHL games. In those nine games, he registered four assists and did not look out of place. Kerins will be an RFA this offseason with arbitration rights, so he will likely remain in the Flames' organization unless he is not qualified, traded, or eventually claimed on waivers if re-signed. With 11 forward spots essentially locked in for Calgary in 2026–27, Kerins will face a difficult path to securing an NHL role. At 24, he needs to make his mark as soon as possible and hope the organization commits to him as well.

Upside Comparable: Matt Moulson (25-35-60+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 15-30-45, 22 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Andrew Basha, LW

(2026: 127) (2025: 205)

Basha had one of the more unusual deployments for a drafted prospect in North America. He did not make the Flames out of training camp, but he did make the AHL Wranglers' roster despite still being junior-eligible. As one of the youngest players in the AHL, he moved in and out of the Wranglers' lineup before being reassigned to the WHL in January to rejoin the Medicine Hat Tigers. He produced just five points in 27 AHL games but, to his credit, played a more physical style rather than trying to finesse his way onto the scoresheet. Back in the WHL, he posted 50 points in 32 games and added 21 points in 15 playoff games before the Tigers were eliminated in the third round. Basha should return to the AHL this season, and ideally, he will see more consistent playing time.

Upside Comparable: Clayton Keller (25-35-60+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 16-23-39, 52 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Maximillian Curran, C

(2026: 136) (2025: 420)

After being drafted 161st overall (fifth round) by Colorado in 2024, Curran exploded for 74 points in 65 WHL games for Tri-City. An offseason trade for a package of picks saw him move to the Edmonton Oil Kings. There, as a 19-year-old, he tallied 41 in 31, missing time to help Czechia's U20 team internationally, tallying 23 points in 20 contests. His rights were recently dealt to the Calgary Flames in a major deadline deal. He has committed in the fall to Univ. of Massachusetts in the NCAA, pushing his timeline back a couple of years. At 6-3, 179, he has a very lanky frame and will need to bulk up and get stronger. Developing in college should give him the optimal runway to add that necessary muscle. The new environment will do him good.

Upside Comparable: Alex Wennberg (25-40-65+, 40 PIM)
3YP: 16-23-39, 36 PIM
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%
Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.
DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Theo Stockselius, LW/C
(2026: 137) (2025: N/A)

Stockselius signed with the Flames in May 2026 to come over and play in North America after his team was eliminated from the SHL playoffs. He found himself in an odd situation in Sweden: he was too good for the under-20 leagues but struggled in the top men's league. It was as though he needed a middle ground—he recorded 16 points in 11 U20 games and just one assist in 16 SHL games, along with 20 points in 11 U20 playoff games and no points in three SHL playoff games. Coming to North America will likely mean spending time in the AHL, which will be a tough adjustment for the soon-to-be 19-year-old. What works in Stockselius's favor is his high hockey IQ and playmaking ability, though it may still take him some time to adapt to the AHL.

Upside Comparable: Kevin Hayes (25-45-70, 40 PIM)
3YP: 20-30-50, 28 PIM
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 80%
Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.
DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Aydar Suniev, LW
(2026: 139) (2025: 76)

It was an interesting campaign for Suniev in 2025–26, as he turned pro at the end of 2024–25 after leaving the NCAA and even appeared in one NHL game. He spent most of the season in the AHL, where he did not produce eye-popping numbers, finishing with 16 goals and 24 points in 57 games. A month-long injury in December didn't help matters. At the end of the season, with the Wranglers outside the playoff picture, Suniev was one of four Flames call-ups. He played six NHL games, registering just one assist while averaging 11:37 of ice time. Suniev is a shooter, but he recorded only 92 shots in the AHL, giving him a 17.4% shooting percentage. If he wants to make an impact in the NHL, Suniev will need to expand his game and become a threat in more areas.

Upside Comparable: Alex Semin (30-35-65+, 60 PIM)
3YP: 17-31-48, 36 PIM
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 85%
Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.
DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Jonathan Castagna, C
(2026: 193) (2025: 255)

Castagna turned pro and signed with the Flames at the end of March, but did not play in any AHL or NHL games to conclude the 2025–26 season. He spent three NCAA campaigns at Cornell University, with his final year putting his trajectory back on track—jumping from 15 points in 32 games to 34 points in 34 games and leading his team in both goals and points. Castagna is an all-around solid and skilled player. He was the main piece the Flames targeted in the MacKenzie Weegar trade with Utah, so the organization clearly thinks highly of him and sees him as part of its future plans.

Castagna should spend a couple of seasons in the AHL, but don't be surprised if he forces the team's hand sooner. He appears to have a high floor, which goes a long way toward securing an NHL role.

Upside Comparable: Jake DeBrusk (25-30-55+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 15-27-42, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 80%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling).



Luke Misa, C/W

(2026: 344) (2025: 372)

Drafted in 2024, Luke is the brother of top Sharks prospect Michael Misa, and the Flames hope he can eventually develop into an NHL player as well. He has the speed and puck skills to stand out in games, but he is also a smaller player who transitioned from the OHL to the NCAA and struggled to maintain his production. One positive is that moving to the NCAA gives Misa more time to develop his frame before turning pro. He went from the OHL's Brampton Steelheads, where he recorded 85 points in 67 games, to playing with top prospect Gavin McKenna at Penn State, where he registered 19 points in 37 games. He remains an intriguing long-term project who must add significant strength to his dynamic pace to project as a future top-nine NHL winger.

Upside Comparable: Tyler Ennis (25-40-65, 20 PIM)

3YP: 15-23-38, 16 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Zayne Parekh, RD

(2026: 2D) (2025: 2D)

Last season was a challenge for Parekh, as both the Flames and his camp knew he was too good to return to the OHL but not quite ready to be a full-time NHLer. He came out of the gate strong but then struggled—like the rest of the Flames—in October, and after November 7 he did not appear in another NHL game until February 2. He didn't play consistently again until the end of February. During that stretch, aside from practicing and sitting in the press box, Parekh excelled at both the World Juniors, where he recorded 13 points in seven games, and in the AHL, where he posted five points in four games. There is no doubting his offensive abilities, but what may hold him back from early fantasy stardom is coaches reining in his minutes due to his still-developing defensive play. Make no mistake, though—Parekh will put up great numbers eventually.

Upside Comparable: Evan Bouchard (20-60-80, 80 PIM)

3YP: 18-46-64, 44 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 99%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP.



Hunter Brzustewicz, RD

(2026: 16D) (2025: 24D)

Brzustewicz spent half of the 2025-26 season in the AHL and the other half in the NHL, essentially rotating two months down, two months up, one month down, and then finishing the year in the NHL.

In 34 AHL games, he recorded 13 points. At the NHL level, he registered seven points—including his first NHL goal and assist—while appearing in 34 games and averaging 16:12 of ice time. Brzustewicz was an impressive scorer in the CHL, and that offensive ability is slowly translating to the pro level. His fantasy upside may not be as high as once projected, but he looks like a solid two-way defenseman who can still produce respectable secondary power-play numbers for a late-round fantasy pick.

Upside Comparable: Devon Toews (10-40-50+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 7-32-39, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Henry Mews, RD

(2026: 24D) (2025: 61D)

There was considerable excitement surrounding Mews' jump to the NCAA in 2025–26 after another impressive OHL campaign in which he posted 82 points in 68 games, split between two teams. It marked yet another season of increased production, and he was set to play for the University of Michigan alongside several highly touted prospects. In fact, he was expected to be the team's primary threat on defense, but just 10 games into the season he suffered an injury on a dirty hit that cost him the remainder of the year. Mews had nine points in those 10 games. He will be able to attend the Flames' development camp in the offseason and plans to return to Michigan for another campaign. Mews has all the tools of a high-end scoring defenseman, but there is some risk regarding whether he can reach the NHL in that role.

Upside Comparable: Adam Fox (10-50-60+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 9-42-51, 34 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Potential star, draft in late rounds (if you can afford to wait a few years).



Etienne Morin, LD

(2026: 58D) (2025: 84D)

Traded to NJD

It was a tough first season in the AHL for the former second-round selection. After a solid four-year QMJHL career with the Moncton Wildcats, where he was heavily relied upon, he joined the Wranglers and was essentially used as an extra defenseman. Morin played just 42 games, registering seven points, while spending a significant amount of time in the press box. He also had a stint in the ECHL during the first two months, where he recorded three points in seven games. After November, Morin played more regularly but was still taken out of the lineup more often than other defensemen. The coming seasons will provide a better indication of the type of defenseman Morin can become as he adjusts to the faster, stronger pro game. He may not develop into a major scorer, but a reliable, two-way, middle-pairing defenseman is still a valuable outcome.

Upside Comparable: Brady Skjei (10-40-50, 50 PIM)

3YP: 7-25-32, 38 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Arseni Sergeev, G

Sergeev played in the ECHL, AHL, and NHL during the 2025–26 season. Despite moving between leagues, he still appeared in the most games for the Wranglers and posted the best save percentage (0.898) and goals-against average (3.35) among their goaltenders with more than seven games played. Sergeev climbed the organizational ladder quickly, starting in the ECHL, where he recorded a 6-6-0 record with a 0.922 save percentage. After being called up at the end of December, he remained in the AHL, and his strong play pushed Ivan Prosvetov into a backup role once he returned from injury. The Flames were impressed enough to give Sergeev the final NHL game of the season, in which he posted a 0.964 save percentage. Dustin Wolf is the obvious roadblock to Sergeev becoming a starter in Calgary, but if the 23-year-old continues to perform, he may earn a chance elsewhere.

Upside: NHL Starter

3YP: 31-15-8, 2.64, 0.900

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.

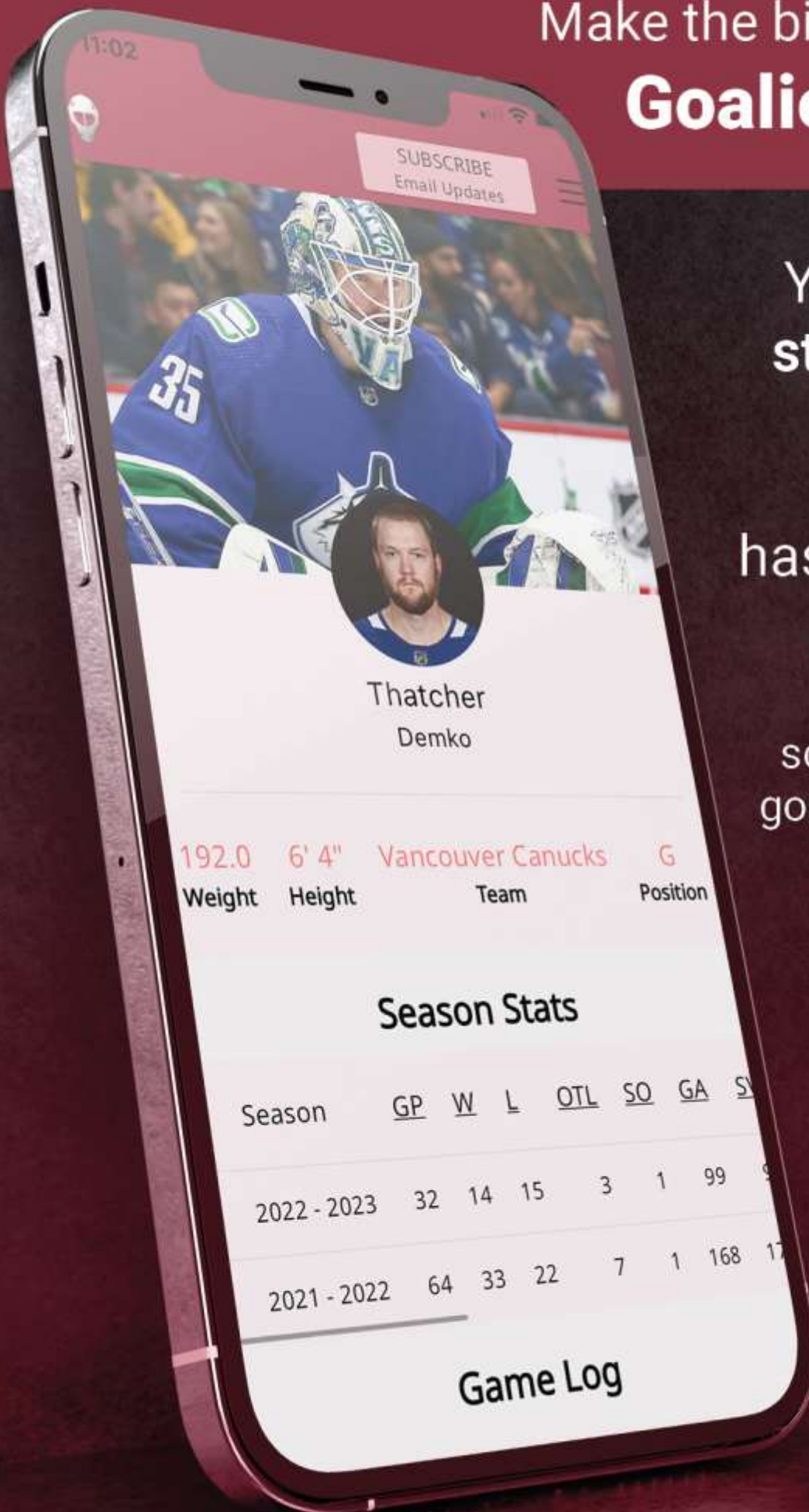
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Top prospect: Bradly Nadeau
 Boom / Bust potential: Justin Poirier
 Long-term project: Kurban Limatov
 Top sniper: Justin Poirier
 Best setup man: Felix Unger Sorum

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Bradly Nadeau
 Defense: Kurban Limatov
 Goal: Semyon Frolov
 Points only: Felix Unger Sorum
 Multicategory: Ivan Ryabkin

2026 Draftees: Mikey Berchild (F), Ryder Fetterolf (G), William Håkansson (D), Zachary Jovanovski (G), Zach Lansard (F), Wiggo Sörensson (F)

by Markus Kalmar



Bradly Nadeau, C/RW

(2026: 15) (2025: 44)

Following up on one of the best U20 AHL campaigns of this millennium is no easy task, but Nadeau has proven it was no fluke. He impressed immediately and earned a six-game call-up. Nadeau didn't manage to stick and was sent back to the Chicago Wolves, where he has continued to torment opposing goaltenders. With an elite shot, improving playmaking, and a strong knack for moving off the puck, he appears close to terrorizing NHL goalies—but some concerns remain. Nadeau's skating is still below average, which could pose problems at the NHL level. At 5-11 and 172 pounds, his physical game remains lackluster, and his defensive play is still too unreliable to earn tougher assignments. Nadeau could blossom with the right linemates, first-unit power-play time, and strong deployment. The question is whether his play will earn him those opportunities.

Upside Comparable: Seth Jarvis (35-45-80+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 25-25-50, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Felix Unger Sorum, RW

(2026: 35) (2025: 153)

Sorum needed the expected adjustment period in the AHL and has made noticeable improvements that better project his game to the NHL level. His skating still holds him back from executing some of the higher-end plays he attempts, but Sorum is smart and adapts his game to make things work. He is stronger (6-0, 190) along the boards and no longer gets overpowered by larger players. While his strength remains an issue, his year-to-year progression is clear. His growing confidence in board battles has led Sorum to play a more direct, north-south style. When given time in the offensive zone, he is an excellent facilitator, able to find lanes and involve teammates on the perimeter. Sorum's energy level is always high, but his overall impact will depend on whether he can improve his skating enough to earn the coaches' trust and secure better roles. He should eventually play on an NHL power-play unit.

Upside Comparable: Trevor Zegras (25-50-75+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 15-40-55, 25 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Ilya Ryabkin, C/LW

(2026: 55) (2025: N/A)

The most divisive player in the Hurricanes' pool, Ryabkin brings good offensive tools, with his playmaking standing out as his best skill. He is a quick passer who isn't afraid to try daring plays, though they come with a mixed success rate. A frequent shooter, Ryabkin's shot is definitely above average, and he loves to fire pucks at the net in any situation. The evolution of his game has been the prominence of his physical engagement, which includes Hits that teeter on the line of dirty and a few that definitely are dirty. Ryabkin will rack up Hits and PIM, there is no doubt there. Skating is the limiting factor that holds his game back in most areas. Both his ability to push the pace and forecheck are limited, which could prevent him from developing into a middle-six forechecker and playmaker at the NHL level, a role that otherwise suits his style.

Upside Comparable: Sam Bennett (30-50-80, 110 PIM)

3YP: 20-35-55, 67 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Nikita Artamonov, RW

(2026: 68) (2025: 70)

There were signs that Artamonov might be in for a rough campaign, but finishing with just 10 points in 58 KHL games was still surprising. The main issue was his dwindling ice time—he never eclipsed 20 minutes in a single game last season and averaged around 12. That reduction came as a consequence of his lack of progression. He remains an energy player who relies heavily on speed. KHL teams have caught on, and shutting him down has become routine, limiting his impact and leading to further cuts in his ice time. Artamonov's motor is still elite, and he darts around the ice at high speeds, getting involved wherever possible. His playmaking ability is still present, but its effectiveness has declined. The projection for Artamonov now resembles that of an energy forechecker more than the quick playmaker we saw in his draft year. He already plays a physical style, and further improvements in that area will help his long-term projectability.

Upside Comparable: Jesper Bratt (20-50-70+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 15-35-50, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Charlie Cerrato, C

(2026: 79) (2025: N/A)

Not many D+2 players get drafted, but Cerrato beat the odds, winning over scouts with his never-ending motor and relentless energy. He is a disruptor who excels in both forechecking and backchecking. Cerrato's skating appears average, but it's sufficient for his elite motor to keep him involved in every play. Not a particularly creative or deceptive player, he relies on his momentum to beat—or threaten to beat—defensemen, forcing them to surrender space that he can exploit. Primarily a playmaker, he loves to set up his teammates while still trying to create chances for himself. Because Cerrato is entering his 21-year-old campaign, his timeline is significantly accelerated compared to most players from the 2025 class. Starting this season with the AHL

Chicago Wolves, Cerrato has two or three years to refine his game as a speedy, responsible forechecker suited for a middle-six role. There is potential for Hits, faceoff wins, and PIM.

Upside Comparable: Morgan Frost (25-45-70+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 12-33-45, 60 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Justin Poirier, RW

(2026: 85) (2025: 158)

A small cannon is still a cannon, and Poirier's shot can certainly rank among the best outside the NHL. He is the biggest boom-or-bust candidate in the Hurricanes' prospect pool. The boom looks incredible, but the bust... well, he fell to the fifth round, 156th overall, for a reason. His size is a significant concern at 5-8 and 185 pounds. His skating is on the higher end of average, but at that size, "average" rarely cuts it. Aside from his size, however, there isn't much to dislike in Poirier's game. He's energetic, physical, and surprisingly strong for his frame. He knows how to use his low center of gravity to fend off much bigger players. Poirier does miss passing lanes when he fixates on the net, but with a shot that good, it's not a major flaw. He should be a trigger man on a top power-play unit. His immediate success in the NCAA gives hope that he might beat the odds.

Upside Comparable: Alex DeBrincat (50-30-80, 50 PIM)

3YP: 30-25-55, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 60%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28, but may play the final few games this season after his college year.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Justin Robidas, C

(2026: 138) (2025: 213)

Robidas would receive far more attention as a legitimate future NHLer if he stood six feet or taller; instead, at 5-8 and 176 pounds, the odds remain against him. He has the AHL game down to a tee, posting 0.8 points per game two years ago and hovering around 1.0 last season. The core of Robidas' game is his hockey sense—consistently reliable in any zone or situation. Predominantly a pass-first player, he keeps things simple, avoids overthinking, and takes what is available to keep plays moving. His defensive effort is evident, with strong stick work and an ability to get into lanes. Robidas isn't afraid to engage in battles, but there are still limitations when opponents outweigh him by several classes. Briefly called up twice, the 23-year-old will need to cement his NHL role soon or risk getting stuck as a tweener.

Upside Comparable: Mats Zuccarello (25-45-70+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 15-30-45, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Jayden Perron, RW

(2026: 261) (2025: 368)

It has been three years since Perron was drafted 94th overall, and his development since then is one of the rare cases where pre-draft expectations have aligned with reality. A supremely skilled hockey player, he blends strong skating with quick hands and an excellent ability to process the game. Pass or shoot, Perron can do both at a high level, forcing goalies to stay honest in every situation. He

projects comfortably as average or above average in every skill set except the one that holds back so many prospects: physical ability. Standing 5-9 and 174 pounds, he has always struggled with physicality, and that remains an issue in the NCAA today. That must improve—smaller players like Perron don't need to excel physically, but they do need to survive. He offers intriguing fantasy upside if he can adapt and handle the increased physicality of the AHL and NHL, but it will be a steep uphill climb.

Upside Comparable: Conor Garland (25-35-60+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 20-30-50, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Alexander Perevalov, LW

(2026: 371) (2025: 211)

There has been progression in Perevalov's game, but the question is whether it's too little, too late. At 22 years old, being a good—but not dominant—forward in the VHL who is still searching for a path into the KHL is not an ideal position. Perevalov is a playmaker at heart, and he has made efforts to become more goal-focused, driving inside to get closer to the net and attempt to beat the goalie himself. However, his effort level varies wildly from game to game, ranging from excellent to poor. Perevalov uses his strong skating and quick hands to open up plays, but he remains too reliant on those tools. He still struggles to create openings on his own, especially when defensemen can match his speed. Perevalov needs to establish himself in the KHL before he becomes relevant as an NHL option. Russian prospects often take longer to develop, but for now, he's someone to monitor rather than invest in.

Upside Comparable: Anthony Cirelli (25-35-60+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Kurbin Limatov, LD

(2026: 54D) (2025: N/A)

In a prospect pool filled with smaller players, Limatov represents the opposite, standing 6-4 and 192 pounds. He already possesses two skills that should give him a clear path to the NHL: outstanding skating and a genuine willingness to play physically. The foundation he has—and already excels at—fits perfectly with what teams look for in defense-oriented defensemen, and NHL clubs always carry a few of those. What makes him a gamble for fantasy purposes is his poor decision-making, which leads to defensive mistakes and turnovers. He plays a very simple game and does not yet use his speed to create offense often enough, earning 30 points in 46 games – but in the MHL, Russia's junior league. Limatov will need to improve his decision-making and puck skills to have any fantasy relevance outside of leagues that value Hits. There is plenty of time for him to grow his game, but until we see signs of that development, hold off.

Upside Comparable: Travis Sanheim (15-35-50, 60 PIM)

3YP: 8-20-28, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 75%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Semyon Frolov, G

Frolov is a good-sized goalie, standing 6-3 and 196 pounds. His selling point is his raw athleticism, paired with an aggressive goaltending style that allows him to cover large areas of the net while moving quickly. Like many young goalies, Frolov can be inconsistent from game to game. At his best, he tracks pucks flawlessly through screens and traffic. His aggressive style still needs refinement; as it stands, he gives up too many rebounds, and when players get in close, that aggression can burn him. Frolov had only sporadic starts last season, but he made the most of them and should get some looks in the KHL this fall. Goaltenders take the longest to develop, and their progression is rarely linear. Frolov is an upside swing who will require many years to develop, but his profile is the type that can boom in a big way.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 28-15-7, 2.65, 0.910

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 40%, 75%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Ruslan Khazheyev, G

Playing for an absolutely atrocious Greensboro Gargoyles team in the ECHL has not made anything easy for Khazheyev. The flashes of athletic upside he was drafted for are still present, but so are the flaws. The environment he plays in has not helped his confidence, and he continues to struggle with tracking and blocker-side saves. Standing 6-4 and 201 pounds, he covers a lot of net, but once the puck is moved laterally, Khazheyev has trouble moving with it. His previous year in the ECHL was better than it appears on paper, and the next step is cracking the AHL roster and proving himself there. Goaltenders can develop very unpredictably, and Khazheyev is still just 21 years old; however, there are better bets in the Hurricanes' system.

Upside: NHL starter

3YP: 19-16-8, 2.98, 0.905

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



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Chicago BLACKHAWKS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Anton Frondell
 Boom / Bust potential: Nick Lardis
 Long-term project: Mason West
 Top sniper: Roman Kantserov
 Best setup man: Anton Frondell

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Roman Kantserov
 Defense: Sam Rinzel
 Goal: Adam Gajan
 Points only: Roman Kantserov
 Multicategory: Ethan Del Mastro

2026 Draftees: Samu Alalauri (D), Alexander Ivanov (D), Ryan Roobroeck (F), William Sörbrand (F),
Xavier Villeneuve (D)

by Dobber



Anton Frondell, C/LW

(2026: 4) (2025: N/A)



Last summer's third-overall pick was a high-upside wild card whom scouts ranked anywhere from third to 10th. He had missed part of the first half with an injury and then needed a few games to get going in Sweden's second league (Allsvenskan). The gamble paid off, as Frondell scored 20 goals in 43 games in Sweden's top league (SHL), then joined Chicago after the season and tallied nine points in 12 games. He quickly established himself as a future superstar and a top candidate for this season's Calder Trophy. He anchored his own line, seeing limited ice time with Connor Bedard, and elevated his linemates (Ilya Mikheyev and Tyler Bertuzzi). He has a wicked shot that he uses often, topping 93 MPH. Early on, he was given the toughest minutes and struggled possession-wise against top players, but it showed the confidence the organization has in him. A surefire two-way stud.

Upside Comparable: Elias Pettersson (35-50-85+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 30-47-77, 22 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 100%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP..



Roman Kantserov, RW

(2026: 9) (2025: 50)



After Kantserov's KHL breakout in 2024-25, fantasy owners scrambled to draft him last summer in dynasty leagues. They were thrilled when he broke out a second time, dominating the KHL with a league-high 36 goals in 63 games in 2025-26. That total broke Kirill Kaprizov's record for most goals in the KHL by a U22 player (he had 30). Kantserov fell to the second round (44th overall) in 2023 due to his size (just 5-9 and 176 pounds), but the Blackhawks are excited to bring him over. Blessed with exceptional vision and agility, he can finish plays or set them up. The sky is the limit for the 21-year-old (22 in September). If the Blackhawks can find a highly skilled centerman to pair with him, the two could do serious damage to opposing goaltenders. If only they could find somebody...

Upside Comparable: Travis Konecny (40-45-85+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 30-37-67, 34 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP..



Nick Lardis, RW/LW

(2026: 26) (2025: 66)

Lardis continues to be underrated, and he continues to exceed expectations. Dominates junior hockey? Well, that was against kids—he won't do that in the pros. Dominates the AHL as a rookie? Sure, but that won't translate to the NHL. Gets to the NHL and still produces? Okay, enough. Time to stop writing him off. He's only 20 years old (21 in July), and he has already played half a season in the NHL (10 goals, 15 points) despite receiving fourth-line minutes. The team had trouble sending him back down and ultimately made room for him. Lardis has underrated speed and an accurate shot (with average power). He's a natural sniper who just finds a way to hit twine. His defense isn't a strength, but so far it hasn't been as poor as many feared. He played the final 10 games or so alongside Connor Bedard, and he should eventually line up with either Bedard or Anton Frondell.

Upside Comparable: Pavel Dorofeyev (40-40-80+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 28-25-53, 24 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 80%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Vaclav Nestrail, RW

(2026: 77) (2025: N/A)

One of seemingly a million highly drafted, highly touted prospects in Chicago's system, Nestrail was selected 25th overall last summer. He is a budding power forward with a very projectable frame (6-6, 190 pounds). For a first-round pick, he is more of a long-term prospect, as he needs to fill out and learn to better assert himself to get what he wants. Moving from the USHL to the NCAA last season was a positive step, and his confidence noticeably increased as the season wore on. He finished with nearly a point per game for UMass (31 in 34). He appears on track to dominate the college circuit this season, and if that happens, expect the Hawks to get him signed. Once in the NHL, he may take several years to find his offensive stride—not unlike Buffalo's Tage Thompson.

Upside Comparable: Alex Tuch (30-40-70+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 17-41-58, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 80%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28, but may play the final few games this season after his college year.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Marek Vanacker, LW

(2026: 78) (2025: 275)

After being drafted 27th overall in 2024, Vanacker suffered a shoulder injury that required surgery, cutting that year of development in half. He bounced back strong last season with Brantford, posting 82 points in 60 games and scoring 47 times (leading the league), earning a spot on the OHL's Second All-Star Team. The setup men on his line were Jake O'Brien (Seattle) and highly touted 2026 draftee Caleb Malhotra. Now 20 and set to take on the AHL, Vanacker attacks the puck with aplomb, never giving up on it and often coming away with it. This skill set will likely result in more assists than goals, despite his track record suggesting the opposite, though much will depend on his linemates. Many of his goals come from snipes off the rush. A quick, successful transition to AHL hockey could see him ascend to the NHL more quickly than projected (there are shades of Brandon Hagel in his game), and he is one to keep an eye on.

Upside Comparable: Bryan Rust (35-35-70+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 22-25-47, 36 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Sacha Boisvert, C

(2026: 94) (2025: 122)

Boisvert joined his third new team in three years, Boston University. He had a three-point game in his debut and nine points in his first eight contests. A shoulder injury suffered in November sidelined him for nearly two months, though he briefly returned and attempted to play through it. He was scratched from the final game of the season—a very meaningful one—but the coach refused to call it a healthy scratch or an injury. Boisvert is a hard-nosed middle-six center with some upside. He signed his ELC with Chicago after the NCAA season and appeared in seven games. He struggled defensively, played fourth-line minutes, and did not fare well in the faceoff circle. He was also credited with just nine Hits. Now 20, Boisvert was selected 18th overall in 2024. Still adding strength and bulk, he's up to 185 pounds. He will certainly play AHL hockey this season, likely for two years.

Upside Comparable: Nazem Kadri (30-35-65+, 80+ PIM)

3YP: 17-24-41, 68 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 80%

Expected Arrival: 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Nathan Behm, LW/RW

(2026: 108) (2025: N/A)

For organizations such as Toronto or Colorado, Behm would be their top prospect. For Chicago, however, he doesn't even crack the top 10—but that doesn't make him any less of an appealing fantasy asset. Drafted in the third round last year, 66th overall, Behm exploded for WHL Kamloops, posting 86 points in 66 contests. Already 6-2 and 207 pounds, he boasts a solid build for a 19-year-old. He plays a bit of a power game, but without piling up banger stats, and his passing (often off fakes) is as strong as his shot, which is high-end. He's a finisher who would mesh well alongside a skilled pivot. His speed isn't great, but he will work on that in the NCAA, as he has committed to Arizona State. How well he transitions to college hockey will determine how soon he turns pro. On most teams he would have top-six upside, but in Chicago he may be capped in the middle six.

Upside Comparable: Tanner Pearson (30-35-65+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 20-25-45, 36 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



John Mustard, LW

(2026: 149) (2025: 220)

Mustard's sophomore campaign with Providence saw him lead the team in scoring, even opening the season with a nine-game point streak. He was a semifinalist for the Walter Brown Award, given to the top American-born player in New England. At press time, he had not yet committed to returning to the NCAA or turning pro, but he is likely heading back for his junior season. His linemate, Roger McQueen (Anaheim), turned pro after the season. Mustard is considered one of the fastest skaters among hockey prospects, particularly in terms of breakaway acceleration. He is a high-volume shooter with an accurate wrist shot. He lacks bulk (6-1, 185 pounds) but plays a physical game. He can be a puck hog at times, not always recognizing the easier pass. With his combination of

game-breaking speed and high-volume shooting, Mustard projects as a dynamic offensive winger who will be a multi-category fantasy asset once he refines his playmaking and reaches his professional ceiling.

Upside Comparable: Timo Meier (25-40-65+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 20-20-40, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Mason West, RW

(2026: 178) (2025: N/A)

Another first-round pick in the system, West was taken 29th overall last summer. This time, the organization went big, rolling the dice on a long-term project. West is 6-6 and 218 pounds, and he spent most of his pre-draft season dominating the high-school ranks—a level that is always difficult to evaluate accurately. In the USHL last season, his offense was average but not great. He spent the year working on improving his speed and agility. He's not a physical player, just physically imposing. He has committed to Michigan State in the fall, where stronger competition should benefit him greatly. He is highly ranked within the organization thanks to his raw skill and obvious size, as well as his strong reputation in the room, but he will need time and proper development. Several NHL-drafted prospects will be on his new team, including Calgary's Cullen Potter.

Upside Comparable: Aliaksei Protas (30-35-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 18-17-35, 35 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 75%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Gavin Hayes, LW

(2026: 289) (2025: 216)

The former junior scoring star (76 points in 55 OHL games in his final season there) has been slow to transition that offense to the pro ranks. And considering his defense is his weak point, that's not a great sign. On the bright side, Hayes nearly doubled his rookie-AHL output and finished his sophomore campaign on a strong note (20 points in his final 36 games after starting with five in 20). He doesn't boast a large frame—just 6-1 and 177 pounds—but if he can take another step this season, he could be a 25-goal scorer at the AHL level (he was a two-time 35-goal scorer in the OHL). At this point, he would need to make significant strides to become a top-six forward in the NHL and seems earmarked for a bottom-six role if he makes it. He's 22, so he still has a couple of years to figure it out.

Upside Comparable: Craig Smith (25-30-55+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 14-17-31, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 65%

Expected Arrival: 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Sam Rinzel, RD

(2026: 6D) (2025: 19D)

After an incredible pro debut on the heels of earning Big Ten Defensive Player of the Year in 2024-25, Rinzel had the power-play quarterback spot laid out for him on a silver platter. Seizing it last season would have effectively blocked off the likes of Artyom Levshunov and Kevin Korchinski,

possibly limiting their upside. Instead, he struggled, saw his ice time decline, and was eventually sent to the AHL. A big man at 6-4 and 194 pounds, Rinzel was drafted 25th overall in 2022—the pedigree is there. In 23 AHL games, he managed a decent 14 points, though just four came with the man advantage. He returned to the big club in March but was again snakebitten. All told, he produced just one power-play point in over 100 minutes of PPTOI. Levshunov was far more effective there, and barring an injury, Rinzel's high-upside window has likely closed.

Upside Comparable: Brandon Montour (10-40-50, 70 PIM)

3YP: 5-26-31, 52 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: A final-round option.



Kevin Korchinski, LD

(2026: 21D) (2025: 8D)

After playing a full NHL season in 2023–24, Korchinski's fantasy owners have been disappointed with what they've seen from him since. In the AHL, his offense went from unimpressive to... well, still unimpressive. It has flatlined, including his power-play production. His shot volume has actually decreased, and defensively he might even be worse. Because he's a former seventh-overall draft pick (2022), we—as well as the Blackhawks—have been slow to move him down the list due to his tremendous upside, but with Artyom Levshunov already in place and possibly another stud defenseman arriving via the draft in late June, the outlook isn't promising. In his NHL cups of coffee last season, he didn't look out of place, though his minutes were heavily sheltered. At this point, a safe bet would be seeing him on the third pairing and getting secondary power-play minutes. He is exempt from waivers for one more season.

Upside Comparable: Bryan Berard (5-45-50, 70 PIM)

3YP: 4-27-31, 48 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Ethan Del Mastro, LD

(2026: 72D) (2025: 31D)

Del Mastro was primarily Sam Rinzel's defense partner in the AHL and Kevin Korchinski's in the NHL. But his forte is his toughness. At 6-4 and 210 pounds, Del Mastro has really improved his physical game and has already shown that he has some offensive ability. He'll never run a power play—especially in Chicago's system—but as a partner for one of the puck movers, he can chip in with secondary assists while rewarding fantasy managers with Hits, blocks, and PIM. While he isn't a transition master, his heavy style and underrated hockey sense allow him to handle top-four minutes against elite opposition. Del Mastro's value lies in his reliability; he is the defensive safety net that enables his more adventurous partners to take risks, making him a multi-category sleeper.

Upside Comparable: MacKenzie Weegar (10-30-40, 90 PIM, 120 BLKS, 200 Hits)

3YP: 5-10-25, 70 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 85%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Adam Gajan, G

The top goaltender taken in the 2023 Draft (35th overall), Gajan hasn't had quite the impact of Jacob Fowler (Montreal), who was selected 34 picks later. Nonetheless, he has been very good, aside from some early-season struggles. He lost five straight games in January before suffering a lower-body injury that cost him a month. Aside from that stretch, he had a very strong year for UMD. At 6-3, he has good size and excellent athleticism, with the upside to steal games on his own. He turned pro on April 1, and although he took a loss in his only Rockford start, he stopped 33 of 36 shots. The Slovak netminder also attended the Olympics as the No. 3 goalie, though he didn't see any game action. Chicago's goaltending position is set for at least the next couple of years, so Gajan will have time to develop.

Upside: Star NHL Starter

3YP: 35-20-7, 2.74 GAA, 0.906 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 80%

Expected Arrival: 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Drew Comness, G

After a prolific three-year stint with NCAA's Boston University, Comness has translated that success into a solid start to his pro career. His numbers in Rockford have been fairly steady, and he also earned the AHL's Goalie of the Month Award for December. His latest cup of coffee with Chicago was a strong one, allowing just two goals on his final 60 shots faced. He displayed impressive poise, bouncing back from a five-goal trouncing on January 9 to post a shutout the very next day. A highly drafted goaltender (46th overall in 2020), the Blackhawks view him as their future backup behind Spencer Knight. He is still waivers-exempt, so expect another year in the AHL. But he's close, and will certainly be the first call-up in the event of an injury. He has not played more than 39 games in any of the past six seasons, so becoming a starter within the next five years is highly unlikely.

Upside: NHL Starter

3YP: 21-16-4, 2.95 GAA, 0.900 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.

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Colorado AVALANCHE

At a Glance

Top prospect: Gavin Brindley
 Boom / Bust potential: TJ Hughes
 Long-term project: Christian Humphreys
 Top sniper: TJ Hughes
 Best setup man: Christian Humphreys

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: TJ Hughes
 Defense: Sean Behrens
 Goal: Ilya Nabokov
 Points only: TJ Hughes
 Multicategory: Gavin Brindley

2026 Draftees: [Shawn Carrier \(F\)](#), [Axel Elofsson \(D\)](#), [Beckett Hamilton \(F\)](#), [Teddy Lechner \(D\)](#), [Alexandre Raymond \(G\)](#), [Ondřej Ruml \(D\)](#), [Yegor Shilov \(F\)](#), [Cole Tuminaro \(D\)](#), [Tobias Tvrtznik \(G\)](#)

by Hayden Soboleski



Gavin Brindley, RW

(2026: 63) (2025: 30)

Brindley made a strong first impression with the Avs, bringing NHL-ready speed and energy to a team that battled injuries out of training camp. His average time on ice began in the single digits like most depth rookies, but he was regularly hitting 10–11 minutes by November, when he earned a brief stint in the Avs' top six and signed a two-year contract extension. He consistently passed the eye test but experienced long cold streaks, and he missed several games with upper-body and lower-body injuries in close succession. He finished the season with 13 points, 62 SOG, and 37 Hits in 56 NHL games, and was bumped off Colorado's roster once trade-deadline reinforcements were acquired. Turning 22 in the fall, Brindley will still be waivers-exempt for the 2025–26 season, so a return to the deep Avalanche lineup isn't guaranteed, but his skill set makes him a realistic option for both top-six and bottom-six roles.

Upside Comparable: Viktor Arvidsson (25-35-60, 40 PIM)

3YP: 20-20-40, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



TJ Hughes, C

(2026: 121) (2025: N/A)

As a Hobey Baker finalist, the undrafted UFA forward could choose any destination, and he selected Colorado, where he immediately became a top prospect in an otherwise bare cupboard. After putting up 57 points in 40 games with Michigan, the 24-year-old signed a one-year ELC, signaling that both sides want to find out quickly whether he's NHL-ready. He has been a consistent point-per-game scorer and high-volume shooter throughout his career, so there's obvious fantasy upside; he also has a strong faceoff record, but considering the Avs' roster depth, the right-shot forward may only crack the lineup initially as a winger while taking strong-side draws. He's known as a two-way player but does not kill penalties, so despite being near a point-per-game pace in his AHL tryout period, he may struggle to earn enough NHL ice time for immediate fantasy production. His pace and hockey sense are pro-ready—the bigger question is whether the Colorado roster is ready for him.

Upside Comparable: Nick Schmaltz (25-40-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 20-27-47, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Zakhar Bardakov, C/RW

(2026: 147) (2025: 357)

Bardakov jumped directly from the KHL to the NHL in 2025–26 without any seasoning in the minors. He played a fourth-line role in 60 games, where he maintained positive possession metrics without being sheltered and improved at using his 6-2 frame to his advantage as the year progressed. Still, he was a healthy scratch for the other 22 games and for the playoffs as the competitive Avs loaded up. His 10 points and low shot volume did not move the needle offensively, and his 42% faceoff win rate saw the natural centerman regularly moved to the wing. The 25-year-old needed a few years in the KHL to develop his scoring instincts, so expect the same in his NHL career—but he won't be getting the ice time needed for that in Colorado. Now an RFA, at press time there were strong indications that he will sign in the KHL and return to Russia.

Upside Comparable: Ryan McLeod (15-40-55+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 10-20-30, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 40%

Expected Arrival: Now or never.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Danil Gushchin, RW

(2026: 266) (2025: 111)

Unrestricted Free Agent

Colorado traded for Gushchin in the 2025 offseason after a productive AHL campaign, gambling that he might fill a depth scoring role out of training camp. Despite his fantastic shot and moderate forechecking ability for his size (5-8, 165), other depth options proved to be better fits, and Gushchin spent another year in the AHL. He managed just 18 goals and 32 points in 49 outings—lower paces than in 2024–25—and his games-played total was affected by two separate LBI injuries and several healthy scratches throughout April and the Calder Cup Playoffs. His contract has expired, and given the team's roster decisions by season's end, it's likely that the former third-round pick will need to find a new home. Now 24 years old, he's unlikely to reach his full upside but still has the tools to be fantasy-relevant if he can earn meaningful ice time in a shallower organization.

Upside Comparable: Andrei Kuzmenko (30-30-60, 50 PIM)

3YP: 20-20-40, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 55%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Christian Humphreys, C

(2026: 290) (2025: 534)

Humphreys was a top-10 scorer in the OHL as a 19-year-old, racking up 27 goals and 85 points in 63 games. He was especially dangerous with the man advantage, picking up 40 points (second most in the league), and he remained a top-10 scorer in the playoffs en route to an OHL championship. He's still assist-heavy, but his shot volume increased to over two SOG per game (more as a winger), which represents some welcome diversity. He also jumped to 33 PIM, though these were mostly minor penalties that will likely be coached out of his game if he makes it to the pros. He was a centerman but finished the year at 48% in the faceoff circle, so the right-shot forward was shifted to his off-wing for the end of the season and playoffs, and he now projects as a winger moving forward.

After an unsuccessful stint with Michigan in 2024, Humphreys has committed to the University of Minnesota for 2026–27 to give the NCAA another chance.

Upside Comparable: Mikael Granlund (25-45-70, 35 PIM)

3YP: 10-30-40, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



Nikita Prishchepov, LW

(2026: 487) (2025: 396)

Prishchepov's AHL season lasted just 22 games after he suffered a serious lower-body injury in the preseason and then another one in February. He performed well, managing 12 points on a grinder line while also anchoring the top penalty-kill unit. He is able to collect rebounds around the net and cycle below the goal line; his skill set and frame should be well suited for a depth NHL role if he can stay healthy. His fantasy value lies in banger leagues that count Hits and penalty minutes—his 28 PIM were slightly inflated by one altercation, but this is still an element of his game that managers can expect if he gets another NHL audition. The 22-year-old has one year left on his ELC to prove he can sustain a physical role and continue his path toward becoming a prototypical bottom-six forward.

Upside Comparable: Alex Laferriere (15-35-50+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 10-15-25, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Sean Behrens, LD

(2026: 50D) (2025: 27D)

After missing the entire 2024–25 campaign with a knee injury, Behrens' (deferred) rookie AHL season was a moderate success. He managed 23 points in 55 games, reduced his penalty count from the midpoint onward, and put together a few hot streaks where he approached the point-per-game mark for one to two weeks at a time. As expected after a year off, his skating and strength still need improvement to become more reliable around his own net and more dangerous in the offensive zone. He has another gear to reach in terms of footspeed and getting the puck off his stick more quickly. In the AHL playoffs, he was used on an offensive pairing that posted a healthy goal differential, but he didn't contribute much scoring himself; the former second-round pick will need to earn ice time in more situations in 2026–27 and beyond in order to become a notable fantasy hockey asset.

Upside Comparable: Neal Pionk (10-40-50, 50 PIM)

3YP: 5-25-30, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Francesco Dell'Elce, LD

(2026: 61D) (2025: N/A)

Colorado selected Dell'Elce 77th overall in the 2025 Draft after the UMass–Amherst freshman tallied 24 points in 40 games and was named to the Hockey East All-Rookie Team. As a sophomore, he

picked up where he left off, maintaining similar points-per-game, shots-on-goal-per-game, and blocks-per-game rates on a roster that was competitive despite lacking high-octane scoring or star power. He isn't flashy, but he finds seams in the offensive zone, can join the rush, has a quick shot release, and is never afraid to throw the puck on net. He continued to see power-play and penalty-kill minutes, and both are expected to grow in his upcoming junior campaign. Expect the 20-year-old to spend additional time in college and the minors filling out and preparing for the physical side of the game before he hits any fantasy radars.

Upside Comparable: Mike Matheson (10-40-50, 40 PIM)

3YP: 10-30-40, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Mikhail Gulyayev, LD

(2026: 69D) (2025: 37D)

In a strange turn of events, Gulyayev's average TOI per game dropped by four minutes last season, down to just 11 minutes per game. Not only that, but the team played him at forward early in the year before moving the blueliner back to his natural position for his fourth KHL campaign. He didn't skate on any special-teams units and managed just three points on the year (down from 15). Fortunately, he saw increased opportunity in the KHL Playoffs, where his numbers bounced back accordingly (15 minutes per night and five points in 17 games). His unusual usage hasn't swayed his long term plans—the 21-year-old previously indicated he would only cross the pond for an NHL role, and he has signed a two-year extension in the KHL.

Upside Comparable: Jared Spurgeon (8-32-40, 20 PIM)

3YP: 5-25-30, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Ilya Nabokov, G

After registering save percentages of 0.930 and 0.923 in his two previous KHL campaigns, Nabokov dipped to 0.901 in 2025–26 and ended up splitting the workload as a result. He played 38 games (down from 49) for Metallurg, lost the crease prior to the playoffs, and did not redeem himself in his eventual postseason starts. Fortunately, there is a reported reason for this drastic shift in play—the 6-1 netminder has adjusted his stance to better prepare for North American play given his height, and the transition is taking time. He signed a two-year ELC in 2025, meaning he is eligible to move to Colorado at any time, and all signs point to him playing in the AHL this fall. If his adjustments help him adapt to North American shooters as hoped, expect the 23-year-old to be stress-tested with 1A/1B duties in the AHL over multiple seasons.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 30-15-5, 2.50 GAA, 0.907 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Louka Cloutier, G

Cloutier entered his freshman year at Boston College coming off a poor D+1 season in the USHL. He finished his freshman campaign as the undisputed starter, earning multiple Goalie of the Week and Rookie of the Week honors, along with a spot on the Richter Award watchlist for the top goaltender in the NCAA. Through 33 starts, he posted a 0.910 save percentage—a career high—which he will aim to maintain with BC as a sophomore. As a fifth-round pick (132nd overall) with a limited track record, Cloutier has not yet signed an entry-level contract and will likely play one to two more seasons in Boston before considering turning pro. At 6-1, he will be considered an undersized goalie, which can limit long-term opportunity, but he is only entering his age-20 season, so there is still plenty of runway ahead.

Upside: NHL starter

3YP: 25-15-5, 2.60 GAA, 0.904 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Trent Miner, G

Over five pro campaigns, the 25-year-old Miner has been a poster boy for undersized goalies getting no respect. He has never dipped below a 0.900 save percentage over a full season and has been solid both when starting for long stretches and when serving as a backup. Despite this, he has never been given a full season as a starter, and that's unlikely to change now in the Avs system, so he currently projects as a tandem or backup goalie at the NHL level. In four appearances with the Avalanche last year, he delivered three quality starts and a 0.933 save percentage, but still passed through waivers unclaimed afterward. He dominated the AHL playoffs with the most shutouts and one of the best GAAs and save percentages in the postseason. The 6-1 netminder remains waivers-eligible, so call-ups may be tricky to navigate, and with one year left on his contract, his status within the organization is likely to be in flux over the coming year.

Upside: 1A NHL split starter

3YP: 20-10-5, 2.60, 0.900

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.

Columbus BLUE JACKETS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Jackson Smith
 Boom / Bust potential: Jordan Dumais
 Long-term project: Cayden Lindstrom
 Top sniper: Luca Del Bel Belluz
 Best setup man: Luca Marrelli

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Cayden Lindstrom
 Defense: Jackson Smith
 Goal: Pyotr Andreyanov
 Points only: William Whitelaw
 Multicategory: Cayden Lindstrom

2026 Draftees: Alessandro Di Iorio, Oscar Hemming (F), Evan Jardine (F), Filip Novák (F), Parker Snell (G), Anttoni Uronen (F), Jonas Woo (D)

by Nick Orr



Cayden Lindstrom, C

(2026: 48) (2025: 19)

Lindstrom is a big, strong center who has struggled to stay on the ice in recent seasons. He plays a heavy game and is never afraid to make sure opponents know he's out there. He is disruptive, strong on the forecheck, and has enough skill to complement his towering presence. Lindstrom missed all of the 2024-25 regular season with an injury but returned to play 31 games last season with Michigan State. Despite his limited ice time, Lindstrom still showcased flashes of play-driving ability and physical dominance. The key for him is staying healthy. Stringing together consecutive seasons of good health would go a long way toward showcasing his skill set and proving to the Blue Jackets that he can solidify his projection as a dominant, high-impact top-six NHL power forward.

Upside Comparable: Roope Hintz (30-45-75+, 100 PIM)

3YP: 17-25-42, 53 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 80%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28, but may play the final few games this season after his college year.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Luca Del Bel Belluz, C

(2026: 59) (2025: 26)

The only knock on Del Bel Belluz is his skating. His offensive toolkit and instincts are strong, as evidenced by his AHL point totals. His shot is what elevates his game, complemented by strong playmaking instincts. He has found ways in the AHL to overcome his skating shortcomings, but that area will need refinement if he is to reach his full NHL potential. His skill set could project as a solid middle-six scoring option, but his skating limits that ceiling. He also possesses strong two-way instincts that should earn him a look in the NHL. From a fantasy hockey perspective, Del Bel Belluz is worth a late-round gamble, though he may need more time before becoming a sound and productive NHL contributor.

Upside Comparable: Bobby McMann (25-40-65+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 15-20-35, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 80%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Luca Pinelli, C (2026: 95) (2025: 232)

Pinelli is an undersized winger who plays with the tenacity of a much bigger, more experienced player. He hunts down pucks and wins board battles effectively. On top of that, Pinelli's offensive game is refined; he now prefers to distribute the puck at the AHL level, a far cry from his junior days. He has high hockey IQ and consistently makes those around him better. His skating is the one area that needs a significant overhaul, but his tenacity and work ethic suggest steady improvement in the coming years. Pinelli should spend this season in the AHL, with occasional spot games in Columbus to aid his development. He is an exciting prospect who may take some time to fully ripen at the NHL level, but he should earn an opportunity in due time.

Upside Comparable: Conor Garland (30-40-70, 60 PIM)

3YP: 20-25-45, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Jordan Dumais, RW (2026: 144) (2025: 94)

Dumais ripped up the QMJHL but has struggled to fully put it together in consecutive professional seasons. The skill is certainly present, but his lack of size and questionable skating mechanics have held him back to this point. Additionally, Dumais has dealt with injuries, preventing him from consistently staying on the ice for a full campaign. He has good anticipation and an ability to find open teammates, even when the passing lane appears limited. Admittedly, projecting Dumais' NHL impact is difficult, as his key development years have been marked by injuries and a need for further refinement. His last full season was in 2022-23 with Halifax, so time is running short for Dumais to show Columbus that he can stay healthy and contribute over a full year.

Upside Comparable: Viktor Arvidsson (25-40-65+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 8-23-31, 18 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Do not draft this year or next.



William Whitelaw, C (2026: 160) (2025: 257)

Transferring to Western Michigan University from the University of Wisconsin did wonders for Whitelaw. He has a strong, well-rounded offensive toolkit that projects a second-line center as his ceiling. He skates well and shoots the puck at an elite level. He can score from anywhere and has a highly deceptive release. Whitelaw also finishes from all areas of the offensive zone and features above-average playmaking ability. Whitelaw reached an elite level at Western Michigan last year and put together a season that suggests a strong professional future. From a fantasy perspective, he is worth a look, though he likely won't be an option for a few years. He should be in the AHL very soon and may not spend much time there before earning a look with Columbus.

Upside Comparable: Logan Stankoven (30-40-70, 25 PIM)

3YP: 20-20-40, 15 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Oiva Keskinen, C

(2026: 209) (2025: 280)

Keskanen has put together a couple of strong seasons in Liiga, steadily improving his production and role each year. He notched his first 20-goal campaign last season and is finally beginning to show real confidence as a center. He reads the play well, is reliable in most situations, and skates well. He is starting to take meaningful strides toward becoming a legitimate NHL forward. Keskanen is still likely several years away from fantasy relevance, as he will probably spend next season in Liiga before coming over and seasoning in the AHL. However, there is value in his projection as a solid third-line center who can produce occasional strong point totals. Time will tell whether what has worked for the 22-year-old in Liiga translates to the North American game. Solid stash option in deeper leagues.

Upside Comparable: Pius Suter (20-35-55+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 7-10-17, 18 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Do not draft this year or next.



Jackson Smith, LD

(2026: 10D) (2025: N/A)



Smith is widely considered Columbus' top prospect for a reason. He is an excellent skater who drives play and controls the pace with seemingly little effort. Smith is also trustworthy in logging big minutes, as he did at Penn State. He features a well-refined offensive game—he's crafty with the puck and consistently sets up his teammates for quality chances. Importantly, none of his offensive prowess comes at the expense of his defensive play. He has a strong stick and maintains good gap control. At the moment, Smith is unsigned, but that status likely won't last long. He has the tools of a legitimate top-pairing defenseman—ironically, similar to future teammate Zach Werenski. He is a bona fide elite defender who should be strongly considered in the first round or two of your draft.

Upside Comparable: Zach Werenski (10-65-75, 55 PIM)

3YP: 7-45-52, 35 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 40%, 95%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP..



Luca Marrelli, RD

(2026: 31D) (2025: 93D)

Marrelli missed the beginning of last season with a torn labrum, giving him a late start to his professional career. After returning, however, he shined. Marrelli can do it all, contributing heavily on the offensive end without sacrificing his defensive responsibilities. He skates well and uses his rangy stick to disrupt attackers as they move up the ice. The primary concern with Marrelli is his relatively light frame. As he progresses in his professional career, time will tell whether he can handle bigger minutes with increased physicality. That said, Marrelli has the potential to produce solid offensive seasons in the NHL. He has the tools and instincts for it, but he will need time to refine his game and find a way to continue contributing at a high level.

Upside Comparable: Filip Hronek (10-40-50+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 5-15-20, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Corson Ceulemans, RD

(2026: 110D) (2025: 76D)

Ceulemans has struggled to cement a role in Cleveland's top four, though this season provided some positive momentum for the 23-year-old. He is a big, mobile defender with good offensive instincts. He can break the puck out of the zone effectively, though he does struggle under pressure at times. Defensively, Ceulemans has yet to consistently impact the game—he often misreads plays and spends too much time chasing. These are the key areas he must improve if he hopes to secure a spot in Columbus. Unfortunately for Ceulemans, age is becoming a factor. He is already 23 and only just completed his first full professional season. Combined with the strength of Columbus' blue line, both now and in the future, his path to the NHL is unclear. A strong season this year would go a long way toward improving his outlook.

Upside Comparable: Dante Fabbro (7-28-35+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 3-10-13, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 65%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Pyotr Andreyanov, G

An extremely athletic goaltender, Andreyanov was considered the best netminder in his draft class when Columbus selected him. He moves well, tracks the puck effectively, and reacts quickly to shots through traffic. Aside from his sheer size, there is little that holds Andreyanov back in the crease. His skill set clearly points toward the potential to become an elite NHL goaltender. The stressful part for the Blue Jackets' front office is Andreyanov's five-year contract in Russia. He will be 23 when that deal expires, leaving a significant portion of his development outside Columbus' control. That said, there is no reason to believe Andreyanov will falter in his progression, and he should be a strong option in net for Columbus whenever he arrives.

Upside Comparable: Star NHL starter

3YP: 30-20-5, 2.20 GAA, 0.930 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 55%, 80%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Potential star; draft in the late rounds if you can afford to wait a few years.



Evan Gardner, G

After a successful three-year run as the starting netminder for Saskatoon in the WHL, Gardner appeared in one AHL playoff game last season and stopped all 10 shots he faced. He moves well and stays calm in the crease, rarely overcommitting or overplaying cross-ice passes. He uses his posts effectively to anchor himself and seal off holes. The one glaring issue for Gardner is his rebound control—he struggles to contain shots and can leave pucks sitting in high-danger areas. It hasn't hurt him in the WHL, but it may become a concern at the professional level. Once again, Gardner is another Columbus netminder without ideal size. That said, he should already be playing with Cleveland this season, giving him a leg up on other Blue Jackets prospects. Time will tell how his first full AHL season progresses.

Upside: NHL starter

3YP: 25-18-7, 2.95 GAA, 0.900 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 40%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Sergei Ivanov, G

Ivanov is a bit of a unicorn, standing at just 6-0 and 157 pounds. He doesn't fill the net, but he has produced results at every level, including last season in the KHL. He appeared in 29 games for SKA St. Petersburg and posted a 0.928 save percentage. Ivanov moves extremely well in the crease and uses his quickness to compensate for the lack of net coverage. The skill set is there to carve out a role in North America, but it remains to be seen whether his size becomes a limiting factor. The second major Russian goaltender in Columbus' system, Ivanov saw his contract with SKA expire after last season, so time will tell whether now is the moment he makes the jump to North America. Regardless of when he arrives, Ivanov should be able to earn time between the pipes, though he may not possess the same ceiling as Andreyanov.

Upside: 1A NHL split starter

3YP: 15-10-2, 2.95 GAA, 0.910 SV%

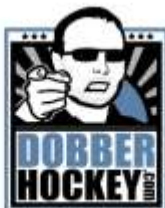
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 50%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.

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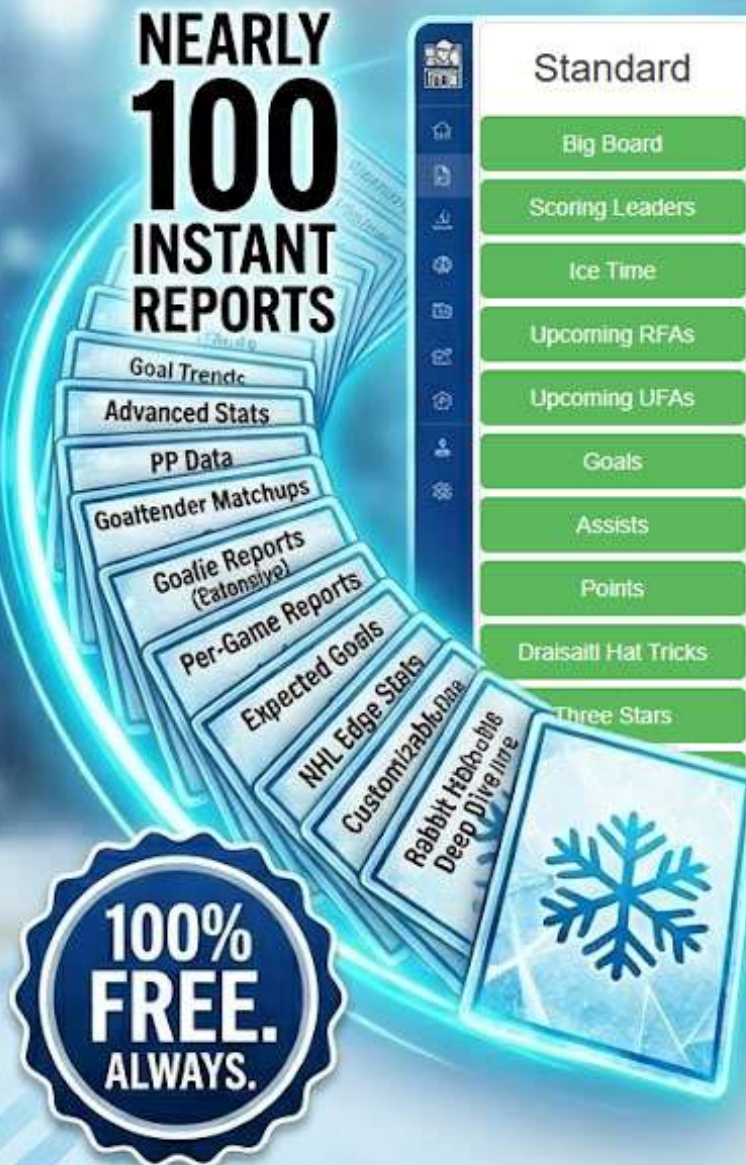
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Name	Conference	Pos.	Age	Team	GP	PPG	PPA	PPP	PP SOG	%PP
WIKTOR KUCHEROV	☐	R	31.3	TB	78	8	38	18	85	82.4
NATHAN BACHMANN	☐	G	28.7	COL	78	9	28	38	84	81.9
CLAYTON KELLER	☐	L	28.8	UTA	81	19	27	37	47	74.1
MARTIN NEULAS	☐	R	28.5	COL	79	12	29	37	54	74.8
LUCAS RAYMOND	☐	R	23.1	DET	82	8	28	37	45	67.2
CALE MARSH	☐	D	28.8	COL	80	12	21	36	80	79.2
DOLAN STROMBERG	☐	C	28.2	WSH	82	9	29	34	36	88.0
JESPER BRATT	☐	R	28.9	NJ	81	9	35	34	34	86.0
JAKOB EKHOLM	☐	D	28.9	VSK	77	9	39	34	57	77.7
MATTHEW MARSH	☐	R	28.8	TOR	81	6	37	33	38	76.7
TIM STUTZLE	☐	C	23.9	OTT	82	9	28	33	39	86.0
LEKH OHLSSON	☐	G	28.8	EDM	71	18	17	33	80	81.3
CONOR MCDAVID	☐	C	24.3	EDM	87	9	22	31	46	79.2
BRAYDEN PONT	☐	C	28.2	TB	77	18	15	31	52	74.9
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Dallas STARS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Emil Hemming
 Boom / Bust potential: Samu Tuomaala
 Long-term project: Jeremie Poirier
 Top sniper: Cameron Schmidt
 Best setup man: Emil Hemming

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Emil Hemming
 Defense: Jeremie Poirier
 Goal: Remi Poirier
 Points only: E. Hemming / C. Schmidt
 Multicategory: Arttu Hyry

2026 Draftees: Ryan Brown (F), Mikhail Cherepanov (D), Anton Emil Wilde Larsen, Jasper Kuhta (F),
Jakub Vanecek (D)

by Puneet Sharma



Emil Hemming, RW

(2026: 50) (2025: 78)

Hemming put together a strong season with the OHL Barrie Colts, producing 63 points in 46 games while showing greater consistency and confidence as an offensive driver. The Stars prospect has always had the raw tools, but this year his game looked more complete. Beyond his shot and finishing ability, he showed real growth as a playmaker, more actively creating looks in transition and involving teammates rather than relying purely on his release. When he's moving with purpose, he generates high-danger chances at a strong rate and forces defenders to respect his shot first. His next steps are to focus on puck management, shift-to-shift consistency, and handling pressure when space closes around him. That said, the trajectory is encouraging. He continues to project as a potential top-six NHL winger with legitimate secondary scoring and power-play upside if his habits keep catching up to his skill set.

Upside Comparable: Anthony Mantha (30-35-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 20-20-40, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 85%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Cameron Schmidt, RW

(2026: 60) (2025: N/A)

Schmidt's stock has continued to rise after posting 60 points in 39 games with the Vancouver Giants while establishing himself as one of the most dangerous offensive players in the WHL. Even at 5-8, he competes with pace, hunts loose pucks, and consistently forces defenders into recovery mode with quick changes of direction and inside cuts. The most noticeable step forward last year was his playmaking. Long viewed primarily as a shooter, he showed more poise with the puck, adding cross-ice feeds and improved reads that helped him create for linemates instead of defaulting to shooting lanes. There are still real question marks around his size, defensive detail, and shift-to-shift consistency. However, players with this level of pace and finishing ability are hard to ignore. If the rest of his game continues to round out, he projects as a legitimate top-six NHL scoring winger with real offensive punch.

Upside Comparable: Alex DeBrincat (35-40-75+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 19-32-51, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Brandon Gorzynski, LW/C

(2026: 165) (2025: N/A)

After producing 42 points in 68 games during his 2024–25 WHL season, Gorzynski elevated his game with 69 points in 65 games last year, split between Calgary and Prince Albert, pushing him above a point-per-game pace (1.07). The jump reflects increased confidence on the puck and a larger role in all situations, with his 27 goals indicating he's getting to more dangerous areas rather than relying on secondary touches. He is not a high-end creator or dynamic offensive driver, and that limits the ceiling, but the consistency is real. He can complement skilled linemates and handle different roles without falling apart away from the puck. This is the type of depth-forward prospect who trends toward a bottom-six projection. The offensive jump does not necessarily turn him into a finisher at the NHL level, but it does reinforce that there may be more offense than first projected.

Upside Comparable: Yanni Gourde (25-35-60+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 15-15-30, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 80%

Expected Arrival: 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Samu Tuomaala, RW

(2026: 185) (2025: 163)

Tuomaala was acquired by the Texas Stars in October 2025, giving him an opportunity for a fresh start within the Dallas organization. Through 19 games between the Lehigh Valley Phantoms and the AHL Stars, he produced 10 points (two goals, eight assists), which is steady rather than explosive. He is at his best attacking in stride, using straight-line speed to gain the zone, pull defenders back, and create offense off the rush. When he has to work through extended cycle shifts or grind along the wall, his effectiveness drops, which has kept the production from taking a real jump so far. His profile is still that of a transition winger first and foremost, but he is not yet a refined power-play driver or a consistent half-wall creator. Right now, he sits in that middle-six projection range where continued AHL development will determine whether he becomes a call-up option or settles into organizational depth.

Upside Comparable: Kasper Kapanen (20-35-55+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 5-15-20, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Matthew Seminoff, RW

(2026: 208) (2025: 217)

Seminoff's season with the Texas Stars is exactly what you want from a player trying to push from an AHL support piece into legitimate NHL depth: clear offensive growth, repeatable habits, and a real jump in finishing ability. Across 72 AHL games, he posted 24 goals and 50 points—nearly a 0.70 points-per-game pace—which is a meaningful step up from his earlier pro seasons, where offense was sporadic and secondary. The most important shift isn't just the production, but how he has become more involved offensively. Seminoff still plays a direct, north-south game built on pace,

work rate, and pressure; however, this year he added more structure to it, especially in his off-puck movement and timing into scoring areas. He should fit well as a middle-six energy scorer, but this is the kind of season that puts him on the radar as a potential NHL call-up option rather than just organizational depth.

Upside Comparable: Michael Bunting (20-35-55+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 10-10-20, 18 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Arttu Hyry, C/RW
(2026: 206) (2025: 98)

Hyry carved out a meaningful depth role between the NHL and the Texas Stars, showing he can handle both levels in a utility capacity. He narrowly missed opening night with the Stars, was sent back to the AHL, and produced 19 points in 27 games while still earning multiple recalls to Dallas throughout the year. At the NHL level, he put up five points in 20 games while working in a low-usage, detail-driven role. His impact came away from the puck: penalty killing, faceoffs, physical engagement, and straight-line reliability rather than scoring touch. Offensively, there's some ability to finish and contribute in spurts, but it's not the driver of his profile. What stands out is how quickly he's become a trusted call-up option. The long-term projection is fairly clear: a bottom-six NHL forward who earns minutes through physical play, matchup reliability, and penalty-kill value rather than offense.

Upside Comparable: Nick Paul (20-30-50+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 10-15-25, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Dylan Hryckowian, RW
(2026: 235) (2025: N/A)

Hryckowian wrapped up his NCAA career at Northeastern with 37 points in 30 games, earning First Team Hockey East honours before jumping straight into the AHL with the Texas Stars. He held his own in a late-season stint, recording six points in 12 games while adjusting to quicker reads, heavier minutes, and a more demanding pro pace. At 5-10, his game isn't built around size; instead, he wins through timing, leverage, and constant movement—especially on the forecheck, where he can disrupt plays and create turnovers. The projection here is fairly clear: he has the tools to carve out a depth role if the transition continues to track. If his pace and defensive reliability keep translating at the AHL level, he profiles as a bottom-six NHL winger with penalty-kill value and secondary-offense upside rather than a top-six scoring threat.

Upside Comparable: Lawson Crouse (20-35-55+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 12-18-30, 45 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 75%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Tristan Bertucci, LD

(2026: 42D) (2025: 51D)

Bertucci handled his first full pro season with the AHL Stars in steady fashion, finishing with 24 points in 63 games while logging regular minutes as a 20-year-old on the back end. He has gradually reshaped his game over the past couple of years, moving away from a highly aggressive, high-activation junior style toward something more controlled and structured at the pro level. He has become more selective about when to jump into the play, and that shift has helped stabilize his game. His offensive production has been modest, but that's a fair reflection of the adjustment to pro pace and heavier competition. The bigger takeaway is that his foundation is trending in the right direction. Bertucci's offensive ceiling still carries some question marks, but his skating, size (6-2, 191), and two-way detail give him a realistic path to NHL games as a depth defenseman if his development continues to track positively.

Upside Comparable: Matt Grzelcyk (10-40-50, 70 PIM)

3YP: 5-14-19, 45 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Jeremie Poirier, LD

(2026: 159D) (2025: 33D)

Unrestricted Free Agent

Poirier endured a difficult 2025-26 AHL season split between the Calgary Wranglers and the Texas Stars after his February trade to Dallas. After putting up 42 points in 71 AHL games the year prior, he managed just 16 points in 51 games this season—a sharp regression for a defender whose value has always been tied to creating offense from the blue line. His skating efficiency, defensive reliability, and decision-making under pressure all remain limiting factors, and they directly affect how much trust he earns from coaches. When his offense is clicking, he can still generate looks with puck movement and vision, but it hasn't been steady enough to offset the defensive concerns. At this stage, the upside that once made him an intriguing prospect has not translated into a realistic NHL path. He still provides AHL depth value, but the trajectory is clearly trending away from a meaningful big-league projection.

Upside Comparable: Shayne Gostisbehere (10-45-55, 20 PIM)

3YP: 4-15-19, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 55%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Remi Poirier, G

Poirier has continued to settle in as a dependable AHL starter with the Texas Stars, building on steady progression rather than any sudden leap. Through 52 games, he posted 27-19-6 with a 2.61 GAA and a 0.912 SV%, handling a full starter's workload while keeping his results fairly stable over a long stretch. He's not an elite athlete or a highlight-reel type, but he competes, tracks pucks cleanly, and generally gives his team a chance to win most nights. That reliability has translated into organizational trust, reinforcing his standing as legitimate depth within the system. Another strong AHL season—showing he can reduce performance swings and sustain consistency—could warrant a call-up to the NHL. He projects as a realistic NHL third goaltender who can step in when needed without the structure of the game falling apart behind him.

Upside: NHL starter
3YP: 26-17-6, 2.75 GAA, 0.899 SV%
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%
Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.
DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Maxime Mayorov, G

Mayorov essentially had a stalled 2025–26 season in terms of actual game action, even while remaining part of Lokomotiv's senior goaltending group. After a strong 2024–25 run in the MHL, where he posted a 13-2-1 record with a 2.40 GAA and a 0.905 SV% over 23 games, plus a brief KHL appearance, the expectation was a gradual push toward more consistent pro minutes. Instead, he did not appear in any KHL or VHL games, making the 2025–26 season more of a holding pattern than a development step. While he remains within the organizational depth chart, the lack of game reps makes it difficult to evaluate any real progression or readiness for higher levels. The long-term intrigue is still there with his size and the flashes he showed in junior, but goaltending development is built on repetition. Until he gets consistent pro starts, he remains a long-range project.

Upside: NHL Starter
3YP: 25-19-5, 2.90 GAA, 0.901 SV%
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 50%
Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.
DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect—don't draft this year or next.



Arno Tiefensee, G

Tiefensee has taken a meaningful step forward in his first full season in North America, splitting his time between the Texas Stars and the ECHL while adjusting to the smaller ice and quicker pace. Across both leagues, he played 31 games and posted a 17-8-6 record. What stands out most is his physical profile combined with calm, efficient athleticism. He doesn't overplay situations, stays compact, and relies on tracking and positioning rather than scrambling to recover. At the AHL level, the remaining gaps are consistency and rebound control, but the tools are clearly trending in the right direction. For now, the 24-year-old remains a developmental goalie, but his first AHL season was an important step in proving that his game can translate to North America, with real long-term upside if the consistency continues to improve.

Upside: NHL backup
3YP: 16-15-6, 2.80 GAA, 0.909 SV%
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%
Expected Arrival: 2027–28.
DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



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Detroit RED WINGS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Sebastian Cossa
 Boom / Bust potential: Max Plante
 Long-term project: Maximilian Kilpinen
 Top sniper: Michael Brandsegg-Nygard
 Best setup man: Max Plante

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Max Plante
 Defense: Shai Buium
 Goal: Sebastian Cossa
 Points only: Max Plante
 Multicategory: Carter Bear

2026 Draftees: [Luka Arkko \(F\)](#), [Myles Brosnan \(D\)](#), [Beckham Edwards \(F\)](#), [J.P. Hurlbert \(F\)](#), [Adam Levac \(F\)](#), [Michal Orsulak \(G\)](#), [Victor Plante \(F\)](#)

by Victor Nuño



Michael Brandsegg-Nygard, LW/RW

(2026: 30) (2025: 52)

Brandsegg-Nygard has established himself as one of the more projectable forwards in Detroit's system. He combines pro-ready strength, physicality, and a heavy shot to drive offense in a direct, efficient manner. His strong AHL production highlights his ability to generate offense while playing a structured, detail-oriented game. He thrives along the boards and around the net, using his low center of gravity and puck-protection skills to win battles and create scoring chances in high-danger areas. Beyond his offensive tools, his well-rounded profile stands out. He is already a reliable defensive presence, contributing as a forechecker and penalty killer, which should help him earn trust at the NHL level. His brief NHL stint—where he recorded 43 Hits in 14 games—reinforced that his physical game translates. While he lacks high-end creativity, his straightforward, heavy style is highly translatable. With expected power-play usage and steady deployment, he projects as a top-six winger with strong multicategory fantasy appeal and significant goal-scoring upside.

Upside Comparable: Matthew Knies (30-40-70+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 25-35-50, 50 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Nate Danielson, C

(2026: 40) (2025: 57)

Danielson saw limited NHL action last season, appearing in 28 games with modest production, but the experience represents an important developmental step. The ninth overall pick in 2023 remains one of Detroit's more polished two-way centers, built on strong skating, positional awareness, and a pro-ready defensive game. He already earns trust in structured roles, including penalty killing and matchup assignments, using his reach and mobility to disrupt plays. With Detroit still seeking long-term stability down the middle, Danielson should have an opportunity to push for a larger role. He projects as an efficient play driver rather than a dynamic creator, relying on puck movement and transition play. His fantasy ceiling may be limited without steady power-play usage, but his well-rounded profile supports a reliable middle-six center with some upside in the right situation.

Upside Comparable: Sean Couturier (20-45-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 18-30-48, 35 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Carter Bear, LW

(2026: 52) (2025: N/A)

Bear is a high-motor winger whose game is driven by pace, pressure, and relentless puck pursuit. A first-round pick in 2025, his WHL production dipped slightly this season, though he was coming off Achilles tendon surgery and rehabilitation. He thrives in transition, attacking defenders with speed and forcing turnovers on the forecheck, while consistently generating opportunities around the net through rebounds, tips, and second-effort plays. His profile is built on competitiveness and two-way reliability, giving him a strong foundation for NHL usage. He is already effective in defensive situations and projects as a player coaches can trust in multiple roles. That said, his long-term upside will depend on continued development of his skating mechanics and puck management, particularly under pressure. If those elements progress, there is a pathway to top-six usage. Otherwise, he still projects as an effective complementary winger who can provide secondary scoring and strong peripheral value—especially in formats that reward effort-driven categories.

Upside Comparable: Brandon Hagel (30-40-70+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 25-35-60, 55 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 45%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Max Plante, C

(2026: 62) (2025: 138)

Plante has quickly become one of Detroit's top offensive prospects after a standout sophomore season at Minnesota Duluth, where he posted 52 points in 40 games and won the Hobey Baker Award. A second-round pick in 2024, he is a skilled playmaking forward who drives offense with vision, deception, and strong puck control. He processes the game quickly and consistently creates passing lanes—especially on the power play and in transition—making him a reliable offensive catalyst. His long-term outlook will depend on physical development and his ability to adjust to professional pace. At 5-11, added strength will be important to handle NHL contact and speed. His skating is agile and efficient but not elite, so his game relies heavily on anticipation and hockey sense. If he adds strength and adapts well, he projects as a top-six, power-play contributor; otherwise, he profiles as a secondary scorer driven primarily by assists.

Upside Comparable: Nick Schmaltz (25-50-75+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 15-35-50, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 75%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28, but may play the final few games this season after his college year.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Jesse Kiiskinen, RW

(2026: 113) (2025: 136)

Kiiskinen is a high-energy, physical winger who plays a direct, hard-nosed game built around forechecking, puck pressure, and net-front presence. He thrives in the interior, using his size and timing to generate chances around the crease, and brings a shoot-first mentality with a deceptive release that enhances his scoring profile. His leadership background and competitive drive further support a projection as a reliable, coach-trusted forward. While he has shown solid offensive

instincts, his overall impact can fluctuate, and his skating pace remains an area to monitor as he transitions to North American pro hockey. That may ultimately determine whether he settles into more of a complementary role. Long term, he projects as a middle-six energy winger with secondary scoring ability and some power-play utility. For fantasy purposes, his value is moderate, likely tied to secondary production and peripherals rather than high-end offensive output.

Upside Comparable: Teuvo Teravainen (25-45-70, 20 PIM)

3YP: 18-32-50, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Eddie Genborg, RW

(2026: 117) (2025: N/A)

Genborg projects as a high-energy, physical winger built on forechecking pressure, puck battles, and defensive reliability. After transitioning from the SHL to North America, he has brought a mature approach centered on effort and physical engagement. He consistently finishes checks, pressures defenders, and creates space for linemates through strength and persistence. His board work and ability to establish body position make him effective in cycle play and defensive situations. Offensively, his upside is largely opportunity-driven. Most of his production comes from net-front play, capitalizing on rebounds and loose pucks, as he lacks the high-end skill to drive offense consistently. However, he was in the SHL—a men's league—as an 18-year-old, and he still managed seven points in his last nine games and finish third in U20 SHL scoring. His skating—particularly his first-step acceleration—remains an area for improvement at NHL pace. Long term, he projects as a middle-six energy winger. In fantasy formats, his value lies in deeper leagues, especially those with banger cats.

Upside Comparable: Mason Marchment (20-40-60+, 60 PIM, 120+ Hits)

3YP: 10-23-33, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Amadeus Lombardi, C

(2026: 174) (2025: 140)

Now with NJD

Lombardi continues to emerge as one of the more intriguing late-round upside bets in Detroit's system. He is a high-tempo, offensively driven center whose game is built around speed, agility, and playmaking. Lombardi thrives in transition, using his skating to push the pace and create separation, while his vision and puck skills allow him to generate chances for both himself and his linemates. His production at the AHL level has reinforced that offensive profile, particularly in situations where he can control the puck and dictate play. The primary questions center on his physical maturity and defensive consistency. At his size, he will need to continue adding strength to handle NHL matchups and improve his reliability away from the puck. If those areas develop, there is legitimate top-six offensive upside here, especially with power-play usage. If not, he may project more as a sheltered, offense-first contributor whose fantasy value is closely tied to deployment and scoring opportunity.

Upside Comparable: Andreas Athanasiou (25-40-65+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 16-23-39, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Maximillian Kilpinen, LW

(2026: 270) (2025: N/A)

Kilpinen is a longer-term project whose game is built around high-end skating, pace, and strong hockey sense. He excels as a transition player, using his speed to pressure defenders and create space, while his awareness allows him to support plays effectively in all three zones. There are flashes of offensive ability from his junior career, but his production at higher levels has yet to translate consistently. The key areas for development are puck-skill refinement and establishing a consistent professional identity, whether at center or wing. He also needs to show greater reliability and physical maturity against senior competition. Given his skating base, there is a pathway to a depth NHL role—particularly as an energy forward or penalty killer—but the offensive ceiling remains uncertain. For fantasy purposes, he is a long-term watchlist prospect with a wide range of outcomes and is not a priority target at this stage.

Upside Comparable: Kasper Kapanen (25-35-60, 30 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Do not draft this year or next.



William Wallinder, LD

(2026: 162D) (2025: 50D)

Wallinder is a smooth-skating, two-way defenseman whose game is built on mobility, reach, and composure. His skating is a standout trait, allowing him to close gaps, defend efficiently, and transition the puck with ease. He has developed into a reliable presence in his own zone, using positioning and length to disrupt plays, while providing steady, low-end offensive support through clean puck movement rather than dynamic creation. While his tools suggest more offensive upside, his production has remained modest, and he is unlikely to serve as a primary power-play driver at the NHL level. Continued strength development could help him better leverage his size in physical situations. With steady progression in the AHL and waiver eligibility approaching, he is well positioned to compete for a full-time NHL role. Long term, he projects as a dependable middle-pair defenseman, though his fantasy value is limited to deeper formats due to modest offensive output.

Upside Comparable: Philip Broberg (5-30-35, 20 PIM)

3YP: 2-23-25, 15 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 65%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Shai Buium, LD

(2026: 172D) (2025: 96D)

Buium is an intelligent, puck-moving defenseman who has developed into a reliable two-way presence. He moves the puck efficiently, shows strong vision under pressure, and helps drive transition while also contributing as a secondary option on the man advantage. His size and reach allow him to defend effectively through positioning, and his game has trended toward a more complete, all-situations profile. There are still areas to refine, particularly his skating explosiveness and his ability to use his frame more consistently to assert himself physically. His shot is also more functional than dangerous at this stage. Even so, his combination of size, hockey sense, and puck-moving ability gives him a clear path to an NHL role. For fantasy purposes, his value will depend on offensive usage—especially power-play deployment—where he has the potential to provide steady secondary production.

Upside Comparable: Nick Perbix (5-25-30+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 2-18-20, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 50%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Sebastian Cossa, G

Now with UTA



Cossa continues to trend upward, evolving from a raw, tools-based prospect into a more technically refined and consistent goaltender. His size (6-6, 221) remains a defining advantage, allowing him to take away large portions of the net, while his lower-body power and mobility enable him to move efficiently for a goaltender of his frame. He has made clear strides in composure, puck tracking, and overall structure, which have translated into strong AHL performance. There are still areas to refine, particularly with depth management and rebound control, but the overall trajectory is encouraging. As with most goaltenders, development can be unpredictable, though his combination of size, athleticism, and improving technique gives him legitimate starting upside. With his progression at the professional level, he is positioning himself to compete for NHL opportunities in the near term. For fantasy, the ceiling is high, but value will ultimately depend on workload and team context.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 32–20–6, 2.68 GAA, 0.905 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 75%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP.



Trey Augustine, G

Augustine is one of the most technically refined goaltending prospects in hockey, relying on positioning, composure, and elite puck tracking to consistently control play. He rarely overcommits, instead using precise movements and strong angles to let pucks come to him, which has driven high-end results at both the NCAA and international levels. His calm, unshakeable presence and ability to track through traffic stand out as defining traits. While he lacks the size (6-1, 183) of some modern NHL goalies, his efficiency and lateral quickness help compensate. Continued refinement in rebound control during chaotic sequences will be important as he transitions to the pro level. His development path may take time, but the foundation is strong. Long term, he projects as a high-end NHL starter or part of a tandem, with fantasy value tied to workload.

Upside: NHL starter

3YP: 24-18-5, 2.70 GAA, 0.902 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 60%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.

Edmonton OILERS

At a Glance

Top Prospect: Isaac Howard
 Boom / Bust Potential: Maxim Berezkin
 Long-term project: Eemil Vinni
 Top sniper: Isaac Howard
 Best setup man: Viljami Marjala

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Isaac Howard
 Defense: Arto Leppanen
 Goal: Samuel Jonsson
 Points Only: Isaac Howard
 Multicategory: Maxim Berezkin

2026 Draftees: Rudolfs Berzkalns (F), Ryan Cameron (G), Malcom Gastrin (F), Caden Harvey (F), Andrew Robinson (D)

by Dobber



Isaac Howard, LW
 (2026: 39) (2025: 49)

Howard was acquired last summer in exchange for Edmonton's top prospect at the time, Sam O'Reilly. Although O'Reilly is a much better two-way player and a surefire NHLer, Howard—coming off a Hobey Baker win—was viewed as the higher-upside option who might eventually play with one of the team's top centers and was considered much closer to being NHL-ready. It turned out he was not. After a good camp, where he played mostly on the second line, he was dropped to the fourth line once the regular season began. After 18 games (three points), he was sent to the AHL, where he dominated with 50 points in 47 games. A January recall proved equally unimpressive. He is a quick skater with an accurate—though not powerful—shot, and defense is not a strong suit. Still only 22, Howard is waivers-exempt and not assured a roster spot in the fall, but the Oilers will push him because they need scoring depth.

Upside Comparable: Jonathan Marchessault (30-40-70+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 28-30-58, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 30%, 80%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Tommy Lafreniere, C/RW
 (2026: 110) (2025: N/A)

A third-round pick (83rd overall) last summer, Lafreniere shifted from wing to center and flourished on a line with potential first-round pick JP Hurlbert and Chicago prospect Nathan Behm. All three are committed to the NCAA for the fall, with Lafreniere heading to Western Michigan. He scored 41 goals with Kamloops and added three more points in eight AHL regular-season and playoff games for Bakersfield after his WHL season ended. Lafreniere isn't big (6-0, 183), but he plays hard. His grit, skill, and nose for the net remind some scouts of Blake Coleman. How well he transitions to the college level will determine how quickly he ascends to the NHL, but had he stayed in junior, his numbers likely would have been massive. This path is probably better for his development.

Upside Comparable: Blake Coleman (30-35-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 23-22-45, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Viljami Marjala, LW

(2026: 123) (2025: 186)

The 23-year-old Finn is a late bloomer who really found his offensive game after returning to Finland as a 19-year-old. His QMJHL numbers had been modest, but once he went back home, he became Liiga's Rookie of the Year. He compiled 101 points in 129 Liiga games, including 52 in his last 54. That was enough to earn him a contract with the Oilers, and he then crossed the pond again to play for Bakersfield. He finished third on the team in scoring with 60 points in 72 games, which tied him for sixth among AHL first-year players (not officially a rookie due to his Liiga experience). He is a smart player with good vision; not very big (6-0, 190); and a pass-first winger with slippery agility and decent, though not great, speed. He should start seeing cups of coffee in the year ahead, but this will be a make-or-break season for him.

Upside Comparable: Teuvo Teravainen (20-45-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 10-25-35, 18 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Maksim Berezkin (Maxim Beryozkin), RW

(2026: 124) (2025: 105)

Berezkin has not yet signed his entry-level contract with the Oilers, but at press time they were still in talks. It was supposed to happen last year, but his agent told him he probably wasn't ready, so he signed a one-year deal to stay in the KHL. Now 24, he's ready. That said, his numbers in the KHL took a significant step back, dropping from 42 to 32 points in 64 games. The ascension of Nashville prospect Yegor Surin took some key offensive ice time away from Berezkin, contributing to the decline, as well as new coach Bob Hartley taking away some of his ideal minutes and giving them to others. A big forward at 6-4 and 212 pounds, it's becoming clear that his NHL future is in the middle six rather than the top six. Even so, he'll get some looks alongside one of their star centermen, and if he catches lightning in a bottle—you never know. He's a bigger Vasili Podkolzin. **UPDATE:**

Reportedly signed a two-year extension to remain in the KHL.

Upside Comparable: Dustin Penner (20-40-60+, 50 PIM, 150 Hits)

3YP: 8-23-31, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: 2028-29

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits).



Quinn Hutson, C/RW

(2026: 146) (2025: N/A)

Yes, Quinn is the less-touted Hutson brother. He's the elder sibling, now 24, and unlike Cole and Lane, Quinn was never drafted. But he dominated the college ranks, compiling 50 points in 38 games as a junior with Boston University, and the Oilers promptly signed him. He adapted to the pro game very well; after recording three points in his first 10 games, he tallied 60 in his next 57 with AHL Bakersfield and earned two call-ups to the big club (one goal in four games). He has great poise and hockey sense, as well as a quick shot release that translates well to the pro level. A strong training camp could earn him a fourth-line job on a team that needs to fill that role. What he does with the opportunity is up to him, but he could absolutely move up to a skilled line.

Upside Comparable: Conor Sheary (25-35-60+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 10-25-35, 18 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



David Lewandowski, C

(2026: 195) (2025: N/A)

The 19-year-old starred for Team Germany at the WJC, finishing third on the team with four points in five games. In two years with Saskatoon (WHL), he posted 104 points in 109 games. Eligible for the AHL, he will look to crack the Bakersfield roster as a teenager, which is a tall order. But he embraces challenges and has risen to the occasion in the past, with strong performances in key WJC games and by coming across the pond to join the WHL midseason. The Oilers nabbed him with the 117th pick last summer and haven't regretted it. He was ranked as a Top-60 player by many scouting outlets before the draft. Lewandowski has a projectable frame, standing 6-2 and 177 pounds, and if he can add some bulk, he should be able to withstand the tougher AHL game.

Upside Comparable: Adam Lowry (20-40-60+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 16-19-35, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Samuel Poulin, LW

(2026: 243) (2025: 227)

Now with MTL

Poulin was once a highly touted prospect, drafted 21st overall by Pittsburgh. A power forward at 6-2 and 227 pounds, he was expected to take a couple of extra years to reach his potential. But injuries and personal issues have taken a toll, pushing him down the depth chart. Poulin was traded as part of the Tristan Jarry package, and a fresh start can only help. He enjoyed his second straight (mostly) healthy season, posting 20 points in 22 games with Wilkes-Barre and 29 in 49 games with Bakersfield. With Bakersfield, he was far more dominant and physical, honing in on that aspect of his skill set. Carrying that style into the AHL playoffs, he was one of their better players (four points in three games). Now 25, he needs to make his mark in camp; otherwise, the window will close.

Upside Comparable: Nick Ritchie (25-30-55+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 16-21-37, 43 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 20%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Now or never.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Paul Fischer, LD

(2026: 51D) (2025: 145D)

Acquired from St. Louis for future considerations (essentially an incentive for the Oilers not to match the Blues' offer sheets for Dylan Holloway and Philip Broberg), Fischer is a big, defense-first blueliner who has recently added an offensive dimension to his game. He has great mobility and is likely NHL-ready. He quarterbacked Notre Dame's power play and finished the season with 23 points in 33 games, earning a Hobey Baker nomination. He has committed to his senior season so the Oilers will have to wait until late March at the earliest, but the 21-year-old has the build (6-1, 211 pounds) to hold his own and profiles as a coveted target for fantasy managers seeking a polished, multi-categorical defenseman capable of providing strong blocks, reliable plus-minus coverage, and sneaky secondary power-play production.

Upside Comparable: Jaccob Slavin (8-37-45+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 4-24-28, 48 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28 but may play a few games after college season ends.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Beau Akey, RD

(2026: 63D) (2025: 65D)

The two-way rearguard missed the start of his first pro season with a core injury and returned to play four ECHL games to find his rhythm. Upon joining Bakersfield in mid-November, he worked his way up to the top pairing but was then slowed by a facial injury in late January. He returned a week later, but in April an upper-body injury sidelined him again. At 6-0 and 173 pounds, it's clear he needs to add bulk and strength to his smaller frame to help avoid some of these injuries. When healthy, he is a solid defenseman you would put out to protect a lead. He has offensive skills, but not in a first-unit power-play capacity. Instead, he would complement an offense-first partner and collect secondary assists that way. He is a sublime skater who is very mobile and at times can make risky passes. Injuries have stalled his development, so his NHL ETA should be pushed back.

Upside Comparable: Sean Durzi (10-35-45+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 5-23-28, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Atro Leppanen, LD

(2026: 65D) (2025: N/A)

Leppanen was a prolific offensive defenseman in Liiga, coming out of nowhere at age 25/26 and leading the entire league with 63 points in 60 games, more than doubling his total from the previous season. The Oilers were quick to sign him, and he agreed from the start that he would bring his game to the AHL. He made an immediate impact on Bakersfield's power play, recording 19 power-play points, including six during an 11-game span in November. He finished 11th among defensemen in points-per-game average with 38 points in 53 contests. He missed six weeks due to an upper-body injury and reportedly felt ready to return a week earlier, but the team's medical staff was extra cautious with him. He earned a contract extension, keeping him in the organization for another year. Now that he has a season in North America under his belt, look for him to push hard for a roster spot.

Upside Comparable: Justin Schultz (15-35-50, 40 PIM)

3YP: 8-28-36, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 25%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Now or never.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Asher Barnett, LD

(2026: 94D) (2025: N/A)

We initially had this spot reserved for Roby Jarventie, who was finally healthy for a full season, was productive in his AHL return, received a call-up to the NHL, and had a legitimate shot at a roster spot in the fall. But he elected to sign a two-year contract in Switzerland, taking him off the fantasy board until he's nearly 26. Barnett is a long shot, drafted in the fifth round last summer, but he does have good offensive instincts and can move the puck. His NCAA debut for a deep team like the

University of Michigan saw him post 18 points in 40 games as a freshman, which is a surprisingly good start and puts him on the fantasy radar. He was also on Team USA at the WJC (pointless in five games). He's still very raw, but he has NHL size (6-1, 201) and he's in a system that is quite shallow, which definitely helps his odds.

Upside Comparable: Mattias Ekholm (10-35-45+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 4-21-25, 32 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Samuel Jonsson, G

The big 6-5 netminder came to North America for the first time in the fall. The Oilers are easing him in the right way, sheltering him in the ECHL and gradually increasing his workload. They see a potential starter, and when he played a career-high 33 games (the most he has played at any level), he responded with a 21-8-2 record and a 0.910 save percentage, including five shutouts. With only Matt Tomkins signed for next season, the door is open for Jonsson to move up to the AHL and build on his successful year. Jonsson has good NHL size, having added 25 pounds since being drafted and now sitting at 217, and he has a quick glove, solid positioning, and very good poise. He is only 22, so the expectation is that he will spend another three years in the minor leagues.

Upside: Star NHL Starter

3YP: 30-20-5, 2.65 GAA, 0.908 SV%

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 25%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Eemil Vinni, G

Vinni is the highest-drafted goaltender currently in Edmonton's system, selected 64th overall in 2024. He has a high ceiling due to his size (6-3), athleticism, and aggressive, reflex-heavy style. After returning from back surgery, Vinni was transferred from HIFK back to JoKP to get healthy, consistent playing time. He struggled, managing just an 0.884 save percentage through 17 games. He lost the net and became a backup. JoKP then loaned him to Kettera, where he turned things around and finished strong in his final four games. He then dominated the Mestis playoffs with a stellar 0.942 save percentage. Just 20 years old, the Oilers will likely give him another season in Finland before bringing him over for a few years of development in the minors to carefully refine his raw tools into a reliable NHL starter.

Upside: Star NHL Starter

3YP: 30-20-5, 2.60 GAA, 0.910 SV%

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 20%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.

Florida PANTHERS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Jack Devine
 Boom / Bust potential: Shea Busch
 Long-term project: Mads Kongsbak Klyvo
 Top sniper: Sandis Vilmanis
 Best setup man: Jack Devine

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Jack Devine
 Defense: Mike Benning
 Goal: Cooper Black
 Points only: Jack Devine
 Multicategory: Shea Busch

2026 Draftees: Ryder Cali (F), Louis-Antoine Denault (G), Simas Ignatavicius (F), Jonas Kemps (D),
Vilho Vanhatalo (F), Cole Zurawski (F)

by Andrew Epps



Jack Devine, RW

(2026: 86) (2025: 101)

Two-time Hobey Baker finalist, Denver national champion, and second in points for Charlotte as an AHL rookie with 43 points in 63 games last season, Devine has quickly emerged as one of Florida's most intriguing late-round finds. The 5-11 seventh-rounder (221st overall, 2022) has been a top-eight scorer among all AHL first-year players, and Coach Paul Maurice has called his game reading "exceptional." Devine earned a brief NHL look earlier in the season and posted solid possession metrics on the fourth line despite limited minutes. His playmaking is the foundation of his game: his 25 assists led the Checkers, and his ability to find passing lanes through traffic and operate on the half-wall has translated at every level he has played. At 173 pounds, the physical concerns are legitimate. He can be outmuscled in board battles and will need to add strength before earning consistent NHL ice time. The Panthers finished 2025-26 with a deep roster, which limits immediate openings, but Devine's intelligence and compete level make him a realistic middle-six option once a spot becomes available.

Upside Comparable: Gustav Nyquist (25-45-70, 20 PIM)

3YP: 14-24-38, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Gracyn Sawchyn, C

(2026: 101) (2025: 108)

Before an upper-body injury shut him down early in 2026, the 5-10 speedster was leading Charlotte in assists and tied for first in points. His 23 points in 35 AHL games as a rookie confirmed what the WHL had already shown (200 points in 166 career games): Sawchyn creates offense through relentless pace and crafty playmaking. At 155 pounds, he is undersized, and the physicality gap against AHL defenders is real. He gets shielded off pucks, and heavier forecheckers can neutralize his cycle game. The skating compensates. He pulls defenders toward him, creates passing lanes through deception, and drives inside without concern for his own safety. Multiple evaluators project a move to wing, where he can focus on his offensive strengths without the full burden of center responsibilities. The injury cost him half a season of development, but if healthy, a second AHL year should clarify whether his speed and skill can translate into a middle-six NHL role.

Upside Comparable: Tyler Johnson (28-42-70, 20 PIM)

3YP: 12-22-34, 15 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Potential star—draft in the late rounds if you can afford to wait a few years.



Shea Busch, LW

(2026: 150) (2025: N/A)

Thirteen goals in 12 games—that was the pace the 6-2, 207-pound power forward was on for Everett before an upper-body injury in late October shut down his season. Busch (128th overall, 2025) had just emerged as a legitimate WHL force: top line, power play, leading the Silvertips in goals, with a noticeably harder and more accurate wrist shot than in his draft year. His GM called the previous spring's playoff run his "coming-out party" after he posted 11 points in 13 games. The scouting report is straightforward: he plays in hard areas, leans into defenders, wins net-front positioning, and does not give up on pucks. The skating is the developmental bottleneck. Unless it reaches pro caliber, his ceiling remains that of a depth forward. He is committed to Penn State, and the NCAA timeline gives him years to develop. The injury clouds the short-term outlook, but the goal-scoring ability he showed before it happened was impossible to ignore.

Upside Comparable: Zach Hyman (30-35-65+, 45 PIM)

3YP: 12-26-38, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Sandis Vilmanis, LW/RW

(2026: 230) (2025: 322)

The first player in Checkers franchise history to score four goals in a game—and he did it in his second pro season at 22 years old. The 6-1 Latvian jumped from 27 points as an AHL rookie to 38 in just 48 games this past year, earning 19 NHL games where he threw 38 Hits and scored three goals on the Panthers' fourth line. His shot is NHL-caliber right now: a quick, deceptive release that beats goaltenders clean from the circles. He represented Latvia at the 2026 Olympics, adding international experience to an impressive résumé for a fifth-rounder (157th overall, 2022). The concerns are consistency and defensive engagement. Vilmanis can look like a point-per-game player for stretches, then disappear for weeks. His ELC expires after 2026–27, and the Cats face a decision on whether to keep him or let him walk. If potential UFA A.J. Greer and Tomas Nosek depart on July 1, a fourth-line spot could open at camp.

Upside Comparable: Nino Niederreiter (20-35-55+, 30 PIM, 150 Hits)

3YP: 10-14-24, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 12%, 80%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling or if your league tracks PIM or Hits).



Mads Kongsbak Klyvo, LW

(2026: 285) (2025: N/A)

The only NHL-drafted player on Denmark's WJC roster—and he played like it. The 6-2, 194-pound power forward served as an alternate captain and tied for the team lead in goals with three, including a two-goal, one-assist performance against Germany. That showing came after he missed

the entire first half of the season with an injury, wiping out what was supposed to be his breakout SHL campaign with Frolunda. When healthy, the scouting report is enticing: a big-bodied winger who skates with explosive acceleration and a low center of gravity that makes him nearly impossible to knock off balance. He earned four SHL playoff games with Frolunda's senior team as a 17-year-old and was named Best Forward at the U18 WJC after posting nine points in five games. Florida's first pick of the 2025 class, he is years away but carries legitimate upside if his frame and skating continue to develop.

Upside Comparable: Ondrej Palat (22-33-55+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 10-14-24, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Do not draft this year or next.



Stepan Gorbunov, C

(2026: 347) (2025: 589)

At 6-5 with the versatility to play forward or defense, the Russian sixth-rounder (169th overall, 2024) is the kind of raw athletic project that either pays off spectacularly or never materializes. He earned a brief KHL roster spot with Traktor Chelyabinsk to open the season before being sent to the VHL, where he posted six points in seven games through November. The prior year told the more compelling story: he tore through the MHL (13 points in nine games) and earned a promotion to the VHL, where his 25 points ranked second among his age group in Russia's second-best league. Florida brought him to development camp, where his hands and puck protection stood out for a player his size. His wingspan creates advantages in board battles and retrievals that smaller forwards cannot replicate. The concerns are standard for Russian projects: unsigned, years from North America, and his skating and processing speed need significant refinement before the NHL becomes realistic.

Upside Comparable: Nick Bjugstad (20-35-55+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 8-12-20, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Do not draft this year or next.



Arvid Drott, RW

(2026: 365) (2025: N/A)

Ranked as high as 23rd by *The Hockey News*, he fell to 192nd overall, and multiple scouting outlets called him a steal. The 6-1, 187-pound Swede from Stockholm plays a compact power-winger game built on explosive skating, a precise wrist shot, and a willingness to drive the net through traffic. He posted 36 points in 40 J20 games in his draft year and maintained a point-per-game pace through the first half of his D+1 season with Djurgarden, finishing the campaign with 15-10-25 in 28 games. He represented Sweden at the 2024 Hlinka Gretzky Cup and the 2025 U18 WJC, winning bronze and silver. At 17, he was one of the youngest players in his draft class, which explains some of the rawness. His anticipation and situational reads need work, and his consistency in 50/50 puck battles fluctuates. The SHL is the next test. If his skating and physicality translate against men, the offensive tools project a legitimate middle-six winger.

Upside Comparable: Jason Zucker (25-35-60+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 10-14-24, 25 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Do not draft this year or next.



Linus Eriksson, C

(2026: 420) (2025: 325)

Florida traded up to draft him 58th overall, and draft analyst Corey Pronman ranked him 26th, so the pedigree exceeds what the scoresheet currently shows. The Swedish two-way center collected two goals and seven points in 43 SHL games with Timrå this season, a line that makes fantasy managers scroll past. The defensive game tells a different story. Eriksson models himself after Aleksander Barkov and Joel Eriksson Ek, and his off-puck habits, forechecking pressure, and penalty kill deployment earned him consistent SHL ice time at 19. He scored twice in four WJC games for Sweden in January 2025 and was named to the 2026 roster, reflecting international trust. *DobberProspects* notes his shot carries "significant upside" and projects a North American arrival around 2027-28. The offensive production needs to catch up before any NHL discussion becomes realistic, though. If it does and matches the two-way foundation, he projects as a bottom-six center who kills penalties and adds 40-50 points, with upside for middle-six.

Upside Comparable: Joel Eriksson Ek (20-35-55+, 35 PIM)

3YP: 8-14-22, 15 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait, 2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



Mike Benning, RD

(2026: 39D) (2025: 32D)

Unrestricted Free Agent

He scored the game-winning goal in the 2022 NCAA National Championship and was named Frozen Four Most Outstanding Player. Three AHL seasons later, the 5-9, 185-pound right-shot defenseman from an NHL family (brother Matt, father Brian, and uncle Jim all played professionally) finally made his NHL debut in March, scoring twice against the Red Wings. Benning has led Charlotte's blue line in scoring for two straight years, posting 31 points in 57 games this season with a plus-9 rating. The power play is his calling card: he quarterbacks the point with vision, a quick release, and the ability to walk the line and find shooting lanes. At his size, the defensive game remains the obstacle. He gets overpowered in front of his own net and struggles against heavier forwards on the cycle. His contract expires this summer, and the RFA negotiation will determine whether Florida views him as a future PP option or an organizational depth piece.

Upside Comparable: Kevin Shattenkirk (12-35-47)

3YP: 5-18-23

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Cooper Black, G

At 6-8, few goaltenders in professional hockey cover as much net as the undrafted Dartmouth product. Black seized the Charlotte crease after Brandon Bussi was claimed off waivers by Carolina before the NHL's 2025-26 season opener and never let go, posting 25 wins in 42 games (fourth in the AHL) while backstopping a team that finished fourth in goals against league-wide. His rookie year numbers were even better: a 1.98 GAA and 0.910 save percentage in 17 games. He cuts angles naturally, makes shooters feel like they are aiming at a wall, and tracks pucks through traffic with surprising lateral ability for his frame. The 0.903 save percentage reflects early-season growing pains before he settled into the starter's role. If Florida re-signs the young UFA, the development runway points toward a legitimate backup role within two years.

Upside: 1A NHL split starter

3YP: 16-12-5, 2.75 GAA, 0.900 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 50%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Tyler Muszelik, G

Every year in college was better than the last. From a 0.883 backup at New Hampshire to a 0.926 starter at UConn who ranked fifth nationally in save percentage, the 6-3 New Jersey native has followed one of the steepest development curves in NCAA goaltending. His senior campaign (19 wins, a 2.21 GAA, and three shutouts) carried the Huskies to a second straight NCAA Tournament appearance and earned him a Hockey East All-Star nod. Florida signed him to a two-year ELC in late March, and he will begin his pro career in Charlotte next fall. The athleticism and poise are legitimate: he reads shooters well, stays patient in his crease, and has improved his lateral quickness each year. The depth chart is the problem. Sergei Bobrovsky, Daniil Tarasov, and Cooper Black all sit ahead of him, and the Panthers' Goaltending Excellence Department will need time to develop him at the AHL level. If the trajectory continues, a backup opportunity could materialize in three to four years.

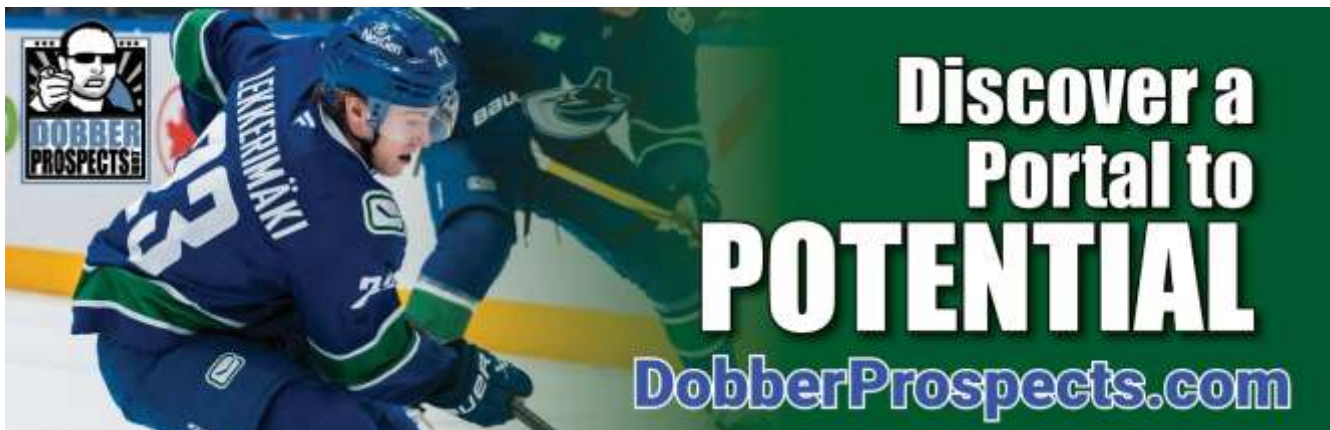
Upside: NHL backup

3YP: 14-10-4, 2.85 GAA, 0.907 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 8%, 35%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Los Angeles KINGS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Carter George
 Boom / Bust potential: Koehn Ziemmer
 Long-term project: Vojtech Cihar
 Top sniper: Koehn Ziemmer
 Best setup man: Martin Chromiak

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Koehn Ziemmer
 Defense: Otto Salin
 Goal: Carter George
 Points only: Martin Chromiak
 Multicategory: Koehn Ziemmer

2026 Draftees: [Lucas Ambrosio \(D\)](#), [Adam Goljer \(D\)](#), [Elton Hermansson \(F\)](#), [Alex Kostov \(F\)](#), [Tobias Krestan \(F\)](#), [Liam Lefebvre \(F\)](#), [Giorgos Pantelas \(D\)](#), [Yegor Rybkin \(G\)](#), [Vertti Svensk \(D\)](#), [Thomas Vandenberg \(F\)](#), [Blake Zielinski \(F\)](#)

by Sean Crocker



Vojtek Cihar, LW

(2026: 88) (2025: N/A)

Cihar transitioned to North America midway through last season to join the WHL Kelowna Rockets, where he scored at a point-per-game pace with 31 points. His 6-0, 179-pound frame allowed him to fight his way through puck battles in a way he couldn't during his pro experience in Czechia. He also played a major role in Czechia's silver medal at the 2026 WJC, recording 12 points in seven games (tops on the team and fourth in the entire tourney). Cihar is a high-motor player with a strong blend of playmaking ability, vision, and grit. He is eligible for the AHL in 2026–27 and could look to contribute as early as next season. He is still likely a few years away from the NHL level, but he has the determination and skill to reach that endgame.

Upside Comparable: Jakub Vrana (30-40-70+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 15-17-32, 16 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Kenny Connors, C

(2026: 120) (2025: 150)

With the retirement of Anze Kopitar, the Kings will have a void at center next season that they will not be able to fill with a single piece. Enter Connors, who has been with the organization for four years, with last season marking his first full professional campaign. He is a responsible pivot beyond his years and has also found ways to contribute offensively. He uses his body intelligently to win faceoffs and board battles, and he employs a strong defensive stick to break up plays and compensate for any shortcomings in his game. Connors is a high-floor player who could make an impact soon, even possessing some of the 200-foot traits Kopitar had—albeit to a much lesser extent. Fantasy managers who remain patient with him should be rewarded with steady production, especially in formats that reward faceoffs.

Upside Comparable: Phillip Danault (15-45-60+, 25 PIM)

3YP: 10-21-31, 14 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Jimmy Lombardi, C

(2026: 122) (2025: N/A)

Every team needs a pest who can stir the pot. The 6-0, 187-pound Lombardi took a major step forward offensively last season, increasing his point production by 50 percent and nearly tripling his goal total to 36 with the Flint Firebirds. He is a tenacious player who loves to drive the paint and create chaos. Lombardi is a steady play-driver who frequently carries the puck through the neutral zone. His quick release is deceptive, but linemates must be ready for a crafty pass because he is so unpredictable. Poolies shouldn't target Lombardi for his offensive upside, but rather for his certainty. He is already a dependable forward for his age and will only grow in that regard as he matures. These habits are the kind that fast-track a prospect to the NHL.

Upside Comparable: Kiefer Sherwood (25-35-60+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 12-31-43, 25 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Koehn Ziemmer, RW

(2026: 148) (2025: 127)

Ziemmer made the jump to professional hockey after a successful junior career in which he produced over a point per game with an even split between goals and assists. His quick release makes him dangerous from all areas of the ice, and he's willing to drive the net. He scored 11 goals in his rookie AHL season, and he should have an opportunity to contribute more next year as he continues adjusting to the pro game. Ziemmer has a large 6-2 frame that allows him to make a physical impact, paired with an excellent compete level, but the rest of his toolkit still needs refinement. He lacks a strong first stride and often struggles to reach top speed. Skating is the top priority heading into the offseason, as his diverse offensive skill set makes him a threat whenever he's on the ice. Ziemmer could emerge as a 30-goal middle-six or top-six sniper, or he could settle into a physical bottom-six scoring role. He has a good chance to reach the former.

Upside Comparable: Alex Chiasson (30-35-65+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 20-25-45, 60 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Martin Chromiak, RW/LW

(2026: 205) (2025: 207)

Chromiak has had a roller-coaster tenure in the Kings organization since being drafted 128th overall in 2020. He has yet to replicate the strong offensive numbers he produced in the OHL with Kingston, and he has not been able to crack the NHL roster or play his first NHL game. A strong showing in the AHL last season, however, put him back on the map. He scored 28 goals and 56 points while recording the highest shot total of his professional career. When he's producing, he can get hot, but when he struggles to generate offense, he risks riding the bench. Chromiak will need to clear waivers to be sent down, giving him a window of opportunity to seize one of the open bottom-six roles in the lineup and work his way up from there.

Upside Comparable: Dominik Kubalik (30-35-65+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 18-15-33, 14 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Brendan McMorrow, LW

(2026: 229) (2025: N/A)

The Kings' trend of drafting players who are tough to play against and bring a physical brand of hockey continues with McMorrow. His 190-pound frame allows him to act as a battering ram against smaller players in board battles. He was used primarily in defensive situations for Denver in the NCAA this past year and was a consistent penalty killer. He is another forward in the Kings' system who projects as an effective bottom-six energy player—the type every good team needs in its depth. His offensive ceiling is limited, but he has the potential to carve out a gritty role that puts him in position to contribute. He is likely a long-term project, albeit one who could become a long-time NHLer once he breaks through—and an instant fan favorite because of his style of play. He will definitely need time, though.

Upside Comparable: Blake Coleman (20-35-55+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 10-15-25, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Do not draft this year or next.



Jan Chovan, LW

(2026: 372) (2025: N/A)

Chovan crossed the pond to play with the Sudbury Wolves of the OHL, where he transitioned well by scoring 28 goals and 55 points. He is better known for his defensive and positional play, using his size and reach to protect pucks and maintain possession, which in turn creates offense. A safe and projectable talent, he showed strong offensive growth compared to his years in Finland and could look to transition to the AHL next season. Chovan is a prospect worth watching. He lacks the unpredictability of a dynamic forward, but that isn't his game. He will be more dependable than most players his age and will need to rely on his blend of size and IQ to reach the NHL.

Upside Comparable: Alex Newhook (20-40-60+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 5-15-20, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



Henry Brzustewicz, RD

(2026: 38D) (2025: N/A)

Brzustewicz already looks like a player with the makings of a No. 4 defenseman on an NHL team. His 6-1, 194-pound frame allows him to bully smaller opponents and protect softer areas of the ice. As he moves up levels the task won't get easier, but he is a fundamentally sound defender who can handle tough minutes, as he showed with the London Knights during their Memorial Cup season two years ago. He lost his most common blue line partner, Sam Dickinson, yet his offense grew last season, producing 19 goals and 54 points in 59 games. Brzustewicz is not quite NHL-ready, but another season in the Ontario junior circuit could do wonders as he adapts to the pro game. The 31st-overall pick in 2025 may be closer to NHL time than many expect, especially with an aging core

in Los Angeles. He won't rack up points for fantasy managers, but he will log tough minutes and could benefit peripherally as a result.

Upside Comparable: Ryan Pullock (10-30-40+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 6-18-24, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Kirill Kirsanov, LD

(2026: 43D) (2025: 69D)

Kirsanov's offensive totals will never jump off the page, like those of Henry Brzustewicz, but he is a towering 6-2, 220-pound defenseman with plenty of physicality. He is a cerebral player who is rarely caught out of position and uses an excellent defensive stick to erase mistakes. After finally coming over from Russia last season, he was a steady presence on the back end. What he lacks in skating ability and speed, he makes up for with smart positioning. He rarely jumps into the rush and instead waits for the play to come to him, yet he is surprisingly seldom caught flat-footed when defending in transition. Kirsanov also has a capable shot when he chooses to use it and can distribute the puck effectively. However, that won't be why fantasy managers roster him—his value will come from peripheral stats, especially in leagues that reward heavy minute-munching defensemen.

Upside Comparable: Jacob Trouba (5-45-50+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 7-15-22, 37 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Otto Salin, RD

(2026: 60D) (2025: 88D)

Salin is a puck-moving defenseman who initiates breakouts well and fits the mold of a modern blueliner. He struggled mightily at times, often looking outmatched against bigger competition. At 5-11, the transition from Finland can be daunting, as the level of physicality ramps up significantly in North American professional hockey. Still, Salin is only 22 years old and showed progress in how he processes the game. He is a breakout specialist who loves to carry the puck, though he wasn't able to do so as freely as he once did. If Salin can further develop into the puck-moving defenseman he was in his draft year, he could become a valuable addition to a Kings defense corps that has lacked that skill set in recent seasons. NHL blue-line construction tends to swing like a pendulum, and it may be swinging Salin's way at the right time.

Upside Comparable: Rasmus Andersson (15-35-50, 10 PIM)

3YP: 5-15-20, 2 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Hampton Slukynsky, G

Slukynsky is fresh off signing his ELC, which means he will immediately factor into the Reign's plans. He was stellar in limited action, posting a 0.957 save percentage and a 1.00 GAA in two games. He is the smallest goalie in the Los Angeles system and will need to secure his spot in the NHL before Carter George or he may never see his upside in this organization. His athleticism is

a plus, but he must continue developing more conventional habits so he doesn't rely on desperation—an area in which he notably improved this past NCAA season. Still, Slukynsky has a strong track record of results, recording a 0.915 save percentage or better in both of his NCAA seasons along with a sub-2.00 goals-against average. The goalie battle will be competitive this season, but Slukynsky has shown he can rise above the competition, and he has a major opportunity to do so.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 32-19-4, 2.72 GAA, 0.910 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Carter George, G

Goalies are always a contentious point of debate among scouts. Between size, athleticism, and vision, George brings the full package. His 6-2, 190-pound frame sits at the lower end of what NHL teams look for in terms of size in goal, but he pairs it with the athleticism and vision required of a slightly smaller goaltender. He had a tough start on an abysmal Owen Sound Attack team but found his game after being traded to the Soo, posting a 2.40 GAA and a 0.913 save percentage. George shows excellent poise and vision—especially through traffic—while maintaining a level of composure rarely seen in young netminders. Goalies often take time to reach the NHL, but if all goes well for George, his stock could rise significantly with a strong season. Turning pro, however, is a completely different challenge and how quickly his game translates will determine how he stacks up versus Slukynsky, who is a year older and a year ahead. He may start off in the ECHL, while Portillo and Slukynsky backstop the Reign.

Upside Comparable: Star NHL starter

3YP: 32-19-4, 2.72 GAA, 0.910 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round pick.



Erik Portillo, G

Portillo is the senior netminder in the AHL crease for the Kings and once again delivered an above-average season for the Reign. With an 18-7-3 record, a 2.45 GAA, and a 0.907 save percentage, Portillo has looked close to NHL-ready for some time. He is a traditional goaltender in the sense that he uses his size to his advantage, allowing him to play deeper in his crease and anticipate cross-ice plays. He primarily split starts with Phoenix Copley, who is now a free agent, meaning Portillo is likely to receive a longer runway as the AHL starter and serve as the first call-up option. With holdover Darcy Kuemper another year older, the Kings may soon need to pivot in goal—and Portillo represents a viable internal solution. He may be just a year away from contending for a split share of the NHL crease, or even the starter's role outright. He is exempt from waivers for one more season.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 32-19-4, 2.72 GAA, 0.910 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.

Minnesota WILD

At a Glance

Top prospect: Charlie Stramel
 Boom / Bust potential: Samuel Hlavac
 Long-term project: Aron Kiviharju
 Top sniper: Charlie Stramel
 Best setup man: Adam Benak

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Charlie Stramel
 Defense: Aron Kiviharju
 Goal: Samuel Hlavac
 Points only: Adam Benak
 Multicategory: Charlie Stramel

2026 Draftees: Adam Andersson (F), Kayden Lemire (F), Filip Ruzicka (G)

by Dobber



Charlie Stramel, C

(2026: 19) (2025: 265)

Stramel is coming off a massive NCAA season that saw him become a Hobey Baker finalist while posting 44 points in 37 games. He played alongside future superstar Porter Martone (Philadelphia), but Stramel was far from a passenger. He was the heart and soul of that line, leading the team in plus/minus (plus-29), faceoffs, and game-winning goals while anchoring both special-teams units. His 6-3, 215-pound frame provided the physical net-front presence that allowed Martone to flourish. A 21st-overall pick in 2023, Stramel had a disappointing first season after the draft, but moving to Michigan State was exactly what he needed. His size and upside undoubtedly played a role in the Wild's decision to include Marco Rossi in the Quinn Hughes trade. Stramel blocked a shot in the NCAA Regional Final that broke his ankle, but the Wild still signed him to his ELC. Expect him to make the big club out of camp.

Upside Comparable: Eric Staal (30-45-75, 70 PIM)

3YP: 21-36-57, 64 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 25%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Adam Benak, C

(2026: 84) (2025: N/A)

It's the usual story—you see one or two of these every year. A player is regarded as one of the best skaters and most intelligent players in the NHL Draft, but he slips to the fourth round because he's 5-8 instead of 6-0. And Benak held the Hlinka-Gretzky tournament record for most points (21, between 2024 and 2025)! Sure enough, Benak took the OHL by storm, posting 77 points in 48 games and missing time because he was busy helping Czechia's U20 team, where he tallied eight points in seven games. He is a pass-first player—an assist machine who could easily help a sniper reach the next level. He has committed to playing for Western Michigan of the NCAA in the fall. It may be wise to secure him now and sit on him rather than wait until he posts gaudy college numbers and his value surges for next year's fantasy draft.

Upside Comparable: Logan Stankoven (but more passes/fewer shots) (25-50-75+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 16-34-50, 38 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Riley Heidt, C/LW

(2026: 140) (2025: 75)

Heidt's transition to pro hockey has disappointed his fantasy owners, but it wasn't all that bad. After dominating the junior circuit with 304 points in his last 194 WHL games, his 25 points in 71 AHL games was quite a letdown. On the bright side, after starting slowly with three points in his first 17 games, his 22 points in the following 54 show that things improved—albeit gradually. The former Prince George captain showed flashes of his strong playmaking and two-way acumen. The fact that he didn't take the league by storm tempers expectations and likely caps his upside, but given his junior numbers and the fact that Iowa played a defense-first system (their leading scorer managed just 42 points in 60 games), you should not rule him out just yet. If you already own him, consider giving him another year, but if he's undrafted, leave him and see what happens in 2026–27.

Upside Comparable: Yanni Gourde (25-40-65+, 60+ PIM)

3YP: 15-37-52, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Hunter Haight, C

(2026: 145) (2025: 151)

Haight is a hardworking, versatile two-way forward who plays with a bit of an edge. He nearly made the Wild out of training camp and was called up five times. He managed two points in nine games while playing fourth-line minutes. He was mostly given offensive-zone starts, but the coach trusted him against tougher opponents, and he performed very well. In the AHL, he has been a 20-goal, 40-point-pace player, and the Wild would like to see a bit more offense. Otherwise, he checks all the boxes for becoming an NHL regular—a true Swiss-Army knife. A second-round pick in 2022 (47th overall), Haight could break camp on the fourth line and work his way up from there over the next several years. Clicking with a top-six winger would be necessary for him to reach his upside.

Upside Comparable: Chandler Stephenson (25-35-60+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 18-25-43, 38 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 10%, 75%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Ryder Ritchie, RW

(2026: 170) (2025: 206)

Ritchie, a second-round pick in 2024 (45th overall), enjoyed a very productive season with Medicine Hat playing alongside Gavin McKenna in 2024–25. But both of them moved to the NCAA afterward, joining different teams, and while the younger McKenna flourished, Ritchie struggled. On a deep Boston University roster, Ritchie managed just 17 points in 36 games, finishing fifth on the team in scoring behind the likes of Cole Hutson (Washington) and Cole Eiserman (NY Islanders). The 6-2, 190-pound forward is clearly a passenger on his line rather than the driver. He did assert himself more physically, showing potential as a middle-six power forward who can chip in modest offense while providing *some* value in banger leagues. The son of former NHLer Byron Ritchie, Ryder will remain with Boston for at least another two years.

Upside Comparable: Rickard Rakell (20-40-60+, 60+ PIM)

3YP: 18-25-43, 53 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Lirim Amidovski, RW

(2026: 260) (2025: N/A)

A power forward drafted in the fourth round last summer (121st overall), Amidovski saw his offense improve to 25 goals and 48 points for North Bay of the OHL, where he served as one of the team's alternate captains. Those numbers aren't overly impressive, but North Bay lacked true offensive stars and instead spread scoring throughout the lineup. Amidovski is a winger who drives the net and plays bigger than his 6-1, 180-pound frame. He has committed to Connecticut for this season, where his relentless puck-hounding mechanics and heavy inside game should translate seamlessly to the college pace. If his linear speed continues to progress against mature NCAA defensive structures, his projection as a versatile, bottom-six energy piece at the professional level remains firmly on track within the Wild pipeline.

Upside Comparable: Barclay Goodrow (25-30-55+, 60+ PIM)

3YP: 16-20-36, 45 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Caedan Bankier, C

(2026: 321) (2025: 180)

After a solid junior career in the WHL and a depth role on Team Canada's 2023 WJC squad, Bankier made a smooth transition to pro hockey in 2023-24. However, his defensive game was seriously exposed that year, and he has spent the two seasons since working to address it. He has rounded himself into more of a checking specialist, but that has come at the cost of developing his offense, which has stagnated. He is a smart player with good hockey sense but lacks the confidence to make risk-reward plays. He also lacks the footspeed to thrive as a defensive specialist at the NHL level, making it likely that he falls short as either a bottom-six or top-six forward. Now 23, his window is closing on his hope of honing those tools and being taken seriously as a fantasy option.

Upside Comparable: Philip Danault (20-40-60+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 10-25-35, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 5%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Rasmus Kumpulainen, C

(2026: 305) (2025: 292)

A point-per-game player in the OHL as an 18-year-old, Kumpulainen returned to Finland to play in Liiga against mature competition. He managed 16 points in 48 games there, which is solid for his age but by no means a statement of future stardom. A 53rd-overall draft pick in 2023, he projects more as a middle-six center who plays with a bit of grit, does a little bit of everything, and plays responsible hockey. He can hold his own in the corners when digging for pucks and puts himself in good spots when he doesn't have the puck. He isn't the most creative offensive player, and without

skilled linemates his production will be limited. He returned to North America last season and was unable to make Iowa, instead bouncing back and forth between there and the ECHL. Given that he's a long way off and his upside is limited, he is a player you shouldn't own in any format.

Upside Comparable: Lars Eller (30-30-60+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 10-20-30, 43 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 5%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Aron Kiviharju, LD

(2026: 56D) (2025: 204D)

When he was 16, Kiviharju was considered one of the top prospects in hockey. However, his growth stalled, his development slowed, and he fell to the fourth round, where the Wild selected him at 122nd overall. Undersized at 5-9 and 170 pounds, the Dane has high-end offensive instincts and very good puck-moving ability. He is signed with HIFK through 2028, so if he doesn't make the Wild, he will return to Finland for further development. That is the likely scenario given his age (20), size, and the fact that he needs another two to three years of seasoning. He captained Finland's U20 team at the WJC and recorded five assists in six games, proving that his elite visual scanning and poise under intense structural pressure remain intact.

Upside Comparable: Samuel Girard (10-40-50, 20 PIM)

3YP: 5-25-30, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Justin Kipkie, LD

(2026: 79D) (2025: 70D)

Kipkie wrapped up a strong WHL career, posting 114 points in his final 121 games for Victoria, a team he captained in 2024-25. Drafted twice—both times in the fifth round (by Arizona in 2023 and by the Wild in 2025)—he moved to Arizona State last season and made a seamless transition. He has grown significantly, adding an inch (now 6-4) and 20 pounds (up to 215) over the past two years. He doesn't yet play to his size, but if he ever learns to do so, he could become an imposing force with strong offensive instincts and a quick-release snapshot. The potential is there for him to carve out an NHL career, but he absolutely needs to build the confidence to use his size more effectively to make things happen.

Upside Comparable: Philip Broberg (10-35-45+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 5-25-30, 34 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Theodor Hallquist, RD

(2026: 167D) (2025: N/A)

Minnesota's top pick last summer didn't come until 52nd overall, when they selected Hallquist. A lanky 6-2 defender with a projectable frame, Hallquist is a fluid right-shot blueliner with high-end hockey sense and vision. Last season, at 18, he played against men in Sweden's second league (Allsvenskan). His numbers were far from impressive—just three points in 30 games with a minus-16 rating—but that's expected for someone so young. He even appeared in eight SHL games,

recording one point. He plays with a maturity beyond his years and makes a strong first pass. He needs to add bulk to his 172-pound frame, which would significantly help his game. Too often he was muscled off the puck and struggled to move bigger forwards from the front of the net. Strength and conditioning this offseason will be Priority One.

Upside Comparable: Nils Lundkvist (5-35-40, 50 PIM)

3YP: 4-23-27, 38 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Samuel Hlavaj, G

Unrestricted Free Agent

The Wild signed Hlavaj as an undrafted European free agent in April 2024 after watching him perform well in the Slovakian League and backstop Team Slovakia at the World Championship. He immediately showed it was a wise move by delivering an even better performance at the 2024 WC, stealing a couple of games. The 6-4, 218-pound goaltender quickly worked his way up to the AHL the following season, and then looked great in the Olympics (2-3, 3.56 GAA, 0.908 SV%), often carrying the team on his back to an unlikely fourth-place finish. He was hit-and-miss in the AHL last season, often looking great for two periods before falling apart in the third. Now 25, it would be ideal for him to see some NHL games in the season ahead, depending on what the Wild do with their two elite starters.

Upside: NHL backup

3YP: 15-10-2, 3.55 GAA, 0.898 SV%

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 35%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

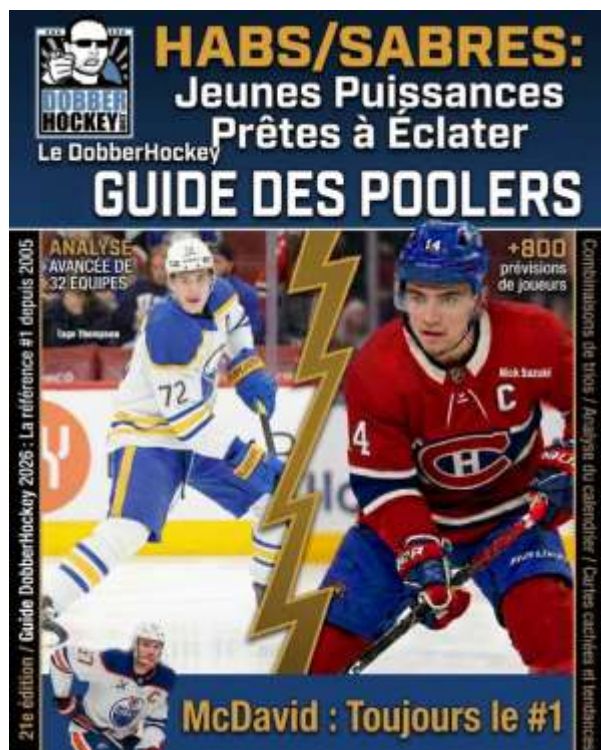
DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.

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Montreal CANADIENS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Michael Hage
 Boom / Bust potential: John Mooney
 Long-term project: Carlos Handel
 Top sniper: Alexander Zharovsky
 Best setup man: Michael Hage

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Alexander Zharovsky
 Defense: Bryce Pickford
 Goal: Jacob Fowler
 Points only: Alexander Zharovsky
 Multicategory: Owen Beck

2026 Draftees: Cooper Cleaves (D), Jean-Samuel Daigneault (D), Tyler Deakos (F), Brayden Klimpke (D), Gleb Pugachyov (F), Wesley Royston (F), Timofei Runtso (D), Parker Trottier (F)

by Dobber



Michael Hage, C
 (2026: 7) (2025: 58)



After a dominant WJC tournament for Team Canada, in which he led all players with 15 points, Hage was named to the All-Star Team while simultaneously moving front and center on the radar of fantasy owners. The 21st overall pick in 2024 has also added strength and bulk to his 6-1 frame (now 199 pounds), helping him impose his will against NCAA competition. He finished tied for third in the nation with 52 points in 39 games, leading the country in assists. A sublime setup man who would flourish alongside a sniper, Hage could eventually center the two Russian studs, Alexander Zharovsky and Ivan Demidov—a potentially ridiculous 1B line behind Nick Suzuki, Cole Caufield, and Juraj Slafkovsky. Things are getting scary in Montreal. Hage has committed to Michigan, where he will serve as an alternate captain and play with his brother, draft-eligible Alexander.

Upside Comparable: Nick Suzuki (30-65-95, 30 PIM)

3YP: 27-52-89, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 95%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28, but he may play the final few games this season after his college year.

DH Draft Advice: Blue-chip prospect—draft ASAP.



Alexander Zharovsky, RW
 (2026: 11) (2025: N/A)



For the second consecutive year, a Habs prospect has been named the KHL's Rookie of the Year. That's not a surprise, given that Zharovsky was Rookie of the Month for three different months last season. His 42 points as a teenager tie Kirill Kaprizov's mark for second all-time, just two points behind future teammate Ivan Demidov's 44 and one point ahead of what Matvei Michkov (Philadelphia) produced. Unfortunately for fantasy owners, Zharovsky is staying in the KHL for one more year, but he'll be worth the wait. A brilliant player with exceptional puckhandling skills, Zharovsky can both finish and distribute. Still only 19, it's difficult to pin down his upside, since whatever projection we give him, he could feasibly surpass—especially given how effortlessly his elite visual scanning and processing speed already allow him to pick apart mature professional defenses. NHL-ready now, we'll just have to wait.

Upside Comparable: Nikita Kucherov (40-55-95+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 32-46-78, 54 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 90%
Expected Arrival: 2027–28.
DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP.



Joshua Roy, W
(2026: 89) (2025: 21)

Now with UTA

Although Roy has played fewer NHL games than he did the year prior, keep in mind that he is still only 22 and his waiver exemption is up. Barring a horrible camp, the Habs will keep him. What he does with that opportunity will determine his role. Already offensively gifted, Roy has spent two years focusing on a complete game, and you can see the difference. In his last NHL appearance, he was given very tough minutes and did well driving possession despite starting in his own zone against top lines. His skating speed has noticeably improved (per NHL Edge—his top speed is up two MPH compared to two years ago). The Habs are filling their top six quickly; if he doesn't make his mark this year, he may need a fresh start elsewhere. In the AHL, his offense has been steady—slightly improved, even—and his play has become noticeably more aggressive, which only helps.

Upside Comparable: Tyler Toffoli (30-40-70+, 50 PIM)
3YP: 20-25-45, 28 PIM
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%
Expected Arrival: This fall.
DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Owen Beck, C
(2026: 100) (2025: 90)

A proven winner with a great work ethic, this jack-of-all-trades forward is on the cusp of earning a full-time NHL roster spot. Beck, drafted 33rd overall in 2022, can play any forward position, but his strength is in the faceoff circle, where he is a rare prospect who already dominates the dot (56.4% FOW rate, 117 NHL faceoffs). He is an integral part of both special-teams units and has strong offensive instincts (81 points in 57 games in his final OHL season). He can produce numbers similar to Mikael Backlund—or even exceed them—but with the offensive talent in Montreal's system, Beck will almost certainly spend his first few seasons in the bottom six. He remains waiver-exempt for another year, but it's doubtful he spends another full season in the AHL. If he doesn't crack the lineup out of camp, he'll be an early call-up.

Upside Comparable: Brayden Schenn (25-35-60, 40 PIM, 200 Hits)
3YP: 15-25-40, 30 PIM, 150 Hits
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 85%
Expected Arrival: This fall.
DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling).



John Mooney, RW
(2026: 162) (2025: N/A)

Another small (5'8") player who dropped in the NHL Draft because of his size despite having high-end skills, Mooney was a point-per-game performer in the USNTDP before moving to the NCAA. In his freshman year, the diminutive forward tallied 30 points in 34 games on a deep University of Minnesota team, playing alongside top Buffalo prospect Brodie Ziemer. Mooney brings a tremendous amount of energy to the game—a jitterbug out there with elite stickhandling and high hockey IQ. His ability to execute complex playmaking adjustments at top speed makes him a modern, high-ceiling offensive threat for the Habs. Drafted in the fourth round last summer (113th overall), the Pennsylvania native is a cousin of Utah star Logan Cooley and is no stranger to the highlight reel.

Upside Comparable: Mats Zuccarello (25-45-70, 30 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Potential star; draft in the late rounds (if you can afford to wait a few years).



Sean Farrell, LW

(2026: 182) (2025: 134)

Farrell was an elite offensive player in the NCAA at just 21 years old, posting an astonishing 53 points in 34 games back in 2023. The Habs promptly signed him and gave him six games to end the season, but he hasn't returned to the NHL since. Besides being small (5-9, 182), Farrell lacks the footspeed a smaller player typically needs to survive the rigors of the NHL. And now that Montreal has so many young players who have leapfrogged him, he may not get another chance. He also cleared waivers last fall, meaning other teams already had an opportunity to take a look—and passed. Still, he's only 24 and is coming off his best AHL season yet, with 53 points in 72 games. He has increased his shot volume and posted an impressive 24 power-play points last season. He's a long shot in Montreal, but perhaps he has now shown enough for another team to give him a look.

Upside Comparable: Alex Kerfoot (20-45-65, 30 PIM)

3YP: 11-26-37, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Now or never.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Hayden Paupanekis, C

(2026: 271) (2025: N/A)

Paupanekis is a long-term project with tremendous upside, drafted in the third round (69th overall) last summer. At just 19, he's already 6-5 and has bulked up to 205 pounds. He is starting to learn how to use his size and play more aggressively. In the WHL, against younger and smaller competition, he should be more dominant—and that will come. He has grown an inch and gained 10 pounds since the NHL Draft. When he was traded to Kelowna in January before his draft year, the team specifically insisted he be included in the deal that sent Andrew Cristall (Washington) the other way. He missed Montreal's training camp and the start of the season due to mono. With WHL Kelowna teammate Tij Iginla turning pro, Paupanekis will shoulder a significant amount of responsibility, and how he responds to that will tell us much more about what to expect from him.

Upside Comparable: Nick Paul (25-35-60+, 80+ PIM)

3YP: 15-20-35, 67 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Bryce Pickford, RD

(2026: 18) (2025: N/A)

Pickford went undrafted in his first draft year, but the Habs selected him in the third round (81st overall) last summer after he surged to a point-per-game pace with Medicine Hat in the WHL. He rewarded them by scoring 45 goals and 83 points in 55 games. Just a reminder: this is a defenseman. His 45 goals ranked second in the league, and no other defenseman had more than 29. Pickford has great instincts and is always moving, though he joins the rush too often, which could

hurt him at the pro level. He also posted a 17% shooting percentage, which obviously won't carry over to the AHL. Still, team brass is excited to see how quickly—and how well—he transitions to Laval in the fall.

Upside Comparable: Mike Green (25-35-60+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 12-18-30, 67 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



David Reinbacher, RD

(2026: 32D) (2025: 28D)

Reinbacher has been injured year after year since being drafted fifth overall in 2023. And like clockwork, he was injured again last training camp, this time suffering a broken metacarpal. The injury took him out of action and sidelined him until November. The impact this has had on his development cannot be overstated. Now 21, it's as if he's only 19 in terms of experience, given the lack of games and exposure. Fortunately, he returned in November and played 57 AHL games (24 points). He has size (6-3, 209) and high-end two-way potential, but his defensive game hasn't progressed the way it likely would have without the injuries. He'll need a healthy training camp and probably a couple of months in the AHL before making the jump full-time, assuming all goes well. A risky fantasy own given his history.

Upside Comparable: Rasmus Andersson (10-35-45, 80 PIM)

3YP: 7-31-38, 48 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 95%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Adam Engstrom, LD

(2026: 30D) (2025: 39D)

We called Engstrom a third-round steal last year, and one year later we're doubling down. His game, already strong, has improved dramatically at both ends of the ice. After playing against men as a teenager in the SHL, Engstrom transitioned very well to AHL hockey, and in his second year (last season) he posted 34 points in 45 games. He also had a couple of NHL stints (15 games, one point), and although he was given sheltered minutes, he performed very well, mostly partnering with Arber Xhekaj. The 22-year-old is 6-2, 198 pounds, but isn't a physical player, which likely makes Xhekaj a good match. He will provide Montreal with excellent depth on the back end and secondary scoring, but he would need to partner with Lane Hutson to reach his full upside (don't rule it out).

Upside Comparable: Gustav Forsling (10-35-45+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 5-20-25, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 80%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Carlos Handel, RD

(2026: 126D) (2025: N/A)

A German-born player drafted late last summer (sixth round, 177th overall), Handel is an offensive defenseman who focused on rounding out his game in his D+1 season. His defense improved, and as a bonus he grew an inch and added five pounds of bulk (now 6-2, 176 pounds), something he will

continue to work on. Offensively, his numbers were stagnant, but he ended his 2024–25 campaign with an injury and also missed a month in November due to another leg injury, so he understandably had a slow start. He served as an alternate captain for Team Germany at the WJC, where he posted four assists in five games. Still a bit of a project, the 19-year-old will return to Halifax for another season before turning pro.

Upside Comparable: Neal Pionk (5-40-45+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 5-20-25, 37 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Jacob Fowler, G

The positive: Fowler continues to show why he is widely considered one of the best goaltending prospects out there. The negative: Jakub Dobes carried the Habs deep into the playoffs, at times outright stealing games. Organizations hope their prized goalie prospect can do exactly that—carry a team and steal playoff wins. Well, Montreal already has a young goalie who has done it, so why hand the job to someone else? And that's the roadblock here. Carey Price faced a similar situation before the team traded Jaroslav Halak. Jonathan Bernier faced it too—and the Kings kept him as a backup behind Jonathan Quick for three years before finally sending him to Toronto. Fowler doesn't carry the Price-level hype (fifth overall pick), so the likely scenario is that he won't provide fantasy relevance for two or even three years. But goalies, particularly in fantasy, are fickle and wildly variable in value from month to month. A smaller goalie (6-1), Fowler has elite instincts, positioning, and reflexes. He dominated the NCAA, AHL, and even the NHL (over 17 games last season). He'll be a star, but hockey politics are playing a huge role here.

Upside: Elite NHL starter

3YP: 35-20-5, 2.4 GAA, 0.918 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 100%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP.

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Frozen Tools													
DETAILED PROSPECT EXHIBITION STATS													
2025-2026 Exhibition Game Log												Frozen Tools Exclusive Data	
Date	Team	Status	G	PTS	+/-	PPG	HITS	BKS	FO	PPTOI	%PP	SHTOI	%TO
Oct 2	LA	✓	0	0	0	0	1	0		03:38	31.7	00:00	10.3
Sep 30	LA	✓	1	1	2	0	0	0		00:00	0	00:00	00.0
Sep 25	VGK	✓	0	0	0	0	0	0		01:07	55.8	00:00	13.3
Sep 25	ANA	✗	0	0	0	0	0	0		05:07	-	-	-
Sep 21	COL	✓	1	0	-1	1	1	1		01:08	45.2	00:00	10.3

Nashville PREDATORS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Yegor Surin
 Boom / Bust potential: Miguel Marques
 Long-term project: Alex Huang
 Top sniper: Joakim Kemell
 Best setup man: Ryker Lee

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Yegor Surin
 Defense: Ryan Ufko
 Goal: Jack Ivankovic
 Points only: Ryker Lee
 Multicategory: Brady Martin

2026 Draftees: Tommy Bleyl (D), Dmitri Borichev (G), Benjamin Cossette-Ayotte (D), Wyatt Cullen (F), Jakub Floris (D), Justin Graf (F), Philip Hemmyr (F), Charlie Puglisi (F)

by Ryan Downey



Brady Martin, C

(2026: 24) (2025: N/A)

Martin made an immediate impression after being selected fifth overall in 2025, earning three NHL games—a trial at 1C driven largely by Nashville's thin options up the middle—before returning to captain the Greyhounds for his D+1 campaign. The 19-year-old posted eight goals and 24 points in 24 OHL games and shone at the 2026 World Juniors, contributing four goals and four assists in six outings on a bronze-medal team. That tournament offered the clearest window into his ceiling: deployed alongside skilled players in a support role, Martin was at his most impactful, and that complementary fit profiles as his ideal NHL usage. He is at his best when not asked to be the most offensively gifted player on his line, but he has the skill to keep up with those who are. Martin projects as a relentless forechecker with middle-six peripheral value—Hits, blocks, PIM—and second-unit power-play upside.

Upside Comparable: Sam Bennett (30-40-70, 70 PIM)

3YP: 15-20-35, 60 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 95%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Yegor Surin, C

(2026: 46) (2025: 119)

Surin is emerging as one of the more exciting forwards in the Predators' pipeline after posting 15 goals and 37 points in 57 KHL games at just 19 years old—strong production for a teenager in one of the world's most physically demanding leagues. The 22nd-overall pick in 2024 brings elite size (6-2, 198) for a winger, along with a high-pace, aggressive game built around inside-driven rush play and transition—exactly the kind of attacking presence Nashville's forwards have been missing. He thrives in a complementary role alongside skilled players, using his size and pace to initiate the cycle, drive the net, and finish in high-danger areas. His rush game and puck-retrieval ability are genuine differentiators at the pro level. Getting him to North America to develop his special-teams' game and adapt to the NHL style is now the priority—he has the raw tools to become a middle-six fixture with power-play upside. His KHL contract runs out after this season.

Upside Comparable: JT Miller (30-45-75, 60 PIM)

3YP: 23-31-54, 53 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 90%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Ryker Lee, RW/C

(2026: 57) (2025: 56)

Lee took a significant step forward in his first NCAA campaign, posting 15 goals and 30 points in 35 games for Michigan State while playing a key role for a Spartans team that reached the quarterfinals of the Frozen Four. The 26th-overall pick in 2025 is a creative, high-fun-factor winger who spins off pressure well, drives play in transition, and brings a scoring touch that profiles as a legitimate top-six option at the NHL level. He made major strides this year, including a notable growth spurt that adds to an already intriguing physical projection. Hero-puck tendencies and a habit of searching for the perfect play rather than the right one can stall possession at critical moments, and his defensive game still needs refinement. Ultimately, though, Lee is a creative, play-driving winger with second-line upside and a skill set Nashville's system is currently short on.

Upside Comparable: Tyler Toffoli (30-35-65+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 20-30-50, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 80%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28, but may play a few games this season after his college year.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Aiden Fink, RW

(2026: 65) (2025: 283)

Fink's whirlwind season ended on a frustrating note—an immigration dispute with the federal government rendered him ineligible to play in Nashville's regular-season finale after signing his ELC. The journey to that moment, however, is a compelling one. The 218th-overall pick in 2022 was likely passed over due to his size (5-10, 160 pounds) while playing in the AJHL, but three seasons at Penn State produced 125 points in 104 games—the last of which was alongside Gavin McKenna. He posted 10 goals and 38 points in 30 NCAA games. Upon turning pro and joining the Admirals, Fink lined up with Kemell and the two were magic together. Fink tallied an astonishing three goals and 10 points in six games. The question now is whether his offensive approach will translate at the NHL level. What he has done over the past year reminds us of Alex Bump (PHI) from last year.

Upside Comparable: Jake Guentzel (25-45-70+, 35 PIM)

3YP: 14-28-42, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will have cups of coffee with club/get a look this year, full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Vitali Pinchuk, C

(2026: 73) (2025: N/A)

Pinchuk was the prized KHL free agent, and the Preds landed him, signing him to an entry-level contract in late April for the league minimum. That's in-line with what the Islanders gave last year's KHL prize, Max Shabanov. Pinchuk scored 31 goals and added 35 points in 65 games for Dinamo Minsk, one of just nine players in the KHL to post more than a point-per-game average. At 6-3, 203 he has good size (unlike Shabanov) and has a defensive conscience. That being said, he had just six Hits last season. Six. To compare Pinchuk, 24, to a player you know, look no further than Andrei

Kuzmenko. In Kuzmenko's final KHL year he scored 45 goals and had 18 Hits, topping Pinchuk in both categories.

Upside Comparable: Morgan Geekie (35-35-70, 30 PIM)

3YP: 14-28-42, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 75%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Joakim Kemell, RW

(2026: 81) (2025: 56)

Kemell enters the final year of his entry-level contract with his NHL fit still taking shape, but the tools that made him the 17th-overall pick in 2022 remain intact. He posted 10 goals and 29 points in 48 AHL games while also earning 16 NHL appearances with the Predators. His profile is well-defined—a winger who can be non-existent for stretches but possesses the scoring touch to change the tenor of a game when given the right opportunity. His elite shot is his calling card, and unlocking it consistently requires skilled playmakers who can find him in the right spots. At 5-11 and 183 pounds, players of his archetype typically need above-average skating to compensate, and while he has made improvements there, his best fit remains as a complementary winger alongside players who can handle the defensive workload and get him the puck in scoring areas. This is a pivotal season for the Finn.

Upside Comparable: Viktor Arvidsson (30-35-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 17-15-32, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 75%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Zachary L'Heureux, LW

(2026: 83) (2025: Grad)

Now with COL

L'Heureux's strong play in the AHL—14 goals and 28 points in 30 games—earned him a call-up that stuck, with the 22-year-old posting four goals and five points in 25 NHL appearances over the final three months of last season. The 27th-overall pick in 2021 has carved out a clear identity: at 5-11 and 196 pounds, he hits everything in sight and brings an agitator skill set that gives him genuine roster value regardless of where he slots into the lineup. The floor is strong, but the fantasy ceiling will largely depend on who he plays with on any given night and whether he can develop his playmaking enough to help elevate some of the exciting offensive talents Nashville is cultivating in its system. Not a scorer by nature, adding that playmaking dimension is the next critical step. Now an RFA coming off his ELC, securing a permanent NHL role next season is the priority.

Upside Comparable: Brad Marchand (30-35-65+, 80+ PIM)

3YP: 20-25-45, 80+ PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 95%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits).



Teddy Stiga, C

(2026: 116) (2025: 116)

Stiga's sophomore campaign at Boston College was quieter offensively than his freshman year—six goals and 21 points in 31 games—but a down year for the program as a whole softens that narrative

considerably. The 55th-overall pick in 2024 wore a letter at the World Juniors and was active, involved, and played with pace throughout, though multiple squandered breakaway opportunities highlighted a tendency to create chances he doesn't convert. His constant effort, high skill, and playmaking ability underpin an energetic game built around defensive support down low and puck retrieval. Offensively, he profiles as a lighter version of some of Nashville's higher-end prospects, but his versatility and compete level give him the potential to slide up and down the lineup. He may settle into a bottom-six role given the offensive talent ahead of him, but his ability to elevate in key moments means a spot on Nashville's top line isn't completely out of the question.

Upside Comparable: Bryan Rust (30-35-65+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 20-25-45, 80 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 80%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28, but may play a few games late this season after his college year.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Miguel Marques, RW

(2026: 159) (2025: 197)

Marques posted 10 goals and 23 points in 33 games during his freshman campaign at Maine before transferring to Northeastern, where he will be expected to lead the team in scoring next season. The 87th-overall pick in 2024 is a purely offensive player who makes effective plays in all three zones, is a reasonable option in transition, and is developing pro habits around board work and getting the puck to the inside. At 20 years old, the foundation is encouraging. The central question is whether his offensive talents will translate at higher levels strongly enough to outweigh his average defensive impact—a question his upcoming season at Northeastern, where he will be relied upon as a top player, should go a long way toward answering. More college development is the right call, and the platform to prove himself arrives at exactly the right time.

Upside Comparable: Anthony Duclair (25-40-65+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 16-20-36, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Cole O'Hara, RW

(2026: 199) (2025: 155)

O'Hara took the scenic route to the pro game, spending three seasons at UMass before making his professional debut with the Milwaukee Admirals last season. The 114th-overall pick in 2022 rewarded Nashville's patience with a promising first AHL campaign—19 goals and 44 points in 67 games—that earned him an NHL debut in Game 82, where he recorded his first career NHL point by stripping a defender and finding Steven Stamkos in one decisive motion. At 6-0 and 187 pounds, O'Hara isn't particularly elite in any one area but profiles as a solid contributor—effective in transition, dependable down the lineup, and clearly capable of translating his game to the pro ranks. With his entry-level contract now signed and expiring after 2026-27, the 24-year-old will need to show his value sooner rather than later. If his AHL debut is any indication, Nashville may have found a useful piece in the middle of the draft.

Upside Comparable: Conor Sheary (20-40-60+, 35 PIM)

3YP: 10-20-30, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling).



Cameron Reid, LD

(2026: 5D) (2025: N/A)

Reid captained the Kitchener Rangers to a strong regular season, posting 15 goals and 56 points in 57 games while cementing his status as one of the more intriguing defensive prospects in the 2025 draft class. The 21st-overall pick brings an explosive skating game—the fastest straight-line skater among defensemen in his draft class—underpinning a modern defensive approach built around stick lanes, edgework, and puck-moving ability rather than physicality. At 6-0 and 194 pounds, he defends with his feet and his brain, and his “escapability” under pressure is a genuine differentiator. His WJC showing was uncharacteristically sloppy for a player who normally reads and defends at a consistently high level, and the track record of players who share his profile—without truly elite offensive skill or a physical presence to fall back on—makes his lineup projection uncertain, though he is almost certainly an NHL player. Still just 19, he has plenty of runway to improve.

Upside Comparable: Noah Dobson (10-50-60+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 13-35-48, 32 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 85%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Tanner Molendyk, RD

(2026: 9D) (2025: 15D)

Molendyk is the definition of reliability—you know exactly what you’re going to get from him, and what you get is a complete, all-around game that covers every facet of the ice. The 24th-overall pick in 2023 posted four goals and 23 points in 60 AHL games with Milwaukee, and were it not for Nashville’s tendency to overcook their prospects in the AHL, few would have been surprised to see him in the NHL this season. His two-way game blends stick work, positional reliability, and physical willingness—making him the most complete defensive prospect in the organization. He won’t light the lamp in bunches, but his versatility and steadiness are in short supply throughout the system. At 6-0 and 181 pounds, he profiles as a second-pair fixture for the better part of a decade. A third-pair debut next season looks likely, with his role expected to grow from there.

Upside Comparable: Gustav Forsling (10-35-45+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 8-31-39, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Ryan Ufko, RD

(2026: 17D) (2025: 35D)

Ufko put together a strong AHL campaign with Milwaukee, posting 11 goals and 44 points in 52 games before earning 18 NHL appearances with Nashville, where he added two goals and 11 points—numbers that suggest he has outgrown the AHL. The 115th-overall pick in 2021 is not a high-end skill player, but hockey IQ is his calling card—he rarely makes the wrong play, distributes the puck with precision, and uses his foresight to activate offensively at exactly the right moments. That intelligence sets him apart from other Nashville defenders who outmatch him physically, though Ufko is no slouch defensively, relying on gap control and puck pursuit rather than physicality. With one year remaining on his entry-level contract, the hope is that he cements his place on the NHL roster next season and provides puck-moving and offensive creativity down the lineup for a Predators defensive corps that lacks his particular brand of hockey.

Upside Comparable: Torey Krug (10-45-55+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 8-25-33, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Alex Huang, RD

(2026: 57D) (2025: N/A)

Huang capped an outstanding QMJHL career with his best offensive season yet, posting 11 goals and 70 points in 62 games for Chicoutimi while earning a finalist nod for QMJHL Defenseman of the Year and winning the David Desharnais Trophy as the league's most sportsmanlike player—before carrying that momentum into a dominant playoff run at better than a point per game. There is little left for him to prove in the QMJHL, so the 122nd-overall pick in 2025 heads to Harvard for the 2026–27 season, ready for the next challenge. Huang is a mobile, offensively driven defender with a powerful stride who attacks with his edges, joins the rush at every opportunity, and is developing the playmaking reads to find teammates in dangerous areas. The defensive side remains the open question, but if it comes, the tools are there for a legitimate NHL role. One of the younger players in his draft class, he has substantial runway ahead of him.

Upside Comparable: Thomas Chabot (10-40-50+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 6-25-31, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Semyon Chistyakov (Chistyakov), LD

(2026: 242D) (2025: 62D)

Chistyakov has spent his entire professional career in the KHL, and at this stage it seems unlikely that will change anytime soon—despite ample opportunity to make the jump given Nashville's blue-line needs in recent years. The 117th-overall pick in 2019 posted seven goals and 25 points in 60 games for Avangard this season while wearing an alternate captain's letter, and a dip in offensive numbers may be attributable to taking on a more defensive, leadership-driven role within the team structure. At 5-11 and 198 pounds, he is a stocky, physical presence for his height. One intriguing wrinkle is the presence of Coach Guy Boucher behind the Avangard bench for a second consecutive season—a North American influence that could prove relevant if Chistyakov ever does decide to make the jump. His KHL contract expires in 2028, and with Nashville's rebuild now underway and opportunity abounding, the door remains open—even if it remains unlikely he walks through it.

Upside Comparable: Alexander Romanov (8-32-40+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 2-15-17, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 50%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Jack Ivankovic, G

Ivankovic's decision to leave the OHL for the NCAA looks inspired in hindsight. The 58th-overall pick in 2025 delivered a standout freshman campaign as Michigan's starting goaltender, posting a 0.921 save percentage, a 2.15 GAA, and a 25-8-1 record before a mid-season injury briefly threatened to derail his year—one he returned from faster than anyone could have anticipated. Ultimately outdueled by Johnny Hicks as Michigan fell to eventual champion Denver in the Frozen Four, the result does little to diminish what was one of the most impressive freshman goaltending seasons in college hockey from an eighteen-year-old. At 5-11 and 179 pounds, the tools

are evident and the development trajectory is pointed firmly upward. Michigan has unfinished business, and Ivankovic will return next season looking to add to an already impressive résumé. When he eventually makes his way to Nashville, a future timeshare with Juuse Saros represents an ideal development track for a goaltender with legitimate number-one upside.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 30-15-4, 2.50 GAA, 0.918 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 80%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.

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New Jersey DEVILS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Seamus Casey
 Boom / Bust potential: Anton Silayev
 Long-term project: Kasper Pikkarainen
 Top sniper: Lenni Hameenaho
 Best setup man: Matyas Melovsky

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Lenni Hameenaho
 Defense: Seamus Casey
 Goal: Mikhail Yegorov
 Points only: Seamus Casey
 Multicategory: Anton Silayev

2026 Draftees: Alexander Command (F), Lavr Gashilov (F), Quinn McKenzie (F), Daniil Rusakovich (G), Nikita Shcherbakov (D), Matias Vanhanen (F), Luke Wilfley (F)

by Andrew Epps



Lenni Hameenaho, RW

(2026: 71) (2025: 60)

The 6-1 Finn from Kajaani made his NHL debut last season and showed he belongs. Hameenaho earned multiple call-ups from AHL Utica, logging at least 10 NHL games and scoring his first career goals, including a shorthanded tally against Winnipeg. Between call-ups, he led the Comets in scoring with 21 points in 33 AHL games through February. Three Liiga seasons with Assat (103 points in 155 games, including a 51-point campaign at age 20) built professional habits that transferred quickly to North America. At 185 pounds, his calling card is net-front work: he wins pucks below the dots, absorbs contact in the crease, and converts second chances. The Devils used him on the penalty kill immediately, a sign of defensive trust most rookies don't earn. His skating needs another gear to separate at the NHL level, and his shot generation must improve. Hameenaho's two-way reliability gives him the inside track for a bottom-six role this fall.

Upside Comparable: Teuvo Teravainen (25-40-65+, 15 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 80%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Matyas Melovsky, C/W

(2026: 169) (2025: 173)

Not many sixth-round picks prove evaluators wrong, but this 6-1 Czech center did exactly that. Melovsky posted 83 points in his over-age QMJHL season with Baie-Comeau and led the 2024 World Juniors in assists (10 in seven games), then stepped into Utica on a one-way AHL deal and quickly became one of the Comets' most reliable forwards. His 13 points in 35 games do not scream offensive upside, but his coach praised his faceoff work, explosive first steps, and ability to play fast through intelligence rather than raw speed. New Jersey signed him to a two-year ELC in March, confirming his standing. His playmaking instincts are legitimate: he finds passing lanes through layers and reads the ice at a rate that exceeds his draft pedigree. His shot needs work, and a mid-season injury slowed his momentum. He fills a positional need as a two-way center with depth-scoring potential.

Upside Comparable: Pavel Zacha (22-38-60, 30 PIM)

3YP: 14-24-38, 18 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Cam Squires, RW

(2026: 301) (2025: 245)

The 6-1 fourth-rounder (122nd overall, 2023) opened in the ECHL with Adirondack before earning a November recall to Utica, where he finished with 16 points in 47 AHL games. That is a significant drop from his 75-point QMJHL campaign and the four-point, three-game AHL audition that closed his junior career. The tools have not disappeared. Squires is a competitive, high-motor winger who drives to the net, wins board battles relative to his frame, and creates off the forecheck. His 37 penalty minutes confirm the edge. The gap is physical. At 176 pounds, he gets knocked off pucks at the AHL level, and his shot release needs to quicken. A full offseason of strength work and a second AHL year should clarify whether the QMJHL production was real or inflated by the league's pace.

Upside Comparable: Josh Anderson (25-30-55+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 10-15-25, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Samu Salminen, C

(2026: 339) (2025: 195)

An NCAA champion with Denver, he delivered the best hockey of his career during the tournament. The 6-2, 205-pound Finnish center scored the overtime winner in the NCHC semifinal, created the opening goal in the conference title game, and scored in the NCAA regional final. His full-season line (29 points in 43 games, plus-22) does not scream offensive upside, but his role tells a different story: matchup center, penalty-kill deployment, board battles, and clutch scoring when it mattered. Salminen transferred from UConn to Denver after 2023–24 and improved his production each year. The Devils drafted him 68th overall in 2021 and face an August 15 deadline to sign him or lose his rights. His skating has improved but still lacks separation speed, and his offensive ceiling is capped by a modest shot. If signed, he projects as a two-way bottom-six center who earns ice time through intelligence and structure.

Upside Comparable: Joonas Donskoi (22-33-55+, 15 PIM)

3YP: 8-16-24, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Kasper Pikkarainen, RW

(2026: 275) (2025: 383)

A long-range bet on physical tools and bloodlines, this 6-3, 198-pound winger is the son of former Devil Ilkka Pikkarainen. Drafted 85th overall in 2024, he lost his entire 2024–25 campaign to a knee injury suffered in his first WHL game with Red Deer. Pikkarainen returned to TPS in Finland and played a full Liiga season at age 19, though the production (six points in 45 games) reflects a player still regaining confidence after a significant setback. The underlying game remains intriguing. He finishes checks, lays open-ice Hits, and plays with an edge that often draws penalties. His playmaking reads are advanced for a power forward: he finds seams through traffic and feeds off cycling patterns. The knee injury is the shadow over everything. If his skating returns to pre-injury

form and his offense grows through a second Liiga year, the physical foundation gives him a legit path to the NHL.

Upside Comparable: Jesse Puljujarvi (25-35-60+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 11-22-33, 35 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Seamus Casey, RD

(2026: 13D) (2025: 14D)

The most dynamic puck-mover in the Devils' system, the 5- 10, 181-pound Michigan product has already logged roughly 30 NHL games across two seasons, scoring four goals in his first 14 appearances and earning third-pairing and power-play time. His skating is the engine: elite edges, deceptive footwork, and the ability to create time and space that bigger defensemen cannot replicate. Casey posted a 90.97% expected-goals share when paired with veteran Jonas Siegenthaler, a pairing that offset his size limitations with a shutdown partner. The Devils kept him in Utica for stretches of 2025–26 to refine his defensive habits, but injuries on the NHL blue line (Dougie Hamilton, Brett Pesce) kept pulling him back. The concern is straightforward: board battles and net-front coverage require constant effort at his size. If his defensive game stabilizes, his offensive tools project a legitimate top-four role.

Upside Comparable: Tyson Barrie (15-40-55)

3YP: 6-28-34

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Daniil Orlov, LD

(2026: 73D) (2025: 181D)

From fourth-round defensive defenseman to KHL All-Star in two years, the 6-0 Russian posted 22 points in 51 games for Spartak Moskva last season, tripling his previous career-high pace. He was named to the KHL U23 All-Star squad. The production is sustainable: his 7.1% shooting rate is not a heater, and his 2.2 shots per game reflect genuine improvement in getting pucks through. Orlov's skating is the foundation. He transitions quickly, holds speed through pivots, and excels on the rush at 185 pounds. The defensive positioning that made him draftable remains strong, now paired with a developing offensive dimension. His KHL contract runs through 2027–28, and both Jonas Siegenthaler's and Dougie Hamilton's deals expire that same year, potentially opening left-side roster spots. He is unsigned by New Jersey, and the Russia variables apply. If he maintains this trajectory, he profiles as a dependable two-way defenseman capable of second-pair minutes.

Upside Comparable: Alec Martinez (12-35-47)

3YP: 4-14-18

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Anton Silayev, LD

(2026: 96D) (2025: 41D)

Standing 6-7 with the edgework of a player half his size, Silayev is not a fantasy-points producer. He is a franchise-caliber defensive asset whose NHL certainty is among the highest in this New Jersey report. The 10th overall pick in 2024 spent two KHL seasons with Torpedo, where his ice time

dropped sharply under a new coach (from 18-plus minutes to under 13), suppressing his already modest production. Torpedo was eliminated in the second round of the KHL playoffs, and his contract has expired. At 207 pounds, the expectation is that he signs an ELC with the Devils this summer and begins his North American career. He closes gaps, cuts off lanes, and uses his reach to disrupt entries. His offensive game is limited to transition passing and the occasional point shot. Fantasy value runs almost entirely through peripherals: Hits, blocked shots, and penalty minutes in leagues that track them.

Upside Comparable: Nikita Zadorov (8-22-30+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 3-16-19, 47 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 90%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Mikhail Yegorov, G

Few mid-season league jumps work this well. The 6-5 Russian moved from the USHL to Boston University in January 2025 and immediately transformed the Terriers. His 0.927 save percentage across 18 freshman starts carried BU to the National Championship Game, and his 0.972 Beanpot performance announced him as a legitimate prospect. Draft analyst Scott Wheeler ranked the 187-pounder as the fourth-best goalie prospect in the NHL. His frame (still filling out), athleticism, and crease movement are the foundation. He tracks pucks through traffic, seals the ice down low, and competes on second and third chances with the intensity that pro scouts value. Yegorov is entering his junior year at BU this fall and is at least two—more likely three—years from pro hockey, let alone the NHL. Now-former GM Tom Fitzgerald acknowledged that his name came up at the trade deadline, confirming his organizational value. The ceiling is a legitimate NHL starter.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 32-14-6, 2.65 GAA, 0.907 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Potential star; draft in the late rounds (if you can afford to wait a few years).



Nico Daws, G

With 51 career NHL games and more than 150 AHL appearances, the question is no longer whether the 6-4, 205-pound netminder can play at the top level. His 0.966 save percentage across six NHL games in 2024–25 was a small sample, but the three-start, 0.908 showing last season confirmed that Daws competes when given the chance. The problem is opportunity. Jacob Markstrom and Jake Allen both remain under contract at the NHL level, leaving him as the third option. His AHL numbers (0.890, 0.893, 0.892 over three consecutive seasons) do not scream dominance, though Utica has been one of the weaker defensive teams in the league. Daws is an RFA this summer at age 25. A trade or qualifying offer that leads to a backup role elsewhere is the most likely path to regular NHL work. The tools are NHL caliber: good size, calm positioning, and an ability to track through traffic. UPDATE: With the Markstrom trade, Daws has a real shot at seeing a lot of NHL action as a 1B goalie. If he does well with that, his future is bright.

Upside: NHL starter

3YP: 28-19-7, 2.85 GAA, 0.900 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 40%, 75%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds



Jakub Malek, G

Three Liiga seasons with Ilves built a résumé most goalie prospects would envy: 82 games, a 40-22-15 record, eight shutouts, and save percentages of 0.903, 0.915, and 0.910. The 6-4, 190-pound Czech's first AHL campaign was bumpier, though. His 0.895 save percentage in 31 outings with Utica reflects the adjustment to smaller ice, a faster pace, and a Comets team that ranked near the bottom of the league defensively. The technical foundation is sound. Malek uses his frame to cut angles, stays patient in his crease, and tracks through traffic with a calm that earned him consistent starts in Finland. The gap is lateral quickness on second and third chances that North American shooters generate off broken plays. He is an RFA this summer alongside Nico Daws, and the Devils' depth chart (Jacob Markstrom, Jake Allen, Daws, Mikhail Yegorov) makes his path narrow. A second AHL year should clarify whether the Liiga success can translate.

Upside: NHL backup

3YP: 12-10-3, 2.95 GAA, 0.905 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 50%, 50%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.

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New York ISLANDERS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Victor Eklund
 Boom / Bust potential: Jesse Pulkkinen
 Long-term project: Daniil Prokhorov
 Top sniper: Cole Eiserman
 Best setup man: Victor Eklund

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Victor Eklund
 Defense: Kashawn Aitcheson
 Goal: Dmitri Gamzin
 Points only: Victor Eklund
 Multicategory: Victor Eklund

2026 Draftees: Bobby Cowan (F), Vladimír Dravecký (D), Malte Gustafsson (D), Lincoln Kuehne (D), Artyom Matyuk (F)

by Kenny Kaminsky



Victor Eklund, RW
 (2026: 17) (2025: N/A)

With the 16th overall pick in 2025, the Islanders selected Eklund, a high-motor winger who quickly established himself as one of their top prospects. He spent last season on loan with Djurgardens in the SHL, recording six goals and 18 assists for 24 points in 43 games before joining AHL Bridgeport late in the year. Eklund plays with pace, detail, and constant movement. Despite his smaller frame (5-11, 170 pounds), he consistently creates space through anticipation and timing rather than power. Offensively, he shows strong vision and a quick release that translates well both off the rush and in in-zone cycles. Defensively, he is engaged and responsible, tracking back efficiently and consistently supporting breakouts. His compete level and two-way reliability project him as a dependable middle-six NHL winger with top-six upside if his offensive game continues to grow.

Upside Comparable: William Eklund (25-50-75+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 15-45-60, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 95%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Cole Eiserman, LW
 (2026: 41) (2025: 20)

With the 20th pick in the 2024 NHL Draft, the Islanders selected Eiserman, a high-end goal scorer with one of the most dangerous shots in his class. He followed that by posting a strong sophomore season at Boston University, recording 18 goals and 28 points in 32 games, while also representing Team USA at the World Junior Championship. He later finished the season with Bridgeport, adjusting to the pace of the AHL. Eiserman's calling card is his shot. His quick-release wrist shot and heavy one-timer consistently beat goalies clean; when they don't go in, they generate rebounds and second-chance opportunities. His skating is average, and he projects more as a finisher than a primary play driver. Defensively, he can be inconsistent, occasionally drifting out of structure and struggling under pressure, though he competes. He projects as a middle-six scoring winger.

Upside Comparable: Brock Boeser (45-30-75+, 37 PIM)

3YP: 32-20-52, 35 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Danny Nelson, C (2026: 93) (2025: 152)

Nelson will return to Notre Dame for his senior season after months of speculation. He continues to develop as a reliable two-way forward, recording 29 points in 36 games while handling difficult matchups in all situations. At 6-3 and 215 pounds, Nelson uses his strength and puck protection to win battles in tight areas and sustain offensive-zone pressure. He also performed well internationally, including in a steady role with the U.S. College Select Team. Offensively, he generates chances more through power and positioning than deception, using a heavy shot and quick release to create offense. His skating remains an area for improvement, though he shows functional mobility for his size. He projects as a bottom-six NHL forward with matchup ability, penalty-killing value, and overall reliability if his pace continues to improve.

Upside Comparable: Lars Eller (25-35-60+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 17-22-39, 57 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon; wait until next year to consider drafting.



Quinn Finley, LW (2026: 133) (2025: 141)

Finley is an offensive winger built around his elite shot, featuring a dangerous one-timer and a quick-release wrister that consistently produces rebounds and secondary chances. He plays with pace and urgency, using strong edges and lateral mobility to create separation and attack off the rush. Once considered undersized, he has added strength and now plays at 6-0 and 187 pounds, allowing him to better handle the physical demands of NCAA competition. Under Coach Mike Hastings at Wisconsin, his two-way game has taken a step forward, earning him penalty-kill usage and late-game defensive responsibilities. While still developing as a playmaker, he has shown growth in reading pressure and making quicker decisions under load. Finley posted 17 goals and 16 assists for 33 points in 37 games last season, along with two goals and three assists at the Spengler Cup, showing he can compete against professional opponents.

Upside Comparable: Robby Fabbri (30-35-65+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 17-16-33, 37 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon; wait until next year to consider drafting.



Jacob Kvasnicka, RW (2026: 207) (2025: N/A)

A high-tempo winger for the Penticton Vees in the WHL, Kvasnicka was drafted 202nd overall by the Islanders in 2025. He is committed to the University of Minnesota for this season, where he will continue his development at the NCAA level. Kvasnicka plays with elite pace, using explosive acceleration and top-end speed to pressure defenders and drive transition play. His motor is constant, making him a reliable forechecker and penalty killer who consistently forces turnovers and disrupts breakout attempts. Offensively, he broke out with 35 goals and 50 assists for 85 points in 65 games, showing growth as both a finisher and a puck-mover in tight areas. He is particularly effective on straight-line attacks and quick give-and-go sequences. While his skill set continues to develop, his pace, compete level, and energy make him a strong candidate to project as a versatile depth forward at the NHL level.

Upside Comparable: Warren Foegele (20-45-65+, 29 PIM)

3YP: 8-17-25, 25 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Matthew Maggio, LW/C

(2026: 218) (2025: 154)

Unrestricted Free Agent

Maggio rebounded under Coach Rocky Thompson this past season Bridgeport, regaining confidence after a difficult stretch the year prior. Familiarity with the system helped stabilize his development, and his offensive production followed, as he recorded 12 goals and 21 assists for 33 points in 63 games. Maggio is an instinctive winger capable of shifting momentum quickly with his hands and acceleration, attacking defenders off the rush with pace and creativity. His shot remains average, and his finishing consistency still fluctuates, limiting his ability to convert chances at a higher rate. Defensively, he requires further refinement, as he can drift out of coverage and lose structure in his own zone. He also saw time at center due to roster needs and adjusted reasonably well, showing positional versatility. Despite being one of Bridgeport's more productive players, he experienced stretches as a healthy scratch, underscoring the ongoing inconsistency in his game.

Upside Comparable: Anthony Beauvillier (20-40-60+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 11-18-29, 32 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Tomas Poletin, LW

(2026: 244) (2025: N/A)

A physical net-front forward who thrives in heavy areas, Poletin uses his 6-1, 205-pound frame to win puck battles and generate offense around the crease. His game is direct and aggressive, built on straight-line pressure and consistent forechecking energy that wears down opponents over time. Despite his physical style, he has shown soft hands in tight spaces, capable of pulling pucks through contact and turning broken plays into quick scoring chances. He is also a proven leader, having captained Czechia at multiple international events, including the U18 World Championship. Last season, he recorded 20 goals and 15 assists for 35 points in 43 games with Kelowna while helping Czechia earn a silver medal at the World Junior Championship. To reach the next level, he must improve his acceleration and first-step quickness, as well as his defensive-zone awareness.

Upside Comparable: Jordin Martinook (25-32-57+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 12-15-27, 68 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Daniil Prokhorov, RW

(2026: 251) (2025: N/A)

Prokhorov is a physically dominant power forward drafted 42nd overall by the Isles in 2025. At 6-6 and 219 pounds, he is one of the most imposing prospects in his class and uses that frame to impact the game in multiple areas. He moved between the MHL, VHL, and KHL before settling in the VHL, where he recorded nine goals and nine assists for 18 points in 25 games. He later earned a brief KHL opportunity, finishing with one goal in 23 games in a limited role. He also captained Russia's U20 Futures Cup team, showing leadership and competitiveness in tournament play. Prokhorov plays a

heavy, north-south game built around net-front presence, board battles, and straight-line attacks. He owns a powerful shot and strong finishing instincts, especially around the crease. While his skating is fluid for his size, his decision-making remains inconsistent at times.

Upside Comparable: Valeri Nichushkin (35-25-60+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 17-15-32, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



Alex Jefferies, LW

(2026: 264) (2025: 202)

Jefferies is a pass-first forward and a fourth-round pick (121st overall) from the 2020 Draft. The Massachusetts native recorded nine goals and 20 assists for 29 points in 60 games this past season, missing time with a lower-body injury. Jefferies' game is built on high-end vision and playmaking ability, consistently creating opportunities for teammates with precise passing and strong awareness. His skating is fluid, and he has an NHL-ready frame. While primarily a distributor, his shot becomes effective when used more frequently, preventing defenders from keying on the pass. Defensively, he remains steady and responsible, showing improvement in positioning and structure. He competes along the boards and plays within the system. Jefferies projects as a smart, versatile forward capable of filling a reliable third-line role while providing playmaking and secondary scoring.

Upside Comparable: Josh Bailey (15-40-55+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 10-16-26, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 60%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Kashawn Aitcheson, LD

(2026: 4D) (2025: N/A)

Aitcheson is a physically dominant, throwback defenseman for the Barrie Colts of the OHL and a 2025 first-round (17th overall) selection of the Islanders. He represented Canada at the World Junior Championship, further cementing his status as one of the most talked-about defensive prospects in hockey. In the 2025–26 season, he produced 28 goals and 42 assists for 70 points in 56 games, showcasing rare offensive growth for a power-style blueliner. Known for his intimidation factor and relentless physical play, Aitcheson consistently delivers heavy Hits while anchoring the Colts as a matchup defender and leader. He logs major minutes in all situations and drives momentum with a booming point shot that is especially dangerous on the power play. While his offensive impact is rising, continued refinement in skating efficiency and discipline will be key to maximizing his NHL ceiling. He continues to trend as a top defensive prospect overall.

Upside Comparable: K'Andre Miller (20-40-60+, 100 PIM)

3YP: 12-37-47, 89 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 85%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Blue-chip prospect. Draft ASAP



Xavier Veilleux, LD

(2026: 71D) (2025: NR)

A smooth-skating, high-IQ defenseman at Cornell University, Veilleux was drafted in the sixth round (179th overall) in 2024. After a record-breaking freshman campaign in which he posted six goals

and 20 assists for 26 points in 34 games—leading all Cornell defensemen in scoring—he has established himself as one of the NCAA’s top emerging blueliners. Veilleux combines elite mobility with exceptional puck management, consistently manipulating forecheckers to open passing lanes and generate controlled exits. His offensive instincts from the blue line make him a constant power-play threat, while his patience and vision allow him to dictate tempo in all three zones. Trusted in heavy minutes and special-teams’ roles, he projects as a modern two-way defenseman with strong upside. He will return to Cornell for his sophomore campaign, where he aims to build on his historic start and continue refining his pro-ready game.

Upside Comparable: Devon Toews (7-43-50, 24 PIM)

3YP: 5-13-18, 22 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don’t draft this year or next.



Dmitry Gamzin, G

A highly athletic goaltender for CSKA Moscow in the KHL, Gamzin was selected 115th overall by the Islanders in 2024. He has emerged as a technically sound netminder, defined by elite flexibility, quick-twitch reflexes, and advanced puck-tracking. He beat out veteran Spencer Martin to earn the starting role at CSKA, showing strong composure and competitive maturity in a demanding professional environment. His style is often compared to Ilya Sorokin’s, featuring a calm, efficient base with explosive lateral movement when reacting to high-danger chances. Areas for development include adding strength, refining crease footwork, and continuing to adjust to the pace and traffic of North American hockey. He is regarded as one of CSKA’s most promising young goaltenders and continues to build experience in a structured system. Gamzin projects as a long-term NHL-caliber prospect with strong upside if his development continues on a positive trajectory. He is signed in Russia until May 2028.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 30-17-8, 2.72 GAA, 0.904 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



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"If you used Rotoworld for NHL player news, there hasn't been a worthwhile alternative until now."

- poker legend Daniel Negreanu

New York RANGERS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Liam Greentree
 Boom /Bust potential: Mikkel Eriksen
 Long-term project: Nathan Aspinall
 Top sniper: Liam Greentree
 Best setup man: Malcolm Spence

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Liam Greentree
 Defense: Drew Fortescue
 Goal: Dylan Garand
 Points Only: Liam Greentree
 Multicategory: Nathan Aspinall

2026 Draftees: Darian Anderson (F), Spencer Bowes (F), Tomas Chrenko (F), Ben Macbeath (D), Andre Mondoux (D), Charlie Morrison (D), Ivan Patrikhayev (D), Danai Shaiikov (G), Alberts Smits

by Christopher Babos



Liam Greentree, RW

(2026: 20) (2025: 31)

Greentree's NHL rights were traded from the Los Angeles Kings to the Rangers as part of the Artemi Panarin deal at the 2026 NHL Trade Deadline. The sizeable winger (6-3, 216 pounds) scored 38 goals and totaled 74 points in 52 games for the Windsor Spitfires (OHL). He followed up his strong regular season with a point-per-game performance in the OHL playoffs, scoring five goals and recording 10 points in eight contests. The 2024 first-rounder (26th overall) possesses NHL-caliber size, hands, and shooting ability, but his skating and defensive play still require improvement for consistent top-six usage at the NHL level. There could be an opportunity to push for an NHL roster spot with the rebuilding Rangers this fall, but the 20-year-old may be best served by spending time in Hartford (AHL) to adjust to the pro game and refine his defensive habits.

Upside Comparable: Brady Tkachuk (30-50-80+, 60+ PIM, 130+ Hits)

3YP: 20-38-58, 53 PIM, 100 Hits

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 85%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Malcolm Spence, LW

(2026: 107) (2025: N/A)

Spence scored 10 goals and 25 points in 40 games during his freshman season at the University of Michigan (NCAA). The speedy winger has good size (6-2, 201 pounds), impressive hands, and the shooting ability to be a threat in the offensive zone. The 2025 second-round pick (43rd overall) will benefit from another NCAA campaign at Michigan this fall, but a Swiss-Army-knife-type player often finds a way to make an impact on pro rosters fairly quickly. Don't be surprised if the 19-year-old receives a look after the college season ends in 2027, particularly if the Blueshirts are out of the playoff race. If you don't mind stashing a player for a season or two in a dynasty league, keep an eye on Spence as someone who could develop into a highly serviceable middle-six forward by the start of the 2028-29 season.

Upside Comparable: Eetu Luostarinen (30-35-65+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 15-20-35, 75 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29
DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Jacob Battaglia, RW/LW
(2026: 237) (2025: 204)

Battaglia's NHL rights were traded to the Rangers from Calgary at the 2026 NHL Trade Deadline in a swap for Brennan Othmann. The 19-year-old winger scored 14 goals and 27 points in 36 games as captain of the OHL Kingston Frontenacs before a deal sent him to the Flint Firebirds, where he maintained a similar scoring rate with 12 goals and 21 points in 28 games. Battaglia, a 2024 second-round pick (62nd overall) by the Flames, saw his offense explode in the OHL playoffs, scoring five goals and posting 18 points in eight games. While anything seems possible on Broadway heading into the fall, the expectation should be for Battaglia to continue his development in Hartford (AHL). A scoring winger with good size (6-2, 200 pounds) can sometimes force his way onto an NHL roster with a standout training camp, so keep an eye on Battaglia in deeper franchise leagues that prioritize scoring.

Upside Comparable: Bryan Rust (30-35-65+, 40 PIM)
3YP: 10-25-35, 30 PIM
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%
Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.
DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Nathan Aspinall, LW/RW
(2026: 297) (2025: NR)

Aspinall doubled his point total from 47 in 2024-25 to 94 last season in his first year as captain of the Flint Firebirds (OHL). The hulking forward (6-7, 207 pounds) carried that production into the postseason, scoring 10 goals and recording 17 points in eight games. He was announced as a finalist for the Red Tilson Trophy, awarded annually to the OHL's Most Outstanding Player during the regular season. Following his offensive breakout, New York hopes it uncovered an important future piece with its fifth-round pick (159th overall) in the 2024 Draft. Aspinall could see NHL action with the Rangers this season if he impresses in camp, but a full year in Hartford (AHL) may be the best path for his development toward becoming a full-time bottom-six NHL forward.

Upside Comparable: Elmer Soderblom (20-40-60+)
3YP: 12-21-33,
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 60%
Expected Arrival: A long wait – 2029-30 at best.
DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



Carey Terrance, C
(2026: 242) (2025: 184)

Terrance, acquired in the Chris Kreider trade to Anaheim, scored eight goals and 17 points in 68 games (including nine in his last 10) along with 44 PIM for Hartford last season, the most among rookie forwards on the team. He completed his first pro season with a minus-9 rating on a club that allowed the third-most goals (253) in the league. Terrance still projects as a bottom-six forward with some offensive upside, but he needs to continue learning how to play defense at the professional level. The 2023 second-round pick (59th overall) is expected to return to Hartford for additional seasoning. Now 21, Terrance finds himself in a prime developmental situation, logging important minutes for the Wolf Pack this fall and winter. He is strong at the faceoff dot and can play any forward position, which bodes well for future opportunities.

Upside Comparable: Jeff Carter (25-35-60, 50 PIM)
3YP: 10-24-34, 32 PIM
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 75%
Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.
DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Mikkel Eriksen, C
(2026: 313) (2025: N/A)

Eriksen had a successful development year in Europe last season. The 2025 fourth-round pick (111th overall) dominated the U20 Nationell in Sweden, scoring 19 goals and 44 points in 25 games for Farjestad BK U20. He was called up to the top-level club, Farjestad BK (SHL), but the teenager did not record a point in 15 contests against bigger men in Sweden's top division. Eriksen saved his best hockey for Norway, posting three goals and 10 points to help his country win gold and earn promotion at the World Junior Championship Division 1A tournament in December 2025. The 18-year-old center doesn't have to look far for inspiration, as his uncle, Espen Knutsen, can offer guidance from a 200-plus-game NHL career that included an All-Star appearance during the 2001-02 season. Eriksen projects as a bottom-six player with middle-six upside, making him a deeper dynasty-league watch candidate if he's available.

Upside Comparable: Mikael Granlund (25-40-65, 50 PIM)
3YP: 10-20-35, 32 PIM
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%
Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.
DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



Brett Berard, LW
(2026: 399) (2025: 93)

Now with MON

Berard was recalled from Hartford six times last season, appearing in 13 games with a retooling Rangers group. The undersized forward (5-9, 174 pounds) did not record a point, registered six penalty minutes, and finished with a minus-1 rating. In the minors, the 23-year-old winger scored six goals and posted 22 points in 41 games. Berard projects as a bottom-of-the-lineup player who can provide occasional offensive punch. It was likely a frustrating season for him, as he split time between two leagues but never received consistent NHL opportunities to showcase his abilities. The 2020 fifth-round pick (134th overall) could position himself well with a strong training camp this fall. However, if he doesn't secure a spot on the NHL roster to start the season, he risks enduring multiple trips between Connecticut and New York once again.

Upside Comparable: Conor Garland (20-30-50, 80 PIM, 150 Hits)
3YP: 5-10-15, 64 PIM, 100 Hits
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 70%
Expected Arrival: Will have cups of coffee with club/get a look this year, full-time in 2027-28.
DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Raoul Boilard, C
(2026: 422) (2025: 531)

Boilard split last season between the Shawinigan Cataractes (seven goals and 23 points in 33 games) and the Cape Breton Eagles (nine goals and 14 points in 28 games) in the Quebec Major Junior Hockey League (QMJHL). The 20-year-old elevated his play in the postseason, recording four goals and four assists in six games, but Cape Breton fell to Newfoundland in a high-scoring playoff matchup. The 2024 fourth-round pick (119th overall) will take his talents to the college ranks this fall with a commitment to Lake Superior State University (NCAA). Boilard brings solid size (6-2, 192

pounds) down the middle, but he needs to continue improving his skating and physicality to complete his development into a defensively reliable, playmaking center at the pro level. He projects as a bottom-six center or middle-six winger with potential to grow into a middle-six defensive specialist at the NHL level, though that outcome is likely several years away.

Upside Comparable: Shane Pinto (15-35-50+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 8-20-35, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Scott Morrow, RD

(2026: 8D) (2025: 10D)

Morrow, acquired in the K'Andre Miller trade, started last season in AHL Hartford, where he scored five goals and 19 points in 34 games as he continued learning the defensive side of the professional game. The 23-year-old right-handed blueliner didn't score at the NHL level but tallied six assists in 29 games for New York. His possession metrics were solid, often playing alongside Matthew Robertson. Morrow showcases all the tools needed to become a top-four NHL defenseman. He has size (6-2, 194 pounds), strong skating ability, and provides reliable defensive play. Morrow should have an opportunity to earn a spot in the starting lineup this fall, particularly if New York moves out a defender ahead of the 2025–26 campaign. The 2021 second-round pick (40th overall) will have a strong chance to claim a vacancy on the Rangers' blue line at training camp.

Upside Comparable: Shayne Gostisbehere (15-40-55, 70 PIM)

3YP: 9-34-43, 57 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Drew Fortescue, LD

(2026: 48D) (2025: 144D)

Fortescue looked extremely comfortable on the Rangers' blue line over the final nine games of the season. The 21-year-old didn't score, but he recorded his first two NHL points and finished as a plus-4 for a rebuilding club. It was a refreshing change of pace after a disappointing season at Boston College (NCAA), where he posted 14 points in 36 games for an Eagles team that went off the rails and missed the 2026 NCAA Tournament. Though his college totals remained muted, his projectable 6-2 frame, highly efficient breakout passing, and elite stick positioning translate seamlessly to the pro game. He excelled as a low-risk, shutdown safety net, swallowing up zone entries against premium NHL forwards. The 2023 third-round pick (90th overall) should have solidified himself as one of the organization's top prospects after his brief late-season showcase.

Upside Comparable: Ryan McDonagh (8-37-45, 80+ PIM)

3YP: 3-25-28, 52 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Will have cups of coffee with club/get a look this year, full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Artyom Gonchar, LD

(2026: 74D) (2025: N/A)

Gonchar enjoyed a successful transition to North American hockey, scoring 15 goals and 51 points in 65 games for the Sudbury Wolves (OHL). The 19-year-old is the nephew of Sergei Gonchar, a

20-year NHL veteran and multi-time Stanley Cup champion as both a player (2009) and a coach (2016/2017). Artyom is slightly smaller at this stage (6-0, 165 pounds); however, he brings similar playmaking ability and solid skating. Those qualities were enough to convince New York to select him in the third round (89th overall) of the 2025 Draft. Gonchar is still a few years away from contributing to the Rangers' blue line, but he remains a prospect worth monitoring. He'll need to add significant bulk to his wiry frame and defensively he is still a bit of a liability even at the junior level.

Upside Comparable: Samuel Girard (10-35-45+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 8-18-35, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Dylan Garand, G

Garand spent most of last season in Hartford, where he posted a 16-15-2 record with a 2.83 GAA and a 0.896 SV%. The 23-year-old netminder also showcased well in his three appearances for the Rangers at the end of the 2025-26 regular season, recording a 2-0-1 log with a 1.62 GAA and a 0.948 SV% in his first test against NHL competition. With Jonathan Quick retiring, the backup goaltender job is open this fall. The 2024-25 AHL First All-Star Team selection should be the first in line to claim the crease behind Igor Shesterkin, though the Rangers could still add competition through free agency. While he is on the smaller side (6-0, 172 pounds) for an NHL netminder, Garand's lateral movement and scramble ability keep him competitive on most plays. He is worthy of a final-round draft slot this fall in hopes that he earns a share of the Rangers' crease. Down the road, if he can get out from behind Shesterkin, he has potential to be a starter.

Upside: NHL Starter

3YP: 28-18-11, 2.80 GAA, 0.904 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 75%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.

Ottawa SENATORS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Carter Yakemchuk
 Boom / Bust potential: Logan Hensler
 Long-term project: Blake Vanek
 Top sniper: Carter Yakemchuk
 Best setup man: Stephen Halliday

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Stephen Halliday
 Defense: Carter Yakemchuk
 Goal: Leevi Merilainen
 Points only: Carter Yakemchuk
 Multicategory: Carter Yakemchuk

2026 Draftees: Louis-Felix Bourque (F), Jaxon Cover (F), Alexander Grunin (D), Oscar Holmertz (F),
Jonas Lagerberg Hoen, Elliot Lennon (G), Adam Nemec (F), Harris Pangretitsch (D)

By Emmanuel Alforque



Stephen Halliday, C

(2026: 66) (2025: 82)

A year after leading Belleville in scoring as a rookie, Halliday continued his offensive production with 29 points in 29 AHL games. His strong play earned him three call-ups to Ottawa during the 2025–26 campaign, and his production translated well despite the tougher NHL competition. Halliday recorded 11 points in 30 NHL games and later signed a two-year, \$2.15 million extension with the Senators in early May. His playmaking ability remains the defining strength of his game—he sees the ice extremely well and consistently creates scoring chances for teammates. At 6-4 and 210 pounds, he uses his size effectively to win board battles, protect pucks, and extend offensive-zone possession, making him difficult to defend down low. While his foot speed remains average, Halliday compensates with quick reads, clean routes, and fast decision-making. He projects as an effective NHL third-line center capable of contributing secondary offense and playing a role on the power play.

Upside Comparable: Sean Couturier (25-40-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 15-30-45, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Xavier Bourgault, C/W

(2026: 142) (2025: 164)

Bourgault had a breakout season with AHL Belleville, finishing second on the team in scoring with 57 points in 70 games. This production marked a significant jump from the previous year, when he recorded just 26 points in 61 games on a Bakersfield team that struggled offensively. His strong first half earned him a call-up to Ottawa, where he made his NHL debut in December 2025. Although he appeared in only two NHL games, Bourgault took an important step forward in his overall development. The former 22nd-overall pick is coming off the best professional season of his career and is now set to sign a new contract this summer as a restricted free agent. If he can build on this momentum, Bourgault will remain an intriguing prospect to watch as he continues working toward establishing himself as an NHL player and proving his junior production can translate.

Upside Comparable: Jonathan Marchessault (20-45-65, 40 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Will have cups of coffee with club/get a look this year, full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Blake Vanek, RW

(2026: 196) (2025: N/A)

Son of former fifth-overall pick Thomas Vanek, Blake Vanek carries many of the same traits that made his father such an effective NHL scorer. At 6-3 and around 210 pounds, he already has a prototypical power-forward frame, pairing size and strength with a heavy shot and soft hands around the net. He's also capable of creating offense one-on-one and finishing in tight areas. Last season, the 18-year-old split time in the WHL with the Wild and Hitmen, recording 36 points in 69 games, including 19 goals. While he may not carry the same first-round pedigree as his father (Blake was selected in the third round, 93rd overall), the bloodline and raw tools are clearly there. Vanek is still early in his development and has plenty of time to grow into his frame and round out his game. As he continues progressing toward the pro level, he'll be a player worth watching closely to see how he handles the pressure that comes with his family name.

Upside Comparable: Thomas Vanek (35-30-65+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 25-25-50, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect—don't draft this year or next.



Dmitri Isayev, LW

(2026: 216) (2025: N/A)

Averaging 1.38 points per game, Isayev finished fourth in MHL scoring rate, capping off an impressive season for the 18-year-old Russian forward. He recorded 61 points in 44 games, ranking among the league's top 15 scorers despite splitting time across three levels. Isayev also appeared in 14 VHL games and earned a four-game audition in the KHL, a strong indication of how highly he's regarded within the organization. He carried that momentum into the postseason, adding 11 points in 14 playoff games for Yekaterinburg in the MHL. Isayev is an undersized winger at 5-9 and roughly 150 pounds, but he compensates with speed and sharp offensive instincts. He thrives in transition, using his quickness to back off defenders and create space to make plays. With his KHL contract set to expire on May 31, 2027, Isayev still has time to add strength and continue rounding out his game before facing an important decision about his future.

Upside Comparable: Maxim Afinogenov (20-45-65+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect—don't draft this year or next.



Javon Moore, LW

(2026: 274) (2025: 305)

Moore, a fourth-round pick (112th overall) in 2024, spent last season with the University of Minnesota (NCAA), recording a respectable 21 points in 36 games while finishing fourth on the team in scoring. The numbers may not immediately jump off the page, but they become far more impressive when considering his development path. Just a few years ago, Moore was still playing high-school hockey, making the way his offense has translated against tougher competition an encouraging sign for his long-term upside—exactly what Ottawa was betting on when selecting him in the fourth round. At 6-4 and 210 pounds, the big winger is still a few years away from fully

realizing his potential, but the foundation is clearly there. Moore is expected to continue his development with the Golden Gophers as he works through the typical growing pains that come with being a young power forward.

Upside Comparable: Mason Marchment (25-35-60+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 15-20-35, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect—don't draft this year or next.



Carter Yakemchuk, RD

(2026: 3D) (2025: 13D)



There's little doubt that Yakemchuk is Ottawa's most coveted prospect. Selected seventh overall in the 2024 NHL Draft, the 6-4, 210-pound right-shot defenseman from Calgary grew up just blocks away from teammate Jake Sanderson. After four seasons with the Calgary Hitmen, where he piled up 185 points in 245 WHL games, Yakemchuk made a seamless transition to the pro ranks last season. The 19-year-old turned heads in Belleville, posting 40 points in 54 games to lead the team's defense corps in scoring. He carried that momentum into his NHL debut in late, making an instant impression with a goal and an assist. A concussion suffered on March 31 kept him out of the lineup briefly, but he returned for Game 4 of the postseason against Carolina, where he recorded two assists in his Stanley Cup debut. Yakemchuk is a cornerstone piece of Ottawa's top-four defense group, and his puck-moving ability should earn him plenty of PP opportunities in the near future.

Upside Comparable: Dougie Hamilton (20-45-65+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 15-35-50, 60 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 95%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue-chip prospect—draft ASAP.



Logan Hensler, RD

(2026: 26D) (2025: N/A)

Ottawa drafted a smooth-skating, puck-moving, mobile defenseman at 23rd overall in the first round of the 2025 NHL Draft when they opted for Hensler. At 6-3 and 200 pounds, he has spent the past two seasons playing in the NCAA for the University of Wisconsin. His 2025-26 campaign was cut short after he suffered a torn ACL in January 2026, an unfortunate setback for the 19-year-old. It remains unclear whether Hensler will be ready for the start of the season in September, but the expectation is that he will continue his development at Wisconsin as he enters his junior year. He projects as a reliable top-four defenseman capable of logging heavy minutes in all situations. While his offensive production hasn't reached the level scouts hoped for, he still possesses the tools to generate offense and contribute on the scoresheet.

Upside Comparable: Gustav Forsling (10-40-50, 40 PIM)

3YP: 8-16-24, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Jorian Donovan, LD

(2026: 102D) (2025: 99D)

Donovan has spent the past two seasons honing his game with Belleville in the American Hockey League, carving out a reputation as a reliable, hard-nosed presence. Offense has never been the

main expectation, but during the 2025–26 campaign he took a noticeable step forward, recording 21 points in 61 games while also racking up 89 penalty minutes. His strong season earned him his first taste of NHL action at the end of March, when he suited up for a brief two-game stint with the big club. While he was ultimately sent back down to Belleville, it did little to overshadow the progress he has made. Donovan's development continues trending in the right direction as he pushes closer to becoming a full-time NHL player. He projects as a reliable, two-way, bottom-pair defenseman with some jam.

Upside Comparable: Marcus Pettersson (8-27-35+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 5-15-20, 50 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Leevi Merilainen, G

Heading into the offseason, Merilainen is due for a new contract after completing a one-year, \$1.05 million deal and entering restricted free agency. After spending the past two campaigns splitting time between the NHL and AHL, the 23-year-old netminder appears ready to make the jump into a full-time role with Ottawa next season. While his numbers dipped somewhat this past year compared to the season prior, Merilainen has already shown he can handle NHL action. During the 2024–25 campaign, he posted an impressive 8-3-1 record with a 1.99 goals-against average and a 0.925 save percentage, demonstrating his potential between the pipes. Calm and composed in the crease, Merilainen relies on sound positioning and strong rebound control rather than an overly aggressive or flashy style. If he remains with the Senators organization moving forward, it is hoped that he can take on an important role behind Linus Ullmark as Ottawa's backup next season.

Upside: NHL starter

3YP: 32-20-4, 2.70 GAA, 0.905 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Mads Sogaard, G

The 6-7, 200-pound Danish netminder has struggled to find consistency through the early stages of his professional career. Still, Ottawa has long viewed Sogaard as a developmental project and has remained patient with his progression. Now 25 years old and heading into the offseason in search of a new contract, Sogaard's future with the organization remains uncertain—especially with Merilainen having clearly passed him on the depth chart. Over the past four seasons, he has appeared in 31 NHL games, posting a 12-11-3 record along with a 3.60 goals-against average and an 0.877 save percentage. With a qualifying offer looming from the Senators this summer, it remains to be seen whether Sogaard views Ottawa as the best place to continue his development or if a fresh start elsewhere may ultimately benefit his career.

Upside: NHL Starter

3YP: 28-22-5, 2.75 GAA, 0.900 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Will have cups of coffee with club/get a look this year, full-time in 2026-27.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Lucas Beckman, G

The 6-2 Montreal native was selected 97th overall in the fourth round of the 2025 NHL Draft and has quickly emerged as an intriguing goaltending prospect worth watching. Since being acquired by Chicoutimi in a December, 2025 trade, Beckman's game has taken off. He closed out the regular season as one of the hottest goalies in the league, going 13-1 down the stretch, and carried that momentum into the postseason. In the playoffs, he went 16-4 with a 1.98 goals-against average and a 0.918 save percentage, backstopping Chicoutimi to the Gilles-Croteau Trophy and a berth in the Memorial Cup. Still years away from NHL duty, Beckman's development timeline remains a patient one, but with his entry-level contract now in place, a quicker path to the pro ranks can't be ruled out for next season.

Upside: NHL Starter

3YP: 28-19-7, 2.50 GAA, 0.910 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 55%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect—don't draft this year or next.

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ORGANIZATIONAL QUICK GLANCE

CUSTOM DATE WINDOWS **TEAM-DEFENSE CONTEXT** **POWERED BY DOBBER SPORTS**

Philadelphia FLYERS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Porter Martone
 Boom /Bust potential: Jett Luchanko
 Long-term project: Nathan Quinn
 Top sniper: Porter Martone
 Best setup man: Porter Martone

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Porter Martone
 Defense: Oliver Bonk
 Goal: Egor Zavragin
 Points Only: Porter Martone
 Multicategory: Porter Martone

2026 Draftees: Max Laatikainen (D), Brek Liske (D), Martin Psohlavec (G), KJ Sauer (F), Marek Sklenička (G), Maksim Sokolovskii (D)

by Christopher Babos



Porter Martone, RW

(2026: 1) (2025: N/A)



Martone dominated the college hockey scene with Michigan State (NCAA) before making the jump to the pros, scoring 25 goals and amassing 50 points in 35 games, good for sixth in the nation (second in goals). As a 19-year-old! After joining Philadelphia's NHL club, the 19-year-old tallied 10 points in his first nine regular-season games as the Flyers secured a playoff spot. The 2025 first-rounder (sixth overall) proved he was ready for NHL action by seamlessly stepping into Philly's top six at the end of the season, driving his line and even earning power-play usage on Rick Tocchet's special-teams unit during the playoffs. Martone should be in the conversation for next season's Calder Trophy, making the winger an early must-add candidate for poolies during fantasy drafts. At 6-3, 209 pounds, he uses his size to rack up the banger stats, too.

Upside Comparable: Brady Tkachuk (45-50-95+, 100+ PIM, 200+ Hits)

3YP: 38-44-82, 88 PIM, 150 Hits

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 100%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue-chip prospect—draft ASAP.



Denver Barkey, C

(2026: 27) (2025: 107)

Barkey began the 2025-26 campaign in Lehigh Valley (AHL), where he was expected to remain for the entire season. While the 2023 third-rounder (95th overall) didn't post massive point totals in the minors, his performance was strong enough to turn heads in Philadelphia. Barkey scored seven goals and totaled 16 points in 16 games for the Phantoms before Philadelphia's brass called him up to the NHL roster in mid-December 2025. The undersized forward (5-10, 172 pounds) scored five goals and 17 points in 43 games and quickly became an important member of Rick Tocchet's lineup. Barkey needs to add weight to his frame to truly compete at the NHL level, but there is no reason to believe he won't be part of the Flyers' opening-night lineup. The 21-year-old forward has 40-50-point potential as a member of the Flyers' top nine this fall, with much more in the future.

Upside Comparable: Claude Giroux (20-50-70+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 17-33-50, 36 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Jett Luchanko, C

(2026: 31) (2025: 13)

It was a chaotic season for Luchanko, who started the first four games of 2025-26 with the Flyers before being returned to the Guelph Storm (OHL). The 19-year-old captain totaled 17 points in 11 games before a mid-season trade sent him to a loaded Brantford Bulldogs roster. Luchanko scored five goals and amassed 26 points in 27 regular-season games, then added two goals and five assists in 15 postseason contests during Brantford's run to the OHL Eastern Conference Final. The 2024 first-round draft selection (13th overall) had a minimal offensive impact (one assist in seven games) as Team Canada secured a bronze medal at the 2026 World Juniors. Luchanko is still a raw hockey product, but he has shown the skill to develop into a speedy, two-way center at the NHL level. However, it may take a full minor-league season (or two) for that potential to materialize.

Upside Comparable: Brayden Point (30-40-70+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 27-32-59, 54 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 90%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Alex Bump, LW

(2026: 32) (2025: 74)

Last year's Dobber Darling, Bump scored 11 goals and 26 points in 36 games for Lehigh Valley (AHL) before a recall in early March. The 22-year-old winger tallied nine points in 17 games during Philadelphia's postseason push. He was a healthy scratch for several playoff games, but he still scored twice across six postseason contests. The 2022 fifth-round choice (133rd overall) will benefit from adding more bulk to his frame (6-1, 201 pounds) this summer. It would be a of a surprise to see Bump return to the AHL this fall, though that depends on what changes Philadelphia makes to its top nine this offseason. The NCAA Championship-winning winger has the tools to be an effective scorer in the middle portion of an NHL lineup, but it's unclear whether he will retain his roster spot in Philadelphia this fall. His metrics show that he wasn't given sheltered zone starts, so Rick Tocchet trusts him against tough opposition lines. Historically, Bump has exceeded expectations.

Upside Comparable: Brandon Hagel (30-40-70+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 20-26-46, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Jack Berglund, C

(2026: 74) (2025: 241)

The 20-year-old Swedish center tallied seven goals and 12 points in 40 games for Farjestad BK (SHL) against older competition. Berglund captained his country to a gold medal at the 2026 World Juniors, finishing with three goals and 10 points in seven games for Team Sweden. The 2024 second-round selection (51st overall) skated in his first professional games in North America late in the 2025-26 season, scoring one goal in five games for Lehigh Valley (AHL) after his European season concluded. Berglund has the size (6-4, 209 pounds) to succeed at the NHL level, and Philadelphia has a significant need for a top-six center. It might be a year too soon for the 20-year-old pivot to push for an NHL roster spot, but he is a prospect to watch closely.

Upside Comparable: Bo Horvat (20-45-65+, 45 PIM)

3YP: 17-22-39, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 80%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Jack Nesbitt, C

(2026: 80) (2025: N/A)

Nesbitt produced his second straight point-per-game season after scoring 25 goals and totaling 58 points in 55 games for the Windsor Spitfires (OHL). Philadelphia invested significant draft capital to trade up for Nesbitt with the 12th pick in the 2025 NHL Draft. The 19-year-old brings a large frame (6-5, 185 pounds) and a workhorse mentality that frustrates opponents, while playing a reliable two-way game down the middle. Nesbitt will need to bulk up this winter at the University of Michigan, but a strong season would put him in position to make a push for the Flyers' roster next spring—much like Porter Martone did last season. It is too early to draft Nesbitt unless you're in a dynasty league, but he's worth monitoring as a potential late waiver-wire addition if he signs his pro deal after the college season ends in 2027.

Upside Comparable: Scott Laughton (25-30-55, 74 PIM)

3YP: 8-20-28

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Potential star—draft in late rounds if you can afford to wait a few years.



Heikki Ruohonen, C

(2026: 227) (2025: 418)

Ruohonen scored six goals and 19 points in 28 games for Harvard University (NCAA) in his first college season. The 19-year-old center helped Finland to a fourth-place finish at the 2026 World Junior Championship with a three-goal, nine-point performance over seven tournament games. Ruohonen is an good-sized player (6-2, 205 pounds), and he consistently outworks opponents to win battles for body position. Another college season next fall—and possibly even an AHL campaign in 2027–28—appears to be the best path for Ruohonen to develop into a full-time pro. The 2024 fourth-round pick (107th overall) will need to outwork others to climb Philly's depth chart, especially given the organization's stated desire to add at the center position this offseason and beyond.

Upside Comparable: Mikko Koivu (25-40-65, 50 PIM)

3YP: 10-15-25, 32 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Nathan Quinn, C

(2026: 298) (2025: N/A)

Quinn, drafted 164th overall (sixth round) last summer, tallied 73 points in 58 games last season for the Quebec Remparts (QMJHL). It was an impressive D+1 season, his production rate topping his prior campaign by more than 50%. Quinn fits Philadelphia's mold as a hard-working center who consistently makes smart plays for both himself and his teammates. An intelligent net-driver who loves to manipulate passing lanes from the high cycle, his projection is elevated by a persistent defensive commitment and excellent board-play coordination. The 18-year-old now heads to Northeastern University (NCAA), where he will test his game against older competition in college hockey. Avoid drafting Quinn this season—it is far too early in his development for pro consideration—but the undersized pivot (5-11, 176 pounds) is a player who could force his way up Philadelphia's depth chart once he completes his college career.

Upside Comparable: Yanni Gourde (30-35-65+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 10-20-30, 32 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



David Jiricek, RD

(2026: 23D) (2025: 7D)

Jiricek landed in Philadelphia at the 2026 NHL Trade Deadline, his third NHL team in the past two seasons. The 22-year-old played 25 games with the Minnesota Wild but lost his lineup spot when the club traded for Quinn Hughes. Jiricek should have ample opportunity to find his game in Philadelphia, where the team is actively searching for right-handed defenders. The 2022 first-rounder (sixth overall) excelled in his first 15 games with Lehigh Valley (AHL), scoring two goals and registering 13 points. The Flyers didn't take long to sign him (\$1.5M AAV). With Jiricek no longer waivers exempt and with that new contract, his spot is secure. On the depth chart, the 6-4 defender has Jamie Drysdale and Rasmus Ristolainen ahead of him. Power-play time will be key to his numbers in his first couple of NHL seasons, so don't expect big numbers unless Drysdale gets hurt. In five years, though, he could be a fantasy beast.

Upside Comparable: Aaron Ekblad (20-40-60, 80 PIM)

3YP: 8-31-39, 60 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 95%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Oliver Bonk, RD

(2026: 36D) (2025: 49D)

After several seasons developing under Dale Hunter with the OHL London Knights, Bonk produced 19 points in 46 games for the Lehigh Valley Phantoms (AHL) in his first pro season. That performance earned him a call-up for Philadelphia's final game of the 2025-26 regular season, where the 21-year-old scored once and added an assist in his debut. Bonk replaced Emil Andrae during the second round against Carolina to make his NHL playoff debut, finishing with no points and a minus-1 rating in an overtime loss. Still, it was a positive indication of how highly the organization views the 2023 first-round selection (22nd overall). Bonk has positioned himself to compete for a bottom-pairing role on the Flyers' blue line this fall, though he could also be returned to Lehigh Valley if the organization feels a top-four role in the AHL would benefit his development more than limited minutes in the NHL.

Upside Comparable: Hampus Lindholm (10-30-40, 50+ PIM)

3YP: 7-28-35, 37 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling).



Spencer Gill, RD

(2026: 75D) (2025: 187D)

Gill lost most of his 2025-26 season to a wrist injury that required surgery in October. The 2024 second-round selection (59th overall) scored three goals and totaled 11 points in 16 games for the Blainville-Boisbriand Armada (QMJHL). He was strong in the QMJHL playoffs, recording 10 points in 17 postseason games during a deep playoff run. The 19-year-old is eligible for one more QMJHL season if the Flyers do not feel the sizable (6-4, 214 pounds) defender is ready for pro duty. It is far

too early to consider drafting Gill for fantasy purposes unless you are looking for a deep stash in a league that prioritizes scoring from defensemen. The Canadian blueliner has the potential to develop into a solid piece for Philadelphia in a few years, but he isn't expected to skate on the frozen floor at Xfinity Mobile Arena anytime soon.

Upside Comparable: Colton Parayko (8-32-40+, 75 PIM)

3YP: 5-19-24, 60 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



Yegor Zavragin, G

Zavragin split time between the KHL (SKA St. Petersburg) and VHL (SKA-VMF St. Petersburg) last season. The 20-year-old netminder recorded a 10-6-2 record with a 1.44 GAA and a 0.949 SV% in 18 VHL games, while posting a 5-7-0 mark with a 2.63 GAA and a 0.919 SV% in 12 KHL games against the top competition Russian hockey has to offer. Zavragin is under contract in Russia until May 2027, but the Flyers' front office has already shown an ability to expedite the arrival of a Russian prospect before the end of his deal (namely Matvei Michkov in 2024). With Aleksei Kolosov re-signing for this season, it appears Zavragin is likely to remain in St. Petersburg until his contract expires before joining the Flyers. Zavragin is considered a top five prospect goalie not in the NHL, in terms of upside potential, but he's young and will need several years. They learned their lesson when they rushed Kolosov and it blew up in their face.

Upside: Star NHL Starter

3YP: 32-18-7, 2.55 GAA, 0.908 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 80%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Carson Bjarnason, G

Bjarnason posted a winning record for Lehigh Valley (AHL) with a 14-11-7 mark, a 3.43 GAA, and an 0.887 save percentage last season in his first pro campaign after several years with the Brandon Wheat Kings (WHL). The 20-year-old was briefly reassigned to the Reading Royals (ECHL) when Philadelphia demoted Ivan Fedotov to the minors before trading him to Columbus in September 2025. Bjarnason recorded a 1-1-0 record with a 3.57 GAA and an 0.881 save percentage during his short stint in the ECHL. The young netminder is expected to return to the Phantoms' crease this fall, while Philadelphia will likely follow precedent by turning to the older goalie (Aleksei Kolosov) for emergency NHL duty. Bjarnason's long-term outlook remains positive, but don't expect to see him in a Flyers jersey during the 2026-27 season.

Upside: Star NHL Starter

3YP: 30-18-5, 2.50 GAA, 0.909 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Aleksei Kolosov, G

Kolosov spent the majority of 2025-26 developing with Lehigh Valley (AHL), where he recorded a 15-21-2 record, a 2.98 GAA, and a 0.895 save percentage. The 24-year-old netminder also appeared in several NHL games with Philadelphia last season, posting an 0-2-0 record with a 4.00 GAA and a 0.830 save percentage in four contests. The 2021 third-round selection (78th

overall) earned a one-year contract extension in May 2026 to remain with the organization for a third season in North America. While his NHL appearances have been underwhelming over the last two seasons, Kolosov has provided value at the minor-league level. Avoid drafting Kolosov this season, but keep an eye on him as a potential waiver-wire option if Philly runs into goalie injuries. The two-time KHL All-Star still has time to develop into a capable backup netminder in the NHL.

Upside: 1A NHL Starter (22-15-5, 2.75 GAA, 0.901 SV%)

3YP: 13-14-5, 2.90 GAA, 0.900 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



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Pittsburgh PENGUINS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Harrison Brunicke
 Boom /Bust potential: William Horcoff
 Long-term project: Zam Plante
 Top sniper: William Horcoff
 Best setup man: Ville Koivunen

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Ville Koivunen
 Defense: Harrison Brunicke
 Goal: Sergey Murashov
 Points Only: Ville Koivunen
 Multicategory: Rutger McGroarty

2026 Draftees: Tomas Galvas (D), Pierce Mbuyi (F), Matvei Nikonovich (G), Liam Ruck (F), Markus Ruck (F), Parker Von Richter

by Christopher Babos



Rutger McGroarty, LW

(2026: 23) (2025: 23)

McGroarty started 2025-26 in Pittsburgh, but an early-season knee injury cost him playing time and a spot in the NHL lineup as the Penguins rolled to a winning record last season. The 22-year-old forward scored three goals and totaled six points in 24 NHL games. The 14th overall pick in 2022, he improved with more playing time in Wilkes-Barre/Scranton, amassing 34 points in 30 games. It was a significant uptick from a 0.65 points-per-game average the season prior. McGroarty should have another opportunity to stick with the NHL Pens' this fall, particularly with some potential subtractions coming from the lineup. If the 2022 first-round selection (14th overall) has a big frame at 6-1, 212 pounds, and could be a breakout candidate. Early on, he has looked steady, but not game breaking, with a skating stride that looks heavy, lacking the speed to keep up with his IQ. McGroarty projects as a top-six winger by the 2027-28 campaign.

Upside Comparable: Anders Lee (30-40-70+, 70 PIM, 150 Hits)

3YP: 22-41-63, 52 PIM, 125 Hits

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Ville Koivunen, C/W

(2026: 28) (2025: 27)

Much like Rutger McGroarty, Koivunen spent much of last season bouncing between Pittsburgh and Wilkes-Barre/Scranton. The 2021 second-rounder (51st overall) scored twice and totaled seven points in 39 games while at times receiving a top-six NHL role, power-play time, and over 18 minutes a night. As Pittsburgh got healthier, Koivunen was returned to the AHL. He recorded 41 points in 34 contests for the Baby Penguins, including earning AHL Player of the Month honors for February 2026 after producing 16 points in 11 games. The Finnish winger showcased the ability to play in the NHL last season, and there is no reason to believe he shouldn't be afforded that same opportunity this fall under Coach Dan Muse. He is another potential breakout candidate, and there is nothing more for him to learn at the AHL level. No longer exempt from waivers, his time is now.

Upside Comparable: Mikael Granlund (25-45-70+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 22-33-55, 30 PIM

Rule Your Pool!

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 80%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Bill Zonnon, C

(2026: 61) (2025: N/A)

Zonnon got off to a slow start with the Blainville-Boisbriand Armada (QMJHL) due to early-season injuries, but he finished strong with 46 points in 35 games. The 19-year-old center produced at nearly a point-per-game pace in the postseason with 15 points in 16 contests as the Armada sailed into deep playoff waters. Zonnon was signed to an amateur tryout contract to join the Wilkes-Barre/Scranton Penguins in May 2026. The 2022 first-rounder (22nd overall) needs to add weight to his frame (6-2, 190 pounds) this summer to compete at the pro level, and he would benefit greatly from a development year in the minor-league system, where he is expected to play as a 19-year-old. Zonnon projects as a middle-six forward with scoring punch, but he isn't expected to tap into that production any time soon.

Upside Comparable: Alexander Radulov (30-35-65+, 32 PIM)

3YP: 10-20-30, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



William Horcoff, C

(2026: 76) (2025: N/A)

Horcoff was selected by Pittsburgh with the final choice of its three first-round picks (24th overall) at last year's NHL Draft after impressing during fitness testing at the Combine. The 19-year-old set a new combine record with a 124.8-inch horizontal jump (slightly more than 10 feet) while placing in the top 10 in five categories last May. Horcoff returned to the University of Michigan (NCAA) for his first full college season, where he scored 25 goals and tallied 39 points in 40 games for the Wolverines. The brawny winger (6-5, 203 pounds) produced two points in five games for Team USA at the 2026 World Juniors in a disappointing non-medal finish. Horcoff projects to have a strong NHL future, with his upside increasing with each month that he proves people wrong. As soon as his frame fills out, he could be quite the force.

Upside Comparable: Tage Thompson (40-35-75, 40 PIM)

3YP: 18-15-33, 32 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Tristan Broz, C

(2026: 156) (2025: 113)

Broz was held off the scoresheet in his NHL debut against Buffalo in November 2025, the only contest he skated in for Pittsburgh last season. The 23-year-old former NCAA star totaled 39 points in 47 games with AHL Wilkes-Barre/Scranton, but he watched many of the Penguins' younger prospects receive call-ups to skate on the NHL stage. Time seems to be running out for the 2021 second-round draft pick (58th overall), but a player with his attacking mentality in the offensive zone can always find a way to be an asset for a hockey club. It will be an important offseason for Broz to bulk up (6-0, 205 pounds) and get ready to showcase what he can do at the NHL level

during training camp. He becomes a change-of-scenery candidate, especially if he continues to be bypassed by younger prospects in Pittsburgh's pipeline.

Upside Comparable: Zach Hyman (25-35-60+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 52 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will have cups of coffee with club/get a look this year, full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Mikhail Ilyin, RW

(2026: 161) (2025: 291)

Ilyin will need to adapt his game to North American ice, but the 21-year-old forward certainly showcased his tremendous hockey skill on the way to a 2025-26 KHL All-Star Game selection last year. The skilled center amassed 44 points for Severstal Cherepovets against the best competition Russia had to offer. Pittsburgh quickly signed the 2023 fifth-round pick (142nd overall) to an entry-level NHL contract at the end of the KHL season. The Russian winger added size (6-3, 191 pounds) to Wilkes-Barre/Scranton's lineup for the postseason, where he produced two points in five games. Ilyin should have an opportunity to impress Penguins brass all over again this summer at development and training camps. However, a learning year adjusting to hockey on a smaller surface (and communicating in an entirely new language) might be best served in Wilkes-Barre/Scranton this fall. He possesses middle-six upside, but it's far too early to depend on that production for fantasy purposes.

Upside Comparable: Ondrej Palat (20-45-65+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 8-32-40, 18 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Cruz Lucius, RW

(2026: 176) (2025: 321)

After a down year at Arizona State with 10 points in 19 games in 2024-25, Lucius rebounded well last season by scoring 15 goals and totaling 46 points in 36 games for the Sun Devils. He finished his four-year college career with 41 goals and 124 points split between two programs: the University of Wisconsin (2022-2024) and Arizona State (2024-2026). Lucius claimed an NCHC First-Team All-Star spot following his impressive final season on college ice. Lucius has refused to sign his ELC and chosen to leverage his big year on August 15 by becoming a UFA. Lucius' fantasy projections will depend on the situation he joins this summer. Teams light on prospects (Avalanche, Maple Leafs, Oilers, Panthers, Golden Knights) will certainly inquire.

Upside Comparable: JT Compher (20-35-55, 50 PIM)

3YP: 10-20-30, 38 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Tanner Howe, LW

(2026: 233) (2025: 277)

Howe was out of action during the first half of the season while recovering from an April 2025 ACL reconstruction surgery. It was a slow return for the 20-year-old forward, who scored eight goals and tallied 16 points in his first 27 games with Wilkes-Barre/Scranton. Howe still managed to collect 43

penalty minutes despite the missed time. The 2024 second-rounder (46th overall) competes hard despite being undersized (5-11, 183 pounds), but he is stronger than he appears, and his deceptive strength can sometimes catch opponents off guard. This fall will be an important campaign for Howe as he attempts to re-establish where he fits in the Penguins' prospect pecking order after recovering from a serious knee injury. It is still too early for fantasy managers to draft him, but he could provide value in 2027–28 for those looking that far ahead.

Upside Comparable: Bryan Rust (25-40-65, 60+ PIM)

3YP: 15-28-43, 48 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling).



Zam Plante, LW/RW

(2026: 201) (2025: 380)

Plante was a major piece of a memorable season at Minnesota-Duluth alongside his brother, Max Plante, a Detroit Red Wings draft pick. Zam doubled his production from 20 points in 33 games during the 2024–25 campaign to 50 points in 40 games last season, including 20 goals for the Bulldogs. Plante will have an uphill battle as a smaller pivot in the NHL (5-10, 170 pounds). Still, the 21-year-old works hard with and without the puck, which should serve him well at the next level of competition. The true test now comes as the 2022 fifth-round choice (150th overall) attempts to make an impact at the professional level without his brother. Plante, who turns 22 in August, lacks a physical edge to his game, and instead relies on positioning and smarts. We'll see how that translates to the AHL.

Upside Comparable: Troy Terry (25-40-65+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 10-15-35, 12 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Ryan Miller, C

(2026: 333) (2025: N/A)

Miller arrives on this list following a dynamic offensive season for the Portland Winterhawks (WHL) in 2025–26. The 19-year-old scored 30 goals and 75 points in 65 contests. Miller signed an amateur tryout agreement with Wilkes-Barre/Scranton in April 2026 and skated in his first two pro games without appearing on the scoresheet. The 2025 fifth-round draft choice (130th overall) is committed to playing for the Denver Pioneers this fall as they attempt to defend their NCAA Championship. Relentless on the puck, Miller has the processing tools to out-produce your typical fifth-round pick. How his CHL success translates to NCAA will determine his true upside, but for now he strikes us as a potential third-liner with potential for more. He's a natural goal-scorer, but can dish as well.

Upside Comparable: Noah Cates (25-35-60+, 90+ PIM)

3YP: 16-20-36, 47 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



Harrison Brunicke, RD

(2026: 11D) (2025: 55D)

Brunicke opened 2025-26 on Pittsburgh's NHL roster with one point in nine games, but he battled an early-season wrist injury that cost him playing time and a roster spot with the big club. The 20-year-old defender was sent to Wilkes-Barre/Scranton, where he totaled four points in five games before heading to the 2026 World Juniors with Team Canada. Brunicke recorded two points in seven games during Canada's run to bronze. Following the tournament, the 20-year-old was returned to Kamloops (WHL) to finish out the season. He scored twice and added 22 assists in 24 games for the Blazers. The 2024 second-rounder (44th overall) was a valuable addition to Wilkes-Barre/Scranton's playoff run after netting a shorthanded goal to clinch a series against Hershey in May 2026. The South African two-way defender has a bright future on the Penguins' blueline.

Upside Comparable: Jacob Trouba (10-35-45+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 6-27-33, 67 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 85%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling).



Owen Pickering, LD

(2026: 41D) (2025: 21D)

Pickering saw only four games of action in Pittsburgh's NHL lineup last season after skating in 24 games during the 2024-25 campaign. The 22-year-old produced a steady season in Wilkes-Barre/Scranton, scoring seven times and totaling 28 points in 68 games for the Baby Pens. The towering lefty (6-5, 201 pounds) uses his size and speed to create breakouts and rush opportunities without making himself a defensive liability. Depending on what happens with Pittsburgh's blue line setup this offseason, Pickering could position himself for a bottom-pairing role with a strong summer and training camp. That would be the best outcome for fantasy managers, but another minor-league season in Wilkes-Barre/Scranton probably wouldn't hurt the 2022 first-round selection (21st overall). Pickering still has plenty of time to reach his potential, so logging high-pressure AHL minutes would prove more beneficial than bottom-pair NHL shifts at this stage of his development.

Upside Comparable: Colton Parayko (10-40-50+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 6-25-31, 47 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will have cups of coffee with club/get a look this year, full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Finn Harding, LD

(2026: 89D) (2025: 156D)

Harding led all Wilkes-Barre/Scranton skaters with a stellar plus-32 rating in 54 games. The 21-year-old defenseman faced adversity early in his first pro season after being the odd man out in a defensive logjam on the Wilkes-Barre/Scranton roster, which forced a demotion to the Wheeling Nailers (ECHL) for seven games in mid-to-late November 2025. Harding returned to the AHL for good in early December, totaling 22 points in 54 games last season. The 2024 seventh-round draft selection (223rd overall) skated in two AHL postseason games for the W-B/S Penguins but also spent time as an extra defenseman during the playoffs. Harding still has a ways to go toward reaching his potential, but it's always a bigger hill to climb when you start off your career as a seventh-round pick. Almost certainly not going to be in the top four for an NHL team, but he's still young.

Upside Comparable: Mattias Samuelsson (10-35-45+, 70+ PIM)

3YP: 6-23-29, 65 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



Sergei Murashov, G

Murashov spent a month with the Penguins' NHL club during the 2025–26 holiday season. The 22-year-old prospect handled himself well, posting a 1-1-2 record, a 2.56 GAA, and a 0.897 SV% in five games. He was returned to Wilkes-Barre/Scranton in mid-December and finished the season with a 24-9-4 mark, a 2.20 GAA, and a 0.919 SV% in 38 appearances. He became the trusted postseason option in the playoffs, recording a 3-1 record while improving to a 1.99 GAA and 0.937 SV% in the first round. The 2022 fourth-round pick (118th overall) sits behind Arturs Silovs on the depth chart. With Stuart Skinner potentially hitting free agency, a strong summer could push Murashov into the conversation for the backup role this fall if Pittsburgh doesn't add another goaltender. There is no reason to rush Murashov into NHL duty, as another minor-league campaign could prove more beneficial for his long-term development as he continues adjusting to the North American game.

Upside: NHL Starter

3YP: 31-22-7, 2.68 GAA, 0.902 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Joel Blomqvist, G

Blomqvist served as a solid backup goaltender for Wilkes-Barre/Scranton last season, posting a 16-5-6 record, a 2.40 GAA, and a 0.913 SV% in 26 contests. The 24-year-old has slipped down the Penguins' depth chart after serving as the minor-league starter during the 2023–24 season. His AHL numbers have been consistent over the last three seasons, but his fate in the organization may have been sealed following a 4-9-1 record in 15 NHL games during 2024–25. Pittsburgh turned to Sergei Murashov for a month of NHL duty last season instead of giving Blomqvist a second crack at life in the NHL. The Finnish netminder, a second-rounder (52nd overall) in 2020, would likely benefit from a change of scenery unless he is content with a career as a minor-league goalie.

Upside: NHL Starter

3YP: 30-24-6, 2.95 GAA, 0.900 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 60%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.

San Jose SHARKS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Igor Chernyshov
 Boom / Bust potential: Teddy Mutryn
 Long-term project: Leo Sahlin Wallenius
 Top sniper: Kasper Halttunen (OTT)
 Best setup man: Luca Cagnoni

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Igor Chernyshov
 Defense: Eric Pohlkamp
 Goal: Joshua Ravensbergen
 Points only: Igor Chernyshov
 Multicategory: Quentin Musty

2026 Draftees: Jake Gustafson (F), Alexander Karmanov (D), Brady Knowling (G), Ryan Lin (D), Ivar Stenberg (F), Keaton Verhoeff (D)

by Ryan Downey



Igor Chernyshov, LW
 (2026: 2) (2025: 40)



Chernyshov, one of the more impressive rookie stories of the 2025–26 campaign, has made a legitimate case to stick in San Jose’s lineup for good. After dominating the OHL with Saginaw in 2024–25 at 2.39 points per game following offseason shoulder surgery, he produced 33 points in 41 AHL games and earned his first NHL call-up, posting nine goals and 19 points in 28 NHL games while playing mostly alongside Macklin Celebrini. His production held regardless of league context or usage. The 20-year-old brings a powerful stride, high-end puck skills, and confidence as a puck transporter, and while defense isn’t a hallmark of his game, Coach Ryan Warsofsky has no hesitation deploying him in a featured role with the Sharks’ top players. Chernyshov profiles long-term as a winger capable of thriving alongside either Celebrini or Michael Misa—whether as a net-front finisher, forechecking cycle driver, or net-driving presence off the rush. He is waivers-exempt, but should open 2026–27 on the NHL roster.

Upside Comparable: Andrei Svechnikov (35-50-85+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 25-35-60, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 60%, 99%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP..



Quentin Musty, LW
 (2026: 43) (2025: 45)

Musty put together an excellent first AHL campaign as a 20-year-old with the San Jose Barracuda, playing an important offensive role and showing a smooth transition to the pro game—at least on the offensive side of the puck. The 26th-overall pick contributed 21-24-45 in 61 games, showcasing a consistent scoring touch backed by good size (6-2, 201 pounds), fluid skating, and a violent wrist-shot release. He drives sustained zone time and contributes at even strength, projecting as a middle-six forward at the next level. The knock has always been his defensive game, and that remains the next clear development area before coaches commit to regular NHL deployment. It is notable that he was drafted earlier than Igor Chernyshov, yet was passed by the Russian winger on the organizational depth chart last season. Waivers-exempt, Musty is a candidate to push for NHL time in 2026–27, the second year of his entry-level contract.

Upside Comparable: JT Miller (30-45-75, 80 PIM)

3YP: 22-25-47, 50 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Kasper Halttunen, RW

(2026: 103) (2025: 109)

Traded to OTT

Halttunen played his first full AHL season with the Barracuda in 2025–26, building on a 2024–25 campaign in which he dominated the OHL playoffs and won the Wayne Gretzky 99 Award as playoff MVP. The 20-year-old power forward tallied 16 goals and 19 assists for 35 points in 69 games and profiles as a trailer and finishing threat, boasting a lethal one-timer, a heavy NHL-caliber shot, and a physical net-front presence. He has rounded out his even-strength game considerably, and his power-play value is obvious. The challenge going forward is pace—getting to his spots consistently against NHL defenders and holding up in transition will determine his ultimate ceiling. If he can keep up, a top-nine, power-play role with the Sharks seems within reach. A full second AHL season in 2026–27 appears likely, especially with similar-profile players like Igor Chernyshov and Quentin Musty ahead of him on the organizational depth chart.

Upside Comparable: Timo Meier (35-40-65, 80 PIM)

3YP: 21-24-45, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Filip Bystedt, C

(2026: 109) (2025: 67)

Bystedt has been a slow burn since arriving in North America, but his trajectory is pointed in the right direction. The 27th-overall pick in 2022 earned AHL All-Star recognition in 2025–26, posting 22-38-60 in 65 games while logging big minutes for the Barracuda. The 22-year-old center brings size (6-3, 210 pounds), skating ability, and above-average vision and playmaking—the tools are there for a legitimate NHL role. The question is whether he can slow the game down consistently and establish himself as a possession center, because without an elite trait to hang his hat on, the risk is that he gets NHL looks but fades from consideration before securing a regular role. He profiles as a third-line center but needs to add to his game to project confidently at that level. Entering the final year of his entry-level contract and with two years of waivers exemption remaining, the runway is clearly defined—2026–27 is a pivotal year.

Upside Comparable: Alexander Wennberg (20-40-60, 30 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Joey Muldowney, RW

(2026: 166) (2025: 226)

Muldowney took a slight step back offensively in his junior campaign at UConn, though context matters. An uncharacteristically quiet stretch to start the season—five goals on 54 shots—skewed his

season-long numbers, and positive regression hit hard once his shooting percentage normalized. He finished with 17 goals and 12 assists for a hard-earned 29 points in 34 games. UConn's fortunes tend to follow his production, which speaks to the assistant captain's impact beyond the scoresheet. The 21-year-old has a strong enough hockey IQ and skating ability that he may be able to overcome his ultimate limitation at the NHL level—his size (5-9, 161 pounds)—and carve out an NHL role. As a 172nd-overall pick in 2022, the value is certainly there for the Sharks, who will have to decide whether they can look past his size and his slow start to the season to give him an opportunity at the pro level.

Upside Comparable: Cam Atkinson (35-30-65+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 15-20-35, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Carson Wetsch, RW

(2026: 241) (2025: NR)

Wetsch took a clear step forward in his second WHL campaign, posting 22 goals and 72 points in 65 games as captain of a competitive Kelowna squad—a meaningful uptick from last year's 52 points, with the assist total in particular reflecting improved playmaking as his role has grown on his new team. The 82nd-overall pick in 2024 is more forecheck- and inside-driven than most WHL forwards, playing a smart, low-risk game that doesn't always generate highlight-reel moments but consistently produces results. The 75 PIM add some peripheral value on top of the offensive production. Whether there is enough upside to project him as a regular NHLer remains an open question—the tools are there, but the ceiling isn't obvious yet. If his forechecking game continues to develop, the 20-year-old will fit well in an organization that has recently placed a premium on physicality. Still unsigned, he is a deeper-league watchlist candidate who offers peripheral category value.

Upside Comparable: Josh Anderson (30-25-55+, 90 PIM)

3YP: 15-15-30, 50 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Teddy Mutryn, C

(2026: 258) (2025: N/A)

Mutryn delivered the kind of D+1 season you'd hope for from a physically gifted 19-year-old: 31 goals and 37 assists in 54 QMJHL games with the Moncton Wildcats, adding 62 PIM that reflect his borderline violent, up-tempo style. The 95th-overall pick in 2025 plays a downhill game, throwing his body relentlessly while representing a genuine dual threat to shoot or pass from high-danger areas. He wins board battles through sheer competitive drive. Moncton deployed him in every situation—top power play, top penalty kill—under Coach Gardiner McDougall, about as good a developmental environment as he could have landed in. The defensive lapses and occasional recklessness with his physicality are concerns, but for a gifted multi-sport athlete who has only truly focused on hockey in the last few years, the runway is substantial. He heads to Boston College next season, where playing against men will serve as the next developmental proving ground.

Upside Comparable: Trent Frederic (25-35-60+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 10-16-26, 60 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



Cole McKinney, C

(2026: 362) (2025: N/A)

McKinney isn't going to light up the scoresheet, but the 52nd-overall pick in 2025 has the makings of a reliable NHL bottom-six forward. The 19-year-old center posted eight goals and 12 assists in his D+1 campaign, and while he doesn't project as more than a 40-point player at the NHL level, his value runs deeper than the scoresheet. Hockey IQ is his standout trait—McKinney is almost always in the right position, which makes the game look easy for him, as he rarely needs to make a flashy play and prefers to keep things simple. An above-average shot he doesn't use enough, decent playmaking, and an already advanced defensive game round out what appears to be a fairly complete player profile, albeit one lacking elite skills or upside. His faceoff and penalty-kill development will be determining factors in how soon he can compete for an NHL role.

Upside Comparable: Andrew Copp (20-35-55+, 35 PIM)

3YP: 13-26-39, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Eric Pohlkamp, RD

(2026: 19D) (2025: 48D)

Pohlkamp had a standout third college season, leading all NCAA Division I defensemen in scoring with 17 goals and 37 points in 38 games while posting a plus-24—and winning the NCAA championship. He was a Hobey Baker finalist alongside TJ Hughes (COL) and Max Plante (DET), and as the only defenseman among the three, his case for top player in college hockey was strong. The 22-year-old transferred to Denver from Bemidji State two years ago and has done nothing but elevate his game since. His shot volume is tremendous, and his power-play instincts from the point give him a well-defined offensive identity at the next level, complemented by a complete defensive game that has been a hallmark of his college career. Fresh off signing his entry-level contract with the Sharks, the 132nd-overall pick in 2023 adds another genuine piece to what is quietly becoming one of the more exciting under-25 defensive cores in the league.

Upside Comparable: Justin Faulk (15-40-55, 35 PIM)

3YP: 10-25-35, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Leo Sahlin Wallenius, LD

(2026: 25D) (2025: 92D)

Sahlin Wallenius had a quietly impressive 2025–26 campaign, posting three goals and 10 assists in 32 games while earning a steady increase in ice time that saw him finish the season averaging 20 minutes per night in a top-four role for his SHL club—a significant jump from the 15–17 minutes he was logging earlier in the year. For a 19-year-old, handling that kind of workload in the SHL—the best development league outside North America—is a meaningful step in the right direction. The 53rd-overall pick in 2024 uses his feet exceptionally well to exit and enter the zone, pairs strong puck feel with excellent awareness of his teammates' positioning, and showed at the World Juniors that he could handle being Sweden's number-one defenseman, logging more than 28 minutes in

high-stakes games. The singular question: can he carve out an NHL role without a truly elite skill at his size (6-0, 180 pounds)?

Upside Comparable: Erik Gustafsson (10-40-50+, 35 PIM)

3YP: 5-15-20, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Luca Cagnoni, LD

(2026: 25D) (2025: 12D)

Cagnoni took a small step back offensively in his second AHL campaign, posting eight goals and 43 points in 67 games on a Barracuda team that lost significant veteran scoring depth from last year. The 21-year-old is holding down a top-pairing role and sits at minus-3, a respectable mark given the club's struggle. The defensive side of the puck remains the primary reason he has did not return to the NHL last season, but the offensive toolkit that made him one of the more talked-about AHL rookies in recent memory has not gone anywhere. His power-play upside gives him a well-defined advantage in the competition for a sheltered scoring role at the next level. The next step is continuing to develop his shot—adding layers to an already elite offensive toolkit, in the mold of a player like Mikhail Sergachev, whose ability to create from the point provides a useful developmental model.

Upside Comparable: Torey Krug (15-45-55, 30 PIM)

3YP: 5-30-35, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Simon (Haoxi) Wang, LD

(2026: 230D) (2025: N/A)

Wang had a difficult 2025–26 campaign split between Oshawa and Niagara, posting limited offense—which fits his profile—but a minus-39 in 57 games, the fifth-worst mark in the OHL and third-worst among defensemen. A minus-5 in five playoff games followed as Niagara fell in the first round. The 33rd-overall pick in 2025 is a long-term project with wide-ranging outcomes—it wouldn't be surprising if it never came together at the NHL level, and it wouldn't be shocking if he developed into a significant minutes-eater either. The tools are real: a hulking 6-6 frame, smooth skating and edge work for his size, and a hockey IQ that is less teachable than the skills he still needs to develop. Reducing the high-event nature of his minutes and tightening his defensive-zone awareness will be key to unlocking a shutdown, top-four projection. He heads to Boston University next season and, still just 18 years old, has plenty of runway.

Upside Comparable: Ben Chiarot (5-25-30+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 2-10-12, 50 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Joshua Rayensbergen, G

Rayensbergen backed up his billing as the top North American goaltender on NHL Central Scouting's list with his best WHL campaign yet, posting a 0.919 save percentage and a 2.51 GAA with Prince George while pushing deep into the playoffs as a frontrunner for WHL Goaltender of the

Year. The 30th-overall pick in 2025 is a rare commodity—a 6-5 goaltender with raw explosiveness, elite foot speed, and flexibility that few goalies in the world can match at any size. His hands and anticipation flash genuine upside, and his confidence is a calling card. The primary development area is decision-making and body control—he tends toward overly aggressive choices and larger movements than situations call for. The 19-year-old joins an organization where Yaroslav Askarov is poised to take the starter's crease, giving Ravensbergen a runway to develop without pressure. The ceiling is that of a high-end NHL starter, though college and minor-pro hockey still await.

Upside: Star NHL Starter

3YP: 32-13-5, 2.45 GAA, 0.910 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 50%, 75%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



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Seattle Kraken

At a Glance

Top prospect: Jake O'Brien
 Boom / Bust potential: David Goyette
 Long-term project: Nathan Villeneuve
 Top sniper: Jagger Firkus
 Best setup man: Jake O'Brien

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Jake O'Brien
 Defense: Lukas Dragicevic
 Goal: Semyon Vyazovoy
 Points only: Jake O'Brien
 Multicategory: Jacob Melanson

2026 Draftees: Viktor Fyodorov (F), Luken Huff (D), Finn Kearns (D), Casey Mutryn (F), Ola Palme (D), Chase Reid (D), Rylan Singh (D), William Tomko (F)

by Alex Wyatt



Jake O'Brien, C

(2026: 8) (2025: N/A)



O'Brien was the key cog in the offensive juggernaut that was the OHL Brantford Bulldogs last season. After a 98-point campaign in his draft year, the 18-year-old produced 93 points in 13 fewer games (53). Gone was frequent pass recipient Nick Lardis (Chicago), who led the OHL in goals while skating beside O'Brien, and in came Marek Vanacker, another Blackhawks draftee who also led the OHL in goals last season. O'Brien's ability to elevate the snipers who play alongside him will help smooth his transition to the professional ranks. The Kraken have Berkly Catton, Shane Wright, and Matty Beniers down the middle in the NHL, so there's no need to rush O'Brien. However, based on skill and pedigree, he projects as a future top-six—if not top-line—contributor in time. He is a must-draft in dynasty leagues, and he's poised to add value to several Seattle snipers.

Upside Comparable: Nick Suzuki (30-60-90+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 25-45-70, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 40%, 95%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Blue-chip prospect—draft ASAP.



Jagger Firkus, LW/RW

(2026: 37) (2025: 43)

Firkus took a fantastic step forward in his sophomore AHL season, scoring 21 goals and adding 35 assists. He grew in several facets of his game, using his increased ice time and overall deployment to record 12 special-teams points and fire 181 shots on net. His shooting percentage remained a reliable 11.6%, and he once again produced twice as many primary assists as secondary helpers. Firkus will benefit from adding a bit more bulk to his frame, as he is still listed at under 165 pounds. He has shown that his junior-level prowess can carry over to the professional ranks against bigger and more experienced competition, and his opportunity to showcase himself at the NHL level could come as soon as this fall. Spend your offseason knocking on doors to acquire him at the right price.

Upside Comparable: Tyler Toffoli (35-40-75+, 46 PIM)

3YP: 25-30-55, 36 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Jani Nyman, LW/RW

(2026: 45) (2025: 34)

Nyman's second pro season in North America was one of quiet growth. Although he saw fewer minutes and less power-play time over his 28 games last season compared to the year prior, he proved he was near the top of the Kraken's call-up list. Due to a three-and-a-half-minute decrease in average ice time, Nyman's statistical output took a step back at the NHL level—dropping from 3-3-6 in 12 games played to 4-3-7 in 28 GP, with 1.2 fewer shots per 60. He started most of his shifts in the offensive zone during his sheltered deployment, skating alongside Kaapo Kakko and Shane Wright for the majority of his minutes. If Nyman establishes himself in the Kraken lineup, pencil him in as a second-liner with above-average shot volume and roughly a Hit per game. He is a strong acquisition target in deep dynasty leagues this offseason.

Upside Comparable: Rickard Rakell (35-35-70, 40 PIM)

3YP: 20-25-45+, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Oskar Fisker-Molgaard, C

(2026: 90) (2025: 170)

Fisker-Molgaard's first season in North America raised his prospect profile with a solid showing in the AHL (10-24-34 in 49 GP) and a 12-game call-up to the NHL Kraken. Billed as a middle-six, defensively responsible forward in his draft year, his career arc has seen him rise quickly to Sweden's top professional league and show offensive prowess—his 0.5 points per game ranks among the top 25 by an 18-year-old in the SHL since 2009. If Fisker-Molgaard continues his strong play in North American hockey, his role will likely settle in as a secondary scorer with heavier usage on the defensive side of the puck. His short NHL audition saw him start fewer than 45% of his shifts in the offensive zone, and Seattle has plenty of more suitable offensive firepower on the depth chart.

Upside Comparable: Barrett Hayton (20-40-60+, 28 PIM)

3YP: 10-20-30, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Eduard Sale, LW/RW

(2026: 92) (2025: 88)

Sale had another season similar to his AHL rookie campaign, recording 13 goals and 14 assists in 58 games. Many fantasy managers were likely hoping to see a step forward in his offensive production after a year of experience and physical growth, but the numbers were nearly identical. He posted the same shots per game (1.5), the same number of power-play points (5), and the same PIM (14), despite playing seven more games. His jump from five goals to 13 year over year came largely from nearly doubling his shooting percentage—14.4% last season compared to 7.4% the year prior. Sale just turned 21, and late bloomers are common across NHL rosters, but for fantasy purposes, more exciting and investable options are beginning to emerge as Seattle's other draft picks pass him on the depth chart. Hold him if you already roster him, but he's a difficult buy right now.

Upside Comparable: Nick Schmaltz (25-40-65+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 10-30-40, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Carson Rehkopf, LW

(2026: 119) (2025: 69)

Rehkopf began his professional hockey career quietly after lighting up the OHL with 142 goals in 250 career games. The Firebirds have been a successful AHL franchise since their inaugural season and have several experienced incumbent wingers who allow them to ease their young draftees into their roles. Jagger Firkus is an example of a player who grew by leaps and bounds in his sophomore season, and as he and Jani Nyman move up to the big club, Rehkopf's deployment and opportunity will increase. Rehkopf is a solid-framed sniper—6-2 and 201 pounds—and could be exactly the type of player who benefits from Jake O'Brien moving to the AHL. Rehkopf may eventually settle in as more of a middle-six, power-play specialist if his development continues positively. He is worth picking up if his post-hype phase has lowered his perceived value in your leagues; keep a close eye on his goal-scoring progression this season.

Upside Comparable: Alex DeBrincat (35-30-65+, 36 PIM)

3YP: 20-20-40+, 22 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Julius Miettinen, LW/C

(2026: 135) (2025: 276)

Miettinen's WHL career was one of consistent, steady growth. He increased his points-per-game pace every year, and won more than 60% of his faceoffs, with nearly three-quarters of his assists being primary. His playmaking and offensive production may not fully translate to the NHL, but they give him plenty of tools in his toolbox. Miettinen will make his mark in pro hockey by being a tough player to play against, using his defensive acumen and physicality to smother opponents on the forecheck and break up plays in his own end. At 6-4 and 207 pounds, Miettinen is already built for the NHL playoffs, but he will need more development before we can count on that outcome. There isn't an immediate path to the NHL for Miettinen, and he will join the AHL Coachella Valley Firebirds soon enough to refine his shutdown game against bigger, more experienced opponents.

Upside Comparable: Boone Jenner (25-40-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Nathan Villeneuve, C

(2026: 192) (2025: 171)

Villeneuve is quietly one of the most intriguing prospects in the Kraken system. He's not the offensive dynamo that Jake O'Brien is, nor is he the sniper that Jagger Firkus is, but he is a highly effective Swiss-Army-knife player with a solid floor and multi-category value. Villeneuve capped off his fourth OHL season with a 21-42-63 line in 61 games split between Sudbury and Windsor, adding 83 Hits, 90 blocks, and 164 shots on goal. He has a strong defensive toolkit: his 311 takeaways ranked among the top 20 OHL forwards, and his 61% faceoff success rate was the best mark among players with more than 100 draws. Villeneuve projects as a bottom-six grinder in the NHL, capable

of adding some secondary scoring. Your league settings will determine his value, but he appears to have the tools needed to crack an NHL lineup.

Upside Comparable: Bo Horvat (25-40-65+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 17-24-41, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Jacob Melanson, RW

(2026: 221) (2025: 182)

Melanson was a bull on skates from the moment he was called up by the Kraken last season, recording 15 Hits in his first three games. That pace held throughout the year, as he finished the season with 5.25 Hits per game. In leagues where a one-trick pony like Melanson or Kiefer Sherwood—who can lock up a category—has value, Melanson appears to be a must-buy. Not only did he out-Hit the aforementioned Sherwood (5.25 per game vs. 4.71), but Melanson also averaged just under nine and a half minutes of ice time, and at that rate he was on pace for more than 425 Hits in an 82-game season. Though Melanson is a former 50-goal scorer in the QMJHL, his limited ice time and minimal offensive opportunity mean he won't offer much value beyond his massive Hit totals. Your league settings will determine whether that makes him elite or simply streaming fodder.

Upside Comparable: Kiefer Sherwood (20-25-45+, 120 PIM, 300+ Hits)

3YP: 15-15-30, 85 PIM, 225 Hits

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits).



David Goyette, C

(2026: 234) (2025: 200)

The 2025–26 campaign was certainly a letdown for Goyette. He was one of two Firebirds to receive a 20-game suspension for a performance-enhancing drug violation. His AHL career has started slowly despite leading the OHL in scoring with a 40-77-117 line over 68 games in 2023-24. Across two AHL seasons, he has produced nine goals, 19 assists, and 28 points in 105 games. Goyette is a solid passer and a capable finisher with a good shot when he's at his best. Kraken fans and poolies alike will hope he can put the disappointing year behind him and return with a chip on his shoulder as he competes for openings in Coachella Valley. At this point, hold him if you already roster him, and pencil him in as a middle-sixer who could see time on a second PP unit if he establishes himself.

Upside Comparable: Vincent Trocheck (30-40-70, 50 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 35 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 55%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Tyson Jugnauth, RD

(2026: 33D) (2025: 150D)

Jugnauth's development as a prospect has been interesting to watch. He was a useful—though not show-stopping—defender in the BCHL and NCAA before moving to the WHL and finding his offensive stride. After producing at a point-per-game pace over 41 games following his mid-season move to

the WHL in 2023–24, he vaulted to the top of the defensemen scoring race the following year with 13 goals and 76 assists in 65 games, finishing 17 points ahead of the runner-up. That performance surpassed fellow Kraken prospect Lukas Dragicevic and seemingly moved Jugnauth up the organizational depth chart, as he is now leading a Firebirds power play over Dragicevic, who arguably entered with more offensive pedigree. Jugnauth doesn't throw the body much for a defender—he recorded just 28 Hits in 75 AHL games last year—but he did register 100 blocks and 130 shots on goal. He projects as a top-four defenseman who could run a power play if his development continues on its current trajectory.

Upside Comparable: Vince Dunn (15-45-60, 40 PIM)

3YP: 10-25-35, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Lukas Dragicevic, RD

(2026: 40D) (2025: 43D)

Dragicevic was an incredible junior performer; his age-17 season scoring pace (1.10 points per game) is the highest by a 17-year-old defenseman in the WHL since 2009–10. His age-16 and age-19 seasons also rank inside the top 20, at 0.52 and 1.06 points per game respectively. Last season, he made his professional debut with Coachella Valley in the AHL, posting a muted 11 points in 43 games. With Ty Nelson and Tyson Jugnauth serving as the incumbent power-play quarterbacks, Dragicevic will likely need to wait for an injury or a graduation to earn meaningful time with the man advantage. His puck-moving and puckhandling skills are well established. Gaining the opportunity to develop his skating and defensive acumen in the AHL could help raise his floor when he eventually auditions for NHL minutes. If his development progresses successfully, he projects as a middle-pair defenseman and a second PP unit quarterback.

Upside Comparable: Shea Theodore (15-40-55, 34 PIM)

3YP: 10-20-30, 24 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Ty Nelson, LD

(2026: 47D) (2025: 59D)

Nelson is a well-rounded blueliner who can move the puck, get shots through traffic, and throw the body when needed. He quarterbacked a power play for the AHL Firebirds last season and led the team's defensemen in shots on goal. Nelson will have to battle with Tyson Jugnauth and Caden Price for the first opportunity to skate at the NHL level, but in the event of an injury, the first call-up should go to Nelson. Peripheral stat tracking outside the NHL can be inconsistent, but his 35 Hits, 96 blocks, and 158 shots on goal in 66 games suggest he could be a useful category filler at the NHL level if he earns the ice time. Fantasy managers should look at Ryker Evans' current deployment as a cautionary tale in the near term, with the Kraken's top two defense pairings locked in for several years barring a trade.

Upside Comparable: Filip Hronek (15-40-55, 65 PIM)

3YP: 8-25-33, 32 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Semyon Vyazovoy, G

In his second full KHL campaign, Vyazovoy was once again a top-five goaltender in the league. His 2.13 goals-against average and 0.913 save percentage ranked fifth in both categories among goalies with at least 25 appearances. A sixth-round pick in 2021 and still unsigned by Seattle, there remains uncertainty about whether he will make the move to North America any time soon. The expectation appears to be that he will join the Kraken once his KHL contract expires after one more season, at which point he could compete for a job in Seattle or Coachella Valley. An athletic netminder with a strong highlight reel—and regularly recognized as one of the KHL's top young players, including being named KHL Goaltender of the Month in January 2026—Vyazovoy would bring a breath of fresh air to Seattle's crease. Add him as he is unowned.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 28-24-8, 2.60 GAA, 0.911 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Niklas Kokko, G

Despite a decline in his rate stats, Kokko's overall record for Coachella Valley remained consistent in his sophomore year. He went from a 20-10-2 record with a 2.26 GAA and a 0.913 save percentage as a rookie to 19-10-2 with a 3.13 GAA and a 0.901 save percentage last season. The Firebirds welcomed three rookie blueliners and saw four veteran defenders with a combined 1,300+ AHL games depart, so it's no surprise that Kokko's numbers took a hit. Kokko is built like an NHL goalie at 6-4 and has a strong body of work in the Liiga—2.09 GAA and a 0.913 save percentage across 33 games—so there is no cause for alarm after a dip that can reasonably be attributed to the defense corps in front of him. At present, Kokko is the most NHL-ready goalie prospect in the Kraken pipeline and is not far from an opportunity. Hold or buy low.

Upside: 1A NHL split starter

3YP: 22-16-5, 2.75 GAA, 0.905 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



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Frozen Tools LEADER TOOLS

St. Louis BLUES

At a Glance

Top prospect: Justin Carbonneau
 Boom / Bust potential: Dmitri Buchelnikov
 Long-term project: Adam Jecho
 Top sniper: Justin Carbonneau
 Best setup man: Otto Stenberg

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Justin Carbonneau
 Defense: Theo Lindstein
 Goal: Vadim Zherenko
 Points only: Justin Carbonneau
 Multicategory: Jack Finley

2026 Draftees: Nick Bogas (D), Maddox Dagenais (F), Colin Fitzgerald (F), Tynan Lawrence (F), Landon Nycz (D), Vladimir Proskurin (G), Luke Schairer (D), Lars Steiner (F), Carter Stevens (F)

by Andrew Epps



Justin Carbonneau, RW

(2026: 34) (2025: N/A)

Selected 19th overall in 2025, the 6-1, 201-pound right-shot winger led the QMJHL with 51 goals in 60 games last season, earning the Mario Lemieux Trophy. He added 20 points (nine goals, 11 assists) in 17 playoff games before Blainville-Boisbriand fell in a Game 7 semifinal to Moncton. Carbonneau generates offense through pace, a quick release, and fearless net-front play. He retrieves pucks, protects them through contact, and finds shooting lanes in traffic. St. Louis assigned him to Springfield in early May and inserted him directly into the AHL playoff lineup. The concerns are real but workable: his defensive reads lag behind his offensive instincts, and his decision-making under forechecking pressure needs refinement. Pending UFA departures clear a path to the NHL roster, and his shot volume, physical engagement, and power-play utility give him a top-six ceiling if the two-way game catches up.

Upside Comparable: Travis Konecny (30-45-75, 55 PIM)

3YP: 20-32-52, 45 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 85%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Otto Stenberg, C

(2026: 36) (2025: 53)

Already 32 NHL games into his career at age 20, the 5-11 Swede collected 10 points (three goals, seven assists) while averaging over 13 minutes of ice time last season. The 25th overall pick from 2023 plays with constant engagement: he wins pucks back, drives through the neutral zone with pace, and distributes with above-average vision. His WJC pedigree (17 points in 14 games across two tournaments) confirmed the offensive instincts that made him a first-rounder. He also added 15 points in 33 AHL games with AHL Springfield. St. Louis reassigned him in mid-April to help the Thunderbirds' playoff push. The expectation is that Stenberg makes the opening-night roster in 2026-27. He needs to generate more shot volume and prove he can sustain offense over a full NHL schedule, but his skating motor and two-way habits are already NHL-caliber.

Upside Comparable: Mikael Granlund (25-45-70, 20 PIM)

3YP: 15-27-42, 15 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Dmitri Buchelnikov, LW

(2026: 126) (2025: 51)

A pure-skill winger whose rights St. Louis acquired in the Justin Faulk to Detroit trade, the 5-10 Russian (52nd overall, 2022) recorded 54 points in 65 KHL games in 2024–25, then missed the first half of last season while recovering from shoulder surgery. He returned to post 25 points in 44 regular-season games for CSKA Moscow, then scored his first KHL playoff goal and added four points in CSKA's five-game Round 1 win over SKA. CSKA was eliminated by Avangard in Round 2. Buchelnikov shoots right from the left side, giving him natural one-timer geometry on the power play. The obstacles are layered. His KHL contract runs through May 2027, he remains unsigned by St. Louis, and the suspended NHL–KHL transfer agreement adds another variable. At 170 pounds, he will also need an AHL adjustment period to handle North American physicality. If he arrives and adapts, there is legitimate middle-six upside.

Upside Comparable: Pavel Dorofeyev (25-40-65, 20 PIM)

3YP: 14-24-38, 15 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Potential star; draft in late rounds (if you can afford to wait a few years).



Juraj Pekarcik, LW

(2026: 151) (2025: 256)

Coming off a QMJHL championship run (67 regular season points and 21 playoff points for Moncton in 2024-25), the 6-2, 205-pound Slovak jumped straight into his first AHL campaign with Springfield this past season, posting 31 points in 59 regular-season games as a 20-year-old rookie. The third-rounder (76th overall, 2023) plays a mature, layered game for his age: legitimate hockey sense, quick processing in transition, and a willingness to drive inside and absorb contact rather than circle to the perimeter. His assist-heavy production (22 of 31 points) reflects vision and playmaking that should translate, though he needs to put more pucks on net. Defensively, his positional tracking still lapses when he gets caught puck-watching. The coaching staff is working to refine those habits before any NHL look becomes realistic. The timeline is patient, but the tools suggest a legitimate top-nine winger.

Upside Comparable: Max Domi (22-43-65, 35 PIM)

3YP: 12-23-35, 15 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Adam Jecho, C

(2026: 186) (2025: 311)

One of the most physically gifted forwards in the Blues' system, the 6-5 Czech center moves in ways players his size typically cannot: fluid stride, puck control in tight, and a hard release off the rush. He produced 53 points in 56 WHL games as a draft-year player, then added seven points at the 2025 World Junior Championship before a hand injury cost him six weeks. His 30 points in 39 games upon returning represent a dip, though the assist-heavy split (22 of 30) suggests he is distributing more than finishing. The concern at 201 pounds is consistent engagement. He does not impose

physically the way his frame allows, and his defensive reads remain underdeveloped for a center. Evaluators project him as a bottom-six pivot who could surprise if the shot and physicality converge. His ELC is slide-eligible, and his AHL transition likely begins next fall.

Upside Comparable: Boone Jenner (22-38-60+, 55 PIM)

3YP: 9-19-28, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Aleksanteri Kaskimaki, C

(2026: 197) (2025: 126)

Quietly one of Springfield's most reliable forwards, the 6-0 Finn from Espoo jumped from 34 points in 63 rookie games to 35 in 56 this past year, with his goal total climbing from 11 to 16. The Blues trusted him enough for a five-game NHL look in December, and while he didn't record a point, the call-up confirmed he is firmly on the organizational radar. His game is built on puck skills in tight spaces, competitive forechecking, and the versatility to play center or wing on both special-teams units. Three Liiga seasons with HIFK gave the 195-pound forward pro habits that translated quickly to North America. The gaps are pace and finishing. His ELC expires after 2026–27, putting pressure on both sides. The recent AHL playoff production (0-6-6 in nine games) was an encouraging sign.

Upside Comparable: Erik Haula (20-35-55+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 11-21-32, 12 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 12%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Tomas Mrcic, C

(2026: 224) (2025: 143)

From 90 WHL points to 10 in 36 NCAA games, the gap in Mrcic's first Colorado College season looks alarming on paper. It carries context: the 6-0, 174-pound forward jumped into the NCHC—the deepest conference in college hockey—as a 2006-born player, and his 18 penalty minutes suggest he is competing rather than coasting. The tools that made him a 90-point producer remain visible. His stride is deep and fully loaded, his release hides the blade angle until the last instant, and he processes quickly in transition. The defensive game and board play are obvious targets. At his weight, he gets outmuscled, and his positional awareness away from the puck remains inconsistent. The NCAA route gives him time. He is unsigned, with a sign-by date of June 2028. If the shot and speed hold up as his frame fills out, the offensive upside is real.

Upside Comparable: Conor Garland (22-38-60, 30 PIM)

3YP: 10-20-30, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Jack Finley, C

(2026: 254) (2025: 120)

The Blues claimed this massive 6-6 center off waivers from Tampa Bay in February 2026. At 227 pounds, Finley (57th overall in 2020) smothers opposing centers on the cycle, wins net-front positioning through sheer size, and kills penalties with his long reach and active stick. His NHL

production is limited—five points in 35 games—but his tools are specific and translatable. His 102 penalty minutes across 164 AHL games reinforce his physical identity, and fantasy managers in leagues tracking Hits and PIM will find added value. The offensive ceiling is narrow. He averaged 8:14 of five-on-five time in Tampa and does not generate shots or controlled entries at a rate that projects beyond a fourth-line role. St. Louis views him as a cost-controlled center to anchor their bottom six. Finley is waiver-eligible, which effectively locks him onto the NHL roster. His upside path runs through penalty-killing volume and occasional net-front power-play deployment.

Upside Comparable: Nick Paul (18-32-50, 55 PIM)

3YP: 7-15-22, 50 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 80%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits).



Matvei Korotky, C

(2026: 257) (2025: 444)

No seventh-round pick should be producing at this rate. The 6-0, 194-pound center posted 14 goals in 39 KHL regular-season games for SKA St. Petersburg despite missing nearly three months with a lower-body injury, ranking among the top under-21 scorers in the league. SKA was eliminated by CSKA Moscow in Round 1 of the Gagarin Cup playoffs, ending Korotky's season. His shooting is his calling card: he moves into dangerous areas with constant head and foot movement, stays open for an extra beat, and releases with deception and accuracy. He earned KHL Rookie of the Month honors in February 2025 and opened 2025–26 with a hat trick. SKA trusted him on the penalty kill and at the faceoff dot (52.5%), signaling two-way maturity beyond his draft pedigree (211th overall, 2024). His KHL contract runs through May 2027, he remains unsigned by St. Louis, and the suspended transfer agreement adds another layer of uncertainty.

Upside Comparable: Vladislav Namestnikov (24-41-65, 25 PIM)

3YP: 12-23-35, 15 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 12%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Juraj Stancl, LW

(2026: 343) (2025: 233)

Few Blues prospects possess a more intriguing physical package than this 6-3 Czech winger. He proved he can score against top competition, leading the 2025 World Junior Championship with seven goals. His first full AHL campaign was tougher: 18 points in 52 regular-season games with Springfield, a significant drop from his 57-point WHL season. The gap is not surprising for a 20-year-old fourth-rounder (106th overall, 2023) adjusting to pro structure after bouncing from Sweden to Kelowna to Springfield in consecutive years. At 198 pounds, the tools flash in sequences: a heavy one-timer from the half-wall, a willingness to bulldoze to the net front, and enough playmaking touch to execute give-and-go patterns. Consistency remains the issue. Defensive-positioning lapses have limited his ice time. If the net-front habits stabilize over a second AHL year, the scoring touch gives him a path to a power-forward role.

Upside Comparable: Yegor Chinakhov (22-38-60+, 25 PIM)

3YP: 12-25-37, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Adam Jiricek, RD

(2026: 7D) (2025: 46D)

The 16th overall pick in 2024 erased all questions about his injury-plagued 2024–25 season with one of the best defensive campaigns in the OHL. The 6-3, 185-pound right-shot blueliner posted 59 points in 55 games, set the Brantford franchise record for goals by a defenseman (19), and added 22 points in 15 playoff games while averaging over 25 minutes a night. He was named WJC Best Defenseman after scoring five goals in seven games during Czechia's silver-medal run. His skating is fluid for his frame, his one-timer from the right circle is a legitimate weapon, and he processes offensive-zone entries with patience uncommon for his age. Brantford's collapse from a 3–1 conference-final lead is not on him. He was assigned to Springfield and joined the Thunderbirds' AHL playoff lineup immediately. The right-shot, power-play-quarterback profile addresses a clear organizational need on the Blues' back end.

Upside Comparable: Evan Bouchard (15-45-60)

3YP: 8-28-36

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 85%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Theo Lindstein, LD

(2026: 29D) (2025: 38D)

After two SHL seasons with Brynas, the 6-0 Swede arrived in North America this fall and immediately proved that his skating and puck-moving translate to the smaller ice. His AHL totals (14 points in 56 games) do not jump off the page, but his late-season NHL call-up told a different story: in 17 games alongside Colton Parayko, Lindstein posted four points, a plus-6 rating, and averaged 15:46 per game with strong possession metrics. The first-rounder (29th overall, 2023) processes the game quickly, holds a tight gap, and makes clean first passes under pressure. His WJC pedigree (12 points in 14 games for Sweden) confirms that the offensive instincts are real. St. Louis reassigned him in mid-April, and he toiled top-pair minutes in the AHL playoffs. At 185 pounds, the development targets are physical: he needs to add 10 to 15 pounds to win more board battles. With Justin Faulk moved to Detroit at the trade deadline, he now holds an inside lane toward securing a roster spot at camp.

Upside Comparable: Jonas Brodin (15-30-45+)

3YP: 8-20-28

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Lukas Fischer, LD

(2026: 59D) (2025: 149D)

The son of former Detroit Red Wings defenseman Jiri Fischer plays a physical, detail-oriented game that belies his age. The 6-3, 185-pound blueliner captained the OHL Sarnia Sting before a blockbuster December trade sent him to the Soo Greyhounds for five draft picks (56th overall, 2024). He scored the go-ahead goal in Game 1 of the OHL playoffs against London, showcasing his best traits: a point shot through traffic, a willingness to jump into the play at the right time, and composure in high-leverage situations. His 81 penalty minutes in the prior season confirm the physical edge, and his two-way awareness earns trust in all situations. The 15-goal breakout in

2024–25 signaled offensive growth, though he remains more of a puck-mover than a true power-play quarterback. He needs to add 15 to 20 pounds before turning pro. The ceiling is a steady top-four defenseman who logs hard minutes.

Upside Comparable: Mattias Ekholm (12-33-45)

3YP: 7-18-25

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 12%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Vadim Zherenko, G

Three AHL seasons and zero NHL games tell the story of the Blues' goaltending logjam. The 6- 4, 196-pound Russian seventh-rounder (208th overall, 2019) flashed legitimate upside in his rookie campaign, posting a 0.918 save percentage behind a Springfield defense that allowed the most shots in the AHL. Since then, his numbers have declined: a 0.904 in year two and a 0.897 last season. He served as the backup to Georgi Romanov during Springfield's AHL playoff run. The size and athleticism remain visible, but his rebound control deteriorates under sustained pressure, and his positioning drifts when the pace increases. Jordan Binnington and Joel Hofer own the NHL crease, leaving Zherenko without a realistic path in St. Louis. His contract expires this summer, making him a Group 6 unrestricted free agent. A change of scenery could unlock a backup opportunity, but the downward trajectory makes that a long shot.

Upside: NHL backup

3YP: 15-12-4, 3.05 GAA, 0.905 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 25%

Expected Arrival: Now or never.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.

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DETAILED PROSPECT EXHIBITION STATS													
2025-2026 Exhibition Game Log												Frozen Tools Exclusive Data	
Date	Team	Status	G	PTS	+/-	PPG	HITS	BKS	FO	PPTOI	%PP	SHTOI	%TO
Oct 2	LA	✓	0	0	0	0	1	0	03:36	31.7	00:00	10.4	
Sep 30	LA	✓	1	1	2	0	0	0	00:00	0	00:00	00.0	
Sep 25	VGK	✓	0	0	0	0	0	0	01:07	55.8	00:00	13.2	
Sep 25	ANA	✗	0	0	0	0	0	0	05:07	-	-	-	
Sep 21	COL	✓	1	0	-1	1	1	1	01:08	45.2	00:00	10.3	

Tampa Bay LIGHTNING

At a Glance

Top prospect: Conor Geekie
 Boom / Bust potential: Jayson Shaugabay
 Long-term project: Everett Baldwin
 Top sniper: Conor Geekie
 Best setup man: Benjamin Rautiainen

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Conor Geekie
 Defense: Jan Golicic
 Goal: Caleb Heil
 Points only: Benjamin Rautiainen
 Multicategory: Dylan Duke

2026 Draftees: Morgan Anderberg (F), Tomas Kralovic (D), Oleg Kulebyakin (F), Stepan Shurygin (G), Cooper Soller (F), Max Vilén (D)

by Victor Nuño



Conor Geekie, C

(2026: 21) (2025: 39)

Geekie is a big, skilled center with strong puck protection, a long reach, and the offensive touch to create in tight. He does his best work below the dots, where he can shield defenders, extend possessions, and turn small advantages into scoring chances around the net. His hands and finishing ability give him clear fantasy appeal, and his significant scoring improvement in the AHL last season is an encouraging sign that his offense is translating against better competition. The key to his ceiling remains his skating and pace, as added quickness would help unlock more consistent top-six production. If he can continue to improve in that area—perhaps with some offseason work alongside his brother, Morgan (Boston)—there may still be another level of scoring to come. Even without that full leap, he projects as a productive middle-sixer with PP utility and solid long-term fantasy upside.

Upside Comparable: Ryan Johansen (30-45-75, 40 PIM)

3YP: 22-33-55, 35 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Benjamin Rautiainen, LW

(2026: 49) (2025: N/A)

Rautiainen is a highly skilled, pass-first winger whose game is driven by elite vision, deception, and offensive intelligence. He processes the game at a high level, manipulating defenders and creating passing lanes, particularly on the power play, where he can control play from the half-wall. His production in Liiga has been exceptional, highlighted by a dominant draft-plus-one season that reinforces his profile as one of the more intriguing late-round swings. His upside will hinge on how well his offensive game translates against stronger, more physical competition. He currently relies heavily on skill over pace or strength, and improvements in physical play and defensive consistency will be important. Rautiainen projects as a middle-six scoring winger with top-six upside if he earns consistent offensive deployment. In fantasy, his value is likely to be assist-driven, with the most appeal in formats that reward power-play production and overall point totals.

Upside Comparable: Jesper Bratt (25-60-85, 20 PIM)

3YP: 20-45-65, 25 PIM

Rule Your Pool!

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Sam O'Reilly, C

(2026: 75) (2025: 97)

O'Reilly is a highly reliable, detail-oriented two-way center whose game is built on structure, work rate, and strong defensive awareness. He consistently anticipates plays well, supports teammates effectively in all three zones, and brings a physical edge through strong board work and a willingness to engage in heavy areas. His intelligence and positioning make him a natural fit for penalty-kill usage and matchup situations. Offensively, he has shown enough vision and quick-touch passing to contribute secondary scoring at the junior level, but he is not projected to be a primary offensive driver. His skating stride—particularly his initial acceleration—remains an area for improvement and will influence how much offense he can generate at higher levels. As it stands, O'Reilly projects as a second-line matchup center who will earn trust through reliability rather than flash. He accomplished the rare feat of OHL MVP, Memorial Cup MVP and OHL Playoffs MVP.

Upside Comparable: Anthony Cirelli (20-45-65+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 15-30-45, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 80%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Ethan Gauthier, RW

(2026: 114) (2025: 80)

Gauthier is a high-energy, competitive winger defined by his relentless motor and physical style of play. He consistently applies pressure as a forechecker, wins puck battles, and creates turnovers through effort, while also showing strong hockey sense and positioning in high-danger areas. His ability to link plays in transition and maintain possession gives him enough offensive touch to contribute secondary scoring. While he lacks true top-end speed and may not project as a primary offensive driver, his all-around game provides a high floor. There are still areas to refine, particularly his defensive consistency and finishing at the professional level, but his work ethic and physical presence should translate well. Gauthier projects as a middle-six energy winger with multi-category fantasy appeal, especially in formats that reward shots and physicality. If he earns situational power-play usage or develops further offensively, there is some upside beyond that role, though his most likely outcome remains that of a reliable, versatile contributor.

Upside Comparable: Blake Coleman (25-35-60+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 20-25-45, 50 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Jayson Shaugabay, C

(2026: 152) (2025: 445)

Shaugabay is a high-end playmaking forward driven by elite spatial awareness, deception, and puck skill. He processes the ice at an advanced level, manipulating lanes and defenders from the half wall, where he projects as a natural power-play facilitator. His skating allows him to find passing lanes others cannot, distributing from nearly any body position. He thrives in possession, often slowing entries to create options and dictate tempo. The concerns are his pace and physical engagement. He does not consistently separate with speed and can be outmuscled in contested areas—issues that

will be magnified at higher levels. His projection hinges on adding strength and maintaining effectiveness against faster, more physical competition. If that comes, he has the tools to contribute as a secondary scorer with power-play value. If not, his path to an NHL role becomes narrower.

Upside Comparable: Zach Benson (20-45-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 10-30-40, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Dylan Duke, C/LW

(2026: 154) (2025: 125)

Duke is a high-compete winger whose game is built around relentless effort, elite net-front presence, and strong hockey sense. He generates offense through positioning, hand-eye coordination, and persistence, consistently creating chances in tight areas and thriving on the power play, where he has been among the AHL's most productive goal scorers. His ability to contribute in all situations, including penalty killing, adds to his overall reliability and increases his likelihood of earning NHL trust. While his skating remains an area to refine and his size (5-10, 184) can present challenges against larger defenders, his style translates well to a middle-six role. Duke's willingness to shoot, battle, and play through contact gives him value in multicategory formats, particularly if he continues to see power-play usage. The ceiling may be somewhat capped without top-unit deployment, but the floor is strong, and players with his profile often find ways to remain relevant.

Upside Comparable: Brendan Gallagher (30-30-60+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 22-24-46, 50 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will have cups of coffee with club/get a look this year, full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Joona Saarelainen, C

(2026: 167) (2025: NR)

Saarelainen is a high-energy, undersized center whose game is driven by pace, motor, and relentless two-way effort. He thrives on pressure, using a quick, agile stride to push play through the neutral zone and disrupt opponents as a forechecker and penalty killer. His ability to handle meaningful minutes in Liiga, including stretches as a top-line center, speaks to his growing trust and professional maturity, and he showed well on the international stage with a strong World Juniors performance. Offensively, much of his production is created through effort and detail rather than elite skill, so continued refinement in his finishing will be important. His size (5-9, 193) remains the primary limitation, particularly in sustained defensive situations. Still, his profile gives him a realistic path to a middle-six role.

Upside Comparable: Yanni Gourde (25-40-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Jack Pridham, RW

(2026: 188) (2025: 428)

Acquired immediately before press time on June 1, Pridham bolsters a very thin Tampa Bay prospect pipeline. He brings potential top-six upside that if it happens it will land in several years when the current crop of stars age out or move on. Traded out of a deep Chicago system, Pridham's rating is actually now higher than the 188 we gave him, now that he's on a team that will move him up quickly. The 6-1, 176-pound forward dominated the OHL in 2024-25 as a 19-year-old, and again last season as a 20-year-old (144 points in 113 games combined), and was a big part of Kitchener's Memorial Cup win alongside fellow Tampa prospect O'Reilly. He needs to bulk up, but will have plenty of time to do so as he has committed to the University of Denver of the NCAA.

Upside Comparable: Drake Batherson (35-35-70, 80 PIM)

3YP: 21-24-45, 58 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Niko Huuhtanen, RW

(2026: 269) (2025: 85)

****Now a UFA****

Huuhtanen brings a prototypical power-forward profile, combining size, physicality, and a heavy shot. He plays a direct, hard-nosed game, finishing checks and establishing a net-front presence, particularly on the power play. His ability to contribute in those areas gives him a pathway to a depth NHL role, even if his offensive ceiling remains modest. The primary limitation is his skating, as his pace can lag behind at the North American professional level. Following an uneven 2025-26 season that led to a mutual contract termination with Tampa Bay, he transitioned to Switzerland and will return to Finland's Liiga for 2026-27. While this shift clouds his NHL standing, he remains a player to monitor. If his skating improves, there is still a path back as a bottom-six, secondary-scoring winger with value in physical, multi-category formats.

Upside Comparable: Pat Maroon (20-30-50+, 100 PIM)

3YP: 14-18-32, 60 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 60%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Connor Kurth, RW

(2026: 332) (2025: 166)

Kurth projects as a reliable, team-first center whose game is built around structure, positioning, and consistency rather than offensive flair. He supports play effectively, handles responsibilities in multiple situations, and brings a steady presence that coaches tend to trust. His approach is direct and detail-oriented, allowing him to contribute through puck support, responsible positioning, and situational awareness more than through creation. The limitation in his profile is his offensive ceiling, as he does not currently project as a primary driver of scoring. His impact can also fluctuate depending on pace and competition level, and without a clear standout tool, his path likely leans toward a depth role. As a result, Kurth profiles as a bottom-six NHL forward who can provide real-life value through reliability and structure but offers limited fantasy appeal outside of very deep formats unless his offensive production takes a meaningful step forward.

Upside Comparable: Mike Fisher (25-30-55, 40 PIM)

3YP: 10-25-35, 25 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 55%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Ethan Czata, C

(2026: 211) (2025: N/A)

Czata is a high-compete, detail-oriented forward whose game is built on defensive reliability, physicality, and strong hockey sense. He plays with a relentless motor, consistently applying pressure on the backcheck, disrupting plays, and winning battles despite a lean frame. His ability to draw penalties, contribute on both special teams, and handle tough minutes has already made him a trusted, all-situations player at the junior level. Offensively, there are flashes of playmaking and support instincts, but he does not project as a primary driver of scoring at this stage. His skating mechanics remain the key variable, as improving his stride will be critical to translating his style to higher levels. As it stands, Czata projects as a high-floor bottom-six forward with the potential to grow into a reliable checking-line center if his skating and offensive consistency improve. For fantasy purposes, he is more of a long-term watchlist prospect, with value likely tied more to real-life impact than offensive production.

Upside Comparable: Anthony Cirelli (20-30-60, 80 PIM)

3YP: 15-25-40, 50 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Daniil Plyenkov, LD

(2026: 80D) (2025: 239D)

Plyenkov has taken a significant step forward, evolving from a steady, defense-first blueliner into a confident puck-moving defenseman following a breakout offensive season in the KHL. He plays a composed, intelligent game, showing patience under pressure and consistently making clean breakout decisions. His mobility and positioning allow him to defend effectively while contributing to transition play, and he has shown the ability to handle power-play responsibilities at the professional level. Despite the surge in production, his overall profile still leans more toward efficiency than dynamic upside. He does not project as a high-end offensive driver, and his path to the NHL is complicated by his current KHL contract, which may delay his transition. Long term, he projects as a reliable middle- to bottom-pair defenseman who can support puck movement and provide stability. For fantasy purposes, there is more intrigue now than before, but his value likely remains limited to deeper formats unless his offensive role carries over to North America.

Upside Comparable: Anton Stralman (10-35-45+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 5-15-20, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 55%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Everett Baldwin, RD

(2026: 136D) (2025: N/A)

Baldwin is a dynamic, offensive-minded defenseman whose game is driven by elite skating and aggressive transition play. He uses his mobility to evade pressure, push pace, and create offense, often activating off the rush or leading breakouts with confidence. His production in the QMJHL reflects that style, and there is clear upside as a modern puck-moving blueliner who can generate secondary offense. That said, his profile remains a longer-term projection. His decision-making under pressure can be inconsistent, and he will need to refine his puck management while adding strength to handle defensive-zone battles at higher levels. The tools are intriguing, but there is still development required before he can be relied upon in a structured role. If those areas come along,

he has the potential to grow into a transition-focused middle-pair defenseman. For fantasy purposes, he is more of a speculative upside play at this stage, with value tied to how much of his offensive toolkit translates.

Upside Comparable: Matt Grzelcyk (5-40-45, 60 PIM)

3YP: 2-23-25, 40 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Jan Golicic, LD

(2026: 143D) (2025: 207D)

Golicic is a massive, defense-first blueliner whose game is built around reach, physicality, and shutdown play rather than mobility or puck-moving. He uses his 6-5 frame effectively to close gaps, win battles, and clear the net front, projecting as the type of defender coaches trust in defensive situations and on the penalty kill. His positioning and awareness are strengths, and while there are flashes of a heavy shot and simple puck movement, offense is not expected to be a major part of his profile. The primary concern is his skating, as limited agility and pace could be a significant hurdle at higher levels. That caps both his overall ceiling and his fantasy appeal. Long term, he projects as a bottom-pair, stay-at-home d-man if his development progresses well. For dynasty purposes, he is more of a deep watchlist name, with value tied to real-life utility rather than offensive production.

Upside Comparable: Niko Mikkola (3-27-30+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 1-14-15, 50 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Caleb Heil, G

Heil is a highly athletic, high-compete goaltender whose game is built around mobility, flexibility, and a relentless battle level. He has the ability to make difficult, highlight-reel saves and plays the puck confidently, effectively acting as a third defenseman in transition. Despite his aggressive style, he shows composure in net and has taken a step forward in performance, handling a significant workload at the USHL level. The challenge in his profile lies in consistency and technical refinement. His tendency to overcommit can leave him exposed on second chances, and tightening his positioning will be key as he advances. That creates a wider range of outcomes compared to more structurally reliant goalies. Long term, he projects as a potential NHL backup or tandem option if his development continues positively. For fantasy purposes, he is more of a long-term, high-variance prospect, best suited for deeper formats where managers can afford to wait on the upside.

Upside: 1A NHL Split Starter

3YP: 22-18-3, 2.95 GAA, 0.902 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.

Toronto MAPLE LEAFS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Ben Danford
 Boom / Bust potential: Alex Plesovskikh
 Long-term project: Tinus Luc Koblar
 Top sniper: Miroslav Holinka
 Best setup man: Miroslav Holinka

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Miroslav Holinka
 Defense: Ben Danford
 Goal: Dennis Hildeby
 Points only: Miroslav Holinka
 Multicategory: Ben Danford

2026 Draftees: Juuso Ainasto (G), Alexander Bilecki (D), Yaroslav Fedoseyev (D), Måns Gudmundsson (D), Ethan MacKenzie (D), Gavin McKenna (F), Zac Olsen (F), Brody Pepoy (F), Patriks Plumins (G), Cooper Williams (F)

by Puneet Sharma



Miroslav Holinka, C

(2026: 112) (2025: 224)

Miroslav Holinka took a major step forward in his second WHL season with the Edmonton Oil Kings, emerging as one of the league's top offensive players with 80 points in 59 games. The biggest development was his jump in goal scoring, nearly doubling his total from 19 to 37 while showing far more confidence attacking inside scoring areas instead of playing strictly as a facilitator. Holinka brings a strong combination of size, hockey IQ, and dependable two-way habits, allowing him to contribute in multiple situations. While he is not an explosive skater or a naturally physical player, he processes the game well, supports the puck effectively, and consistently makes smart plays in all three zones. He had a brief AHL stint (one game) and will likely get more looks with the Marlies this season.

Upside Comparable: Anton Lundell (25-40-65+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 10-15-25, 18 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Jacob Quillan, C

(2026: 131) (2025: 285)

Quillan appeared in 23 NHL games with Toronto, recording one goal and two assists while averaging just over 10 minutes of ice time per game. His game is built on straight-line speed, puck pursuit, and a willingness to engage physically and win board battles. That compete level and work rate have been consistent calling cards since his NCAA days, including his Frozen Four MVP run. The concern, however, is his offensive ceiling. He does not naturally drive play or create much independently, and his profile trends more toward reliable energy depth than impact scoring presence. With ongoing changes in Toronto, his roster spot remains uncertain heading into the RFA offseason, and his path forward will likely depend heavily on role, opportunity, and how the Leafs reshape their bottom six.

Upside Comparable: Bobby McMann (25-30-55+, 45 PIM)

3YP: 12-18-30, 18 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick if you need immediate help and can accept a lower ceiling.



Tinus Luc Koblar, C

(2026: 174) (2025: N/A)

Koblar quietly put together a solid season with Leksands IF, finishing with 14 points in 47 SHL games while holding a regular role against older and far more physically mature competition. The raw production does not immediately stand out, but earning consistent minutes in the SHL as an 18-year-old is impressive and speaks to the trust he earned from the coaching staff. The Maple Leafs prospect brings a strong combination of size, strength, skating, and competitiveness that already projects well for the pro game. Koblar plays a direct style, works hard around the net, and consistently puts himself in good positions. He competes well in physical areas, supports the puck effectively, and already shows pro-level habits. While the offensive upside remains a question, his defensive reliability and physical tools give him a path toward a bottom-six NHL role.

Upside Comparable: Mikael Backlund (20-40-60+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 16-25-40, 25 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Alexander Plesovskikh, LW

(2026: 249) (2025: NR)

Plesovskikh put up 27 goals and 51 points in 53 games with MHK Spartak Moskva in the MHL, finding his footing offensively after brief looks in the VHL and KHL, where he appeared in only five total games. The production spike is encouraging, but it also highlights where he is in his development curve at this stage. At 6-1, he uses his frame effectively and plays with a high motor, consistently engaging defenders and competing hard on pucks. There are flashes of an interesting offensive player, particularly when he is able to build speed through the neutral zone. That said, the long-term projection remains uncertain. If he does make the jump, it likely won't be for a few years, and an NHL or AHL path is still very much an uphill climb.

Upside Comparable: Valeri Nichushkin (30-35-65, 55 PIM)

3YP: 18-22-40, 45 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 55%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Roni Hirvonen, LW

(2026: 293) (2025: 319)

Hirvonen has settled in well during his first season back in Finland, transitioning from the AHL to Liiga hockey and finding a more comfortable offensive rhythm. In 2025–26, he produced 16 goals and 36 assists in 57 games, operating at nearly a point-per-game pace and re-establishing himself as a consistent offensive contributor. He has shown he can still drive play, create chances off the cycle, and contribute as both a scorer and playmaker at a high professional level. The big question now is direction. With no contract currently in place and Toronto still holding his rights, the path forward remains open. Depending on roster turnover and opportunity within the organization, there is a real possibility he considers returning to push for a training-camp role. Alternatively, another season in Finland could remain on the table if development is the priority.

Upside Comparable: Dawson Mercer (25-35-60, 40 PIM)

3YP: 18-24-42, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling).



Tyler Hopkins, C

(2026: 325) (2025: N/A)

Hopkins continued taking positive steps during the 2025–26 season, recording 25 points in 29 OHL games after putting up 51 points in 67 games the year prior with the Kingston Frontenacs. The overall production may not jump off the page, but the increase in his scoring pace points toward steady offensive progression in his second junior season. Hopkins projects as a dependable two-way center whose game is built around structure, competitiveness, and consistent habits. He skates well, uses his edges effectively to escape pressure, and shows good vision and puck-distribution ability in transition. While he likely does not project as a major offensive producer at the NHL level, his versatility, work ethic, and responsible play style continue to give him a legitimate path toward pro hockey. If he can continue getting stronger while adding more confidence and consistency with the puck, there is realistic upside as a reliable bottom-six NHL forward.

Upside Comparable: Anthony Cirelli (25-40-65, 40 PIM)

3YP: 17-25-42, 35 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 65%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Brandon Buhr, RW

(2026: 338) (2025: N/A)

Buhr split his season between Union College and a short AHL stint with the Toronto Marlies, and the contrast between levels told most of the story. At Union, he was an offensive driver, finishing with 36 points in 35 games while consistently generating offense through both finishing and playmaking. His game is built around attacking high-danger areas, where his motor, heavy shot, and strong hand-eye coordination around the net stand out. He plays with pace and isn't just a net-front presence, but a player who can both finish chances and create them in tight. Overall, he profiles as a late-blooming college free agent with real offensive instincts and a pro frame. The next step is proving his pace and processing can translate over a full AHL season before any NHL projection becomes realistic.

Upside Comparable: Michael McCarron (20-30-50+, 90 PIM)

3YP: 12-18-30, 70 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 60%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Harry Nansi, RW/C

(2026: 389) (2025: N/A)

Nansi jumped from 23 points to 56 points in the 2025–26 OHL season while becoming far more involved offensively from the back end. The Leafs prospect showed noticeable growth as a puck mover and distributor, finishing with 43 assists and looking more confident carrying and moving the puck through transition. His skating still needs refinement, but he looked stronger physically this

season and handled pressure better in contested areas and along the walls. At 6-3, Nansi brings good size, competitiveness, and a willingness to battle in difficult areas while also showing some offensive creativity and vision with the puck. The offensive breakout helped push him further into the legitimate-prospect conversation, though there is still work needed defensively and with his overall consistency. If his skating, defensive processing, and physical development continue trending upward, there is a realistic path toward becoming a depth piece.

Upside Comparable: Mason Marchment (28-35-63, 85 PIM)

3YP: 16-22-38, 60 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



William Villeneuve, RD

(2026: 64D) (2025: 73D)

Villeneuve (6-2, 183) is a puck-moving defenseman whose primary fantasy appeal is tied to his high-IQ passing and multi-cat foundation. Drafted 122nd overall in 2020, Villeneuve graduated from a highly productive QMJHL career into a reliable top-four role with the Marlies. He possesses an excellent first pass, commands breakouts under pressure, and displays smooth lane-finding vision that generated a career-high 36 assists in the minor leagues during the 2024–25 campaign. While his straight-line foot speed and need for physical bulk remain obstacles to securing an everyday top-four role, his three-game NHL emergency recall with the Maple Leafs highlights his standing within the organizational depth chart. Ultimately, his statistical ceiling hinges on developing enough defensive consistency to earn secondary power-play repetition at the NHL level. He cleared waivers last fall, so being eligible for waivers is not a deterrent for the Leafs to send him down—he'll need to earn it.

Upside Comparable: Conor Timmins (5-40-45+, 85 PIM)

3YP: 6-24-30, 72 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will have cups of coffee with club/get a look this year, full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits.



Ben Danford, RD

(2026: 103D) (2025: 68D)

Danford may not have the offensive production typically associated with a first-round defenseman, but his game has steadily progressed over the last few seasons. He has become more involved offensively, showing improved confidence carrying pucks, supporting transition, and activating into plays. Where Danford stands out is defensively. His gap control, positioning, stick detail, and ability to close quickly on attackers already project well for the pro game. He competes hard, wins battles consistently, and brings the type of physical engagement coaches trust. While his puck play can simplify under pressure at higher levels, his overall consistency, defensive IQ, and strong habits continue to make him one of the safer prospects in Toronto's system. The long-term projection still looks like a reliable third-pair NHL defenseman who can handle difficult defensive minutes.

Upside Comparable: Brandon Carlo (5-30-35+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 6-24-30, 65 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 80%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits.



Dennis Hildeby, G

Hildeby split his time between the AHL Marlies and the NHL Maple Leafs while looking far more comfortable in Toronto. After struggling in limited appearances the previous year, Hildeby posted a 0.914 save percentage across 20 NHL games and showed he could handle NHL pace with much more consistency. His size remains his biggest advantage at 6-7, but what makes him intriguing is his calm positioning, strong puck tracking, and solid hands for a goalie with that frame. He naturally takes away a large portion of the net and stays composed through traffic and broken plays around the crease. There are still moments where his movement can look heavy during quick east-west sequences, but his rebound control and overall positioning continued to improve throughout the season. The Leafs consistently trusted him with NHL opportunities, and he increasingly looks like a legit big-league backup candidate moving forward; however, given the volatility of the team's goalie situation, anything can happen.

Upside: 1A NHL split starter

3YP: 25-15-8, 2.80 GAA, 0.900 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 70%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Artur Akhtyamov, G

Akhtyamov posted a 21-12-4 record and a 0.904 save percentage across 37 games while handling a significantly larger workload with the Marlies. The raw numbers may not fully stand out, but his season showed improved consistency and the ability to manage starter-level minutes in the AHL. And in the playoffs he head the Marlies to the Calder Cup, earning playoff MVP and solidifying himself as a legitimate goalie prospect. He relies heavily on athleticism, quick lateral movement, and strong reflexes, particularly in scramble situations and against cross-ice plays. Despite not having an imposing frame, he tracks pucks well, competes hard, and uses strong positioning and quick hands to limit clean looks high in the net. His brief NHL stint was difficult statistically, but the sample was extremely limited and more valuable as a developmental experience. Akhtyamov still projects as a legitimate prospect with a realistic path toward becoming a capable backup goaltender at the NHL level.

Upside: NHL backup

3YP: 15-10-6, 2.88 GAA, 0.900 SV%

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 55%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.

Utah MAMMOTH

At a Glance

Top prospect: Tij Iginla
 Boom / Bust potential: Gabe Smith
 Long-term project: Yegor Borikov
 Top sniper: Tij Iginla
 Best setup man: Caleb Desnoyers

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Tij Iginla
 Defense: Artyom Duda
 Goal: Michael Hrabal
 Points only: Tij Iginla
 Multicategory: Maveric Lamoureux

2026 Draftees: Carl Axelsson (G), Ethan Belchetz (F), Florent Houle (F), Theodor Knights (D), Artyom Prima (F), Adam Valentini (F)

by Dobber



Tij Iginla, LW

(2026: 5) (2025: 2)



Jarome's son bounced back nicely after missing much of 2024–25 with a hip injury that required surgery. As the alternate captain of Memorial Cup host Kelowna, Iginla scored 41 goals and 90 points in just 48 games, plus another seven goals and 12 points in nine playoff games. He also recorded eight points in seven games for Team Canada at the WJC. A sniper with strong two-way skills and a growing aggressive edge—much like his father—Iginla was the sixth overall pick in 2024 and likely would have played in Utah had he not missed that key development year at age 18. The 6-0, 192-pound forward isn't the biggest on the ice, but he plays hard—described as "hyper-competitive"—and brings a power-forward mentality. He will likely make the Mammoth this year; if he's sent down, it will probably be due to a numbers game, and he should be called back up once that's resolved.

Upside Comparable: Jarome Iginla (50-40-90, 70 PIM)

3YP: 32-30-62, 57 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 35%, 95%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP..



Caleb Desnoyers, C

(2026: 13) (2025: N/A)



Last summer's fourth-overall pick suffered a wrist injury that required surgery and caused him to miss camp. Upon returning—and after an understandable slow start—Desnoyers took off, exploding for 78 points in 45 games and tying for fourth in assists (56) despite playing nearly 20 fewer games than anyone else in the top 10. He is a two-way forward who is very strong in the faceoff circle. Desnoyers projects to be the two-way force behind Logan Cooley. He posted 25 points in 21 playoff games for Moncton while being deployed as a defense-first forward. The team captain would have had more points were that not the case, but it hints at his future as a pro. He played the same role with Canada at the World Juniors—a defensive specialist on the checking line—yet still managed six points in seven contests. He is looking like a potential Patrice Bergeron/Jonathan Toews/Sean Couturier-type player.

Upside Comparable: Patrice Bergeron (25-55-80+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 18-45-63, 52 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 20%, 95%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP..



Daniil But, LW/RW

(2026: 29) (2025: 79)

As with all 6-5 teenagers drafted high (12th overall in 2023), patience is required before we see any upside. But But is making fantastic progress. However, because he was drafted three years ago, his fantasy owners are losing patience—perhaps disappointed that he managed only six points in his 29 NHL games. That makes him an ideal offseason target in your dynasty league. He was very successful in the KHL despite being just 20 years old, including winning the Gagarin Cup, and he adapted quickly to AHL hockey last season, posting nearly a point per game (39 in 41). A natural leader who loves to shoot the puck, he reminds us of Tage Thompson. If you recall, Thompson was a 14-point player before he turned 24. You might be looking at a similar wait time with But. He's worth holding for three more years because, while he probably won't be *that* good, there's a strong chance he'll get pretty close.

Upside Comparable: Valeri Nichushkin (35-35-70, 50 PIM)

3YP: 28-33-61, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 35%, 95%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Cole Beaudoin, C/LW

(2026: 51) (2025: 115)

Now with NYR

Utah brass believe Beaudoin will be a surefire NHLer, citing his two-way game, character, and drive. Offensively, he has more than proven himself at the junior level, posting 88 points in 55 games as OHL Barrie's team captain, plus another seven in seven for Team Canada at the WJC. A possible future captain of the Mammoth, Beaudoin projects as a middle-six center who may slot in on the third line behind Logan Cooley and Caleb Desnoyers for the first few years of his career. But much like it was with a young Sean Couturier, there is some upside here that will depend on PP usage and linemates. At 6-2 and 211 pounds, he has NHL size, but given his usage and play in exhibition games last fall (low minutes, minus-3), he is still a bit away.

Upside Comparable: Jordan Staal (25-40-65+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 20-30-50, 60 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 25%, 85%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Gabe Smith, C

(2026: 104) (2025: N/A)

Smith was one of the youngest players in the 2024 NHL Draft, selected at just 17 years old. When a player hasn't emerged yet and is still so young, it can go one of two ways—boom or bust. After Smith's breakout last season, the pick (103rd overall) appears to fall into the "boom" category. At 6-4 and 208 pounds, Smith's talent is finally catching up to his size. Lining up in Moncton alongside fellow Utah prospect Caleb Desnoyers, he has benefited from Desnoyers' slick passing, scoring 34 goals plus another 19 in 21 playoff games. He actually led the entire QMJHL in playoff scoring (33 points). It remains to be seen whether he can translate that offense to AHL hockey in the fall, but it

would help if Desnoyers is sent to the AHL for the first few weeks to support him. Smith also won the QMJHL Best Defensive Forward award.

Upside Comparable: Tom Wilson (35-35-70+, 80+ PIM)

3YP: 26-24-50, 75 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Vadim Moroz, LW/RW

(2026: 184) (2025: 142)

Moroz's offense took a big step back in the KHL last season, mitigated by a combination of Dynamo Minsk acquiring veterans like Stanislav Galiyev and the emergence of new Predators forward Vitali Pinchuk. That said, he did play in the KHL All-Star Game and still managed just over a point every two games. There are rumors that Utah will sign him, but at press time that had not yet happened. Bringing him over to play in the AHL would benefit him greatly, especially with the high quality of top-tier prospects the organization has turning pro this season. He should slot in nicely as an impactful, multi-dimensional piece. He has a projectable 6-2 frame that desperately needs to bulk up to handle heavy North American contact.

Upside Comparable: Dmitry Voronkov (25-35-60+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 15-27-42, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Yegor Borikov, RW

(2026: 228) (2025: N/A)

The Mammoth picked up on Borikov's skill while scouting their already-drafted player, Dynamo Minsk teammate Vadim Moroz, and subsequently drafted him 110th overall last year, which was his third year of eligibility. After improving to 16 goals and 30 points in 59 games—both career highs—his KHL contract expired, and Utah signed him in May to his ELC. Not overly big at 6-1 and 187 pounds, he nonetheless loves to throw his body around (78 Hits last season) and has immense potential for fantasy owners looking to add Hits. This aggressive physical edge, combined with an active stick on the forecheck, makes him a highly intriguing multi-categorical sleeper. He steps up when it counts, scoring big goals in the postseason, proving his clutch instincts should translate beautifully when he transitions to the smaller North American ice surfaces this fall.

Upside Comparable: Alex Formenton (25-35-60+, 30 PIM, 150 Hits)

3YP: 12-25-37, 20 PIM, 120 Hits

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Dmitri Simashev, LD

(2026: 14D) (2025: 25D)

A big 6-5 defenseman drafted sixth overall in 2023, Simashev brought his game over from the KHL last season and made the team out of camp. A smooth skater with that kind of size is rare, and Simashev has the two-way skills to go with it. He partnered with Mikhail Sergachev early on but struggled to defend against the tougher opponents that came with that assignment, and he drifted

down the lineup. He also struggled to find offense, tallying just one assist in 24 games before being sent down. With Tucson, he certainly found it—using his heavy shot to score eight times in 40 games and finishing with 35 points. This was his best offensive output at any level since he was 16, so it caught more than a few fantasy owners off guard. Still just 21, when he finds his mojo—and he will—he projects to be the Devon Toews to Sergachev's Cale Makar.

Upside Comparable: Alex Pietrangelo (8-37-45+, 70 PIM)

3YP: 10-30-40, 57 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 30%, 99%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Artyom Duda, LD

(2026: 35D) (2025: 36D)

Tucson's top defenseman started off hot with 11 points in his first 18 games, but he suffered a mid-body/core muscle strain in November. He returned to play nine games in which he wasn't quite himself, and then suffered a severe tear in his hip-flexor/groin area that ended his season. Between missing much of 2023–24 (the NCAA ruled him ineligible, and he eventually played university hockey in Canada) and much of last season in the AHL, Duda's development is a little behind. Had he stayed on track, he would likely be cracking the Mammoth lineup. Instead, he will give the AHL another go, showcasing the deceptive playmaking ability and strong two-way game that made him a high pick (36th overall) in 2022.

Upside Comparable: Cam Fowler (10-35-45+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 7-25-32, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 25%, 75%

Expected Arrival: 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Tomas Lavoie, RD

(2026: 49D) (2025: 71D)

A huge rearguard at 6-4 and 218 pounds, Lavoie has been feasting on QMJHL opponents, shutting down their forwards and finding seams in their defenses. As team captain of Cape Breton, he posted 21 points in his first 24 games before being traded at midseason to powerhouse Chicoutimi, where he added another 34 points in 52 regular-season and playoff games en route to the Memorial Cup. In Chicoutimi, he was second on the PP-QB depth chart behind Nashville prospect Alex Huang. A former No. 1 pick in the QMJHL Draft, Lavoie was selected by Utah 89th overall in 2024. Despite his offensive production, he projects more as a shutdown defenseman. But the potential is there, and if he partners with a skilled puck-mover, he could hit his upside.

Upside Comparable: Adam Larsson (10-35-45+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 8-25-33, 43 PIM

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Maveric Lamoureux, RD

(2026: 68D) (2025: 30D)

The 6-7 giant looked poised to crack the Mammoth's lineup last year after a 15-game stint in the NHL the year prior as a 21-year-old. Lamoureux had gained 15 pounds of muscle and is now up to

217. Ultimately, the team decided that one more year in the AHL couldn't hurt. Once Simashev (6-5) was sent down, the two were paired together to form a devastating, nearly unbeatable duo. They could both graduate to the big club this season and eventually dominate the NHL in the same way. Lamoureux is more of a stay-at-home, shutdown type, but he does know how to move the puck and chip in the odd point, and he offers tremendous upside in PIM and Hits. His punishing physical style makes him a certified fantasy powerhouse.

Upside Comparable: Nikita Zadorov (5-35-40, 90+ PIM, 180+ Hits)

3YP: 5-25-30, 90 PIM, 150 Hits

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 30%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits).



Max Psenicka, RD

(2026: 153D) (2025: N/A)

Another giant of a defenseman that Utah has added to its stable is Psenicka, who was selected with the 46th overall pick last summer. Standing 6-5 and 184 pounds, Psenicka is a physical player with two-way upside. Compared to the other two giants profiled above, Psenicka is the more physical and punishing—even more than Maveric Lamoureux. Offensively, he lacks the hockey sense and creativity needed to make plays consistently at the pro level, but he does offer a heavy shot. His appeal lies in banger leagues, and you saw this in his two games with Tucson at the end of the season, when he posted 10 PIM (he already had 67 PIM in the WHL with Portland), though those 10 minutes came from his involvement in a late-game scrum. At the WJC, he was a standout defensive anchor for Czechia, helping them earn a silver medal.

Upside Comparable: Erik Cernak (5-30-35+, 100 PIM, 180+ Hits)

3YP: 6-15-21, 85 PIM, 150 Hits

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Michael Hrabal, G

The 6-7 netminder finished his NCAA career by posting personal bests in save percentage (0.937), goals-against average (1.95), and shutouts (four) before turning pro after his junior season. Upon joining Tucson, he went 3-1-1 with a 2.96 GAA and a 0.897 SV%, which was the best performance among the three goalies—albeit in a much smaller sample size. Hrabal, drafted 38th overall in 2023, was the second-highest goaltender selected (after Adam Gajan by Chicago at 35). In his last WJC tournament for Czechia, he was on another level, leading the team to a bronze medal. With Karel Vejmelka in place for the next four seasons, Hrabal will likely spend two years in the AHL, one year as a backup/apprentice, and then possibly enter a split-starter scenario in the fourth year. But make no mistake—Hrabal will be an NHL starter.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 35-20-5, 2.60 GAA, 0.908 SV%

Fantasy Upside/NHL Certainty: 30%, 90%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: He should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.

Vancouver CANUCKS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Braeden Cootes
 Boom / Bust potential: Jon. Lekkerimaki
 Long-term project: Riley Patterson
 Top sniper: Jonathan Lekkerimaki
 Best setup man: Arshdeep Baines

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Jonathan Lekkerimaki
 Defense: Sawyer Mynio
 Goalie: Nikita Tolopilo
 Points only: Jonathan Lekkerimaki
 Multicategory: Braeden Cootes

2026 Draftees: [Niklas Aaram-Olsen \(F\)](#), [Lucian Bernat \(F\)](#), [Yaroslav Bryzgalov \(F\)](#), [Connor Davis \(F\)](#), [Samuel Eriksson \(D\)](#), [Dmitri Ivchenko \(G\)](#), [Caleb Malhotra \(F\)](#), [Adam Novotný \(F\)](#), [Brooks Rogowski](#)

by Owen Hilsenger



Jonathan Lekkerimaki, RW

(2026: 25) (2025: 8)

Lekkerimaki feels like the type of prospect fantasy managers either aggressively target or completely avoid—there is rarely much middle ground. He is a pure offensive weapon whose game revolves around touch, deception, and one of the deadliest releases in the prospect pipeline. When he gets time and space in the offensive zone, defenders are often already too late. Even during an injury-interrupted campaign that temporarily slowed his momentum, the flashes of high-end scoring talent never disappeared. He attacks coverage with patience, slips into soft ice effortlessly, and thrives as a one-touch finisher on the power play. The fantasy upside is a future top-six sniper capable of pushing 30-plus goals while piling up power-play production alongside elite talent. The gamble, however, lies in whether his pace, physical engagement, and overall consistency can keep up with NHL speed.

Upside Comparable: Lucas Raymond (30-45-75, 20 PIM)

3YP: 25-30-55, 10 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 85%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Braeden Cootes, C

(2026: 47) (2025: N/A)

Cootes projects as a safe, high-floor center built on pace, intelligence, and competitiveness. He consistently impacts play through strong defensive detail, reliable puck support, and a relentless motor that shows up in transition, on the forecheck, and in puck battles. In transition, he is efficient and direct, using quick reads and speed to advance momentum under pressure. Offensively, he drives play through habits and decision-making rather than high-end creativity, contributing more as a facilitator within structured possession than as a primary scorer. For fantasy purposes, his ceiling is limited by the lack of elite offensive tools, but his translatable two-way game, pace, and reliability give him a strong chance to earn special-teams usage, consistent middle-six minutes, and steady secondary scoring.

Upside Comparable: Brayden Schenn (30-40-70+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 20-35-55, 25 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 85%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Riley Patterson, C

(2026: 128) (2025: NR)

Patterson emerged as one of the more intriguing late-rising forward prospects after transitioning to center full time and unlocking another offensive level. He combines strong straight-line speed with a shoot-first mentality, generating offense effectively off the rush and through quick-strike scoring plays. Patterson attacks with pace, drives the middle lane well, and consistently pressures defenders through his motor and puck pursuit. His finishing ability took a major step forward this season, showing improved confidence attacking inside space and creating chances from dangerous areas. For fantasy purposes, his appeal comes from the combination of center eligibility, goal-scoring upside, and transition-driven offense. While he may not project as a pure high-end playmaker, Patterson's speed and shot give him legitimate middle-six NHL upside with the potential for secondary power-play usage. His long-term upside will likely depend on how much his processing and overall offensive creation continue to develop against faster, more structured competition.

Upside Comparable: Ryan Strome (25-40-65+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 15-24-39, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Kieren Dervin, C

(2026: 326) (2025: N/A)

Dervin projects as a dependable, detail-oriented forward whose fantasy value will be driven more by role stability than high-end scoring upside. He brings a structured, two-way game built on pace, defensive awareness, and consistent puck support through all three zones. Dervin is effective on the forecheck, closes space quickly, and shows strong habits in retrievals and board battles, allowing him to maintain possession and tilt the ice in subtle but valuable ways. Offensively, he is more of a secondary contributor, relying on smart positioning, quick reads, and opportunistic finishing rather than dynamic creation or high-end skill. His pathway to fantasy relevance will likely come through middle-to-bottom-six usage, penalty-kill deployment, and matchup assignments where coaches trust his reliability. While his offensive ceiling is modest compared to higher-skill peers, Dervin's translatable habits, motor, and defensive responsibility give him a realistic chance to carve out a long-term NHL role with occasional depth-scoring value in deeper fantasy formats.

Upside Comparable: Phillip Danault (20-40-60, 35 PIM)

3YP: 10-15-25, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Arshdeep Bains, LW

(2026: 155) (2025: 84)

Bains has established himself as one of the most reliable depth options in the Vancouver system, functioning as a high-end "insurance policy" capable of stepping into NHL minutes when needed. Following a standout run with Abbotsford's Calder Cup championship group, where he produced at a point-per-game pace through a deep postseason run, Bains has shown he can elevate his game in high-leverage situations while remaining one of the AHL's most consistent offensive drivers. A

cerebral, high-IQ playmaker, Bains thrives by manipulating pace, extending possessions, and threading passes through tight seams rather than beating defenders with speed or power. By rounding out his 200-foot game, he has earned trust in lower-lineup matchups and secondary penalty-kill usage. While his NHL offensive impact has been limited to date, his puck skill and composure allow him to fill in across the bottom six and occasionally move up when injuries arise. For fantasy purposes, his ceiling remains depth-oriented, but his ability to contribute as a call-up gives him niche value in deeper formats.

Upside Comparable: Conor Sheary (25-35-60+, 22 PIM)

3YP: 7-15-22, 22 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 65%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Ty Mueller, C

(2026: 423) (2025: 176)

Mueller represents the classic “high-floor, low-ceiling” archetype that serves as an essential depth piece for deep fantasy rosters. He has already shown the professional polish needed to handle an NHL role, and although his six-game stint with Vancouver in 2026 resulted in just a single goal, his defensive metrics and penalty-killing utility have earned him significant trust from the coaching staff. For poolies, Mueller is a player who can contribute Hits and blocked shots while offering steady, if modest, offensive production. As the Canucks continue to retool their bottom six, Mueller is a candidate to secure a permanent center spot, making him a reliable high-floor asset in dynasty formats and a streaming option in deep redraft leagues.

Upside Comparable: Teddy Blueger (10-30-40+, 35 PIM)

3YP: 10-15-25, 30 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Ilya Safanov, C

(2026: 455) (2025: NR)

Safanov is becoming one of the most interesting two-way centers outside North America, steadily building momentum as a potential NHL option down the middle. The big-bodied pivot combines physical maturity, defensive awareness, and strong puck-protection habits, allowing him to handle difficult matchups while still contributing offensively. His fantasy appeal comes primarily from his multi-category profile. He thrives in high-traffic areas, plays through contact effectively, and uses his reach and positioning to disrupt transition plays and extend possessions. While he may lack the explosive skating or dynamic offensive upside of a top-line center, his hockey sense and engagement level give him a chance to carve out an NHL role. For fantasy managers in deeper formats, Safanov projects as the type of player who could provide sneaky value through Hits, puck battles, defensive usage, and secondary offense if his transition to North America is successful.

Upside Comparable: Adam Lowry (15-30-45+, 57 PIM)

3YP: 8-10-18, 35 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.



Sawyer Mynio, LD

(2026: 52D) (2025: 47D)

Mynio has moved beyond his early reputation as a shutdown specialist and is developing into a legitimate two-way defenseman within the Vancouver system. In his first full AHL season, he handled heavy pro minutes and showed he can absorb pace while gradually expanding his offensive impact. He finished among the top rookie defensemen in scoring and earned consistent power-play usage, reflecting growing trust in his puck-moving ability at the blue line. From a fantasy perspective, his value is rooted in stability and category coverage rather than high-end offensive upside. Mynio combines strong hockey IQ, composed puck management, and a competitive edge that translates well to multi-category formats. While his minus rating reflects an adjustment period against stronger competition, his underlying transition defense and special-teams deployment point to a player trending in the right direction. He remains a strong early call-up candidate with sneaky value in deeper leagues.

Upside Comparable: Damon Severson (10-35-45+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 3-14-17, 47 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Hugo Gabrielson, LD

(2026: 70D) (2025: 75D)

Gabrielson has steadily shifted his projection from a defense-first prospect into a far more intriguing two-way option with legitimate puck-moving upside. His recent play in HockeyAllsvenskan showcased a new level of offensive confidence, as he emerged as one of the league's more productive young defensemen while taking on increased responsibility with the puck on his stick. Gabrielson processes the game extremely well from the back end, consistently identifying passing seams, managing pace through transition, and facilitating possession efficiently in all three zones. His fantasy appeal lies more in intelligence and volume than in flashy offensive creation. He has become more willing to activate offensively and increase his shot totals, adding another layer to his projection as a potential secondary power-play contributor. While he still needs to add strength to handle the physical demands of North American hockey, his poise and composure give him a path toward NHL depth value. If he eventually transitions to the AHL, he profiles as a sneaky dynasty target capable of contributing assists, blocks, and secondary special-teams production.

Upside Comparable: Marcus Pettersson (5-35-40+, 44 PIM)

3YP: 2-14-16, 38 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 60%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Nikita Tolopilo, G

Tolopilo is beginning to evolve from intriguing organizational depth into a legitimate NHL goaltending option. The towering netminder has developed a reputation as a capable call-up with the ability to handle a heavy workload while keeping games within reach. When given NHL opportunities, he has shown notable composure under pressure, relying on strong positioning and patience rather than pure desperation athleticism. He profiles as the type of goaltender who can quietly accumulate strong save totals simply through volume, particularly in formats that reward raw saves and starts. His size naturally eliminates space, but his improving rebound control and puck tracking have helped

stabilize his overall game against faster competition. The next step is securing a permanent NHL spot; he projects as a depth goalie with potential upside.

Upside: 1A NHL Split Starter

3YP: 18-17-5, 2.73, 0.902

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 50%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Alexei Medvedev, G

Medvedev projects as a high-ceiling, volatility-driven goaltending prospect whose fantasy value will be defined by his development arc rather than immediate production. The athletic netminder combines strong reflexes, natural flexibility, and an aggressive crease style that allows him to challenge shooters and erase high-danger looks when his timing is on. His game is built around reaction speed and competitiveness. He tracks pucks well through traffic and shows confidence handling lateral movement, but his projection still hinges on refining his rebound control and maintaining calm structure under sustained pressure. Fantasy-wise, he is not an early safe-play target but rather a long-term upside stash. If his technical game catches up to his athletic tools, Medvedev could develop into a tandem or 1B option capable of delivering strong save-per-start value. The profile is classic high-variance goalie upside: low certainty but meaningful payoff if development trends break in the right direction.

Upside: NHL backup

3YP: 14-12-1, 2.83, 0.905

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 50%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.

Vegas GOLDEN KNIGHTS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Trevor Connelly
 Boom / Bust potential: Lukas Cormier
 Long-term project: Lukas Van Vliet
 Top sniper: Trevor Connelly
 Best setup man: Trevor Connelly

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Trevor Connelly
 Defense: Lukas Cormier
 Goal: Carl Lindbom
 Points only: Trevor Connelly
 Multicategory: Kai Uchacz

2026 Draftees: Sean Burick (D), Will McLaughlin (D), Matthew Minchak (G), Noel Pakarinen (F), Juho Piiparinen (D), Jonah Sivertson (F), Ben Wilmott (F)

by Alex Wyatt



Trevor Connelly, LW

(2026: 33) (2025: 32)

Connelly made the jump to pro hockey last season after just one year in the NCAA. In 46 AHL games, his 14 goals and 35 assists for 49 points rank him with the second-highest point-per-game pace (1.06) by a 19-year-old, with a minimum of 10 games played, since Mikko Rantanen reached 1.15 a decade ago. It's also worth noting that 25 of his assists were primary. There was never any question about Connelly's skill during his draft year. He's a dynamic speedster with high-end puckhandling who creates offense through both playmaking and finishing ability. Off-ice conduct prior to the draft, combined with an injury-shortened NCAA season and another injury at the World Juniors, may have lowered his perceived value more than warranted. Connelly should be an acquisition target in your drafts if you can flip a pre-hype pick for a post-hype prospect who is already knocking on the NHL door in Vegas.

Upside Comparable: Mathew Barzal (30-50-80, 46 PIM)

3YP: 20-30-50, 34 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 80%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027-28.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Jakob Ihs-Wozniak, RW

(2026: 56) (2025: N/A)

A big-bodied winger standing 6-3 and 190 pounds, Ihs-Wozniak has begun working his way into the higher Swedish ranks, seeing limited minutes in 17 SHL games and scoring 23 points in 36 Allsvenskan games. He absolutely dominated Sweden's junior ranks, and his career 1.37 points-per-game rate is a top-25 mark all time for players with 30+ games. His offense has slowed slightly as he's stepped up to tougher competition, but this is where his development should begin to accelerate. Ihs-Wozniak possesses an incredible shot and is a capable playmaker who can vary his attack, but he will need to develop his off-puck skills and improve his ability to drive his own line to cement a spot on an NHL roster. Ihs-Wozniak will require patience, and the perennially cup-contending Golden Knights have no need to rush him. Hold if you have him, and monitor whether his SHL progression mirrors his junior production.

Upside Comparable: Viktor Arvidsson (30-40-70+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 15-20-35, 22 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.



Mateo Nobert, C

(2026: 168) (2025: N/A)

Nobert has steadily increased his stock over the last three seasons in the QMJHL. He finished last year with 30 goals and 48 assists in 62 games, ranking 14th in the league in assists, two-thirds of which were primary. Not just a playmaker, even though he skated with the league's leading shot-taker and goal scorer in Justin Carbonneau, Nobert's 204 shots and 30 goals placed him inside the top 35 league-wide in both categories. The QMJHL is known for its high-octane offense, but seeing that Nobert finished not only with strong totals but also with solid rankings among his peers is encouraging. The fact that he wasn't merely a passenger riding shotgun with an elite scorer—and consistently put pucks both on net and in the net himself—also bodes well. There is still plenty of growth and development ahead for Nobert, and managers should track his progression to the AHL for a clearer measure of his NHL chances. For now, he looks like a solid stash-and-hold prospect.

Upside Comparable: Morgan Frost (25-40-65+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 12-23-35, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 65%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Mathieu Cataford, RW/C

(2026: 189) (2025: 135)

Cataford hit AHL ice for his rookie season last year, scoring three goals and adding 10 assists in 59 games. The offensive output isn't exciting, though that has never been the hallmark of Cataford's two-way game. Cataford averaged just over one shot and fewer than one Hit per game, and he won under 50% of his 200 faceoffs. He will need to seize deployment opportunities and carve out a niche that can move the needle for us in fantasy. At present, his performance doesn't give us much indication of what his long-term value will be. The offense can certainly still develop (he had 154 points in his last 119 QMJHL games), but without it, he'll need to refine a standout skill he can rely on to secure NHL opportunities—and fantasy relevance. Cataford will most likely settle into a bottom-six role at the NHL level, where his motor and two-way game may prove more valuable to the Golden Knights than to fantasy managers.

Upside Comparable: Anthony Beauvillier (20-40-60, 50 PIM)

3YP: 10-20-30, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Tuomas Uronen, LW/RW

(2026: 190) (2025: 137)

After a strong OHL season in which he finished 10th in goals and led Finland's U20 team in scoring, Uronen graduated to the AHL. As a rookie for the Henderson Silver Knights, he recorded 12 goals and added eight primary assists for 20 points in 57 games. A competent scorer with solid hockey IQ and reliable passing skills, Uronen has a varied offensive toolkit to draw from. No single skill stands out as a top-six-caliber asset, but his well-rounded game and physical edge (1.6 Hits per game)

could help him develop into a bottom-six winger. The Golden Knights are perennial contenders, but they currently roster four UFA wingers and 35-year-old Nic Dowd for one more season. Eventually, Vegas will need to promote from within, which could open space for Uronen—though he remains a season or two away from meaningful NHL time.

Upside Comparable: Tyler Bertuzzi (25-35-60+, 56 PIM)

3YP: 15-20-35, 44 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Kai Uchacz, C

(2026: 212) (2025: 344)

Uchacz entered the Golden Knights' organization as an undrafted free agent and has quickly become an intriguing prospect. A 6-2, 209-pound center, Uchacz doesn't possess game-breaking offensive skill, but he boasts a well-rounded toolkit that could earn him NHL minutes in short order. His 1,019 faceoffs ranked 35th in the AHL, and he won nearly 52% of them. He also won close to 60% of his puck battles, delivered a Hit per game, and recorded 52 PIM in 68 outings. On top of peripherals that suggest a decent floor for a bottom-sixer, Uchacz scored 20-31-51. A 16% shooting percentage and a primary-assist rate above 50% show that he earned that production. He won't make fantasy rosters, but his skill set may help him stick in the NHL. Eventually.

Upside Comparable: Philip Danault (20-40-60+, 85 PIM)

3YP: 10-15-25, 75 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 5%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Late-round pick (if you need immediate help but don't mind a lower ceiling, or if your league tracks PIM or Hits).



Matyas Sapovaliv, C

(2026: 259) (2025: 123)

Sapovaliv's second AHL season brought notable offensive growth, as his 18 goals and 17 assists in 72 games nearly doubled his totals from the previous year. To carve out an NHL role, he will need to continue improving his goal scoring, likely by increasing his shot volume—he recorded just 103 shots on net in 2025–26. Sapovaliv is a 6-4 center who won 46% of his faceoffs and could benefit from adding more physicality to his game, as he registered only seven Hits. There is still time for him to develop into a secondary offensive option. He only turned 22 in the spring, but for now there are areas he needs to refine with AHL Henderson. As incumbents on the Silver Knights graduate or move on, his role should expand, giving him more opportunity and deployment. The year-over-year improvement is encouraging, but it will need to continue for him to become a fantasy asset.

Upside Comparable: Ivan Barbashev (25-35-60, 40 PIM)

3YP: 15-20-35, 34 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Lucas Van Vliet, RW

(2026: 366) (2025: NR)

Van Vliet made the leap to the NCAA in 2025–26, scoring 14 goals and adding 21 assists for 35 points in 37 games. He fired nearly three shots on net per game, and he was roughly even in both primary-to-secondary assist ratio and puck battles won versus lost. His 6-2 frame has room to add size and strength, and given that he began the season at 19 years old, there is time for that development to occur. The Golden Knights would be happy to get a useful player out of a seventh-round pick, and based on Van Vliet's NCAA rookie performance, the shot-happy winger certainly looks like he has the potential to outperform his draft position. He will return to NCAA hockey in the fall to build on his body of work. Van Vliet is a reasonable stash in a deep dynasty league, but he still requires plenty of seasoning before warranting significant investment.

Upside Comparable: Chris Kreider (35-20-55+, 34 PIM)

3YP: 15-15-30, 26 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 55%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Lukas Cormier, LD

(2026: 15D) (2025: 17D)

After an injury limited Cormier to 19 AHL games two seasons ago, he delivered his best work yet last year. His 39 assists, 47 points, and 0.96 points per game all marked career highs, and his scoring pace ranks as the 13th-best by an AHL defenseman since 2009. A puck-moving defenseman capable of quarterbacking a power play, Cormier's near point-per-game production in the minors is highly encouraging. The Golden Knights have Shea Theodore and Noah Hanifin locked up long-term, with Rasmus Andersson a pending UFA, leaving Cormier without an obvious power-play role. Vegas also leans heavily on forwards with the man advantage, further clouding his path. There is room for him on the blue line eventually, but barring injuries, power-play deployment will be difficult to secure. If Vegas can't carve out a role for him, Cormier may be limited to even-strength usage—or he could find an opportunity elsewhere.

Upside Comparable: Shea Theodore (15-40-55, 50 PIM)

3YP: 5-30-35, 34 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Carl Lindbom, G

Lindbom's body of work at every level stands out—most recently in the AHL, where he completed his sophomore season with a 24-5-8 record and a 2.16 GAA, 0.926 SV%, and three shutouts. He earned a call-up to the NHL and made eight appearances, performing less effectively with a 2-4-2 record, 3.00 GAA, and 0.873 SV%. The 23-year-old former seventh-round pick has posted impressive numbers in every league he has played in, recording GAAs below 2.50 and save percentages above 0.906 across the U18, U20, Allsvenskan, SHL, and even the AHL. The NHL is a different challenge, but Lindbom has shown the ability to succeed at every step so far. Goalie prospects are always a dice roll, but Lindbom appears worth betting on and should be owned in every league.

Upside: Star NHL starter
3YP: 28-17-5, 2.70, 0.905 SV%
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 60%
Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.
DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Pavel Moysevich, G

Prior to last season, Moysevich had two contrasting years in the KHL. First came a scintillating 1.25 GAA and 0.942 SV% in 13 games as a 19-year-old, followed by a 3.32 GAA and 0.898 SV% over 37 games the next year. Moysevich spent last season in the VHL—Russia's AHL equivalent—and didn't dress in the KHL at all. His 2.41 GAA and 0.917 SV% in the VHL were an improvement, but came against weaker competition. At 6-7 and 190 pounds, Moysevich has the stature of an NHL goaltender, and he moves his hulking frame efficiently around the crease. The Golden Knights signed him to his ELC in March, indicating he may be on his way to North America. Until he gets games under his belt and begins building a larger body of work, the jury is still out on which version of Moysevich will show up in the AHL—but he's a solid, lightly-owned stash in deeper leagues.

Upside: NHL starter
3YP: 20-10-2, 2.65, 0.912 SV%
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 35%
Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029-30.
DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Cameron Whitehead, G

An interesting statistical tidbit from Whitehead's ECHL season is that his 3.01 GAA ranked 52nd among goalies with 10+ appearances, while his 0.921 SV% ranked ninth. The discrepancy stems from the sheer volume of shots he faced on a nightly basis—over 24 appearances, he saw an average of more than 38.5 shots per game. In the AHL, his 3.54 GAA and 0.873 SV% ranked ninth-worst and sixth-worst, respectively. A goalie who gets shelled every night yet still posts saves and a respectable save percentage can hold value in certain formats, even if his GAA is inflated. However, Lindbom was head-and-shoulders above him last year and sits ahead of him on the depth chart. Don't rush out and roster Whitehead, but if goalies are scarce in your league, keep an eye on his development—particularly whether he can rebound from last season's AHL numbers.

Upside: NHL backup
3YP: 12-12-1, 2.82 GAA, 0.908 SV%
Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 10%
Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.
DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft this year or next.

Washington CAPITALS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Ilya Protas
Boom / Bust potential: Petr Sikora
Long-term project: Eriks Mateiko
Top sniper: Ivan Miroshnichenko
Best setup man: Andrew Cristall

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Andrew Cristall
Defense: Cole Hutson
Goal: Garin Bjorklund
Points only: Andrew Cristall
Multicategory: Lynden Lakovic

2026 Draftees: Brian McFadden (D), Tyus Sparks (F), Logan Stuart (F), Oliver Suvanto (F)

by Pat Quinn



Ilya Protas, LW

(2026: 10) (2025: 114)



Protas has blown all expectations out of the water. After being drafted 75th overall in 2024, he dominated the OHL with 124 points in 61 games. His next stop was the AHL, where it would be determined whether his CHL numbers were a fluke or the real deal—and then he posted 66 points in 69 games, leading the Hershey Bears in scoring, leading all AHL rookies, finishing tied for sixth in league scoring, and winning AHL's Rookie of the Year Award (Red Garrett Memorial). Protas then played four NHL games, registering four points and his first NHL goal, before being sent back to Hershey for the Bears' playoff run. He added six points in six games as the Bears were eliminated in the second round. It was an absolutely stellar performance, one that has rocketed Protas up all drafted-prospect lists to a must-own asset.

Upside Comparable: Tage Thompson (40-45-85+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 31-43-74, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 95%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP.



Andrew Cristall, LW

(2026: 16) (2025: 17)



The reason Cristall had not been ranked higher on many lists was the uncertainty around how his game would translate to the pros. All he did in his first AHL campaign, however, was finish second on the Bears in scoring, third among rookies, and tied for 16th overall in league scoring. Cristall's 60 points in 72 games were not enough to earn a call-up from the Capitals, but leading the team in playoff scoring (seven points in six games) should help his chances of making the roster this season. Cristall has a high fantasy ceiling, but there are still a few areas he needs to improve—namely his defensive play and his shot. He has a legitimate chance to make the Caps out of camp, but the sense is that it may take an extra season, largely due to Washington's current roster construction.

Upside Comparable: Robert Thomas (25-60-85, 40 PIM)

3YP: 24-52-76, 24 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 85%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP



Ivan Miroshnichenko, LW

(2026: 38) (2025: 29)

Miroshnichenko likely should have been on the team's NHL roster to start 2025-26, but his waiver exemption made it easy for the Capitals to send him down. Two games into the AHL campaign, however, he was injured and missed a month. He was recalled three times, with his March recall keeping him on the roster for the remainder of the season. Miroshnichenko played 13 NHL games but averaged just 9:38 of ice time. In the AHL, he recorded 34 points in 41 games and tied Andrew Cristall for second in points per game (minimum two games played). He is still eligible to be assigned to the AHL, but this is his final season of eligibility, and his new two-year one-way contract shows the Capitals do have faith in him. Not all of his contributions show up on the scoresheet, but it would be encouraging for fantasy managers to see him truly dominate the AHL if he spends any meaningful time there again.

Upside Comparable: Vladimir Tarasenko (40-30-70+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 30-28-58, 46 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Should be drafted in the first couple of rounds.



Lynden Lakovic, RW

(2026: 58) (2025: N/A)

The good news for Lakovic in 2025-26 was that he was named captain of the WHL Moose Jaw Warriors; the bad news was that he suffered yet another injury. He sustained an officially undisclosed upper-body injury—most likely a shoulder issue—that required season-ending surgery just 22 games into the campaign. In 2024-25, Lakovic had suffered a broken collarbone, limiting him to only 47 games. He was having a true breakout with 29 points in those 22 games, including 18 goals. That was his final WHL season, and he will now make the jump to the pro ranks, though he will likely spend time in the AHL as he needs consistent game action. The Capitals hope Lakovic can become their next 30-plus-goal power forward, but he has more of a playmaking skill set, which may lower his potential multi-category value.

Upside Comparable: Drake Batherson (30-40-70+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 26-22-48, 18 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 85%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Terik Parascak, RW

(2026: 98) (2025: 62)

Parascak completed his final WHL campaign and will be looking to make the NHL roster in 2026-27. As skilled as he is, it is a bit concerning that his points-per-game rate has declined each season since he was drafted in 2024. He was drafted at 1.54 points per game, then dropped to 1.39 (after high-scoring junior Zac Funk left), and finally to 1.29 (after Minnesota's Riley Heidt graduated). It may be more of a nitpick than a true red flag, however. His defensive play improved throughout his time with the Cougars, and his playoff scoring rate increased each year. He was unable to get any ice time in the Bears' playoff run after the Cougars were eliminated. Parascak will see time in the AHL before making the NHL, as there are contracts and more developed players ahead of him.

Upside Comparable: Artturi Lehkonen (35-35-70+, 60 PIM)

3YP: 22-29-51, 36 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Petr Sikora, C

(2026: 223) (2025: 381)

For a sixth-round draft pick in 2024, Sikora has really put himself on the radar. Much of that is due to his impressive international play and strong performance in the Czech U20 league. He stood out at the World Junior Championship as one of the top Czech players as the team captured bronze. In U20 international play, he recorded 18 points in 15 games, but that also highlights where he currently stands as a prospect: Sikora excels against his own age group, but making the jump to playing against men has been a tougher challenge. He had nine points in 24 Czechia league games and no points in five men's international games. Sikora signed his three-year ELC in early May and will come to North America for the 2026–27 season. He has a knack for getting under opponents' skin, so expect him to cause havoc whenever he can.

Upside Comparable: Vincent Trocheck (25-35-60+, 90 PIM)

3YP: 16-22-38, 52 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Erik Mateiko, LW

(2026: 239) (2025: 332)

Mateiko had a difficult transition from the QMJHL to the AHL in 2025–26, and his season ended abruptly. In a high-scoring league like the QMJHL, you would expect Mateiko to produce more than he did—he never reached a point-per-game pace in any season—but his size continues to make NHL general managers salivate. There is skill there as well, especially when he gets into scoring areas. Mateiko is a player who will need time to develop due to his 6-6 frame. Unfortunately for him, after 27 games with the Bears he suffered a skate cut to his Achilles that ended his season and cost him the chance to play in the Olympics (for Latvia). In those 27 games, he recorded just six points—one goal on 27 shots. The injury will not help his skating speed, so Mateiko will need to put in significant work to become fantasy-relevant.

Upside Comparable: Johan Franzen (35-25-60, 60 PIM)

3YP: 16-12-28, 35 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 75%

Expected Arrival: A long wait—2029–30 at best.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon—wait until next year to consider drafting.



Milton Gastrin, C

(2026: 245) (2025: N/A)

Traded to STL

Gastrin was quick to sign his ELC with the Capitals after being drafted 37th overall in 2025, which came as a bit of a surprise. The plan was likely for him to play one more season in Sweden before coming to North America, as his ELC slid for the first year. Gastrin played in the HockeyAllsvenskan with MoDo, registering 24 points in 39 games and adding four points in 13 playoff games. Internationally, he recorded four points in 18 U20 games, though he went pointless at the World Juniors while being trusted in a shutdown role against top lines. He is a solid two-way center who projects as a defensive bottom-sixer capable of contributing in big moments. Gastrin also appeared in one playoff game for the Bears, showing that the organization already has confidence in him.

Upside Comparable: William Karlsson (20-35-55+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 13-18-31, 24 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Cole Hutson, LD

(2026: 1D) (2025: 16D)



Hutson came as advertised when he joined the Capitals at the conclusion of his NCAA campaign with Boston University, registering 10 points in 14 games. He scored a goal in his first game—albeit an empty-netter—and averaged 17:27 of ice time. It certainly helped that additional minutes were available after Washington sold assets at the deadline. The only blemish on Hutson's 2025-26 season, aside from BU not advancing in the NCAA tournament, was an injury at the World Juniors that limited him to just three games, though he still produced four points. The Capitals hope Cole can be as dynamic for them as Lane is for Montreal. Hutson may not open on the first power play with Jakob Chychrun carrying the bigger contract in Washington, but he should still see time there and could run the unit if Chychrun falters for any extended stretch.

Upside Comparable: Lane Hutson (15-55-70+, 80 PIM)

3YP: 11-52-63, 48 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 35%, 99%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Blue chip prospect—draft ASAP.



Leon Muggli, LD

(2026: 53D) (2025: 201D)

Muggli's first full campaign in North America with the Hershey Bears was derailed by multiple long-term upper-body injuries. The first kept him out until December, though he was still able to represent Switzerland at the World Junior Championship. He captained the team and recorded five points in five games, looking much improved compared to the previous year. He returned to the Bears in January but was injured again in late February, resulting in a month-long absence. In the 27 games he did play, he registered seven points, but it was difficult for him to find any rhythm. In international play, he showed the type of impactful defenseman he can become, but he will need a fully healthy season to truly get going in the AHL.

Upside Comparable: MacKenzie Weegar (10-40-50, 60 PIM)

3YP: 8-32-40, 44 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option



Cam Allen, RD

(2026: 62D) (2025: 130D)

A lot of Hershey Bears were felled by injuries in 2025-26, and Allen was no exception. He missed a small chunk of time to start the season, and then in January he sustained a shoulder injury that sidelined him for the remainder of the campaign. It took Allen some time to get going, as he didn't register his first point until 12 games in, but he then compiled six points in his final 10 outings. He has always been strong with the puck on his stick, able to create offense and move the puck effectively. His skating is also a major asset, as he has no trouble catching up to plays or skating the puck out of the zone. Allen's biggest challenges come in his own end, where he can make some costly turnovers that drive coaches nuts, though this is an area in which he has shown improvement.

Upside Comparable: Bowen Byram (10-45-55, 60 PIM)

3YP: 7-30-37, 45 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Garin Bjorklund, G

Unrestricted Free Agent

Bjorklund was expected to take the backup/1B role behind Clay Stevenson, who was slated to handle the starter's duties for the Hershey Bears. Unfortunately, Bjorklund lost that role to Mitch Gibson in December and spent more time in the ECHL, with only a few call-ups to the Bears for the remainder of 2025-26. Fortunately for him, he is the youngest of the Capitals' signed goaltending prospects, which may earn him a longer developmental leash than the older goalies in the system. Bjorklund has clearly figured out the ECHL—on a much healthier team than Hershey—as he posted a 0.935 save percentage in eight games and added a 0.909 mark in nine playoff games. He is currently an RFA, but the Capitals will almost certainly re-sign him, as his timeline aligns well with the end of Charlie Lindgren's contract. However, he will need to become more consistent at the AHL level to reach that point.

Upside: Star NHL starter

3YP: 32-14-8, 2.56, 0.909

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option



Jesper Vikman, G

Unrestricted Free Agent

Vikman was part of the trade that sent Nic Dowd from Washington to Vegas. Since being signed by the Golden Knights in 2023, he has bounced between the ECHL and AHL, posting save percentages between 0.883 and 0.897 from 2023-24 to 2024-25. He did record a 0.914 save percentage in eight 2025 playoff games with the Tahoe Knight Monsters. With the Silver Knights, however, Vikman was relegated to more of a backup role last season and produced his worst numbers yet, finishing with an 0.866 save percentage in 18 games. He barely played after arriving in Washington, appearing in just one ECHL game. It is unclear whether Vikman was simply a contract throw-in, especially given the number of signed goalies already in Washington's system. Vikman has good size (6-4) and athleticism, so there is still a chance he can eventually play in the NHL—but at 24, he needs to take a step forward soon.

Upside: NHL backup

3YP: 20-15-3, 2.81, 0.899

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 30%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Do not draft.

Winnipeg JETS

At a Glance

Top prospect: Isak Rosen
 Boom / Bust potential: Colby Barlow
 Long-term project: Kevin He
 Top sniper: Isak Rosen
 Best setup man: Brayden Yager

Most Fantasy Upside

Forward: Isak Rosen
 Defense: Elias Salomonsson
 Goal: Thomas Milic
 Points only: Isak Rosen
 Multicategory: Colby Barlow

2026 Draftees: Viggo Björck (F), Landon Hafele (F), Samuel Hrenak (G), John Parsons (G), Noa Ta'amu (D), Alexandre Taillefer (D), Zach Wooten (F)

by Pat Quinn



Isak Rosen, LW

(2026: 42) (2025: 46)

Rosen was the big acquisition for the Jets at the 2025–26 trade deadline, as the team moved Logan Stanley and Luke Schenn for him, a second-round pick, and defenseman Jacob Bryson. It was a numbers game for Rosen in Buffalo, where he found himself on the outside looking in, and he now joins a team that desperately needs scoring help. His early results in Winnipeg didn't show much offense—he scored just three goals in 21 games—but he averaged only 10:49 of ice time, roughly two minutes less than he received in Buffalo earlier in the season. With proper NHL minutes in 2026–27, he should have a better opportunity to produce. Rosen has clearly figured out the AHL, with his points-per-game progression since 2022–23 rising from 0.56 to 0.75 to 0.90 and finally to 1.16. Expect him to adjust to the NHL game soon as well.

Upside Comparable: Alex DeBrincat (30-40-70, 30 PIM)

3YP: 28-34-62, 16 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 80%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Brayden Yager, C

(2026: 44) (2025: 14)

Yager had a decent introductory AHL season with 30 points in 68 games. That total ranked seventh on the Manitoba Moose and tied for 29th among all rookie scorers—so overall, a solid first year. Yager appeared in three games with the Jets to close out 2025–26, recording no points while averaging just 10:59 of ice time. He will look to build on that experience and produce more for the Moose heading into 2026–27, as he is still quite slight at 6-0 and 170 pounds. Yager will need to add muscle and learn how to remain dynamic with that added strength in order to play regularly in the NHL. Given that the Jets rarely sign big-ticket offensive help, they will likely do what is necessary to support his development.

Upside Comparable: Matt Duchene (30-35-65+, 30 PIM)

3YP: 24-32-56, 20 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 85%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Kieron Walton, C

(2026: 91) (2025: 161)

Considering Walton was a sixth-round pick (187th overall) in 2024, it is remarkable how quickly he has risen up prospect rankings. In 2024–25, he recorded 92 points in 66 games for Sudbury, finishing top-10 in OHL scoring and top-five in shots. He followed that up with a similar points-per-game rate the next season, ranking top-five in goals, top-10 in points, and leading the OHL in shots. Walton's PPG did dip after his mid-season trade, as he was not relied upon as heavily, but he still managed six points in six playoff games. Unfortunately, once his OHL playoffs ended, so did his season, as he was unable to suit up for the Manitoba Moose due to injury. Walton will get a clean slate to show what he can do in the AHL in 2026–27, and his size—6-6 and 212 pounds—has Jets management extremely excited about his potential.

Upside Comparable: Tage Thompson (35-40-75, 40 PIM)

3YP: 24-32-56, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Potential star; draft in late rounds (if you can afford to wait a few years).



Nikita Chibrikov, RW

(2026: 105) (2025: 59)

Chibrikov put himself on the map for the Jets in his first AHL season with 47 points in 70 games, and he scored a goal in his first—and only—NHL game. In 2024–25, he again impressed in the NHL with three points in four games, but he managed just 18 points in 30 AHL games before a season-ending lower-body injury in January. That total still led the team at the time. Chibrikov struggled to produce in 2025–26, though he did make the Jets' roster out of camp; however, no points and frequent scratches led to his return to the Moose. He recorded 16 points in 53 AHL games before finishing the season there. Then, at the end of the Jets' season, it was revealed that he would miss the Moose playoffs after undergoing core-muscle surgery. A promising start to his career has been hampered by injuries and bad luck—hopefully he can rebound.

Upside Comparable: TJ Oshie (20-35-55+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 12-23-35, 38 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 10%, 80%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Brad Lambert, C/RW

(2026: 129) (2025: 48)

It was another season of declining production for Lambert, and this time he requested a trade mid-season, reportedly feeling he was not getting a fair NHL opportunity. A trade did not materialize, but he was given an NHL look at the beginning of March. In those 21 games, he posted five points while averaging 10:48 of ice time. After his breakout 2023–24 season with the Moose, when he produced 0.86 points per game, he followed it up with marks of 0.57 and, most recently, 0.38. Additionally, he recorded no points in seven games for the Moose during the 2026 playoffs. Whether this weak production is a sign of frustration with the organization or simply a failure to adapt, it is a concerning trend. Lambert will need to rebound in 2026–27.

Upside Comparable: Jonathan Drouin (25-35-60+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 18-23-41, 28 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option



Colby Barlow, LW

(2026: 132) (2025: 86)

Since being drafted in 2023, the first-round pick has not reached the heights of his draft-day hype. He somewhat plateaued points-wise in the OHL, though that was partly due to his efforts to diversify his game, and he finished his junior career with a major breakout—33 points in 21 playoff games. His first AHL season with the AHL Moose was a difficult one, as he recorded just 16 points in 65 games and, most concerning, only 88 shots. For a noted goal-scorer, not shooting the puck is failing to play to one of his biggest strengths. Barlow often looked overwhelmed and slightly nervous adjusting to the pro game, but that should change in 2026–27. The experience—especially the seven playoff games he appeared in—will help his development, though the early numbers are concerning. His draft status ensures the Jets will do everything they can to help him develop into an NHL player.

Upside Comparable: Andrei Svechnikov (30-30-60+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 28-24-52, 38 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Will get cups of coffee/a look this year; full-time in 2027–28.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Kevin He, LW

(2026: 183) (2025: 240)

He entered the 2025–26 season as the captain of the Niagara IceDogs but was traded midseason to the Flint Firebirds in the OHL. He set new career highs in both points and goals in his final OHL campaign. He also recorded nine points in six playoff games, but he was injured before Flint's elimination game and, like Kieron Walton, did not appear in any AHL games. He has a motor that never stops and loves to celebrate goals in Ovechkin-style fashion. This gives him a relatively safe floor as an NHL projection, but if he can maintain his scoring at the professional level, he could become a top-six threat thanks to his impressive forechecking ability. The Jets could have quite a steal on their hands if he continues along this strong development path.

Upside Comparable: Brandon Hagel (28-37-65+, 50 PIM)

3YP: 20-20-40, 32 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 20%, 70%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028–29.

DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.



Viktor Klingsell, LW

(2026: 314) (2025: N/A)

Klingsell signed a two-year contract extension with Skelleftea AIK of the SHL in late April, a team he has been with since 2022–23. Last season, he played across three different levels in Sweden, dominating the U20 league with 43 points in 25 games. He added seven points in eight games with Ostersunds IK in the HockeyAllsvenskan and scored one goal in 12 SHL games with AIK. Klingsell has been loaned to Kalmar HC in the HockeyAllsvenskan for the 2026–27 season, and according to AIK's general manager, the plan is for him to remain there for the entire year. Klingsell is a smart

and highly skilled player who routinely competes above his age group. He will need to add some mass to adjust to the North American game, as he is listed at 5-10 and 187 pounds.

Upside Comparable: Jesper Bratt (25-40-65+, 20 PIM)

3YP: 22-26-48, 16 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Long-term prospect. Don't draft, this year or next.



Sascha Boumedienne, LD

(2026: 20D) (2025: N/A)

The hype around Boumedienne's offensive potential still did not materialize in 2025-26—at least not in the NCAA. At Boston University, surrounded by high-end NHL prospects including Cole Hutson, he posted just 10 points in 35 games. Internationally, however, Boumedienne has produced. At the World Junior Championship, he recorded four points in seven games; in another U20 event, he added six points in 13 games; and he also contributed three points in six men's-league games for Sweden. Boumedienne has transferred and will play for Ohio State University in 2026-27, where the hope is that he can be leaned on to generate more offense. Even when the numbers aren't there, Boumedienne is an excellent skater who can transition the puck efficiently. There is a high floor here, but the ceiling remains a question mark.

Upside Comparable: Cam Fowler (10-40-50, 40 PIM)

3YP: 6-30-36, 22 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 90%

Expected Arrival: 2027-28, but may play the final few games this season after his college year.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Elias Salomonsson, RD

(2026: 22D) (2025: 26D)

Salomonsson was up and down all season before being called up for the final time at the end of February. He spent 32 games in the NHL and 29 games in the AHL. Surprisingly, Salomonsson averaged 17:58 of ice time, as Coach Scott Arniel showed considerable trust in him—he topped 20 minutes in 10 different games. In his 32 NHL games, he recorded five points, including his first NHL goal. In the AHL, Salomonsson added nine points in 29 games. Like several other Jets prospects, he was injured near the end of the campaign, but he did manage to appear in the final two Moose playoff games. Salomonsson should be on the Jets' opening-night roster, though it may take some time before he provides meaningful fantasy production.

Upside Comparable: Thomas Harley (15-35-50, 70 PIM)

3YP: 8-28-36, 42 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 90%

Expected Arrival: This fall.

DH Draft Advice: Middle-round option.



Alfons Freij, LD

(2026: 37D) (2025: 94D)

Freij spent all of 2025-26 in the SHL at just 19 years old. He played for Timrå IK, which was not a strong team, but being trusted in Sweden's top league at that age is extremely impressive. In his 42 games, he recorded 11 points—a strong total for a teenage defenseman. At the World Junior Championship, he posted seven assists in seven games for Sweden, and in other U20 international

play he added 10 points in 14 games. Once Timra IK's season ended, Freij came to North America and appeared in five AHL games, recording an assist. He did not play in any playoff games, as the team prioritized players who had been there all season. Freij will likely spend a couple of seasons in the AHL developing his game, and hopefully his offensive potential will emerge, as he has excellent puck-moving ability.

Upside Comparable: Filip Hronek (10-40-50+, 40 PIM)

3YP: 7-31-38, 22 PIM

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 25%, 75%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

DH Draft Advice: Final-round option.



Thomas Milic, G

Milic and Domenic DiVincentiis battled for starts in the AHL, with Milic coming out slightly ahead by appearing in 41 games compared to DiVincentiis' 34. Both players are essentially competing to become Connor Hellebuyck's backup before potentially earning opportunities to start elsewhere in the NHL. However, if things were to go sour between the Jets and Hellebuyck's camp, either of these two could eventually become the starter. Milic improved across all of his AHL numbers, most notably in save percentage, which rose from 0.877 to 0.905. He was also the only one of the two to appear in an NHL game, taking a loss while posting an 0.882 save percentage, with two additional appearances coming in relief. The competition between them will continue, but for now, Milic appears to have the edge. As a smaller goalie (6-0, 175), he relies on his speed, athleticism, and strong ability to read the play.

Upside: NHL starter

3YP: 30-19-10, 2.64, 0.903

Fantasy Upside / NHL Certainty: 15%, 65%

Expected Arrival: Probably 2028-29.

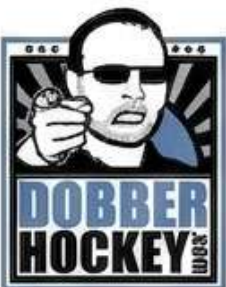
DH Draft Advice: Too soon. Wait until next year to consider drafting.

Blue-chip Prospects – 2026

This year's edition of prospects to which we applied the label "Blue chip", all gathered together in one spot for you...

James Hagens	BOS
Konsta Helenius	BUF
Cole Reschny	CGY
Zayne Parekh	CGY
Anton Frondell	CHI
Roman Kantserov	CHI
Jackson Smith	CBJ
Sebastian Cossa	DET
Michael Hage	MTL
Alexander Zharovsky	MTL
Kashawn Aitcheson	NYI
Carter Yakemchuk	OTT
Porter Martone	PHI
Jake O'Brien	SEA
Igor Chernyshov	SJS
Tij Iginla	UTA
Caleb Desnoyers	UTA
Ilya Protas	WSH
Andrew Cristall	WSH
Cole Hutson	WSH





DobberHockey's 2026

NHL DRAFT SECTION

**Gavin
McKenna**



Who's Who in 2026

These players are so young that upsides are higher than that of an older player, since their career trajectory can go in so many different directions. So, what we try to do instead is pin down a proper 3YP (three-year projection). For example, if said player becomes a full-time NHLer and we calculate his three best seasons, what will that average end up being? That's the 3YP. Think of it as a "likelihood" if he becomes an NHLer. There is upside for more. In our 2010 Fantasy Prospects Report, we had Nikita Kucherov's likelihood at 70+ points – and here we are!

Please note:

- Player comparisons are 'ballparked' in terms of statistical upside, not so much of playing style.*
 - The 'Rank' is our overall NHL Draft rank—not our fantasy-hockey ranking.*
 - Players appear in alphabetical order.*
-

by Jordan Harris and Anni Karvinen

Aaram-Olsen, Niklas — LW, Orebro HK, U20 Nationell 41st overall (**VAN**)

DH pre-Draft: 36

Aaram-Olsen is a Norwegian winger whose tools have turned heads in the scouting community. He's a plus-level skater with a quick, powerful stride and a high-velocity shot he isn't shy about using. He's at his most dangerous on the power play, where his release gives defenders almost no time to react. When the shot isn't producing, however, there isn't much else to lean on. His physical game can disappear, his defensive engagement wavers, and he hasn't shown much passing creativity to generate offense when the shot isn't falling. He needs to round out his game, but the tools make it worth hoping he does.

3YP: 30-30-60 | **PIM:** 28 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Owen Tippett

Alalauri, Samu — RD, Pelicans, SM-sarja 66th overall (**CHI**)

DH pre-Draft: 55

Alalauri has the kind of well-rounded toolkit that NHL organizations covet. The 6-2, 205-pound right-shot defenseman skates well, plays with a physical edge, and has flashed offensive potential through his regular activations from the blue line. He's shown he can contribute as both a shooter and a distributor. The main weakness to address is decision-making, particularly puck management: he can attempt overly ambitious plays that hand possession right back to the

opposition. Alalauri doesn't project as a pure puck-mover at the next level, but defenders with his combination of tools and two-way instincts are exactly what NHL teams look for.

3YP: 10-30-40 | **PIM:** 32 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Brady Skjei

Andersson, Adam – C, Leksands IF U20, U20 Nationell 83rd overall (MIN)

DH pre-Draft: 67

Andersson is a big, steady center standing 6-4 and 209 pounds. He makes life frustrating for his opponents, consistently winning board and net-front battles through sheer strength. He plays a mature game that translates seamlessly to pro rinks, supporting his defensemen down low and anticipating the next play early. He lacks high-end offensive skill, but players with his compete level and physical maturity tend to stick around for a long time. It's easy to envision him scoring greasy goals near the net, where he's almost impossible to move.

3YP: 25-30-55 | **PIM:** 54 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Patric Hornqvist

Bartholdsson, Nils – RW, Rogle BK U20, U20 Nationell 88th overall (BOS)

DH pre-Draft: 81

Bartholdsson is a high-octane winger with a high ceiling but a low floor. The 5-11, 179-pound Swede blends plus-level puckhandling and a strong release with good offensive instincts to generate chances. He has shown the ability to attack with fearless intensity, cutting inside from the boards to create his own shooting lanes. There is genuine concern about whether his game will translate to North American pro rinks due to his lack of size and imperfect skating mechanics. Still, the goal-scoring upside is enticing, and he's worthy of a pick in the later rounds.

3YP: 25-35-55 | **PIM:** 22 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Logan Stankoven

Belchetz, Ethan – RW, Windsor Spitfires, OHL 17th overall (UTA)

DH pre-Draft: 13

Belchetz entered the season with a ton of hype and excitement among scouts. There simply aren't many 17-year-olds who are 6-5 and over 225 pounds—especially ones who can score like Belchetz. Unfortunately, his season was filled with highs and lows and ultimately ended with an injury that caused him to miss the final few months. When he's on, Belchetz can score in a multitude of ways: he can pick corners with a heavy wrister, unload a bomb of a slapshot, and finish in tight thanks to his size and hands. At his best, he's also a very physical player who can dominate junior hockey. However, there are blemishes in his game. He's not particularly quick, even if his top gear is fairly fast. He's also just an average playmaker for a junior player, and his intensity and consistency disappear for stretches. There's a lot to like about Belchetz, but he'll need to improve his skating and consistency to reach his high-end potential. At the very least, he should be able to carve out a role as a depth scorer with plenty of size.

3YP: 35-35-70 | **PIM:** 82 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Alex Tuch

Berchild, Mikey – C/LW, USNTDP, USHL 105th overall (CAR)

DH pre-Draft: 73

Berchild has been on the draft radar for quite some time. Entering the U17 USNTDP, there were very high expectations for what he could accomplish over the next two seasons in Plymouth. Berchild has been an effective offensive contributor with the program, but he hasn't stood out as a high-end prospect. Part of that is due to an underwhelming 2008 class with the USNTDP, but part of it is because he has below-average size. Combine the lack of size with skating and skill that aren't as dynamic as some expected, and Berchild has bounced between center and wing quite a bit. While he is a smart player with good skill, there are plenty of draft-eligible players each year with similar profiles, and unfortunately many of them do not make the NHL.

3YP: 15-25-40 | **PIM:** 28 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Nick Robertson

Bernat, Lucian – RW, Tappara U20, U20 SM-sarja 176th overall (VAN)

DH pre-Draft: 97

Standing 6-4 and 201 pounds, Bernat is a physically imposing power-forward project. His frame and effective forechecking make him an immediate nuisance for opposing defenses. He reads outlet passes well, positions himself to disrupt plays, and drives the net with a powerful release that gives him genuine scoring upside. The concern is his hockey sense: he can become very tunnel-visioned, overhandling the puck in traffic or firing low-percentage shots. His physical tools and defensive reliability give him a safe floor, and if he can refine his decision-making, there's potential for a complementary power forward here.

3YP: 25-30-55 | **PIM:** 48 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Josh Anderson

Berzkalns, Rudolfs – C, Muskegon Lumberjacks, USHL 58th overall (EDM)

DH pre-Draft: 57

Berzkalns is a hulking two-way center with a strong physical game. He competes well, uses his big frame effectively along the boards without the puck, and shields off defenders as a puck carrier. He is effective around the net and can be a useful net-front presence on the power play. There isn't a ton of skill or playmaking in his game, mostly due to below-average hands and hockey sense. He won't be relied upon as an offensive threat at the NHL level, but he could carve out a role as a bottom-six center in a shutdown role.

3YP: 8-16-24 | **PIM:** 74 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Nick Bjugstad

Bilecki, Alexander — LD, Kitchener Rangers, OHL 60th overall (TOR)

DH pre-Draft: 69

Bilecki is a puck-moving defenseman who really broke out this season on a loaded Kitchener Rangers team that won the OHL Championship. Despite being the No. 4 defenseman behind three NHL-drafted players, Bilecki was able to showcase his offensive game on PP2 and serve as a reliable passer in transition. He's a bit thin and his skating is only pretty good, and he's not a dynamic player like his teammate Cameron Reid was last draft. Bilecki will need to get stronger and improve the defensive side of his game, which is currently his biggest weakness. Perhaps once players like Wooley and Andonovski move on next season, he can truly break out.

3YP: 8-25-33 | **PIM:** 32 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Nils Lundkvist

Bjorck, Viggo — C, Djurgardens IF, SHL 8th overall (WPG)

DH pre-Draft: 4

Bjorck makes everything look almost embarrassingly simple. He plays the game in a smooth, effortless manner, always two steps ahead, anticipating plays before they develop and exposing defensive mistakes rather than overpowering opponents with speed or flash. His stride is fluid and deceptively agile, with quick crossovers that let him carry the puck into space and create at his own pace. Size will give some NHL executives pause—he checks in at 5-10, 172 pounds—but Bjorck has a habit of making that debate irrelevant. Lining up as the 1C for an SHL playoff team as a draft-eligible teenager isn't something you can easily explain away.

3YP: 35-50-85 | **PIM:** 22 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Sebastian Aho

Bleyl, Tommy — RD, Moncton Wildcats, QMJHL 31st overall (NSH)

DH pre-Draft: 46

Bleil was one of the most surprising offensive performers among draft-eligible defensemen, leading all QMJHL blueliners in scoring en route to being named the league's Defensive Rookie of the Year. Bleil is a very mobile, puck-moving defender with sharp offensive instincts. He is one of the best playmaking defensemen in the draft and can rack up points both on the power play and at even strength. While he's a good skater, he's not an explosive one in the way some top NHL defensemen are. His defensive game needs considerable work, as his defensive-zone instincts are below average and he lacks size and physicality. Still, if the offensive game translates, he could become a very good offensive defenseman who simply needs some sheltering defensively.

3YP: 12-40-52 | **PIM:** 36 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Luca Cagnoni

Boettiger, Harrison – G, Kelowna Rockets, WHL Undrafted

DH pre-Draft: 88

Last season's USNTDP goalie, Boettiger, is a different type of netminder than his successor at the program, Brady Knowling. Boettiger is much more of a tactician, and at 6-2 he is also smaller—considered undersized by modern NHL goalie standards. In addition to being undersized, his athleticism and movement skills are only average to slightly above average. Where Boettiger excels is in his positioning, his ability to read plays, his knack for picking pucks cleanly off shooters' sticks, and his ability to control rebounds. He is composed and battle-tested, having played in numerous international tournaments and the Memorial Cup. It's uncertain whether he has the physical attributes to become an NHL starter, but he could develop into an effective backup.

PLAYER COMPARABLE: Samuel Ersson

Borichev, Dmitri – G, Loko-76 Yaroslavl, MHL 70th overall (NSH)

DH pre-Draft: 48

Borichev played only 24 MHL games this past season, but he certainly made the most of them. Because the Yaroslavl organization cycled its goalies between Loko-76 Yaroslavl and Loko Yaroslavl, it was difficult for any of them to get consistent games behind the same group of skaters. Borichev posted an excellent 0.929 save percentage and 2.25 GAA. Physically, he has average size at 6-3, and his movement skills are also average. Where he shines is in his ability to track the puck—especially valuable in a chaotic league like the MHL. He'll have the opportunity to become an NHL goalie, but it remains to be seen whether he has true NHL-starter potential.

PLAYER COMPARABLE: Vitek Vanecek

Cali, Ryder — C, North Bay Battalion, OHL 48th overall (FLA)

DH pre-Draft: 37

Cali is a big, thick center who competes hard and can skate at an NHL level—a strong foundation to build on. He's also very young for the draft as an early-September 2008 birthday, which suggests he has more development runway ahead of him. While he's not a dynamic player and isn't among the most skilled forwards in the class, he plays with great detail and can complement more talented linemates with ease. Cali should still be able to produce a reasonable amount of offense in the NHL thanks to his intelligence and ability to get to scoring areas, but he's unlikely to become a top-six scorer or earn significant power-play time. If he hits, expect him to be a solid bottom-six forward who can handle tough matchups.

3YP: 15-25-40 | **PIM:** 58 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Andrew Copp

Carels, Carson — LD, Prince George, WHL 6th overall (CGY)

DH pre-Draft: 5

Carels is a prospect without many major flaws in his game. He has good size with a thick build, which he pairs with great skating and high-end physicality. This combination of physical tools allows him to thrive in both zones as a junior player logging well over 25 minutes per night. Carels is a talented defender who consistently shuts down plays in his own end and prevents opponents from entering the offensive zone with control. He has one of the best compete levels in the draft and delivers punishing Hits along the boards and in open ice. Offensively, he's impressive as well—even if he doesn't possess the same high-end upside as some other defenders in the class. He can run a power play at the junior level, get pucks on net, and distribute effectively. Carels picks his spots well and jumps into the play when opportunities arise. At his best, he could become a very impactful No. 2 or No. 3 NHL defenseman.

3YP: 12-40-52 | **PIM:** 78 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Cam Fowler

Chrenko, Tomas — C, HK Nitra, Slovak Extraliga 81st overall (NYR)

DH pre-Draft: 39

Few prospects in this class carry a wider range of outcomes than Chrenko. The boom side is genuinely exciting: he manipulates defenders with feints and body angles to create shooting and passing lanes, making him especially dangerous on the power play. He also has a solid two-way game to support his offense—he's a smart player who is trusted on the penalty kill as well. The bust side is just as real. At 5-11, 170 pounds, physical battles are an issue, and the smaller North American ice will only tighten the spaces he relies on to thrive. That said, betting on skill is always appealing, and Chrenko has plenty of it.

3YP: 22-45-67 | **PIM:** 20 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Jackson Blake

Chudzinski, Rian — RW, Moncton Wildcats, QMJHL 82nd overall (ANA)

DH pre-Draft: 71

Chudzinski is a pain to play against. He's skilled enough to hurt you on the scoreboard, big enough to hurt you physically, and pesky enough to throw you off your game. He gets to the hard areas of the ice and earns every goal he scores. His combination of effort and speed makes him very effective as the F1 on the forecheck. Chudzinski doesn't possess high-end offensive traits. He's a below-average playmaker and doesn't have great vision, but that's not where he'll earn his living in the NHL. If he hits, he projects as a very effective bottom-six player who can moonlight in the top six when a team needs more hard skill alongside its more talented players.

3YP: 12-27-39 | **PIM:** 78 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Ridly Greig

Command, Alexander — C, Orebro HK, U20 12th overall (NJD)

DH pre-Draft: 21

Command doesn't dazzle with one signature tool, but he keeps doing everything right. The strong center scans the ice constantly, reads plays well, and brings a surprisingly physical edge for a player his age, winning board battles and handling contact with ease. His passing vision and puck-carrying confidence stand out, and his game translates naturally to the North American style: he's effective in tight spaces, reliable in his own end, and genuinely hard to knock off pucks. The skill ceiling isn't sky-high, but Command is a polished, two-way center with first-round tools and the compete level to maximize them.

3YP: 20-40-60 | **PIM:** 33 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Jordan Staal

Cover, Jaxon — LW, London Knights, OHL 32nd overall (OTT)

DH pre-Draft: 40

If there's a player with a long development runway, it's Cover, who didn't start playing hockey until his early teens yet now finds himself a potential second-rounder in the NHL Draft. Cover has

raw talent, very skilled hands, and a desire to create offense and experiment with plays. He's an athletic player with good size as well. Given his lack of experience, he has mechanical flaws in his skating and lacks the awareness you'd expect from someone projected to go fairly early in the draft. Cover was one of the better players on a team that found itself in the playoffs after trading several big-name players at the deadline. Despite the rawness in his game, he's a very intriguing bet given how far he's come in such a short time. Once he learns the game better and processes plays more effectively, he could become an impactful middle-six winger at the NHL level.

3YP: 12-42-64 | **PIM:** 36 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Zachary Bolduc

Cullen, Wyatt — RW, USNTDP, USHL

10th overall (NSH)

DH pre-Draft: 12

Cullen comes from a long line of former professional hockey players, and it shows when you watch him play. He moves well, has an excellent motor, and takes optimal routes to the puck or puck carrier when in pursuit. He knows how to knife his way into better positioning to gain leverage and tilt 50/50 battles in his favor. He's a very skilled player who is both a shooting and passing threat. He's also incredibly young for this draft—just eight days away from being eligible for next year's class. Although he's not the biggest player, he looks and plays bigger than his weigh-in suggests. Cullen has the skill and tenacity to be effective on a wide variety of lines with many different types of teammates. He may not project as a top-end player, but he should be a very effective middle-six winger with potential for more.

3YP: 25-35-60 | **PIM:** 46 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Mats Zuccarello

Dagenais, Maddox — C, Quebec Remparts, QMJHL 16th overall (STL)

DH pre-Draft: 26

The former first-overall pick in the QMJHL Draft, Dagenais has progressed nicely in his junior career, even if he's not a high-end point producer. He's a big-bodied center who combines imposing size with physicality and skill to play a multi-dimensional game. He has a heavy shot that he can release from different angles and distances, making him a plus-level scoring threat. He plays a heavy style along the boards and works well off the cycle. While he spent much of the season on the wing, his size, athleticism, and skating ability should allow him to develop into a middle-six center at the NHL level.

3YP: 25-30-55 | **PIM:** 62 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Phillip Danault

Di Iorio, Alessandro — C, Sarnia Sting, OHL

94th overall (CBJ)

DH pre-Draft: 72

Di Iorio was the second pick in the 2024 OHL Draft behind Ethan Belchetz. While he's been an effective OHL player, he hasn't lived up to the hype he carried entering the league. Part of that stems from the Sting struggling over the past few seasons, but typically you'd hope he—and some of their other young talents—would have taken a bigger developmental step by now. Di Iorio has many of the physical tools you want in a center. He has good size, skates well, shows strong hockey sense, and plays effectively in both the offensive and defensive zones. The offense hasn't popped at this level, and it's starting to look like his skill and playmaking may not be as high-end as initially expected. He's unlikely to be a major point producer in the NHL, but he could carve out a role as a depth center for a team that believes there's more to unlock in his game.

3YP: 12-22-34 | **PIM:** 58 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Joe Veleno

Edwards, Beckham — C, Sarnia Sting, OHL

143rd overall (DET)

DH pre-Draft: 63

Edwards is another Sarnia Sting center who will be drafted this year alongside teammate Alessandro Di Iorio. He has good size and a strong shot, which he uses to beat OHL goalies from different areas and distances. He is a bit more offensively proficient than Di Iorio but may not be as well-rounded. Edwards has a chance to make the NHL as a bottom-six depth player, either on the wing or down the middle.

3YP: 10-25-35 | **PIM:** 44 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Stephen Halliday

Elofsson, Axel — RD, Orebro HK, U20 Nationell 128th overall (COL)

DH pre-Draft: 76

Undersized offensive defensemen haven't exactly been popular in NHL Draft rooms lately, but when they hit, they can pay real dividends. Elofsson is that kind of bet. The 5-11, 165-pound Swede activates into the rush with purpose, finds passing lanes through multiple seams, and plays with a surprising physical bite for someone his size. The defensive side is where the concerns are real. He can wander from his assignments, lose coverage, and make poor decisions with the puck under pressure. "Hit or miss" doesn't quite cover it—but if it hits, Elofsson is going to look like a steal.

3YP: 12-38-50 | **PIM:** 24 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Tony DeAngelo

Fitzgerald, Colin – C, Soo Greyhounds, OHL 203rd overall (STL)

DH pre-Draft: 82

It is an understatement to say that Fitzgerald had a disappointing draft season. Despite possessing many of the tools scouts covet, he never really seemed to put it together for either of the two teams he played for. Fitzgerald is a big 6-2 center weighing over 200 pounds. He has a very hard shot that should be good enough to beat NHL goalies. He can play with physicality and be a strong defensive player at times as well. Unfortunately, consistency is a major flaw, driven in part by an inconsistent motor. Fitzgerald has almost all the tools a player needs to become an NHLer, but he needs to put it all together and become a more serious competitor to make it. If he hits, he has middle-six center potential, but a lot needs to be fixed.

3YP: 20-24-42 | **PIM:** 62 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Frederik Gauthier

Floris, Jakub – RD, Lukko U20, U20 SM-sarja 106th overall (NSH)

DH pre-Draft: 59

Floris is a rangy, aggressive defenseman with a toolkit that immediately catches your eye. The 6-3, 192-pound Slovak skates with effortless four-way mobility, gaps up hard in the neutral zone, and plays with a genuine mean streak. He destroys opponents on entry and reads developing plays early enough to break them up before they become dangerous. There is a chaos factor in his game, though: he activates without much of a plan at times, carries pucks into traffic, and his decision-making under pressure needs significant work. The tools are worth the patience, as he has top-four upside if he can add more structure to his game.

3YP: 10-30-40 | **PIM:** 48 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Darnell Nurse

Frolo, Jakub – C, Ilves U20, U20 SM-sarja Undrafted

DH pre-Draft: 92

Frolo is a calculating playmaker who picks apart defensive structures with sophisticated passing and deceptive manipulation. The 6-1, 194-pound Czech slows the game down to his pace, threads passes through multiple seams, and plays with a pest-like edge that gets under opponents' skin. To translate his game to professional North American rinks, he needs to significantly improve his skating, as he lacks explosiveness and overall motor. With his projectable frame and genuine

playmaking ability, there is real middle-six upside here.

3YP: 22-38-60 | **PIM:** 52 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Mats Zuccarello

Fyodorov, Viktor — C, Torpedo-Gorky NN, VHL 99th overall (SEA)

DH pre-Draft: 53

Fyodorov is a center who wins through intelligence rather than imposing tools. The 5-10, 176-pound Russian plays fast within structure, constantly scanning before his first touch and finding teammates through tight passing lanes with impressive composure. His defensive habits are already pro-caliber: he's active on the penalty kill, reliable in his own zone, and rarely caught out of position. His lack of elite tools combined with his frame are legitimate concerns, but there is a lot to like in his game. Smart players tend to find a way to make things work, and if he can bump those tools up even slightly, he might end up being one of the steals of this NHL Draft.

3YP: 20-35-55 | **PIM:** 22 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Anthony Cirelli

Galvas, Tomas – LD, Liberec, Extraliga 54th overall (PIT)

DH pre-Draft: 85

Everyone can appreciate Galvas' game. He's a really fun and exciting player to watch. When playing in his age group, especially in international play, he excels and has played some great hockey. Against men in the Extraliga, he has steadily improved and become a top offensive defenseman in that league. So why is this Galvas' third time through the draft after going undrafted the previous two seasons? Unfortunately, it's due to being 5-10, 168 pounds, with good—but not great—skating ability. It's unlikely that Galvas could be relied upon in a defensive role in the NHL due to his physical limitations, and there are several offensive defensemen in this draft with both higher floors and higher ceilings. Still, Galvas has had success wherever he goes and is worth a mid-to-late-round pick in the hopes he can continue to excel as he moves up levels.

3YP: 10-25-35 | **PIM:** 18 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Erik Brannstrom

Gashilov, Lavr – C, Avto Yekaterinburg, MHL 119th overall (NJD)

DH pre-Draft: 61

Gashilov carries a clear boom-or-bust label. The 6-2, 170-pound Russian has flashed genuine NHL-level skill with precise passing, deceptive dangles, and an ability to find teammates through layers of traffic at high speed. There are serious concerns with his game, though. He has below-average pace and skating, and not enough motor to compensate. He can appear lazy and tends to avoid physical engagement. The skill is too good to ignore, because if everything clicks—his effort level rising and his frame filling out—he could develop into a real playmaking threat.

3YP: 18-42-60 | **PIM:** 18 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Teuvo Teravainen

Goljer, Adam — RD, HK Dukla Trencín, Slovak Extraliga 49th overall (LAK)

DH pre-Draft: 31

Goljer is an intriguing project out of Slovakia with the tools to make a case for himself at the next level. He moves well for his size, reads the play with calm awareness, and can execute a reliable first pass under pressure. There are flashes of genuine puck-moving ability, including stretch passes that can spring teammates in transition, and his active stick and long reach make him a consistent disruptor in the defensive zone. The question mark in his game is urgency. He takes what's given rather than going to get it, and his defensive reads need to catch up. Still, the tools are worth betting on.

3YP: 8-25-33 | **PIM:** 36 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** John Marino

Gudmundsson, Mans – RD, Farjestad BK U20 Nationell 76th overall (TOR)

DH pre-Draft: 60

Gudmundsson is a physical, mean-spirited defender who makes life miserable for opposing forwards. The 6-3, 190-pound Swede gaps up aggressively, uses his size to win board battles and wall off attackers, and brings a nastiness to his defensive game that translates well to professional leagues. He plays effective, low-event hockey built around his reach and physicality. While he may make hasty decisions with the puck under pressure, there is some intriguing offensive upside that could make him even more interesting if he can refine his puck skills.

3YP: 8-25-33 | **PIM:** 36 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Erik Cernak

Gustafsson, Malte — LD, HV71, SHL 13th overall (NYI)

DH pre-Draft: 10

There aren't many 17-year-old defenders who can hold their own in SHL play, but Gustafsson isn't your typical draft-eligible defenseman. At 6-4, 201 pounds, the Swede moves with a fluidity that belies his size, with sharp edgework and mobility that allow him to contain attackers most defenders with his frame simply can't. His gap control and off-puck awareness are already pro-caliber, and he plays a physical, assertive game with composure. A booming slap shot gives him a legitimate threat from the point and adds an offensive dimension to his game. His puck decisions under pressure could use refinement, but the foundation here looks like that of a future top-four defenseman.

3YP: 8-32-40 | **PIM:** 28 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Vladislav Gavrikov

Hakansson, William — LD, Lulea, SHL 51st overall (CAR)

DH pre-Draft: 42

Hakansson is a composed, rangy defender who doesn't do much wrong. He scans constantly, covers ice naturally with his long reach, and delivers a reliable first pass under pressure. His booming shot gives him a legitimate weapon from the point, though the offensive game hasn't taken a meaningful step forward yet. His gap control can be passive, giving attackers more room than they should get. The projection is a steady, responsible defender with upside for more if those defensive reads sharpen.

3YP: 8-28-36 | **PIM:** 24 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Mattias Ekholm

Hamilton, Beckett — RW, Red Deer Rebels, WHL 74th overall (COL)

DH pre-Draft: 64

Hamilton burst onto the scene by leading a very weak Red Deer team in scoring by 24 points. He's an energetic winger who competes at a high level. There is skill in his game, but not top-50 skill in this draft class. Another downside is that he's not the biggest player, meaning he'll have to rely heavily on his tenacity to be effective. Given the way he plays, he should still be able to produce some offense—players who compete and live around the net, like Hamilton, tend to find opportunities. Overall, he's the type of player coaches appreciate and could carve out a living as an energy winger in the NHL.

3YP: 14-24-38 | **PIM:** 68 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Michael Amadio

Harrington, Chase — RW, Spokane Chiefs, WHL 36th overall (CGY)

DH pre-Draft: 47

There are a handful of players like Harrington in this year's draft coming out of the WHL. He's a very tough winger with both size and skill. He's not elite in any category, and most of his traits

are average, but he's an effective player nonetheless. Like a few other WHL prospects, he was somewhat trapped on a weak Spokane team that lost Berkly Catton to the NHL and traded Mathis Preston at the deadline. There may be more to Harrington's game, but it was difficult for him to showcase it with the lack of talent around him. If all goes well, he could become an effective complementary depth scorer who also contributes defensively.

3YP: 15-22-37 | **PIM:** 72 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Barclay Goodrow

Hemming, Oscar — LW, Boston College, NCAA 14th overall (CBJ)

DH pre-Draft: 17

Hemming (Dallas prospect Emil's brother) has had one of the strangest draft seasons in recent memory. There were political reasons that led to him not being able to play in Kitchener before finally signing with Boston College in December. While his production was just average at BC, it's safe to put a lot of the blame on not playing for three months, making the transition to North America, and playing as one of the youngest NCAA players when he did arrive. From a traits perspective, he's got so much to like about him. He's big, strong, and moves quite well for a big man (6-4, 193). Hemming has a cannon of a shot and can score from range, but he's also aggressive getting to the net and scoring in the harder areas of the ice. He competes hard and is an underrated playmaker too. His hockey sense is probably his biggest flaw as it's just okay. Overall, Hemming has top-10 upside, but he's a wild card in this draft. Scouts are wondering what he could have looked like with a full season in a consistent environment.

3YP: 30-30-60 | **PIM:** 68 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Chris Kreider

Hermansson, Elton — RW, MoDo Hockey, HockeyAllsvenskan 19th overall (LAK)

DH pre-Draft: 16

Hermansson has some of the most electric hands in this crop. The skilled Swede can pull off the Michigan, thread look-off passes through defenders' feet, and manipulate coverage on the power play in ways that make you lean forward in your seat. The problem is that he tries the jaw-dropping play at the wrong moment just as often, gifting possession back to the opposition in dangerous areas. And when the skill isn't producing, there isn't much of a B-game to fall back on. Still, the ceiling here is genuinely exciting.

3YP: 30-50-80 | **PIM:** 24 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Kevin Fiala

Hextall, Jack — C, Youngstown Phantoms, USHL 30th overall (CGY)

DH pre-Draft: 27

Hextall is a player scouts universally appreciate because he does many of the subtle things extremely well. He's a smart player who makes good reads and competes at a solid level. He was one of the driving forces behind Team USA's Hlinka Gretzky Cup win last summer—especially impressive given that the USNTDP does not attend that event. Hextall produced at a point-per-game pace in the USHL with Youngstown, which is strong output for that league. Despite all the positives, he lacks dynamic or explosive traits, and he's not the biggest or strongest player either. The absence of high-end tools may prevent him from becoming an effective middle-six center, but he's the type of player you can never count out.

3YP: 20-30-50 | **PIM:** 34 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** J.T. Compher

Holmertz, Oskar — C, Linkoping HC, U20 Nationell 87th overall (OTT)

DH pre-Draft: 66

Holmertz is one of the most talented skaters in the 2026 class. He makes the game look effortless, using a fluid stride to hunt for seams and connect on deceptive, high-end passing plays. While his vision and poise suggest a top-six facilitator, his nonchalant approach to the

game remains a legitimate concern. He frequently shies away from contact, his motor wavers, and he lacks the power needed to battle for inside ice. The tools are elite, providing clear top-six upside, but he must add both strength and intensity to make a successful transition to the North American game.

3YP: 20-45-65 | **PIM:** 20 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Andrei Kuzmenko

Hrenak, Samuel – G, Fargo Force, USHL 71st overall (WPG)

DH pre-Draft: 79

Hrenak was well-traveled this season, playing in multiple leagues and international events before finishing the year as a backup with the Fargo Force. While he didn't appear in any playoff games, he posted an impressive 9-1-1 record and a 0.918 save percentage during the regular season. He is an average-sized goalie but a very smart one. He reads plays effectively and positions himself at a high level. He is a good athlete, though he doesn't project as more than average from an NHL standpoint. Hrenak is worth a mid-round pick and could work his way into an NHL backup role down the line.

PLAYER COMPARABLE: Eric Comrie

Hurlbert, JP – F, Kamloops Blazers, WHL 23rd overall (DET)

DH pre-Draft: 19

Hurlbert was a huge signing for Kamloops this offseason after he defected from the USNTDP, and he did not disappoint. From day one, he was the driving force behind the Blazers' offense, nearly reaching the 100-point mark. He has an excellent shot, as evidenced by his 42 goals in 68 games, and he is also a dynamic playmaker. On the power play, Hurlbert takes his game to another level. He's a threat to score or set up teammates from the half-wall, or drive toward the slot and rip one. The downside is that he plays a bit of a junior-hockey style, and it's fair to wonder how much of it will translate as he climbs levels. He also isn't a defensive stalwart, so that part of his game will need work. Hurlbert will need time to round out his game, but if it translates, he should be a PP1 option and a second-line scoring winger at the NHL level.

3YP: 30-35-65 | **PIM:** 28 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Jack Quinn

Ignatavicius, Simas – RW, Geneve-Servette HC, NL 40th overall (FLA)

DH pre-Draft: 35

Ignatavicius is a 6-3, 198-pound forward whose game translates directly to North American pro hockey. He takes smart routes, scans constantly, and supports teammates with strong off-puck awareness. There isn't much elite offensive ability yet, but he flashes enough playmaking to make you wonder. If those moments become more consistent, he could blossom into an impactful middle-six winger who makes his line better and works hard every night. That's not the most probable outcome, but even if it doesn't happen, he still projects as a solid contributor.

3YP: 20-35-55 | **PIM:** 32 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Nino Niederreiter

Katolicky, Simon – LW, Tappara U20, U20 SM-sarja 132nd overall (CGY)

DH pre-Draft: 90

Katolicky is a towering, toolsy forward whose value lies in a rare combination of a 6-4, 198-pound frame and explosive straight-line speed. He beats defenders wide, protects pucks with his long reach, and owns a heavy release that gives him genuine scoring upside. The frustration is that he rarely imposes himself the way his physical profile suggests he should. He plays a casual game, avoids extra contact, and tends to glide through situations where a player his size should be dominating. The tools form the base for intriguing power-forward upside, but his game needs

significant developmental steps to reach it.

3YP: 24-32-56 | **PIM:** 34 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Anthony Mantha

Klepov, Nikita — RW, Saginaw Spirit, OHL 15th overall (ANA)

DH pre-Draft: 20

After losing elite players like Michael Misa and Zayne Parekh to the NHL, Saginaw was far less potent than in past seasons. Fortunately, the team still made the playoffs almost entirely thanks to Klepov and 2027 draft-eligible Dima Zhilkin. Klepov is a highly talented winger with great hands and puck skills. He has an excellent wrist shot and can release it almost instantly. While he's not the biggest or fastest player, his size and skating are good enough—especially when paired with his high-end offensive game. If he hits his potential, Klepov could become a top-six scoring winger and PP1 mainstay in the NHL.

3YP: 12-42-64 | **PIM:** 36 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Tomas Tatar

Knowling, Brady – G, USNTDP, USHL 127th overall (SJS)

DH pre-Draft: 70

The USNTDP has a strong track record of developing goalie prospects, and while Knowling isn't at the level of past standouts like Trey Augustine or Spencer Knight, he is still a goalie with NHL potential. Knowling had an up-and-down statistical year. He was excellent at the Hlinka-Gretzky Cup, helping Team USA win gold, and he had a strong showing in one of the CHL-USA Prospects Challenge games this fall. At his best, he looks like a massive goaltender with better-than-expected athleticism, capable of making big saves and bailing out his team. At other times, however, he appears to be fighting the puck and looks less comfortable, as reflected in his mediocre league-play numbers and U18 performance. Selecting a big goalie with legitimate NHL tools—like Knowling—in the middle rounds is often worth the risk. The downside is minimal, while the upside could be tremendous.

PLAYER COMPARABLE: Dennis Hildeby

Laatikainen, Max – RD, Kiekko-Espoo U20, U20 SM-sarja 213th overall (PHI)

DH pre-Draft: 98

September-born Laatikainen is one of the youngest players eligible for this draft, and the tools he already brings to the table are genuinely intriguing. The right-shot Finn moves with grace and four-way mobility, allowing him to weave through pressure, break the puck out smoothly, and activate offensively with comfort against pro competition. He plays with a nonchalance that can be a double-edged sword. He can be too trusting of his own skill, which has led to costly turnovers. Standing 5-11 and 172 pounds, he relies heavily on his stick in the defensive zone, and his game currently lacks physicality. He's a risky pick but could be very rewarding if he can ramp up the physical engagement.

3YP: 8-34-42 | **PIM:** 22 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Rasmus Sandin

Lacelle, William – G, Blainville-Boisbriand Armada, QMJHL Undrafted

DH pre-Draft: 75

If there's a goalie to root for in this year's NHL Draft, it's Blainville's Lacelle. He is undersized at 6-1 and has no hearing in one ear and partial hearing in the other. Despite this, Lacelle thrived this season—both before and after his trade to Blainville—thanks to excellent mobility and an aggressive playing style. It's uncertain whether his size will prevent him from becoming an NHL starter, but he could carve out a role as a backup.

PLAYER COMPARABLE: Colten Ellis

Lagerberg Hoen, Jonas – RW, Leksands IF U20, U20 Nationell 25th overall (OTT)

DH pre-Draft: 77

Lagerberg Hoen is a toolsy winger with a plus-level release. The 6-2, 176-pound Swede shoots at high volume and blends speed with puckhandling skill to create offense. A knee injury limited him to just 11 games this season, which is unfortunate because the tools are genuinely interesting. His hockey sense and decision-making under pressure need significant work. There is also a question of whether his game relies too heavily on the space junior hockey provides. The tools alone make him intriguing, and it will be interesting to see how he develops if he stays healthy.

3YP: 25-35-55 | **PIM:** 28 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Owen Tippett

Lawrence, Tynan — C, Boston University, NCAA, 11th overall (STL)

DH pre-Draft: 9

Like many North American prospects, expectations for Lawrence were sky-high entering the season after a dominant D-1 USHL campaign in which he was the Clark Cup MVP. While he remains a strong prospect for this year's draft, injuries, the transition to the NCAA, and questions about his offensive ceiling kept him from meeting those lofty expectations. Lawrence does many things well. He's a burner who gets up ice in a hurry. He competes relentlessly and is a constant threat on the forecheck. It feels like he generates a couple of breakaways every game. He has just average size—especially for a center—but he is very young for this draft class, so he may still grow before reaching the NHL. Even at his size, his speed and compete level should allow him to play center at the next level. The main criticism is that he only seems to know one speed: maximum. He needs to vary his pace and incorporate more delay into his game. Coaches appreciate his relentless pursuit away from the puck, but changing speeds with the puck will open up far more opportunities to manipulate defenders and use his teammates effectively. Overall, Lawrence may not become a high-end point-producing center in the NHL, but he should still be a valuable contributor down the middle for whichever team drafts him.

3YP: 25-33-58 | **PIM:** 62 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Oliver Moore

Lin, Ryan — RD, Vancouver Giants, WHL 21st overall (SJS)

DH pre-Draft: 22

Lin is a very intelligent two-way WHL defenseman. Defensively, he reads plays extremely well and can break up passes and deny zone entries with strong positioning and an effective stick. He's a smooth mover who can walk the line on the power play. Lin will activate in the offensive zone and is a legitimate scoring threat. He sees teammates well and is a talented passer who can hit targets with accuracy. The biggest downside with Lin is that he doesn't possess the most desirable physical traits. He's not a very big defenseman, his skating is good but not great, and he isn't particularly physical. There are concerns that his defensive game may not translate to the NHL level, where he could be overwhelmed by size and speed. Overall, Lin carries some translatability risk, but he's a very smart and talented defenseman who could become a bottom-pairing player at even strength while contributing on one of the two power-play units.

3YP: 10-40-50 | **PIM:** 32 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Cam York

Macbeath, Ben — LD, Calgary Hitmen, WHL 64th overall (NYR)

DH pre-Draft: 30

As a 17-year-old rookie in the WHL, Macbeath burst onto the scene with 51 points in 67 games. He was everything for the Hitmen's blue line—playing the most minutes and handling all situations. What makes Macbeath such an intriguing prospect is that he's 6-2 and skates extremely well, not just for his size but in general. He moves pucks well, defends adequately, and can produce offense both as a distributor and as a shooter. He does most things at a reasonable

level, but he isn't a standout in any category outside of being an excellent skater. Additionally, despite his height, he's quite lean and will need to add muscle. Macbeath is a player worth monitoring over the next few years. He's committed to Denver—a strong development program—and could really take off in a few years.

3YP: 10-28-38 | **PIM:** 28 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Jake Middleton

Mackenzie, Ethan — LD, Edmonton Oil Kings, WHL 69th overall (TOR)

DH pre-Draft: 74

There are usually a few players who get drafted on their third attempt, and MacKenzie could be one of them this year. He had a great start to the season, earning a spot on Team Canada's World Junior roster. He played a lot early in the tournament, lost ice time as it progressed, and then regained some minutes late. MacKenzie does many things well and plays a mature game, though that's partly due to his age and experience. There aren't many standout qualities in his toolkit, but he has rightfully put himself on the radar to be selected this year.

3YP: 5-20-25 | **PIM:** 48 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Jacob Bernard-Docker

Malhotra, Caleb — C, Brantford Bulldogs, OHL 3rd overall (VAN)

DH pre-Draft: 6

Malhotra burst onto the scene in his first OHL season on a Brantford team that dominated thanks to its abundance of NHL-level talent. Despite the depth around him, Malhotra wasn't buried—he played a major role in all situations. He has many traits scouts love: he's a detailed, intelligent center who plays hard and skates well. He has no size concerns and competes effectively. He produced at very high levels this year, though it's fair to question whether his true skill level fully matches that production, even if he is skilled. He doesn't have many weaknesses, but he also doesn't possess any glaring deficiencies. He'll likely be selected fairly high in a draft lacking high-end centers. Malhotra projects as an above-average second-line center and should have little trouble translating up levels as he progresses toward the NHL.

3YP: 25-40-65 | **PIM:** 66 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Anthony Cirelli

Mbuyi, Pierce — LW, Owen Sound Attack, OHL 86th overall (PIT)

DH pre-Draft: 65

Mbuyi is an exciting winger with some of the best skill in the draft. He's a flashy player who isn't afraid to try anything to create offense. He plays a bit of a junior-hockey style, which will likely need to be reined in, as some of the plays he attempts in the OHL won't work at the NHL level. Mbuyi has a very slight frame and isn't tall, which complicates his projection as he moves up levels. He's committed to Penn State, which will be a significant challenge. One could argue that staying in the OHL for another year and producing a big D+1 season before joining PSU in 2027–28 might have been the better route, but Mbuyi is fearless and will embrace the challenge. Although there is a wide range of outcomes, he has middle-six offensive winger potential.

3YP: 20-28-48 | **PIM:** 64 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Kasper Kapanen

McKenna, Gavin — LW, Penn State University, NCAA 1st overall (TOR)

DH pre-Draft: 1

McKenna is the most talented player in this draft. He regularly makes high-difficulty plays look easy. He's a very skilled playmaker who should have no trouble piling up assists in the NHL, especially running the power play from the half-wall. Even though playmaking is his calling card, he has the shooting ability to score 30+ goals as well. With the puck on his stick, he checks nearly every box you want from a projected first-overall pick. Unfortunately, there are concerns about his off-puck play and compete level. Typically, when teams pick first overall, effort and

competitiveness are defining traits. It's rare for a potential No. 1 pick to have those areas listed as weaknesses. If he improves them, McKenna has 100-point potential. If he doesn't, he could become an imperfect but highly productive second-line winger.

3YP: 35-65-100 | **PIM:** 32 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Patrick Kane

Morozov, Ilya — C, Miami University (Ohio), NCAA 20th overall (BUF)

DH pre-Draft: 23

There is so much to like about Morozov. He's huge, moves reasonably well, has an excellent compete level, and plays a reliable two-way game. That alone gives him a strong chance of becoming a bottom-six NHL forward. Morozov accelerated his development by going to college a year early, becoming the youngest player in the NCAA at the time. He joined a weak program at Miami-Ohio, which allowed him to play significant minutes at center but didn't provide much talent around him. While 20 points in 36 games as a 17-year-old is very impressive, he didn't display the high-end offensive traits you'd expect from a potential top-six NHL center. Still, Morozov has plenty of time to develop into a more dynamic scorer. For now, he looks like a safe bet to become a highly effective 3C or 4C, with top-six upside if his offensive game takes a step forward.

3YP: 25-30-55 | **PIM:** 56 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Eetu Luostarinen

Morrison, Charlie — LD, Quebec Remparts, QMJHL 77th overall (NYR)

DH pre-Draft: 62

Morrison is a hulking defensive defenseman who moves well for his size. He's very physical and plays with a mean streak. He's at his best as an in-zone defender, clearing traffic from the front of the net and making opposing players pay for entering his territory. He defends the rush fairly well thanks to his length and adequate skating, which prevents attackers from burning him wide. There are minimal offensive instincts in his game, and he won't factor into an NHL power play. Overall, Morrison projects as a third-pairing NHL defenseman who adds size, physicality, and penalty-killing value.

3YP: 4-12-16 | **PIM:** 88 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Tyler Kleven

Mutryn, Casey — C, USNTDP, NTDP 38th overall (SEA)

DH pre-Draft: 45

Mutryn captained the USNTDP U18 team this past season, playing an important role split mostly between right wing and center. He has great size and plays a supportive role at 5-on-5 while commanding the front of the net on the power play. There isn't much offense in his game and he's not a dynamic player, but he's fairly intelligent, competes well enough, and should be able to carve out a depth role on an NHL roster.

3YP: 15-20-35 | **PIM:** 58 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Nico Sturm

Nemec, Adam — LW, Sudbury Wolves, OHL 72nd overall (OTT)

DH pre-Draft: 41

A few years after older brother Simon Nemec was drafted second overall by New Jersey in 2022, Adam Nemec is set to hear his name called—likely in the middle rounds. He's a well-rounded winger who brings an intense, energetic style of play. He wins puck battles thanks to his competitiveness and size, helping him extend possessions in the offensive zone. He gets to the net effectively and can score in tight or from medium range. His hockey IQ is just okay, and he isn't the skater his brother is, but he still has NHL potential. Expect Adam to compete for a bottom-six winger role in time.

3YP: 15-25-40 | **PIM:** 40 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Mason Appleton

Nordmark, Marcus — LW, Djurgardens IF, U20 Nationell 28th overall (ANA)

DH pre-Draft: 43

Nordmark is one of the more polarizing prospects in this draft class. The 6-2, 187-pound Swedish winger has plus-level puck-handling, a lethal wrist shot, and the vision to find passes through multiple seams. When the skill is clicking, he manipulates the game rather than simply playing it. The problem is everything that comes after. He plays at a low pace, brings minimal physicality, and tends to disappear when the offense isn't flowing. There is legit top-six upside here, but the lack of compete and a reliable B-game raises questions about whether he'll ever attain the NHL.

3YP: 25-45-70 | **PIM:** 23 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Jonathan Drouin

Novotny, Adam — LW/RW, Peterborough Petes, OHL 24th overall (VAN)

DH pre-Draft: 14

Novotny is a very likable prospect. He's a plus-level skater, has an excellent shot, and brings a great motor. He moved to the OHL this past season and started slowly on a Peterborough team coming off a last-place finish the year prior. As the year progressed, both Novotny and the Petes made significant strides. His north-south game will be welcomed on a line with more skilled players—but that doesn't mean he can't contribute offensively; he absolutely can. Novotny will likely play a power-forward, finisher-type role and can be deployed up and down the lineup wherever needed. His hockey sense, vision, and playmaking are nothing special, so don't expect him to be a high-assist producer. Overall, there will always be lineup spots for players like Novotny, and he should be able to produce wherever he plays.

3YP: 13-20-33 | **PIM:** 40 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Zach Hyman

Olsen, Zac — RW, Saskatoon Blades, WHL 73rd overall (TOR)

DH pre-Draft: 58

Olsen's most likely path to the NHL is as a bottom-six checking winger. He has good size, a strong build, and competes hard. He's an aggressive forechecker who forces opposing puck carriers into quick decisions when he's in pursuit. There isn't much offensive hockey sense or playmaking in his game, and his shot is unlikely to be a major weapon at the NHL level. Coaches will appreciate his effort and physical style, which may give him an edge over other young players competing for depth roles.

3YP: 8-15-23 | **PIM:** 62 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Paul Cotter

Pakarinen, Noel — LW, Kiekko-Espoo U20, U20 SM-sarja 207th overall (VGK)

DH pre-Draft: 80

Pakarinen is a physical, high-motor winger who makes life difficult for opposing defenders. The 6-2, 198-pound Finn combines an excellent work rate with genuine finishing ability, featuring a heavy shot that gives him real secondary-scoring potential. He plays a style that should translate naturally to pro rinks. He forechecks relentlessly, finishes every hit, and protects pucks effectively. He isn't much of a play-driver and his skating mechanics aren't perfect, but he has the upside to develop into a hard-working complementary winger who can chip in offensively.

3YP: 28-27-55 | **PIM:** 48 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Lawson Crouse

Palme, Ola — LD, Vaxjo Lakers HC U20, U20 Nationell 166th overall (SEA)

DH pre-Draft: 95

Palme is a steady, low-maintenance defender who reliably handles the unglamorous work. The

6-2, 201-pound Swede gaps up early, shields forecheckers on retrievals, and moves the puck out of the zone with a composure coaches appreciate. While not the most dynamic offensive presence, he shows significant poise on the breakout and demonstrates a modern willingness to activate and support the rush. His skating can look choppy, and he lacks a standout tool that separates him from the pack. His defensive fundamentals give him a relatively high floor with potential top-four upside.

3YP: 6-22-28 | **PIM:** 28 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Matt Roy

Pantelas, Giorgos — RD, Brandon Wheat Kings, WHL 153rd overall (LAK)

DH pre-Draft: 55

Pantelas burst onto the scene in Brandon, leading some outlets to prematurely rank him inside the top 10–15 prospects. A deeper look and a larger sample size showed he's more of a second- or third-round prospect than a first-rounder. Pantelas is a big, thick right-shot defenseman with both offensive and defensive upside. He has a hard shot and will jump into the rush. He's an aggressive defender who can sometimes chase plays or the big hit. Pantelas competes hard, and given his size and mobility, he should get an opportunity to compete for a bottom-pairing NHL role.

3YP: 8-16-24 | **PIM:** 82 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Ben Chiarot

Piiparinen, Juho — RD, Tappara, Liiga 29th overall (VGK)

DH pre-Draft: 24

Piiparinen is the best defensive prospect from Finland since Miro Heiskanen came through the pipeline. The 6-3, 203-pound blueliner is a suffocating defender—physical, positionally disciplined, and relentless in puck pursuit. There is some offensive potential, and unlocking it could elevate his overall game. His skating is solid but not explosive; both his first-step quickness and top-end speed need improvement, as does his assertiveness with the puck in the offensive zone. His shot is hard but needs better accuracy. If he rounds out those edges, Piiparinen could become a genuinely complete top-four defenseman.

3YP: 8-27-35 | **PIM:** 26 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Damon Severson

Plante, Victor — LW, USNTDP U18, USHL 47th overall (DET)

DH pre-Draft: 52

Plante is the youngest of the Plante brothers. Next season, all three will play at Minnesota-Duluth—the alma mater of their father, former NHLer Derek Plante. Like Zam and Max, Victor is undersized, but he doesn't let that limit his offensive impact. He brings a relentless motor and a constant desire to create chances. If he were bigger, he would almost certainly be ranked much higher. Given the success his older brothers have had in the NCAA despite their size, Victor may be worth betting on in the second or third round. If his game translates to the NHL, a team could find a middle-six offensive winger who plays with a ton of pace.

3YP: 20-30-50 | **PIM:** 22 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Jackson Blake

Preston, Mathis — C/RW, Vancouver Giants, WHL 50th overall (ANA)

DH pre-Draft: 29

Preston was another player many outlets ranked inside the top 10–15 at the start of the season. Unfortunately, consistency was an issue throughout the year, and he didn't look as effective as you'd expect from a player with his skill, speed, and hands. Part of that was due to an injury and a mid-season trade, but scouts still wanted to see more from him. When he's on, he's a highly dynamic winger who can burn defenders on the outside and then make a move on the goalie to finish the play. He has a bit of a junior-hockey style to his game, which will need to be smoothed

out as he moves up levels, but he's worth a pick in the latter part of the first round or into the second because his upside is enormous.

3YP: 25-40-65 | **PIM:** 20 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Brad Lambert

Pugachyov, Gleb — LW, Chaika Nizhny Novgorod, MHL 26th overall (MTL)

DH pre-Draft: 44

Gleb Pugachyov is exactly the kind of player NHL coaches love and opponents dread. The 6-3, 198-pound Russian imposes himself on every shift through physicality and relentless forechecking, winning board battles, driving the net, and forcing turnovers. Getting KHL minutes as a teenager is no accident. His puck skills are raw, but he takes smart routes and plays well off his teammates. He's a safe bet to make the NHL, with upside as a middle-six complementary power forward if he can elevate his puck skills.

3YP: 18-22-40 | **PIM:** 52 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Blake Coleman

Reid, Chase — RD, Soo Greyhounds, OHL 7th overall (SEA)

DH pre-Draft: 3

Reid is an offensively gifted defenseman with an enviable combination of size, skating, and skill. He burst onto the scene in his D-1 season with the Greyhounds, and his trajectory has been steadily upward ever since. Reid is dynamic as a puck carrier, passer, and shooter, and he should be a force on the power play thanks to his big shot and uncanny ability to get pucks through traffic. He's also a talented distributor who can rack up points at 5-on-5 and on the man advantage. While offense will be his calling card in the NHL, he has the tools and desire to become an above-average defender if he puts it all together. His high panic threshold allows him to calmly navigate pressure in his own end and start breakouts with confidence. Reid has many traits teams covet in a top-pairing defenseman, but if something holds him back from true star potential, it's that his offensive tools aren't quite elite like a Cale Makar or Quinn Hughes, and he's not a high-end defender either. Still, he projects as a very talented blueliner who should easily log 20+ minutes a night while producing north of 50 points.

3YP: 20-50-70 | **PIM:** 44 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Jakob Chychrun

Rogowski, Brooks — C, Oshawa Generals, OHL 33rd overall (VAN)

DH pre-Draft: 32

Rogowski is a tank—plain and simple. One of the biggest players in the 2026 NHL Draft, he's also highly athletic. While he's unlikely to be much of a point producer at the NHL level, he can play a punishing two-way game while chipping in secondary offense, especially around the net. He's the type of player you throw out to defend a lead: he blocks shots, wins battles, and helps close out games. He's not a great skater, but few 17-year-olds at 6-7 are. He'll likely improve, though he may only top out at average. Expect Rogowski to project as a shutdown bottom-six center if he makes the NHL.

3YP: 10-20-30 | **PIM:** 74 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Michael McCarron

Roobroeck, Ryan — LW, Niagara Ice Dogs, OHL 35th overall (CHI)

DH pre-Draft: 28

Roobroeck entered the season with enormous hype, with many draft analysts ranking him inside the top five early in the year. Unfortunately, his play didn't match those expectations. At his best, he's a big-bodied (6-3, 209) offensive creator who can threaten as both a passer and a scorer. He has surprisingly soft hands and impressive dexterity for a big man, allowing him to make plays in tight spaces. His size and strength give him the potential to become a power winger with high-end point production. The biggest issue is his inconsistent motor. For a player with his size,

skill, pedigree, and age, he should have dominated the OHL this season—but he was merely good. Too often, he doesn't look like he's competing hard enough, and he gets away with it because of his natural gifts. That won't work in the NHL, where his physical advantages won't stand out as much. If he significantly elevates his effort level, he has first-line winger and point-per-game potential. If not, a frustrating player who never reaches his ceiling.

3YP: 35-40-75 | **PIM:** 57 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Anthony Mantha

Ruck, Liam – RW, Medicine Hat Tigers, WHL 22nd overall (PIT)

DH pre-Draft: 25

Name a more exciting duo than Medicine Hat's twin phenoms, Liam and Markus Ruck. Liam torched the WHL with 45 goals and 59 assists in 68 games. He does so many things well. He's a natural scorer and should be able to score at the NHL level. He competes well and has a great set of hands. The only negatives for Liam are his below-average size and his skating, which is just okay. While the upside could be that of a top-six scoring winger, the physical limitations are very real. It seems like there are a few players every draft in the mold of Liam and Markus, and not all of them end up making it. Fortunately, those who do tend to hit big. If all goes well, Ruck could be a dynamic scoring winger for years to come, but there is risk here.

3YP: 33-35-68 | **PIM:** 28 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Andrew Cristall

Ruck, Markus – C, Medicine Hat Tigers, WHL 39th overall (PIT)

DH pre-Draft: 56

The other half of the Ruck duo, Markus is the playmaker of the two brothers, and the stats back that up. He had an outstanding season with Medicine Hat, racking up 21 goals and 87 assists in 68 games. While he might be the weaker of the two brothers, Markus still has plenty of positives. Like Liam, he competes hard. He's an excellent puck-mover and passer—very few players in this draft are better passers than him. He also has good defensive details, which should help him transition to the NHL. The downsides are that he's not really a scorer and doesn't seem likely to be much of a scoring threat at the NHL level. Similar to Liam, he's a smaller player who isn't a great skater. This combination of size and skating deficiencies clouds his future as a center at the NHL level. Whoever drafts Liam should likely try to draft Markus as well, as their chemistry is unmatched and could help hide some of their bigger flaws. If Markus can translate his game to the NHL, it's likely on the wing in a middle-six role.

3YP: 17-30-47 | **PIM:** 26 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Morgan Frost

Rudolph, Daxon — RD, Prince Albert Raiders, WHL 4th overall (BUF)

DH pre-Draft: 11

Rudolph is a smooth-moving, right-handed defenseman with size and offensive ability—traits that always draw the attention of scouts. He has a good shot and walks the line well to create better shooting lanes. Rudolph activates at the right times and can be a real threat joining the rush, both as a passer and as a finisher. His draft-year production in the WHL was high-end, and it often felt like he was on the ice every other shift, logging huge minutes. The concerns with Rudolph stem from how he defends. While he defends well at the junior level, he relies more on athleticism and skating than on physicality or aggression. To be as effective defensively in the NHL as he is in the WHL, he'll need to be more assertive on the back end and develop a more physical game. Adding a higher compete level and more physicality to his big frame and excellent mobility would go a long way toward earning top-four minutes in the NHL. While he has put up a ton of points in junior, he doesn't possess the same level of dynamic skill as some of the other top defensemen in this draft. Still, given his talent, size, and mobility, Rudolph should be able to carve out a role as a No. 4 or No. 5 defender at minimum—and if he improves his deficiencies, he

could push toward becoming a No. 2 or No. 3 defenseman on a strong NHL team.

3YP: 15-35-50 | **PIM:** 54 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Thomas Chabot

Ruzicka, Filip – G, Brandon Wheat Kings, WHL 137th overall (MIN)

DH pre-Draft: 83

Ruzicka is a massive goalie, measuring 6-8 and 229 pounds. In an era where NHL goalies continue to get bigger, he would be among the largest. At that size, he covers a tremendous amount of net, and when he steps out to cut down angles, shooters must feel like they can barely see the net at all. Although he moves well for his size, his movement skills are still below average relative to typical goaltenders. He covers so much net that he can get away with being slow on post-to-post plays, but his agility remains a concern. If Ruzicka can improve his movement even slightly, it would bode well for his development. He is an intriguing project who could become an NHL backup—potentially more.

PLAYER COMPARABLE: Mads Sogaard

Schairer, Luke – RD, USNTDP U18, USHL 75th overall (STL)

DH pre-Draft: 68

There was a fair bit of hype around Schairer at the start of the season, and why wouldn't there be? He's a big, athletic, right-shot defenseman—players who are always in high demand. Throughout the year, his stock steadily fell as he didn't show much offense and proved to be just a decent puck-mover. He defends fairly well, but he's not the high-end stopper you'd hope for in a player of his size who lacks offensive upside. It looks like Schairer is still figuring out what kind of player he needs to be to be effective. Given his athletic gifts, his best bet might be to hone in on his defensive game and become a physical stopper at the next level.

3YP: 6-20-26 | **PIM:** 58 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Kaedan Korczak

Shaikhislamov, Alan — LW, Tolpar Ufa, MHL 55th overall (CGY)

DH pre-Draft: 87

Born in September, Shaikhislamov is one of the youngest players in this draft class—and the rawness shows. But so does the potential. The Russian winger has a quick, powerful stride, flashes of puck control, and a willingness to drive the net and do the unglamorous work that gets noticed at the pro level. His skill execution is inconsistent, and the creative vision isn't there yet, as he often defaults to simple plays rather than manufacturing chances. Both areas can improve with time—and he has plenty of it. His motor and frame give him a safe floor, while his tools make the ceiling worth watching.

3YP: 25-30-55 | **PIM:** 52 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Ross Colton

Shcherbakov, Nikita — LD, Toros Neftekamsk, VHL 44th overall (NJD)

DH pre-Draft: 34

Every draft class has at least one hulking defender who skates like size simply doesn't apply to him. In 2026, that player is Shcherbakov. The 6-5, 187-pound Russian moves with lateral agility and reach that shouldn't exist at that frame, shutting down rushes and exiting the zone cleanly under pressure. The tools are rare. The concern is his sense. There are regular lapses in defensive awareness, and his decision-making can be passive. He also hasn't learned to use his frame to physically impose himself the way you'd hope. None of this is unusual for a player this raw. Prospects with this kind of physical runway don't come around often.

3YP: 8-32-40 | **PIM:** 36 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** K'Andre Miller

Shilov, Yegor – C, Victoriaville Tigres, QMJHL 43rd overall (COL)

DH pre-Draft: 50

Shilov had a great rookie season with Victoriaville in the QMJHL after playing in the USHL the year before. He's a skilled, offensive centreman who loves having the puck on his stick. He has great hands and can handle the puck in tight areas without giving up possession. While he's a good junior-level center, he has average size and average skating, and he doesn't have any high-end or dynamic traits despite having very good skill. Because of this, it's unclear whether he'll be able to stick at center as he moves up levels. His compete level is also just okay, which further hurts the center projection. If he does make the NHL, it would likely be as a depth scorer on a sheltered line where he can produce offense without tough assignments.

3YP: 20-25-45 | **PIM:** 42 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Robby Fabbri

Sivertson, Jonah – RW, Prince Albert Raiders, WHL 113th overall (VGK)

DH pre-Draft: 93

One of the more under-the-radar prospects in this year's NHL Draft, Sivertson came out of nowhere to have a major breakout season for the Raiders. He is a big man despite being very young for this year's draft (late August 2008 birthday). He can work through traffic and do damage around the net. He has an above-average shot that should translate to some goals in the NHL. He's not a dynamic player by any means, as he's a below-average skater. His skill is just average, and he's not much of a playmaker either. Where he does shine is in playing an honest, straight-line game and being strong in both ends of the ice. If he can gain a step and use his size to an even greater extent, Sivertson could carve out a role in the NHL in a bottom-six capacity.

3YP: 12-20-32 | **PIM:** 70 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Pierre Engvall

Smits, Alberts – LD, Mikkelin Jukurit, Liiga 5th overall (NYR)

DH pre-Draft: 7

Players with Smits' combination of size, skating, and puck-handling don't grow on trees. The Latvian defenseman is an electrifying presence on the ice. His reach and mobility allow him to make plays that have no business working, and his aggressive activations regularly turn defense into offense in an instant. He tries a lot, which means the highlight-reel moments come with the occasional costly turnover. His defensive game and overall hockey sense still need refinement. But with tools this dynamic and a skating base that covers for many defensive lapses, Smits projects comfortably as a future top-four contributor.

3YP: 20-35-55 | **PIM:** 38 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Noah Hanifin

Soderberg, Ludvig – LD, Sodertalje SK U20, U20 Nationell Undrafted

DH pre-Draft: 99

Soderberg is a mobile, puck-moving defenseman who builds his game around effective transition play. The 5-11, 181-pound Swede navigates the neutral zone with deceptive fluidity, distributes accurately through forechecking layers, and uses cutbacks and feints to shake pressure at the point. He earned HockeyAllsvenskan minutes as a draft-eligible player, which speaks to how well his skating and passing translate against men. The main concern is that he lacks the stopping power to win net-front battles, and his defensive reads need refinement. The path to the NHL for a defender with his profile is narrow, but the tools give him intriguing upside.

3YP: 6-22-28 | **PIM:** 20 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Jordan Spence

Sorensson, Wiggo – C, Boro/Vetlanda HC, Division 2 61st overall (CAR)

DH pre-Draft: 94

Sorensson is a slightly undersized center whose game is built around elite quickness and deceptive manipulation. The 5-11, 181-pound Swede uses explosive acceleration to create separation, attacks the net with purpose, and freezes defenders with no-look passes. He dominated the lower tiers of Swedish hockey and proved against top international competition that the tools are real. His size is a concern against men, and his NHL projection carries uncertainty because of it. Still, players who combine his skating, creativity, and two-way compete may be exactly the kind of late-round finds teams are hunting for.

3YP: 20-35-55 | **PIM:** 18 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Andrew Mangiapane

Steiner, Lars — RW, Rouyn-Noranda Huskies, QMJHL 171st overall (STL)

DH pre-Draft: 78

Steiner was considered a first-rounder entering the draft season, but after proper evaluation, he's more of a third- or fourth-round prospect. He's a skilled winger who can score at the junior level and excels on the power play, where he earns many of his points. Despite his production, it became clear as the season progressed that his offensive talent isn't as dynamic as initially believed. Combine that with a smaller frame and average skating, and you get a player who has a chance to become a bottom-six depth scorer—but could just as easily top out as a good AHLer.

3YP: 10-15-25 | **PIM:** 26 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** John Leonard

Stenberg, Ivar — LW, Frolunda HC, SHL 2nd overall (SJS)

DH pre-Draft: 2

Stenberg makes highlight-reel plays look routine. His individual toolkit is striking: fluid skating with excellent edgework and glide, high-speed puck-handling that rarely breaks down, and the ability to thread passes through multiple seams that most forwards wouldn't even attempt. He drives to the middle, forechecks with real purpose, and isn't shy about attacking defenders one-on-one. Nearly every attribute you look for in a first-line winger is already present. His decision-making under pressure can be cleaned up, but with stable linemates and a defined role, Stenberg has the tools to develop into a genuine top-line contributor.

3YP: 40-60-100 | **PIM:** 16 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Martin Necas

Suvanto, Oliver — C, Tappara, Liiga 18th overall (WAS)

DH pre-Draft: 15

Suvanto is about as safe a pick as this draft class offers. The big-bodied center forced his way into Tappara's Liiga lineup at just 17. He plays a mature, detailed two-way game that most prospects his age simply can't replicate against professional competition. His calling card is hockey sense: he reads plays early, positions himself intelligently, and uses his powerful frame to protect pucks and win battles without needing to outskate opponents. His stride is heavy-footed and unlikely to become a weapon, and the lack of dynamic puck skills caps his ceiling. But high-floor players with Suvanto's compete level and hockey IQ tend to stick around.

3YP: 20-35-55 | **PIM:** 18 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Charlie Coyle

Svensk, Vertti — LD, SaiPa U20, U20 SM-sarja 145th overall (LAK)

DH pre-Draft: 96

Svensk is a mobile defenseman with genuinely special skating. He uses his quick feet to escape forecheckers with rapid crossovers, carry the puck through the neutral zone as a one-man breakout, and join the rush in ways that make you envision a modern top-four contributor. His decision-making is where things fall apart. He has a habit of throwing pucks away without clear purpose, and his reads are reactive rather than anticipatory. He also needs to add strength;

right now, he gets pushed around against men. The skating alone makes him an intriguing upside bet. If his processing speed catches up, he could become an impactful modern defender.

3YP: 10-35-45 | **PIM:** 24 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Samuel Girard

Trejbal, Tobias – G, Youngstown Phantoms, USHL 42nd overall (CGY)

DH pre-Draft: 38

Trejbal enjoyed an excellent first year in the USHL, posting a 0.916 save percentage and a 2.12 GAA. Starting with the physical toolkit, Trejbal has what teams want. He has above-average size at 6-4 and above-average athleticism, which blend nicely with his frame. He reads developing plays effectively and doesn't get fooled often. He moves around the net well and can push post-to-post to stop one-timers. His rebound control is average but something he can continue to build on. Trejbal has nearly everything scouts look for in a goalie who could become a potential NHL starter. Only thing holding him back is a lack of elite traits, despite having few weaknesses.

PLAYER COMPARABLE: Jet Greaves

Tukio, Ossi — LD, Ilves, U20 SM-sarja

Undrafted

DH pre-Draft: 89

Tukio is a 6-2, 187-pound Finnish defenseman with intriguing upside. He has the mobility, puck skills, and confidence to create from the blue line. His transition game stands out in particular, as he carries the puck with purpose. There are quirks as well. His defensive game needs significant work—both his positioning and reads must sharpen. His play can lean toward chaos rather than cohesion, but if it all comes together, there could be something very interesting developing here.

3YP: 12-28-40 | **PIM:** 28 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Rasmus Sandin

Uronen, Anttoni — C, HIFK, Liiga

182nd overall (CBJ)

DH pre-Draft: 100

Uronen is a sturdy forward who uses his pro-ready build to excel in heavy, gritty situations. Already proven in Liiga, he leans on opponents to win battles and scores greasy net-front goals. While not an elite playmaker, Uronen flashes finesse, including deceptive spin-passes and highlight-reel dangles. His primary concerns are sluggish skating and inconsistent decision-making. If his skating base improves and he learns to leverage his frame to drive the net more consistently, he could develop into a reliable middle-six contributor.

3YP: 25-30-55 | **PIM:** 34 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Boone Jenner

Valentini, Adam — LW, University of Michigan, NCAA

96th overall (UTA)

DH pre-Draft: 51

Valentini was yet another 17-year-old playing in the NCAA this season, and he fared quite well on a strong Michigan team. He has a well-rounded skill set with both skill and drive. He competes hard and is a strong forechecker. Valentini is also a good puck carrier and can transition the puck up the ice effectively. His hockey IQ and playmaking ability are just okay, but he's a player with few weaknesses and plenty to like. The biggest downside is that he's a bit undersized, but he should be able to overcome that and become a bottom-six offensive contributor if he makes it.

3YP: 15-23-38 | **PIM:** 30 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Connor Dewar

Vandenberg, Thomas — C, Ottawa 67's, OHL

103rd overall (LAK)

DH pre-Draft: 49

Another early-September 2008 birthday, Vandenberg is one of the youngest players in the 2026

NHL Draft. He plays a very mature game in Ottawa's pro-style system. He's a smart player who plays a strong two-way game from the center position. While there's a lot to like, he's not the biggest, strongest, or most dynamic player, which makes it difficult to project whether he'll reach his ceiling at the NHL level. Otherwise, he checks all the boxes of someone who can play in the bottom six, handle multiple roles, and chip in some offense.

3YP: 12-22-34 | **PIM:** 20 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Alex Turcotte

Vanecek, Jakub — LD, Tri-City Americans, WHL 59th overall (DAL)

DH pre-Draft: 33

Vanecek had a great rookie season in the WHL, leading all rookie defensemen with 14 goals. He's a very mobile defenseman with a big slapshot, which accounts for many of his goals. Vanecek has good size, and the combination of size, mobility, and shot is very intriguing. His defensive game is just okay, but he has the tools to develop it over the next few years. Despite his size, he could afford to play a more physical and aggressive style. Still, Vanecek is a player worth monitoring and could carve out a role as a No. 4 or No. 5 defenseman if all goes well.

3YP: 11-22-33 | **PIM:** 30 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Jake Walman

Vanhanen, Matias – LW, Everett Silvertips, WHL 37th overall (NJD)

DH pre-Draft: 91

After having an excellent team in the 2024-25 season, Everett welcomed back nearly all of its best players for 2025-26. The team also welcomed newcomer Vanhanen, an undersized yet highly skilled playmaker from Finland. Vanhanen contributed from day one, producing 21 goals and 66 assists in 62 games for the Silvertips. While the goals weren't as abundant as you'd like, he does have an above-average shot and should be able to score at a moderate level in the NHL.

Vanhanen is at his best when using his puck skills to deke through and around defenders and using his vision to set up teammates. He has power-play upside and could carve out a role on a PP2 unit at the NHL level. The main thing holding him back is a lack of size and strength. Like many smaller forwards with lots of skill but without standout skating or compete, he may struggle to make the NHL simply due to how many similar players exist. If Vanhanen can improve his skating and add strength, he could potentially find his way onto an NHL roster as a depth scorer and PP2 flank option.

3YP: 18-25-43 | **PIM:** 12 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Anthony Beauvillier

Vanhatalo, Vilho — LW, Tappara, U20 SM-sarja 168th overall (FLA)

DH pre-Draft: 86

Vanhatalo may be a diamond in the rough—and a big one. The 6-4, 198-pound Finn combines a hulking frame with a plus-level shot and decent puck-handling, a combination that doesn't come around often at his size. He earned Liiga call-ups as a 17-year-old and even drew penalty-kill deployment, which shows his hockey sense and reach already translate against men. The rough edges are real: his skating stride is awkward, and he can disappear from games entirely. He also tends to tunnel-vision toward shooting regardless of the situation. But the tools are there, and players this big with real skill are worth the patience.

3YP: 25-30-55 | **PIM:** 48 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Mason Marchment

Verhoeff, Keaton — RD, North Dakota, NCAA 9th overall (SJS)

DH pre-Draft: 8

Verhoeff was the youngest defenseman in the NCAA this season on a very strong North Dakota team. While he didn't light it up as a freshman, he showed he belonged and largely thrived.

Verhoeff has the size and strength teams covet in a top-pairing right-shot defenseman, and he pairs that size with above-average competitiveness. He's a solid breakout passer and can move the puck up the ice in transition. He has a booming shot and should be able to score double-digit goals in his NHL prime. He's an aggressive defender who can afford to take risks thanks to his size and reach, even if that aggressiveness occasionally burns him. The biggest concern is his skating, which needs significant improvement before he reaches the NHL. As he adds strength and matures physically, he should be able to get more out of his stride and improve his agility. If he does, he has top-pairing upside and could be a great player for years. If not, he should still be an NHLer, but likely in a lower-lineup role.

3YP: 15-35-50 | **PIM:** 68 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Aaron Ekblad

Villeneuve, Xavier — LD, QMJHL

34th overall (CHI)

DH pre-Draft: 18

Villeneuve is the most offensively talented defenseman in the draft—hands down. He skates as though the puck is on a string, maneuvering around opponents with slick dekes and dangles. He's a smooth mover who glides around the ice with fluidity. His top-end speed isn't special yet, but he'll likely gain a step as he adds strength. Villeneuve can run a power play and operate in the offensive zone at a near-elite level. He uses his mobility to create space and open passing lanes, and his superior vision allows him to set up teammates for scoring chances. While he doesn't have a big shot, he gets it off quickly and still finds ways to score. Defensively, however, he is equally deficient. At times this season, he looked disinterested without the puck. His compete level is below average, and he lacks physicality due to his thin frame. Villeneuve needs to gain significant strength and play with more edge to succeed in the NHL. There is a ton of risk in his game, but if he puts it all together, he could become an upper-tier PP1 quarterback while handling sheltered third-pairing minutes at 5-on-5—all while scoring at an efficient rate.

3YP: 17-45-62 | **PIM:** 24 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Shayne Gostisbehere

Wassilyn, Braidy – LW, London Knights, OHL

Undrafted

DH pre-Draft: 86

Wassilyn is a skilled left-shot winger who produced at a decent level on a rebuilding London Knights team. He was a former top-5 pick in the OHL Draft but hasn't become the player many thought he could be. He is more of a playmaker than a goal scorer. He has good hands and sees plays developing before others. Wassilyn has a decent compete level, but he is also undersized. He will need a big summer as he enters Boston University to get his development trajectory back on track toward making the NHL.

3YP: 12-20-32 | **PIM:** 70 | **PLAYER COMPARABLE:** Pierre Engvall

Harris/Karvinen: Combined Top 64 for the NHL Draft

NOTE: This is not a Mock Draft.

Throw away all of the uncontrollable factors that concern NHL teams come Draft Day – notably nationality (ahem, Russian, KHL) and size. This ranking is simply based on skill and potential. Voilà, you have Jordan Harris (DP Head of Scouting, Europe) and Anni Karvinen (DP Head of European Scouting) ranking for the upcoming Draft. This is not to reflect a player's fantasy value but rather how their draft-day list would look.

1	Gavin McKenna	33	Jakub Vanecek
2	Ivar Stenberg	34	Nikita Shcherbakov
3	Chase Reid	35	Simas Ignatavicius
4	Viggo Bjorck	36	Niklas Aaram-Olsen
5	Carson Carels	37	Ryder Cali
6	Caleb Malhotra	38	Tobias Trejbal
7	Alberts Smits	39	Tomas Chrenko
8	Keaton Verhoeff	40	Jaxon Cover
9	Tynan Lawrence	41	Adam Nemec
10	Malte Gustafsson	42	William Hakansson
11	Daxon Rudolph	43	Marcus Nordmark
12	Wyatt Cullen	44	Gleb Pugachyov
13	Ethan Belchetz	45	Casey Mutryn
14	Adam Novotny	46	Tommy Bleyl
15	Oliver Suvanto	47	Chase Harrington
16	Elton Hermansson	48	Dmitri Borichev
17	Oscar Hemming	49	Thomas Vandenberg
18	Xavier Villeneuve	50	Yegor Shilov
19	J.P. Hurlbert	51	Adam Valentini
20	Nikita Klepov	52	Victor Plante
21	Alexander Command	53	Viktor Fyodorov
22	Ryan Lin	54	Giorgos Pantelas
23	Ilia Morozov	55	Samu Alalauri
24	Juho Piiparinen	56	Markus Ruck
25	Liam Ruck	57	Rudolfs Berzkalns
26	Maddox Dagenais	58	Zac Olsen
27	Jack Hextall	59	Jakub Floris
28	Ryan Roobroeck	60	Mans Gudmundsson
29	Mathis Preston	61	Lavr Gashilov
30	Ben Macbeath	62	Charlie Morrison
31	Adam Goljer	63	Beckham Edwards
32	Brooks Rogowski	64	Beckett Hamilton

Top-10 Lists

Multicat Forwards	Offensive Defensemen	Multicat Defensemen
Ivar Stenberg	Xavier Villeneuve	Carson Carels
Gavin McKenna	Chase Reid	Chase Reid
Caleb Malhotra	Tommy Blehl	Keaton Verhoeff
Ethan Belchetz	Ryan Lin	Daxon Rudolph
Viggo Bjorck	Daxon Rudolph	Malte Gustafsson
Adam Novotny	Keaton Verhoeff	Alberts Smits
Tynan Lawrence	Carson Carels	Xavier Villeneuve
Ryan Roobroeck	Axel Elofsson	Adam Goljer
Ilia Morozov	Alberts Smits	Ryan Lin
Oliver Suvanto	Adam Goljer	Ben Macbeath

Goal Scorers	Centers - Fantasy	Wingers - Fantasy
Ivar Stenberg	Viggo Bjorck	Gavin McKenna
Ryan Roobroeck	Caleb Malhotra	Ivar Stenberg
Ethan Belchetz	Tynan Lawrence	J.P. Hurlbert
J.P. Hurlbert	Markus Ruck	Wyatt Cullen
Gavin McKenna	Alexander Command	Liam Ruck
Viggo Bjorck	Jack Hextall	Oscar Hemming
Marcus Nordmark	Oliver Suvanto	Adam Novotny
Niklas Aaram-Olsen	Maddox Dagenais	Elton Hermansson
Chase Reid	Ilia Morozov	Marcus Nordmark
Elton Hermansson	Ryder Cali	Niklas Aaram-Olsen

Playmakers	Top Goaltenders	Power Forwards
Gavin McKenna	Tobias Trejbal	Ethan Belchetz
Viggo Bjorck	Dmitri Borichev	Adam Novotny
Ivar Stenberg	Brady Knowling	Maddox Dagenais
Xavier Villeneuve	William Lacelle	Ilya Morozov
Markus Ruck	Samuel Hrenak	Gleb Pugachyov
Wyatt Cullen	Filip Ruzicka	Brooks Rogowski
Caleb Malhotra	Harrison Boettiger	Simas Ignatavicius
Chase Reid	Michal Orsulak	Alexander Command
J.P. Hurlbert	Jan Larys	Oliver Suvanto
Tommy Blehl	Parker Snell	Rian Chudzinski

Top 25 Forwards Points-only Leagues

Dobber		Harris		Karvinen	
1	Gavin McKenna	1.	Gavin McKenna	1.	Gavin McKenna
2	Ivar Stenberg	2.	Ivar Stenberg	2.	Ivar Stenberg
3	Viggo Bjorck	3.	Viggo Bjorck	3.	Viggo Bjorck
4	Caleb Malhotra	4.	Caleb Malhotra	4.	Wyatt Cullen
5	Wyatt Cullen	5.	Tynan Lawrence	5.	Mathis Preston
6	Nikita Klepov	6.	Ethan Belchetz	6.	Caleb Malhotra
7	Ryan Roobroeck	7.	J.P. Hurlbert	7.	Tynan Lawrence
8	J.P. Hurlbert	8.	Wyatt Cullen	8.	Elton Hermansson
9	Elton Hermansson	9.	Adam Novotny	9.	Liam Ruck
10	Liam Ruck	10.	Ryan Roobroeck	10.	Ethan Belchetz
11	Mathis Preston	11.	Oscar Hemming	11.	Adam Novotny
12	Adam Novotny	12.	Liam Ruck	12.	Oscar Hemming
13	Jaxon Cover	13.	Elton Hermansson	13.	Nikita Klepov
14	Oscar Holmertz	14.	Mathis Preston	14.	J.P. Hurlbert
15	Marcus Nordmark	15.	Nikita Klepov	15.	Alexander Command
16	Victor Plante	16.	Marcus Nordmark	16.	Tomas Chrenko
17	Markus Ruck	17.	Oliver Suvanto	17.	Casey Mutryn
18	Ilya Morozov	18.	Maddox Dagenais	18.	Ryan Roobroeck
19	Ethan Belchetz	19.	Alexander Command	19.	Yegor Shilov
20	Lavr Gashilov	20.	Markus Ruck	20.	Jack Hextall
21	Adam Nemec	21.	Yegor Shilov	21.	Oliver Suvanto
22	Alexander Command	22.	Niklas Aaram-Olsen	22.	Niklas Aaram-Olsen
23	Jakub Frolo	23.	Ryder Cali	23.	Marcus Nordmark
24	Tynan Lawrence	24.	Jaxon Cover	24.	Ilya Morozov
25	Oscar Hemming	25.	Simas Ignatavicius	25.	Victor Plante

20th Annual Mock

Our annual NHL Mock Draft. DobberProspects' Head of European Scouting, Jordan Harris, accompanied by Head of European Scouting, Anni Karvinen, will be doing the honors.

A combination of team drafting history, system needs and gut instinct are part of their formulas. A Mock Draft is not an order of players in terms of talent, nor is it in order of their fantasy value—it is meant to predict which team will take whom, even if it means dropping down a few spots on the list to grab the guy they want.

Notes:

- BPA = Best Player Available
 - For more information on these players, check out [DobberProspects' NHL draft-eligibles here.](#)
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By Jordan Harris and Anni Karvinen

Round 1

1. Toronto – Gavin McKenna, LW, Penn State, NCAA

The Maple Leafs select the most talented player in the draft in McKenna. He should be an immediate contributor on the PP for Toronto and should work his way into the top-six forward group before long. He'll be set up to succeed playing on a team with two great Cs who can allow him to make plays.

2. San Jose – Chase Reid, D, SOO, OHL

The Sharks' trade for Michael Kesselring sparked chatter that it's now more likely the team selects Ivar Stenberg instead. We still have the Sharks opting for Reid here, as defensemen with true No. 1 upside are extremely hard to find. The highly mobile right-shot defender fills several organizational needs and projects as a genuine PP1 quarterback at the next level.

3. Vancouver – Caleb Malhotra, C, Brantford, OHL

It's hard not to look at the hiring of Manny Malhotra as Vancouver's head coach, the organizational need at C, and not think the Canucks will select Caleb. He is a very well-rounded

potential top-six center with good size. He'll likely play at least another year in the NCAA before turning pro in 2027–28.

4. Chicago – Ivar Stenberg, LW, Frolunda, SHL

Stenberg makes too much sense for Chicago. If their system lacks anything, it's a true first-line winger. The supremely skilled Swede generates scoring chances at an outstanding rate, and it's easy to imagine how good he'd look next to Connor Bedard.

5. NY Rangers – Carson Carels, D, Prince George, WHL

The Rangers add to their blue line with Carels, a well-rounded and physical WHL defenseman. Carels can impact the game at both ends of the ice but could really flourish as a stopper at the next level thanks to his size, skating, and physicality. He projects as a top-four defender with potential No. 2 upside.

6. Calgary – Viggo Bjorck, C, Djurgardens, SHL

The Flames need skill as much as any team, and Bjorck brings exactly that. While undersized, he has an exceptional compete level and intangibles that make him a player you can win with. Selecting a center also fills a positional need, and in Bjorck, they might land the best C in this year's Draft.

7. Seattle – Albers Smits, D, Jukurit, Liiga

The Kraken has never selected a defenseman in the first round. That's about to change. Smits is a mature player who has already played a significant amount of professional hockey—and thrived. He has two-way upside even if the offensive ceiling and elite hockey sense aren't quite there. Smits should be a plus-level defender with the potential to put up 30+ points per season, and possibly more with PP time. A player like Smits is badly needed in Seattle's prospect pool.

8. Winnipeg – Keaton Verhoeff, D, Univ. of North Dakota, NCAA

The Jets bet on upside here. Verhoeff slid down boards after a rocky finish to his NCAA season, but the 6-4 right-shot defenseman still carries one of the best floor/ceiling combinations in the class. A Jets blue line built for more size and offense from the back end is a logical fit.

9. Ottawa (via Florida) – Ethan Belchetz, LW, Windsor, OHL

After a shocking Brady Tkachuk blockbuster trade, it's the Senators picking 9th overall. Ottawa is deep on the blue line and at center, so they try to replace Tkachuk with a big, hulking winger in Belchetz. He's a lot to handle and would complement players like Tim Stutzle very well—a dual-threat scorer who can finish both down low and from distance.

10. Nashville – Tynan Lawrence, C, Boston University, NCAA

An injury and a midseason move to a struggling BU squad cooled Lawrence's stock, but the tools never disappeared. Nashville lands a relentless two-way center whose skating and compete level give him one of the safer floors in this range, even if the offensive ceiling remains a question mark at this point.

11. St. Louis – Malte Gustafsson, D, HV71, SHL

While center could be the bigger need for the Blues, Caleb Malhotra, Tynan Lawrence, and Viggo Bjorck are already off the board. Even so, St. Louis should be thrilled to see the 6-5 smooth-skating defenseman available. There are some similarities between Philip Broberg and Gustafsson, so the Blues' front office will likely be more than happy to wait a bit longer to address their center position.

12. New Jersey – Wyatt Cullen, LW, USNTDP, USHL

Cullen has flown up draft boards throughout the season and makes it to pick 12 in this mock. He has near-high-end skill and could be an impact point producer at the next level. He adds more firepower to the Devils' future top-six forward group.

13. NY Islanders – Daxon Rudolph, D, Prince Albert, WHL

The Isles loaded up on the left side of their blue line last season by adding Matthew Schaefer and Kashawn Aitcheson. This year, it's time to address the right side by adding a big, rangy defender in Rudolph. He has great mobility and knows how to score. While he needs to add more physicality to his game, he has more than enough size to do so. If all goes well, a Schaefer–Rudolph top pairing could be in the cards for the Islanders before long.

14. Columbus – Oscar Hemming, LW, Boston College, NCAA

The Blue Jackets continue to build around big, skilled players by adding a versatile power forward in Hemming. Along with strong shooting mechanics and playmaking instincts, his defensive detail stands out, making him an effective winger up and down the lineup.

15. St. Louis (via Detroit) – Oliver Suvanto, C, Tappara, Liiga

The Blues find their center at a more appropriate spot in the draft with Suvanto. While he doesn't project as a high-end offensive play-driver, he does just about everything else well. Given the wealth of wing talent in St. Louis' prospect pool, Suvanto is a player who could complement those pieces nicely.

16. Washington – Alexander Command, C, Orebro, U20

With Command, Washington lands a highly projectable middle-six center whose game is built on strength, awareness, and anticipation. While he's not a dynamic creator, he's effective in tight spaces and uses his frame to his advantage.

17. Los Angeles – Adam Novotny, LW, Peterborough, OHL

The Kings play a very defensive style and require players with hard two-way skill. That's exactly the type of player Novotny is. Expect him to score tough goals around the net while also finishing from mid-range with his excellent shot. Los Angeles can count on Novotny to bring it every shift and serve as a stopper away from the puck as well.

18. Washington (via Anaheim) – Nikita Klepov, F, Saginaw, OHL

The Capitals have recently trended toward drafting high-upside players, and they continue that approach by adding Klepov. His size and skating give some pause, but the combination of his puckhandling and release is too enticing for the Caps to pass up here.

19. Utah Xavier – Villeneuve, D, Blainville-Boisbriand, QMJHL

Villeneuve is difficult to project. Some teams may have him inside the top 10, while others may have him outside the first round entirely. In this mock, the Mammoth land a player type they don't currently have in their system. If Villeneuve hits, he could become a high-end offensive defenseman with 60-plus-point potential. He just needs to ensure his offensive game translates, as there isn't much to like defensively at this stage.

20. Buffalo (from Edmonton via San Jose) – Ilia Morozov, C, Miami, NCAA

After the trade that sent Michael Kesselring to San Jose and moved Buffalo up to this spot, there's been buzz connecting the Sabres to Morozov. His offensive ceiling isn't sky-high, but the 6-3 center thinks the game at a high level and has a strong foundation to build on thanks to his reliable two-way play.

21. Philadelphia – Maddox Dagenais, C, Quebec, QMJHL

The Flyers have selected two centers in the first round over the past two seasons (Jack Nesbitt and Jett Luchanko), but that shouldn't preclude them from taking another swing at the position with Dagenais. He's a big, physical center with skill. While he's unlikely to become a 1C, he gives the team valuable flexibility down the middle moving forward.

22. Pittsburgh – Elton Hermansson, RW, MoDo (Allsvenskan)

The Penguins pivot to the skilled winger who spent his season playing against men in Sweden's second-tier league. Hermansson is definitely an upside pick—his game currently lacks consistency and pace, but his puck skills and the highs in his game suggest top-six potential.

23. Boston – Ryan Lin, D, Vancouver, WHL

Boston adds a player archetype they don't really have in their prospect pool — at least not at this quality level—by selecting Lin. He is a very cerebral, offensively tilted defenseman. Lin isn't the biggest player, but he may be smart and competitive enough to overcome that and develop into a strong two-way NHL defender.

24. Vancouver (via Minnesota) – JP Hurlbert, F, Kamloops, WHL

Vancouver's prospect pool lacks skill, and they add plenty of it with Hurlbert. His shot is a difference-making tool, and his plus-level puck skills complement it well. Hurlbert will need to develop the physical side of his game to make it in the NHL, but for Vancouver, he's the perfect swing at this point in the draft.

25. Ottawa (via Florida, Seattle, and Tampa Bay) – Gleb Pugachyov, RW, Nizhny Novgorod, MHL/KHL

The Senators may very well trade this pick before the Draft (potentially even pick No. 9), but in this mock, they land another big-bodied winger with scoring touch. Pugachyov fits nicely with Ottawa's style of play and should develop into a solid middle-six winger for years to come.

26. NY Rangers (via Dallas) – Mathis Preston, RW, Vancouver, WHL

After a truly disappointing season, it's clear the Rangers need to retool—if not rebuild—and to do that, they need some home-run swings. Preston could be exactly that, with intriguing, legitimate top-six upside, even if the projection is murky and his game still needs significant rounding out.

27. San Jose (via Buffalo) – Casey Mutryn, C, NTDP, USHL

The Sharks grab a versatile forward in Mutryn, who can play throughout the lineup. Mutryn isn't the most dynamic player, but he does a lot of things well, allowing him to be an effective complementary option on any line. Given the players in San Jose's system, he likely projects as a bottom-six center, though he could move up the lineup or shift to the wing when needed.

28. Montreal – Jack Hextall, C, Youngstown, USHL

The Habs continue adding pieces to their already impressive young core. Hextall brings a steady, physical defensive presence, and with his high hockey sense, he could develop into a reliable middle-six center for years to come.

29. St. Louis (via Colorado) – Nikita Shcherbakov, LD, Tolpar Ufa, MHL

The Blues add another massive defenseman in Shcherbakov. He projects as a bottom-pairing defender who plays with a physical edge and defends well. He's also an effective puck mover, giving St. Louis more flexibility on their blue line.

30. Calgary (via Vegas) – Liam Ruck, F, Medicine Hat, WHL

Ruck torched the WHL, scoring at a remarkable rate, and his hands and scoring instincts are

undeniable. Craving elite talent, Calgary accepts the size-and-skating risk that comes with his profile for a shot at a dynamic top-six winger.

31. Carolina – Tommy Bleyl, D, Moncton, QMJHL

Shayne Gostisbehere isn't getting any younger, and Scott Morrow was traded last offseason for K'Andre Miller, so the Hurricanes will need to find their future PP1 defenseman. Bleyl provides high-end playmaking and vision in the offensive zone. He's not the strongest defender, but the Hurricanes always seem to find ways to insulate their offensive-minded blueliners. This could not be a more Eric Tulsky-style pick.

32. Ottawa – Juho Piiparinen, D, Tappara, Liiga

Ottawa's recent trend of drafting defensemen in the first round continues as they add Piiparinen. The best Finnish defense prospect since Dallas' Miro Heiskanen, Piiparinen kills plays with his reach and physicality and projects as a two-way minute-muncher, with intriguing flashes of offense still to refine.

Round 2

33. Vancouver – Ben MacBeath, D, Calgary, WHL

The Canucks already have strong pieces on its blue line in Tom Willander and Zeev Buium, but you can never have too many potential top-four defenders. MacBeath is a bigger defenseman who skates well—full stop, not just "for his size." He's a two-way defender who could be highly effective eating big minutes alongside someone like Willander for years to come.

34. Chicago – William Hakansson, D, Lulea, SHL

The Hawks could use more stability on the back end, and they get that in Hakansson. The 6-4 defender naturally covers a lot of ice, and while he hasn't shown much offense playing against men, there may be untapped potential. He has a booming shot, and at junior levels he displayed more creativity with the puck.

35. Calgary (via NY Rangers) – Adam Goljer, D, HK Dukla Trencín, Slovakia

Calgary already has a few smaller right-shot defensemen in Zayne Parekh and Henry Mews, so they add size on the right side with Goljer. He's a raw prospect who spent this past season playing professional hockey in Slovakia. While unrefined defensively, his size, physicality, and skating give scouts optimism that he'll eventually defend effectively at the NHL level.

36. Calgary – Tobias Trejbal, G, Youngstown, USHL

With back-to-back picks, the Flames use one to land a promising goaltending prospect in Trejbal. His hip mobility and footwork separate him from most big-bodied netminders. Add intelligent positioning and dynamic recoveries, and you have a top-two goalie in this class.

37. Chicago (via Toronto) – Ryder Cali, C, North Bay, OHL

Chicago grabs a future bottom-six center in North Bay's Cali. He has steadily climbed draft boards thanks to a strong OHL season and international play. Cali competes hard and is an excellent forechecker. He's exactly the type of player Chicago will need in the lower half of its lineup, given the amount of skill they already have up front.

38. Seattle – Yegor Shilov, C, Victoriaville, QMJHL

The Kraken make an upside bet by drafting Shilov. Arguably one of the best puck-handlers in the

draft, Shilov can create highlight-reel plays that get you out of your seat. He needs to add physicality and significantly improve his pace, but he has legitimate top-six upside if everything comes together.

39. Pittsburgh (via Winnipeg) – Simas Ignatavicius, F, Geneve-Servette HC, NL

General manager Kyle Dubas grabs the big Lithuanian forward who played a regular role in a strong professional league in Switzerland. Ignatavicius is a structured and effective complementary player who can slot throughout the lineup in a support role.

40. Florida – Tomas Chrenko, C, HK Nitra, Slovakia

The Panthers are known for swinging for the fences, and they do exactly that by selecting Chrenko. They land an extremely skilled player who can create offense in multiple ways with his plus-level tools and smarts. The physical side of his game needs significant development before he can step onto NHL ice.

41. Vancouver (via San Jose) – Dmitri Borichev, G, Loko-76, MHL

The second goalie off the board, Borichev joins Vancouver's prospect pool as a potential future starter. The development runway for goalies is often long, and it will be no different for Borichev, who will likely spend another year in Russian junior hockey before progressing through the professional ranks there and eventually coming to North America.

42. Nashville – Niklas Aaram-Olsen, RW/LW, Orebro, SHL/U20

Nashville adds a winger with middle-six upside in Aaram-Olsen. His shot is high-end and pairs well with his plus-level speed. He plays with a great motor and can look dynamic in flashes. He'll need to round out his game and continue building his B-game.

43. Columbus (via St. Louis) – Adam Nemec, F, Sudbury, OHL

The Blue Jackets inject size and speed to its prospect pool with Nemec, brother of Devils defenseman Simon Nemec. The younger Nemec is a possession-driven forward who excels on the forecheck. He projects as a strong fit in a middle- or bottom-six role in a few years.

44. New Jersey – Jaxon Cover, LW, London, OHL

The Devils make one of the biggest upside bets in the draft by selecting Cover. Having only started playing hockey a few years ago, Cover's game remains raw and very much a work in progress, but he possesses several intriguing tools: great hands, smooth skating, and plus-level shooting and passing.

45. Chicago (via NY Islanders) – Victor Plante, F, USNTDP, USHL

Plante is a smaller but tenacious forward with skill. The youngest of the three Plante brothers, he will attend UMD next season to play alongside Max and Zam. Victor plays a similar style and could overcome his size limitations to carve out a role as a middle-six playmaker at the NHL level.

46. Los Angeles (via Columbus) – Jonas Lagerberg Hoen, RW, Leksands, U20

After missing almost the entire season, Lagerberg Hoen has flown under the radar in public scouting circles. The Kings select a 6-2 winger who remains something of a mystery box. His shot is a legit weapon, and when paired with his strong pace, it gives him genuine middle-six upside.

47. Detroit – Jakub Vanecek, D, Tri-City, WHL

The Red Wings need to add to the left side of their blue line, and Vanecek provides size and mobility while projecting as a plus defender at the next level. There is some offense in his game, but he's unlikely to become a major point producer.

48. Florida (via Washington) – Brooks Rogowski, C, Oshawa, OHL

Florida adds a hulking 6-7 centerman with a highly projectable physical profile. Rogowski's skating and range give him a safe floor as a bottom-six forward, but he has shown flashes of playmaking that could give him even higher upside if everything clicks.

49. Los Angeles – Ryan Roobroeck, F, Niagara, OHL

At the start of the season, Roobroeck was viewed by many as a potential top-10 pick. In this mock draft, he falls all the way to 49. Roobroeck is a big, talented scoring winger with underrated playmaking ability. While there are concerns about his consistency and compete level, he has plenty of talent and is worth a gamble at this stage.

50. Anaheim – Mans Gudmundsson, D, Farjestad, U20

The Ducks add a 6-3 blueliner who has climbed draft boards recently thanks to his versatile profile. Gudmundsson has a relatively safe floor as a third-pair defender due to his physicality and shutdown ability. He also has some puck-moving upside, which adds to his appeal.

51. Calgary (via Utah) – Markus Ruck, F, Medicine Hat, WHL

Everyone wants one team to land both Markus and Liam Ruck just to see their chemistry as they develop into pros. We grant that wish here, with Calgary selecting both brothers. Markus is the more playmaking-oriented of the two and may need to shift to the wing in the NHL, but he has high-end skill that could take him a long way.

52. Edmonton – Marcus Nordmark, LW, Djurgardens, U20

The Oilers make a high-upside bet by selecting one of the more skilled Europeans in this class. Nordmark's puck skills, vision, and shot are top-six caliber when he's engaged, but his pace, physicality, and effort need significant improvement for his game to translate to North American ice.

53. Philadelphia – Samu Alalauri, D, Pelicans, SM-sarja

Alalauri is a big, physical defenseman who could eventually provide the Flyers with a bottom-pair stopper. There are some question marks in his game—particularly his decision-making—but he has enough plus-level attributes to justify a second-round selection.

54. Pittsburgh – Rudolfs Berzkalns, C, Muskegon, USHL

The Penguins land a reliable two-way center in Berzkalns. While his offensive upside is limited, he has many of the traits required to play center in the NHL: he connects plays, protects the puck well, and shows strong defensive awareness. If his pace and engagement continue to improve, a bottom-six role looks attainable.

55. Calgary (via Ottawa) – Thomas Vandenberg, C, Ottawa, OHL

Calgary is back on the clock and selects a tenacious, reliable two-way center from the 67's. Vandenberg has average size and average tools, but his intangibles give him a real chance to carve out an NHL role, likely in the bottom six.

56. Boston – Adam Andersson, C, Leksands, U20

Andersson is a prototypical bottom-six center with a projectable 6-4 frame. Boston lands a hard worker with impressive defensive detail, highlighted by smart positioning and strong defensive-zone support. He lacks some creativity, but improvements in his speed and puckhandling could give him upside as a potential third-line center.

57. Nashville (via Minnesota) – Brek Liske, D, Everett, WHL

For much of the draft season, Liske looked like a third- or fourth-round pick. Once the playoffs

began, he elevated his game, showing offensive flashes not previously seen. While he still projects primarily as a lower-pairing defensive defenseman, there may be more to his game that teams can develop.

58. Tampa Bay – Adam Valentini, F, Univ. of Michigan, NCAA

The Lightning has a habit of drafting well, and in Valentini they pick up one of the more undervalued players in the class. He's not an explosive skater, but his plus-level passing and hockey sense have allowed him to score at an impressive rate for a draft-eligible NCAA player. He's undersized, but he compensates with strong work ethic.

59. Dallas – Zac Olsen, F, Saskatoon, WHL

Olsen is a bigger-bodied forward with snarl. He was also a consistent top performer at the NHL Scouting Combine, highlighting his high-end athleticism. He's unlikely to be a major playmaker or point producer in the NHL, but he could certainly carve out a role as an energy forward.

60. Toronto (via Buffalo) – Brady Knowling, G, NTDP, USHL

With four picks in the first three rounds, Toronto uses one on a goaltender. At 6-5, Knowling has the frame and athleticism teams covet, playing well off his posts and staying composed amid net-front chaos. Tracking and recoveries remain question marks, but his size, poise, and big-moment résumé make him an intriguing swing at this stage.

61. Montreal – Lavar Gashilov, F, Avto, MHL

Montreal has recently found success drafting Russian players and looks to replicate that by selecting Gashilov. He's a tenacious player who hounds pucks but can also create offense for himself and his teammates. He's an intriguing bet for the Habs at this point in the draft.

62. San Jose (via Colorado) – Giorgos Pantelas, D, Brandon, WHL

The Sharks continue to add to their blue line, landing an effective shutdown defender in Pantelas. His puck play needs improvement, but his physicality and strong stick work form a defensive foundation that projects well to the NHL.

63. FORFEITED (Vegas)

64. NY Rangers (via Carolina) – Jakub Floris, D, Lukko, U20

The Rangers grab a rangy 6-3 defender with plus-level four-way mobility and a genuine mean streak. His game remains a work in progress—his reads and decision-making under pressure need refinement—but the physical tools could translate into a reliable two-way game with proper development.

Round 3

65. Calgary (via Vancouver) – Chase Harrington, F, Spokane, WHL

66. Chicago – Oliver Murnieks, F, Saint John, QMJHL

67. NY Rangers – Malcolm Gastrin, F, MODO, J20

68. Calgary – Viktor Fyodorov, F, Torpedo, MHL

69. Toronto – Beckett Hamilton, F, Red Deer, WHL

70. Nashville (via Seattle) – Beckham Edwards, F, Sarnia, OHL

71. Winnipeg – Adam Ruzicka, G, Brandon, WHL

72. Ottawa (via Florida) – Luke Schairer, USNTDP, USHL

73. St. Louis (via San Jose) – Oscar Holmertz, F, Linkoping, J20
74. Colorado (via Nashville) – William Lacelle, G, Rimouski, QMJHL
75. St. Louis – Alessandro Di Iorio, F, Sarnia, OHL
76. St. Louis (via New Jersey) – Ethan MacKenzie, D, Edmonton, WHL
77. NY Rangers (via NY Islanders) – Rian Chudzinski, F, Moncton, QMJHL
78. Vancouver (via Columbus) – Colin Fitzgerald, F, Soo, OHL
79. Detroit – Jonah Sivertson, F, Prince Albert, WHL
80. Los Angeles (via Washington) – Lars Steiner, F, Rouyn Noranda, QMJHL
81. NY Rangers (via Los Angeles) – Tomas Galvas, D, Liberec, Extraliga
82. Anaheim – Nils Bartholdsson, F, Rogle, J20
83. Utah – Samuel Hrenak, G, Fargo, USHL
84. Edmonton – Casper Juustovaara, F, Lulea, SHL
85. Toronto (via Philadelphia) – Braidy Wassilyn, F, London, OHL
86. Pittsburgh – Noel Pakarinen, F, Kiekko-Espoo, U20
87. Ottawa – Alan Shaikhislamov, F, Tolpar Ufa, MHL
88. Boston – Ossi Tukio, D, Ilves, U20
89. Minnesota – Simon Katolicky, F, Tappara, U20
90. Tampa Bay – Vilho Vanhatalo, F, Tappara, U20
91. Ottawa (via Dallas) – Matias Vanhanen, F, Everett, WHL
92. NY Rangers (via Buffalo) – Jakub Frolo, F, Ilves, U20
93. Montreal – Viggo Sorensson, D, Boras, U20
94. Columbus (via Colorado) – Ola Palme, D, Vaxjo, J20
95. Vegas – Pierce Mbuyi, F, Owen Sound, OHL
96. Utah (via Carolina) – Charlie Morrison, D, Quebec, QMJHL

Summary – Mock Draft 2026

NOTE: *This is a Mock Draft, not a ranking of value.*

1	TOR: Gavin McKenna, LW	33	VAN: Ben MacBeath, D	65	CGY: Chase Harrington, F
2	SJS: Chase Reid, D	34	CHI: William Hakansson, D	66	CHI: Olivers Murnieks, F
3	VAN: Caleb Malhotra, C	35	CGY: Adam Goljer, D	67	NYR: Malcolm Gastrin, F
4	CHI: Ivar Stenberg, LW	36	CGY: Tobias Trejbal, G	68	CGY: Viktor Fyodorov, F
5	NYR: Carson Carels, D	37	CHI: Ryder Cali, C	69	TOR: Beckett Hamilton, F
6	CGY: Viggo Bjorck, C	38	SEA: Yegor Shilov, C	70	NAS: Beckham Edwards, F
7	SEA: Albers Smits, D	39	PIT: Simas Ignatavicius, F	71	WPG: Adam Ruzicka, G
8	WPG: Keaton Verhoeff, D	40	FLA: Tomas Chrenko, C	72	OTT: Luke Schairer, D
9	OTT: Ethan Belchetz, LW	41	VAN: Dmitri Borichev, G	73	STL: Oscar Holmertz, F
10	NAS: Tynan Lawrence, C	42	NAS: Nik Aaram-Olsen, W	74	COL: William Lacelle, G
11	STL: Malte Gustafsson, D	43	CBJ: Adam Nemec, F	75	STL: Alessandro Di Iorio, F
12	NJD: Wyatt Cullen, LW	44	NJD: Jaxon Cover, LW	76	STL: Ethan MacKenzie, D
13	NYI: Daxon Rudolph, D	45	CHI: Victor Plante, F	77	NYR: Rian Chudzinski, F
14	CBJ: Oscar Hemming, LW	46	LAK : J Lagerberg Hoen, RW	78	VAN: Colin Fitzgerald, F
15	STL: Oliver Suvanto, C	47	DET: Jakub Vanecek, D	79	DET: Jonah Sivertson, F
16	WSH: Alex Command, C	48	FLA: Brooks Rogowski, C	80	LAK: Lars Steiner, F
17	LAK: Adam Novotny, LW	49	LAK: Ryan Roobroeck, F	81	NYR: Tomas Galvas, D
18	WSH: Nikita Klepov, F	50	ANA: M Gudmundsson, D	82	ANA: Nils Bartholdsson, F
19	UTM: Xavier Villeneuve, D	51	CGY: Markus Ruck, F	83	UTM: Samuel Hrenak, G
20	BUF: Ilia Morozov, C	52	EDM: M Nordmark, LW	84	EDM: Casper Juustovaara, F
21	PHI: Maddox Dagenais, C	53	PHI: Samu Alalauri, D	85	TOR: Braidy Wassilyn, F
22	PIT: Elton Hermansson, RW	54	PIT: Rudolfs Berzkalns, C	86	PIT: Noel Pakarinen, F
23	BOS: Ryan Lin, D	55	CGY: T Vandenberg, C	87	OTT: Alan Shaikhislamov, F
24	VAN: JP Hurlbert, F	56	BOS: Adam Andersson, C	88	BOS: Ossi Tukio, D
25	OTT: Gleb Pugachyov, RW	57	NAS: Brek Liske, D	89	MIN: Simon Katolicky, F
26	NYR: Mathis Preston, RW	58	TBL: Adam Valentini, F	90	TBL: Vilho Vanhatalo, F
27	SJS: Casey Mutryn, C	59	DAL: Zac Olsen, F	91	OTT: Matias Vanhanen, F
28	MTL: Jack Hextall, C	60	TOR: Brady Knowling, G	92	NYR: Jakub Frolo, F
29	STL: Nikita Shcherbakov, LD	61	MTL: Lavr Gashilov, F	93	MTL: Viggo Sorensson, D
30	CGY: Liam Ruck, F	62	SJS: Giorgos Pantelas, D	94	CBJ: Ola Palme
31	CAR: Tommy Bleyl, D	63	VGK: FORFEITED	95	VGK: Pierce Mbuyi, F
32	OTT: Juho Piiparinen, D	64	NYR: Jakub Floris, D	96	UTM: Charlie Morrison, D



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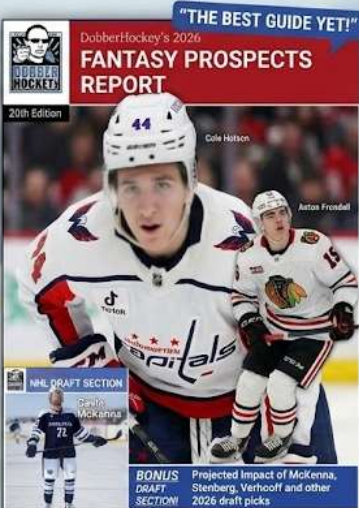


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